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PREFACE

There are memories we carry because we want to remember them, and there are others we carry because we have never found a way to forget them.

For years, I carried both.

I did not set out to write this book. The idea began much more quietly. I started keeping weekly notes about my experiences and reflections, giving them the title *Behind the Presidential Curtain*. At first, they were little more than fragments—observations, recollections, conversations, questions, and memories from a period of my life that I had not yet learned how to put into a single story. I wrote because some experiences refuse to disappear simply because we stop speaking about them.

With time, those scattered writings began to form something larger.

I began to understand that what I had been recording was not merely the story of one man or one period of my own life. It was also a story about power: how it is acquired, how it is protected, how it changes relationships, and what can happen to those who stand close to it for too long. It was a story about loyalty and fear, friendship and betrayal, courage and silence. Above all, it was a story about what a person sees when he is close enough to power to witness what the public rarely sees.

That closeness carries a particular burden.

From 1992 to 2001, I served in the security of Paul Kagame. During those years, I was not looking at him as a historian might look at a political figure decades later. I was there, inside the machinery of power, performing my duties and observing the people and events around me as they unfolded.

At the time, I did not possess the distance I have today.

Distance changes the questions we ask.

When we are young, we often accept the world we have inherited. We learn whom to trust, whom to obey, what not to question, and when silence appears safer than curiosity. Only later, sometimes many years later, do we begin to revisit those moments and ask ourselves whether we understood them correctly.

What did I actually see?

What was I told?

What did I fail to understand because I was too close to the events?

And what did I understand perfectly well but was too afraid—or too inexperienced—to confront?

Those questions have followed me for years.

I grew up in exile, and the experience shaped much of the person I became. Like many children whose lives are formed by displacement, I learned early that history is not something that belongs only in books. History can enter a family through a closed door. It can alter the meaning of a name. It can determine where a child grows up, what language he hears around him, what country he calls home, and what questions he carries into adulthood.

Perhaps that is why I have always been drawn to stories in which the difference between right and wrong is not presented as something easy.

I remember reading *Oliver Twist* by Charles Dickens and being struck by the moral world within the story—the encounter between innocence and cruelty, vulnerability and power, good and evil.

Life, however, is rarely as neatly arranged as a novel.

In real life, the powerful do not always announce themselves as villains. The frightened do not always look frightened. The loyal may have doubts they never express. A person can serve someone for years and still struggle to explain exactly when admiration became uncertainty, or when uncertainty became disillusionment.

That is part of the difficulty of telling this story.

I have written about the period in which I worked closely with Paul Kagame, but this is not simply a book about proximity to a president. It is an attempt to examine what that proximity taught me about the man behind the public image: his temperament, his relationships with those around him, the manner in which decisions were made, the way advice was received—or rejected—and the atmosphere in which people learned to conduct themselves.

Some of what I recount comes from my own experience.

Some comes from people who occupied important positions within the political and military structures of the period.

Some of the material was gathered through later conversations and accounts, including information I encountered after leaving the military.

These distinctions matter.

A responsible account of history must distinguish between what a person personally witnessed, what was reported to him, what he came to believe, and what he can establish with certainty. I have therefore tried, throughout this book, to present these different forms of knowledge as honestly as I can.

I do not expect every reader to agree with my conclusions.

Indeed, disagreement is one of the reasons a book such as this needs to exist.

A society cannot understand its history if it permits only one interpretation of that history. Nor can a nation heal itself by deciding that certain questions are too uncomfortable to ask.

The past does not become harmless because we refuse to discuss it.

It simply becomes harder to understand.

There are also people whose stories are intertwined with mine—comrades with whom I shared a struggle, people who helped bring Kagame to power, and others who later paid a heavy price after questioning the direction in which that power was being exercised. Some lost their lives. Others lost their freedom. Others were driven into exile. Their stories are part of the burden carried by this book.

For a long time, I found it difficult to write about these things.

There is a particular kind of silence that develops around painful memories. At first, silence may seem like protection. Eventually, however, it can become another form of imprisonment.

Writing became my way out.

After leaving the military, I continued my education and eventually built a professional life in Britain, working in the field of mental health. That later experience gave me a different perspective on some of the behaviour I had witnessed earlier in my life.

But I do not want the reader to confuse professional training with omniscience.

No person can look into another human being's mind and claim complete knowledge of what lies there. Human behaviour is complicated. Political power makes it more complicated still. My later education and professional experience have influenced the way I interpret behaviour, but they do not transform interpretation into certainty.

The reader must ultimately judge the evidence, the testimony, the events, and the conclusions for themselves.

That is how this book should be read.

Not as a command to believe.

Not as an invitation to hate.

But as an invitation to look behind the curtain.

For more than a decade, I lived close enough to the centre of Rwanda's political power to observe a world that most people could encounter only from a distance. I saw relationships form and change. I saw people rise. I saw others disappear from positions they had once occupied with confidence. I witnessed the difference between the public language of leadership and the private atmosphere surrounding those who exercised it.

Years later, I began asking myself a question that would eventually become the foundation of this book:

What does a person owe to history when he has seen something that others have not?

Is silence loyalty?

Is speaking out betrayal?

Can a former insider ever tell the truth without being accused of settling old scores?

And if he remains silent, what responsibility does he bear for what future generations will never know?

I have wrestled with these questions throughout the writing of this book.

I know that memory is imperfect. I know that people remember the same event differently. I know that political history is rarely free from competing narratives. But I also know that fear can disappear from public speech without disappearing from people's memories.

Eventually, someone has to speak.

This book is my attempt to do so.

I write especially for Rwandans, whose history has been marked by extraordinary suffering, displacement, political violence, broken trust, and the struggle to understand what happened to their country. But I also write for readers beyond Rwanda—for scholars, political observers, students, journalists, historians, policymakers, and anyone who wishes to understand the political world from which these experiences emerged.

The story belongs to a wider world because Rwanda's history does not exist in isolation.

What happens in a country can shape its neighbours. What happens in the Great Lakes region can affect an entire continent. And the decisions of political leaders can leave consequences that outlive the leaders themselves.

I therefore offer these pages not as the final word, but as a record of one man's experience and understanding.

Read critically.

Question what you encounter.

Compare accounts.

Pay attention not only to what is said, but also to what is left unsaid.

And above all, remember that behind every political event are human beings—people who loved, feared, hoped, betrayed, endured, fought, lost, survived, and remembered.

That is where this story begins.

Not with a president.

Not with a government.

Not even with a war.

It begins with a man who spent years close to power, walked away from it, and eventually found himself unable to remain silent about what he had seen.

This is what lies behind the presidential curtain.

INTRODUCTION

Behind the Presidential Curtain

Every government has a public face.

There are speeches delivered before cameras, official photographs carefully composed, ceremonies filled with flags and uniforms, handshakes exchanged before the watching world, and statements prepared in language designed to reassure rather than unsettle. A president may be known to millions of people without most of those people ever having stood within a few metres of him.

But what does a leader look like when there are no cameras?

What happens after the doors close?

What does the atmosphere become when the people in the room are no longer speaking to the president as citizens speak to a head of state, but as subordinates speak to the person who controls their careers, their movements, their futures—and, in some circumstances, their lives?

These are uncomfortable questions.

Yet they are precisely the questions that arise when one attempts to understand political power from the inside rather than from the distance of public appearances.

I spent years close to Paul Kagame.

From 1992 until 2001, I served in his security. During that period, I saw a side of political and military life that could not easily be observed from the outside. I watched the way decisions were made, the way Kagame related to those under his command, the way he responded to advice, and the manner in which his character appeared through his dealings with the people around him.

At the time, however, I did not think of myself as someone who would one day write about these experiences.

I was simply there.

I had duties to perform. I belonged to a system. I had comrades. I had responsibilities. And, like many people living within a powerful institution, I learned that there are things one notices without immediately understanding their significance.

Sometimes history announces itself.

More often, it does not.

An ordinary conversation can become important only years later. A decision that seems insignificant when it is made may acquire an entirely different meaning when viewed from a distance. A person who appears indispensable today may be forgotten tomorrow. And someone who once stood confidently at the centre of power may eventually find himself outside the very system he helped to build.

This is one of the peculiarities of memory.

We do not always understand our own experiences when we are living through them.

It is only later that the questions begin.

For me, those questions became increasingly difficult to ignore after I left the military.

I had grown up in exile, and that experience had already taught me that political events are never merely political. They reach into ordinary lives. They determine where families live, what children know about their origins, what they fear, and what they hope will happen to the country from which they or their parents were displaced.

My own life was shaped by that history.

I eventually pursued my education and built a professional life in Britain, working in mental health. That later experience changed the way I looked at human behaviour and at some of the things I had encountered earlier in my life.

But there is a danger in looking backward.

The danger is believing that because we now understand more, we must have understood everything then.

We did not.

No human being has perfect access to another person's mind. Political behaviour is complicated, and the behaviour of powerful people is more complicated still. A gesture can have several meanings. A decision can be interpreted differently by different people. A rumour can acquire the appearance of fact simply because it has been repeated often enough.

That is why the distinction between **what one witnessed, what one heard, what one inferred, and what one believes** matters so greatly.

This book contains all of those dimensions.

Some events I describe from my own experience. Other accounts come from people who were themselves close to the political and military structures of the Rwandan Patriotic Front. Some of the material was gathered through conversations and writings from later years. The book therefore represents not a single moment of observation, but a collection of memories, accounts and reflections that came together over time.

That distinction should remain in the reader's mind throughout the pages that follow.

The purpose of this book is not to ask the reader to surrender judgment.

Quite the opposite.

I want the reader to question.

Why did certain people behave as they did?

Why did others remain silent?

Why did some individuals who once stood together eventually turn against one another?

What makes a person remain loyal to a leader?

And what happens when that loyalty begins to conflict with conscience?

These questions are not limited to Rwanda.

They are human questions.

History repeatedly shows us that power can transform relationships. A friend may become a rival. A comrade may become an enemy. A subordinate may discover that obedience has a price. A political movement that began with promises of liberation may eventually find itself confronted by the responsibilities and temptations that accompany power.

At what point does the struggle for liberation become a struggle to preserve authority?

At what point does loyalty cease to be freely given?

And when fear enters the relationship between a leader and those around him, can genuine loyalty survive?

These questions form part of the intellectual journey of this book.

But there is another question that is perhaps even more important:

What does it mean to tell the truth about a past in which one was personally involved?

I do not pretend to stand outside the history I describe.

I was part of it.

I served within the system. I knew some of the people whose stories appear in these pages. I witnessed events from a particular position, with all the limitations that such a position inevitably carries.

That is precisely why I believe my account is worth reading—and precisely why it should also be read critically.

An insider does not possess the whole truth simply because he was close to power.

Sometimes proximity gives a person knowledge.

Sometimes proximity gives him blind spots.

Sometimes it gives him both.

The pages that follow therefore move between personal memory and broader political events. They move from the early history of the Rwandan Patriotic Army and the circumstances surrounding the death of General Fred Rwigema, toward the years in which Paul Kagame became the dominant figure in Rwanda's political and military life. The first chapter begins with the origins of that history and asks questions about events whose consequences would shape everything that followed.

From there, the story becomes progressively wider.

It enters the presidential household.

It examines relationships between Kagame and those around him.

It considers allegations of violence and unexplained deaths.

It follows the fractures that emerged among former comrades.

It moves beyond Rwanda's borders into Congo and Burundi and examines the country's relationships with its neighbours.

Eventually, it reaches the international arena and the relationships between Kagame's government and Western governments.

And then, after all the politics, wars, accusations, rivalries and questions about power, the story returns to people.

Comrades.

Leaders.

Friends.

Those who remained behind.

Those who went into exile.

Those who were imprisoned.

And those who did not live long enough to tell their own stories.

That final return to individuals is important.

Political history can become dangerously abstract.

We speak about governments, armies, movements, borders and strategies as though they were independent beings. But governments do not suffer. People do. Armies do not mourn. Families do. Political movements do not lose a brother, a father, a friend or a child.

People do.

Behind every political decision there are human consequences.

That is why this book is not simply an attempt to describe political events. It is an attempt to remember the people who inhabited them.

There is another reason for writing.

Silence can become a kind of history.

When those who witnessed difficult events refuse to speak, future generations inherit an incomplete account. They may know what happened officially, but not what it felt like to live through it. They may know the names of leaders but not the atmosphere surrounding them. They may know the outcome of a political struggle without understanding the fears, ambitions and personal relationships that shaped it.

I do not want my memories to disappear in that way.

For years, I kept notes under the title *Behind the Presidential Curtain*. What began as weekly writings and shorter reflections eventually developed into the idea of a book.

The act of writing has itself become part of the journey.

Putting difficult experiences into words forces a person to confront them differently. Memory that exists only in the mind can remain disordered. Writing demands sequence. It demands names. It demands context. It forces the writer to return to questions he may have spent years avoiding.

In that sense, writing this book has also been an attempt to understand myself.

Who was I when I stood inside that world?

Who did I become after leaving it?

And what responsibility do I have now toward the people and events I once knew?

I cannot answer those questions for every reader.

I can only place my account before you.

You may agree with some of it.

You may challenge other parts.

You may believe that I have interpreted certain events correctly, while concluding that I have misunderstood others.

That is the nature of history.

The most dangerous history is not necessarily history with which we disagree.

It is history we are no longer permitted to question.

So I invite you to question.

Question me.

Question the people whose actions are described here.

Question the official narratives.

Question the alternative narratives.

Question your own assumptions.

And, above all, resist the temptation to believe that a complicated country can be explained by a simple story.

Rwanda's history is too painful for that.

Its politics are too consequential.

Its people have lived through too much.

The story that follows is therefore not offered as the final account of Rwanda, Paul Kagame, the RPF, or the events described in these pages.

It is one man's account of a world he entered as a participant, experienced from close range, left behind, and eventually began to write about.

Perhaps that is the greatest reason this story needs to be told.

Because sometimes the most revealing view of power is not from the throne.

It is from the corridor outside the room.

From the person standing beside the door.

From the man who hears the conversation but is not expected to speak.

From the soldier who follows orders before he has learned to question them.

From the former insider who, years later, begins to ask:

What did I really see?

What did I fail to see?

What did I once accept that I would no longer accept today?

And perhaps the hardest question of all:

When the curtain finally falls, what remains of the person who spent so long standing behind it?

Those are the questions with which I invite you to enter this book.

The curtain is about to open.

CHAPTER ONE

HOW IT ALL BEGAN

1.1 A GLIMPSE INTO THE BEGINNING

Every story has a beginning.

But beginnings are rarely as clear as we imagine them to be. Looking backward, we are tempted to draw a straight line between the events that came before and those that came after, as though history had always known where it was going. It rarely does.

Before there was a government in Kigali led by the Rwandan Patriotic Front, before Paul Kagame became the dominant political figure in Rwanda, before the wars that would reshape the Great Lakes region, there was a generation of Rwandans living outside the country of their birth and wondering whether they would ever be allowed to return.

For many of them, exile was not a temporary inconvenience.

It became a way of life.

They were born outside Rwanda. They grew up outside Rwanda. They went to school outside Rwanda. They married and raised children outside Rwanda. Some eventually knew the countries of exile better than they knew the country their parents continued to call home.

Yet the question of return remained.

What does it mean to belong to a country from which you have been separated for most of your life?

And what happens when an entire generation grows up believing that the right to return home must be fought for?

These questions are essential to understanding what came next.

In the early 1990s, the Rwandan Patriotic Army, or RPA, was based in Uganda. When the movement launched its military campaign against the Rwandan government, it did not begin from an empty landscape. Uganda provided important support, including military equipment, food, medicine and clothing, while its territory offered the RPA space from which to organize and, when necessary, regroup.

The movement also existed within a much wider network of Rwandan refugees.

Uganda and other countries bordering Rwanda had become home to large numbers of Rwandans who had been displaced from their country. Among these communities were people who believed that returning home was not merely desirable but necessary.

Some supported the political movement.

Others supported the military effort.

Some gave money.

Others gave property.

And some gave away the very things on which their families depended.

The source recalls that, in the years preceding the 1990 invasion, Rwandans living in Uganda sold livestock—including cattle, goats and chickens—in order to contribute to the effort against the government of President Juvénal Habyarimana.

To someone who has never experienced exile, such sacrifices can be difficult to understand.

Why would a person sell the animals that feed his family?

Why surrender property for a war whose outcome is uncertain?

Why risk everything for a country in which you may not even have been born?

The answer, at least for many of those involved, was painfully simple:

Because it was home.

I grew up in Uganda, and I watched this world from close enough to understand its emotional force, even though I had not yet experienced Rwanda for myself.

I remember struggling with the idea that a human being could live without the freedom to return to the country from which his family came. To me, there was something almost incomprehensible about it: the idea that a person could be born into a nationality yet be denied the ordinary freedom to live in that country.

For those of us who grew up in exile, the absence of a homeland was not merely a political problem.

It was an identity problem.

You could belong somewhere and still feel that you belonged somewhere else.

You could grow up speaking the language of the country that had received you while hearing stories about another country from your parents.

You could know its hills through descriptions before ever seeing them.

You could inherit memories that were not entirely your own.

And eventually, those inherited memories could become your own reason for action.

That was the atmosphere in which the RPA's struggle developed.

The movement's supporters believed that history had denied Rwandans in exile a fundamental right: the right to return. The military campaign therefore came to represent more than a contest for political power. For many of those involved, it was presented as a struggle to reverse years of displacement.

But political movements are never made up of ideas alone.

They are made of people.

And people bring their hopes, ambitions, loyalties, fears and weaknesses with them.

Among the people who came to embody the aspirations of many Rwandan refugees was Fred Gisa Rwigema.

His importance to the story cannot be understood simply by listing his military positions.

Before he became a general, before he became a senior figure in Uganda's military establishment, and before he became one of the central figures in the Rwandan struggle, he was himself a refugee.

That experience mattered.

Fred Rwigema was born in Gitarama in southern Rwanda on 10 April 1957. His birth name was Gisa Emmanuel. Following the upheaval of 1959 and the displacement that followed, his family fled to Uganda, where they lived in refugee settlements.

His early life therefore unfolded against the same historical background that shaped so many other Rwandan refugees.

But Rwigema's path would take him much further.

After completing secondary school, he became involved in revolutionary movements in the region. He went to Tanzania and joined FRONASA, the movement associated with Yoweri Museveni's struggle against the Ugandan government. He later travelled to Mozambique, where he became involved with FRELIMO during its struggle against Portuguese colonial rule.

These experiences were formative.

Rwigema was not simply learning how to fight.

He was learning how political movements are built.

He was learning how armies operate.

He was learning how power can be challenged.

And, perhaps most importantly, he was developing a conception of political struggle that extended beyond the boundaries of a single country.

In 1979, he joined the Ugandan National Liberation Army, or UNLA, which fought against the government of Idi Amin. The movement, together with Tanzanian forces, eventually helped overthrow Amin's regime.

When Museveni later established the National Resistance Army, Rwigema became one of those who joined his struggle against Milton Obote. After the NRA seized power in 1986, Rwigema became Uganda's deputy minister of defence.

Yet even the title of deputy minister does not adequately capture the way he was remembered by those who fought alongside him.

According to the author's account, Rwigema continued to place himself close to the battlefield even after attaining senior political and military office. He participated in operations in northern Uganda and earned a reputation among soldiers for his courage. Some called him *Mungu wa Vita*—"God of War."

For the Rwandan refugees who watched his rise, however, Rwigema represented something even more powerful.

He represented possibility.

A person who had once lived as a refugee had risen to one of the highest levels of authority in a neighbouring country. A man who had been separated from his homeland was now helping to organize the movement that would eventually attempt to take his people back there.

For young Rwandans growing up in exile, that symbolism mattered.

The author recalls first hearing of General Rwigema when he was only twelve years old. At the time, he and others had grown up with what he describes as the humiliation of having no homeland. Rwigema's rise therefore transformed him into something more than a military commander: he became, in the author's words, a source of hope for a generation that had grown up without a country of its own.

But Rwigema's vision, as presented in this account, was not limited to bringing Tutsi refugees back to Rwanda.

The author portrays him as seeking a broader reconciliation among Rwandans.

As preparations for the return to Rwanda intensified, Rwigema is described as reaching out to Rwandans from different political and social backgrounds, including Colonel Alexis Kanyarengwe, who would later become chairman of the RPF. While Rwigema concentrated heavily on the military dimension, Kanyarengwe was expected to contribute political knowledge and engagement.

That distinction is important.

A military victory does not automatically produce a political settlement.

An army can capture territory, but it cannot by itself determine whether a divided society will eventually live together.

Someone must imagine what comes after the fighting.

Someone must ask what kind of country is being built.

Someone must decide whether victory means replacing one group with another or creating a political order in which those who once lived on opposite sides can coexist.

According to the author's recollection, Rwigema was thinking about that larger question.

He was simultaneously involved in maintaining Uganda's security, caring for his family, and helping to organize a future Rwandan military structure from within the Ugandan army. He also worried about what would happen to Uganda's military once Rwandan soldiers eventually left its ranks to return home.

This was the man who was preparing to return to Rwanda.

And this was the movement preparing to follow him.

The dream had taken years to form.

The sacrifices had already been made.

The refugees had waited.

The soldiers had trained.

The plans had been discussed.

And then, in October 1990, the return finally came.

But the story did not unfold as many had imagined.

The man who had become a symbol of hope for so many Rwandan refugees would die only days after the beginning of the invasion.

Fred Gisa Rwigema was killed on 2 October 1990.

His death created a question that has never entirely disappeared from the history of Rwanda:

Who killed Fred Rwigema?

That question is where the next part of this story begins.

Not because there is a simple answer waiting to be announced, but because the circumstances surrounding his death, and the competing explanations that followed, would leave a wound in the memories of those who had believed in him.

Twenty-three years after his death, the author was still questioning the explanations that had been given. He acknowledges that he was not yet a soldier when Rwigema died, but says that he lived among people who had fought alongside him in Uganda and entered the military shortly after the war began. For him, the circumstances of Rwigema's death remained insufficiently explained.

And so the question remains suspended over the opening pages of this book:

If Fred Rwigema was the man around whom so many hopes had gathered, what exactly happened on the battlefield that brought his life to such a sudden end?

Before attempting to answer that question, however, we must first examine what was officially said about his death—and why, according to the author, that explanation left so many questions unanswered.

1.2 THE DEATH OF GENERAL FRED RWIGEMA: WHAT REALLY HAPPENED?

There are deaths that become part of history because everyone knows how they happened.

And there are deaths that become part of history precisely because the answer never seems complete.

The death of General Fred Gisa Rwigema belongs to the second category.

For the people who had followed his journey from exile to the battlefield, his death was not simply the loss of a military commander. He had become a symbol of return, of possibility, and of a future that many Rwandans in exile had spent years imagining.

Then, almost as soon as that future appeared within reach, he was gone.

Fred Rwigema died on 2 October 1990, only days after the RPA launched its invasion of Rwanda.

More than two decades later, the circumstances of his death continued to trouble the author.

The question is deceptively simple:

Who killed Fred Rwigema?

A simple question.

A complicated history.

And, for many who knew him or had followed his story, an answer that never fully settled the matter.

I was not yet a soldier when Rwigema died. But I was living among people who had fought beside him in Uganda, and I entered the military not long after the war began. Over the years, I heard different accounts of what had happened. I

encountered people who had known him personally and people who had been involved in the military structures surrounding the RPA.

The more I learned, the less satisfied I became with the explanation I had been given.

I do not claim that every rumour is true.

Nor do I claim that every alternative account is false.

But when several questions remain unanswered after a death of such historical importance, those questions deserve to be asked.

Before presenting my own concerns, however, it is necessary to begin with the official explanation.

The Bullet Nobody Could Account For

One explanation that circulated publicly was that Rwigema had been killed by a stray or otherwise unidentified bullet fired by enemy forces.

The account was supported publicly by the Rwandan authorities and was repeated in discussions surrounding his death. In one version, the bullet was said to have come from the direction of the enemy, possibly from an armoured personnel carrier or a military jeep.

At first glance, such an explanation is not impossible.

War is chaotic.

Commanders can be killed by artillery, sniper fire, stray bullets or fragments from weapons fired without any knowledge of the person who will ultimately be struck. On a battlefield, a single projectile can travel farther than its intended target, and death can arrive without warning or explanation.

So why question it?

Because the details surrounding what happened afterwards raise another set of questions.

One of the people who gave an account of Rwigema's death was Colonel Happy Ruvusha, who had been among those responsible for his close protection.

According to the account discussed in this book, Ruvusha said that he and three other soldiers—Matungo and Nkubito among them—were responsible for burying Rwigema.

That detail immediately raises a question.

Why would a general of Rwigema's stature be buried by only a handful of junior soldiers?

This is not a question of ceremony alone.

It concerns procedure.

It concerns hierarchy.

It concerns the circumstances in which the body of a senior military commander was handled immediately after his death.

According to the author's account, the men named in Ruvusha's explanation were junior soldiers at the time, rather than officers of a rank normally associated with handling the burial of a commander of Rwigema's seniority.

And that leads to a second question:

Where were the senior officers who had served alongside him?

The RPA still had experienced officers and commanders in its ranks. The source names figures including Lieutenant Colonel Adam Waswa, Chris Bunyenyezi, Peter Bayingana, Steven Ndugute, Sam Kaka and others who were involved in the military struggle.

Why, then, according to the author's account, did so few senior figures appear to be involved in the immediate handling and burial of Rwigema's body?

Perhaps there was a military explanation.

Perhaps circumstances on the battlefield made a normal burial impossible.

Perhaps the situation was too dangerous.

Perhaps the decision was taken simply because there was no time.

Those possibilities must be acknowledged.

But acknowledging them does not eliminate the question.

It merely makes the question more precise.

The Rules of the Battlefield

The author further argues that military practice would normally favour soldiers of comparable or nearby rank when burying a senior officer.

If that is the case, why was Rwigema's burial handled differently?

Was the battlefield situation so unstable that normal practice could not be followed?

Was there a deliberate effort to keep the burial small?

Or was something else happening that those present did not understand?

There is another detail that complicates the account.

Ruvusha's version, as presented by the author, did not mention Sergeant Blackman, whom the author identifies as Rwigema's driver and who later died, despite his connection to Rwigema's movements.

Again, the omission does not prove anything.

An omission is not evidence of guilt.

But in a historical investigation, omissions can become questions.

And questions, when they accumulate, deserve examination.

The source also raises concerns about what happened to Rwigema's body immediately after his death.

According to the account presented, the body was transported in a vehicle normally used for heavy equipment while those around him had not yet decided where he would be buried.

That raises another uncomfortable question:

Why was a commander of Rwigema's stature not immediately taken to an established military position or medical facility?

The author specifically asks why the body was not transported to the military hospital at Mbuya in Uganda, where battlefield casualties could ordinarily be taken, regardless of where they had fallen.

Again, there may have been circumstances we cannot reconstruct today.

The realities of war are often less orderly than the rules written for them.

But that is precisely why testimony and documentation matter.

When the normal procedure is not followed, the reasons should ideally be recorded.

When a commander dies, the circumstances should be documented.

When the body is buried, those responsible should be identifiable.

When a senior military figure dies at the beginning of a national struggle, the historical record should be exceptionally clear.

According to the author, it was not.

What Was Being Hidden?

This is where the question becomes more troubling.

Why was Rwigema's burial, as described in the account, carried out with such secrecy?

The author openly acknowledges that he cannot understand why it happened that way.

He also asks whether Happy Ruvusha might have known more than he disclosed.

Yet here the author's own recollection becomes important.

He remembers Ruvusha not as an obvious conspirator but as someone who had served close to Rwigema and who appeared genuinely affected by his death. Ruvusha, according to the author's memory, continued to speak of Rwigema and mourned the loss of a commander who had maintained good relations with the soldiers under him.

That creates an important complication.

If Ruvusha was hiding something, what was his motive?

If he was not hiding anything, why did his account leave so many questions?

The difference matters.

A serious inquiry cannot begin with the conclusion and then force every piece of evidence to fit it.

The correct approach is to ask what each piece of information can—and cannot—establish.

The Bayingana and Bunyenyezi Allegations

The questions surrounding Rwigema's death did not end with the circumstances of his burial.

Another set of claims emerged around two senior RPA officers: Major Peter Bayingana and Major Chris Bunyenyezi.

According to accounts described by the author, the two men were accused of killing Rwigema because of a struggle over leadership.

These were serious allegations.

But the story did not stop there.

According to the accounts presented in the source, Bayingana and Bunyenyezi were subsequently killed, with competing explanations offered for their deaths. One version suggested that they were killed by other soldiers seeking revenge for Rwigema's death. Another alleged that General Salim Saleh himself killed them in retaliation for the death of his close friend Rwigema.

Such claims require particular caution.

They involve multiple deaths.

They involve senior military officers.

They involve competing narratives.

And they involve people who had personal relationships with the principal figures in the story.

In other words, the closer one gets to the centre of the story, the more difficult it becomes to separate testimony from interpretation.

The author's account also describes a different version of events: that Bayingana and Bunyenyezi were killed after being ambushed by forces of the Rwandan government while attempting to assist Major Sam Kaka, who had become surrounded near Nyagatare. According to that account, they had gone to provide heavy weapons, including weapons capable of significant firepower, before being caught in the ambush.

The timing of their deaths, as reconstructed by the author, is also presented as inconsistent with some versions of the story.

This is where history becomes difficult.

One account says one thing.

Another says something else.

A third interpretation attempts to connect events that occurred at different times.

And beneath all of them lies the same unresolved question:

What actually happened?

The Story of Lieutenant Kato

Then another name enters the story:

Lieutenant Kato.

According to information the author says he gathered from former RPA soldiers, including both men and women who had served during the period, there was another version of events that had allegedly remained secret for years.

The account begins before the invasion.

According to this testimony, Rwigema had been involved in selecting young men and women for specialized training in preparation for the military

campaign. Among those selected was Lieutenant Kato, who had been chosen by Paul Kagame.

Kato subsequently received specialized training abroad, including training described in the source as involving hostage-taking and commando operations.

Another group of trainees included future senior figures such as James Kabarebe, Charles Kayonga, Alex Kagame, Vincent Gatama, Tom Mpaka and Rose Kabuye.

According to the account, Kagame was familiar with Kabarebe and was involved in presenting Kabarebe and Kato to Rwigema before Kagame travelled to the United States for military training.

The source says Kagame had recommended Kabarebe as someone who could contribute to Rwigema's office, while also emphasizing Kato's useful military skills.

Rwigema, however, is said to have declined Kagame's proposal that Kabarebe replace Emmanuel Kanamugire as one of his assistants.

Then comes the most serious allegation.

The author reports testimony from a former RPA soldier claiming that Rwigema possessed a firearm capable of firing without an audible report and that the weapon had been placed in Kato's hands. The same account alleges that this weapon may have been used to kill Rwigema.

This is an extraordinary claim.

And precisely because it is extraordinary, it must be treated as a claim—not as a fact established by the evidence presented here.

The alleged sequence is that Kato was seen leaving an area after Rwigema was killed, at a moment when attention was focused on the battlefield rather than on identifying the person who had fired the fatal shot. The same source claims that Kato was later brought close to Kagame after Kagame returned from the United States.

If true, the implications would be enormous.

But that is exactly why the allegation demands scrutiny rather than assumption.

The Death of Kato

The account continues with another death.

According to the testimony presented by the author, Kato was subsequently assigned to soldiers under the command of Kayitare. James Kabarebe is said to have informed Kato of the assignment.

The source then alleges that, while Kato was travelling to join those forces, he was shot by Silas Udahemuka, described as a cousin of Kagame, and that his death was subsequently attributed to enemy action.

The author presents a possible motive suggested by the testimony: that Kato was killed because he allegedly knew something about Rwigema's death and that his continued existence might have exposed information that others wanted concealed.

Again, this is an allegation.

It is not something the author presents with documentary proof sufficient to eliminate every alternative explanation.

That distinction cannot be ignored.

The same account extends the alleged cover-up to Kato's brother, Major Mupenzi, who is said to have died later after being poisoned. The author describes Mupenzi as Kato's twin brother and a trusted military figure.

If the account were true, it would suggest a chain of killings designed to prevent information about Rwigema's death from becoming public.

But if the account is not true, then the deaths have been woven into a narrative that may not accurately explain them.

That is precisely the dilemma facing anyone who tries to reconstruct a disputed historical event decades after it occurred.

The absence of certainty does not mean that questions should not be asked.

But questions should not be mistaken for answers.

Kagame's Return

According to the account presented in the source, Kagame returned from his military training before completing it and was subsequently appointed to a senior command position, replacing Adam Waswa, who later died in circumstances the author describes as unclear.

The source then presents an even more serious allegation: that after Rwigema's death, Kagame told Museveni that Bayingana and Bunyenyezi were responsible and encouraged retaliation against them, eventually leading to their deaths.

If that allegation were established, it would fundamentally alter the interpretation of the events that followed Rwigema's death.

But once again, we must ask:

What is the evidence?

Who gave the information?

When was it given?

Was the witness in a position to know?

Can the account be corroborated?

What alternative explanations exist?

Those questions are not signs of weakness.

They are the foundation of responsible historical inquiry.

A Struggle over the Future

There is another dimension to the story that deserves attention.

According to the author's account, disagreements existed within the RPF leadership over strategy, including questions surrounding the timing of the military campaign and the possibility of negotiations.

The author portrays Rwigema as more willing to consider an outstretched hand from President Habyarimana, while suggesting that other members of the movement favoured continuing the military struggle.

Whether this difference was as decisive as later accounts suggest is another question.

But it introduces a fundamental political issue.

Military movements are rarely united by one idea alone.

People may agree on the destination while disagreeing profoundly about the road.

One commander may believe that victory requires negotiation.

Another may believe that negotiation represents weakness.

One may see compromise as a means of saving lives.

Another may see compromise as surrender.

And when the stakes are the future of a country, such disagreements can become more than disagreements.

They can become struggles over who gets to decide the future.

The Questions That Remain

By this point, the questions surrounding Rwigema's death have multiplied.

Why was the body reportedly buried in such circumstances?

Why were so few senior officers involved?

Why was the body not taken to the military hospital at Mbuya, according to the author's account?

Why was the burial apparently kept so private?

Why were the bodies of Bayingana and Bunyenyezi not, according to the source, recovered and publicly accounted for?

Why was there no deeper investigation that could conclusively resolve the competing accounts?

Why did the various versions of Rwigema's death continue to circulate?

And why, after so many years, does the question still return?

The author also asks why Rwigema's historical legacy appears, in his view, to have been treated differently in Rwanda and Uganda, despite the fact that Rwigema was born in Rwanda and died during the attempt to return there.

There are questions here that deserve answers.

But there is also a danger.

When an event becomes surrounded by unanswered questions for decades, speculation can begin to fill the space left by missing evidence.

One theory gives birth to another.

A rumour becomes a story.

A story becomes an accepted belief.

And eventually people forget which parts were witnessed, which were reported, and which were inferred.

That is why I return to the question not as though I possess a final answer, but because I believe the unanswered questions themselves are part of the history.

Fred Rwigema's death changed the course of the Rwandan struggle.

It changed the people who inherited the movement he had helped build.

It changed the balance of leadership.

And, whether one accepts or rejects the competing allegations surrounding his death, one fact cannot be disputed:

the man who had become a symbol of return was dead, and the people who remained had to decide what would happen next.

The war did not end with his death.

It had barely begun.

And for those of us who would later enter that struggle, the consequences of that beginning would follow us for years.

For me, they eventually followed me all the way into the presidential security system—and, years later, into a prison cell.

That is where my own story takes its next turn.

1.3 MY ESCAPE TO FRANCE

There comes a moment in a person's life when fear ceases to be something felt in the distance and becomes something physical.

You hear it in the silence around you.

You notice it in the way people look at you.

You begin to measure your words before speaking.

And eventually, you understand that the question is no longer whether something might happen to you.

The question is whether you will remain there long enough to discover what it is.

By the end of 2000, I had reached that point.

I had spent years serving within the presidential security structure. I had seen how power operated from close range. I had watched people enter positions of influence and later disappear from them. I had witnessed the atmosphere surrounding those who were considered loyal and those whose loyalty was suddenly questioned.

But there is a difference between observing fear in other people and discovering that fear has become your own companion.

I was eventually imprisoned at the military facility in Kimihurura.

I did not know with certainty why I was being held.

That uncertainty was itself frightening.

When a person is accused of a specific offence, at least there is something tangible to confront. There is an allegation. There are questions. There is a charge that can, in principle, be answered.

But what happens when you do not understand what you are being punished for?

What do you defend yourself against when nobody tells you precisely what you have done?

And how do you know whether your detention is temporary or whether the people holding you have already decided what will happen to you?

These questions became increasingly difficult for me to ignore.

I had spent years around a system in which information mattered enormously. Those close to Kagame knew that knowledge could be valuable, but they also knew that knowledge could become dangerous.

A person did not necessarily have to commit a crime to become a problem.

Sometimes knowing too much was enough.

Sometimes asking the wrong question was enough.

Sometimes simply being connected to the wrong person could make someone suspicious.

And sometimes suspicion itself could become a form of punishment.

While I was being held, I began to understand that my position had changed.

I was no longer one of the men protecting the centre of power.

I was now someone being watched by it.

That reversal is difficult to describe to someone who has never experienced it.

Yesterday, you may have been trusted to stand beside a powerful man.

Today, the same system may regard you as a threat.

What changed?

Did you change?

Did they change?

Or did you simply become aware of something that had always been there?

These questions followed me.

Eventually, I decided that remaining in Rwanda was too dangerous.

I escaped and reached a neighbouring country.

But leaving Rwanda did not mean that I had escaped the reach of the system I feared.

According to what I later learned, information about my whereabouts reached French diplomatic and intelligence officials. The French authorities wanted information and testimony about Kagame and the people surrounding him.

They offered to help me leave the region.

They offered travel documents.

They offered an air ticket to Paris.

And, most importantly, they gave me the impression that I would be protected.

For someone who had just fled the military structure in which he had served, such an offer could sound like the beginning of safety.

I accepted.

I travelled to France.

I believed I was leaving behind the immediate danger.

I was wrong.

Paris

When I arrived in France, the situation changed.

The assurances I had received did not translate into the freedom I had imagined.

I was instructed not to tell people that I had entered France using travel documents provided by the French authorities. Looking back, I understood that this was connected to the legal implications of my arrival and the possibility that I could claim protection under the international refugee framework.

I was also told not to reveal that I was in France.

The reason given was diplomatic sensitivity.

If Rwanda discovered where I was, I was told, it could create problems between the two countries.

The irony was difficult to ignore.

I had left Rwanda because I feared the security system surrounding Kagame.

I had crossed a border believing that I was entering a country where I would be safe.

Yet, even after reaching Europe, I found myself being told to hide.

There was another condition.

I was permitted to communicate only in circumstances that served the information the French authorities wanted. I could provide information about former colleagues and, according to the account, potentially help them locate people who could be returned to Rwanda.

The situation was becoming increasingly uncomfortable.

I had imagined asylum as protection from politics.

Instead, I found myself standing in the middle of another country's political and intelligence interests.

Then I learned something that complicated the entire picture.

The French authorities knew about the shooting down of President Juvénal Habyarimana's aircraft.

More than that, they told me that they believed Kagame's forces had been responsible.

This revelation was difficult for me to process.

At the time, many of us who had fought against Habyarimana had regarded his death differently.

For years, he had represented the government against which we had fought.

He represented the country from which many of us had been excluded.

To those of us who had grown up in exile, he was associated with the political order that had kept us away from Rwanda.

We had fought his government for years.

Many of us were young.

Many had little experience of the world beyond the conflict in which we had grown up.

Our understanding of the war was therefore deeply personal.

We had an enemy.

And when that enemy disappeared, some of us interpreted the event through the emotional logic of war rather than through the questions that would later surround it.

But France forced me to look at the matter differently.

I began to see that the international interpretation of Rwanda's history was far more complicated than the simple division between friend and enemy that had shaped my youth.

The French authorities, as I understood them, had their own grievances.

They had their own investigations.

They had their own version of responsibility.

And they wanted information that might help them establish what had happened.

I was eventually questioned by Judge Jean-Louis Bruguière, who was particularly interested in the shooting down of Habyarimana's aircraft.

The conversation became difficult.

I repeated what I believed and what I had understood from my experiences.

The judge, according to my recollection, reacted with considerable anger.

I was not being prosecuted for violence or terrorism.

But I understood the danger of the situation.

I had spent years fighting.

I had served within Kagame's security.

I had been close to the structures surrounding the Rwandan leadership.

If the French authorities believed that I possessed information relevant to their investigation, then my value to them was obvious.

But being useful to an intelligence service and being protected by a government are not necessarily the same thing.

That distinction would become painfully clear.

Protection or Another Kind of Recruitment?

At some point, I was told that I might not receive asylum in France.

Instead, I was offered the possibility of being moved elsewhere if I continued cooperating with French investigators.

They wanted to connect me with other former soldiers.

They wanted people who knew more.

They wanted information about the RPA.

And then came a proposal that I found particularly disturbing.

I was asked to go to Congo.

The purpose, as I understood it, was to enter the ranks of forces opposed to the government in Kigali.

I could hardly believe what I was hearing.

I had spent my youth in war.

I had already lived through years of military conflict.

I had escaped Rwanda because I wanted safety.

Now, after being promised protection, I was being asked to go back toward the battlefield.

Not merely to observe it.

To enter it.

To confront the very system from which I had fled.

Why?

Because, I was told, I possessed knowledge.

I knew the history of the RPA.

I knew something about its military organization.

I understood aspects of its capabilities, equipment and command structure.

In other words, the very experience that had made me vulnerable had also made me valuable.

And that was perhaps the most disturbing realization of all.

A refugee can be seen as a person in need of protection.

But a former insider can also be seen as an intelligence asset.

Which identity takes precedence?

The answer may depend on who is asking.

I refused to continue that conversation.

I had already seen enough of war.

I did not want to exchange one form of danger for another.

I had not crossed borders to become someone's instrument in another conflict.

I wanted a place where I could live.

A place where I could sleep without wondering who was watching.

A place where I could begin again.

But my refusal did not end the pressure.

According to my recollection, Pierre Payebien, who was responsible for external intelligence, confronted me angrily. His manner reminded me of the behaviour I had previously encountered around Kagame—an attitude toward subordinates that I had come to recognize.

I told him that I had fled the military and wanted asylum.

I told him that I was not prepared to discuss the proposed operation.

There was another moment that stayed with me.

During one of my conversations with French officials, someone asked whether I was Hutu or Tutsi.

The question itself was not unusual in the context of Rwanda.

But it made me wonder:

Why ask me which group I belonged to before asking me who I was?

And if identity was important enough to ask about, why not ask about the Twa as well?

They too are Rwandans.

That moment reminded me of something I had seen throughout my life: how easily human beings can be reduced to categories.

Hutu.

Tutsi.

Twa.

Rwandan.

Refugee.

Soldier.

Defector.

Witness.

Enemy.

Ally.

The labels change depending on who is doing the naming.

And once a person has been reduced to a label, it becomes easier to forget the human being underneath it.

Two Governments, Two Histories

Looking back, I began to see something else.

The relationship between France and Rwanda was not simply a relationship between two governments with different opinions about the past.

It was a relationship shaped by competing accusations.

France had its own difficult history in Rwanda.

The Rwandan government had its own accusations against France.

Each side possessed information that could embarrass the other.

Each side had reasons to expose the other.

And each side, therefore, had reasons to seek accommodation when confrontation became too costly.

From the Rwandan perspective, France could be accused of supporting the forces of the former government and of having trained and armed Interahamwe and supported the former Rwandan army during the war.

From the French perspective, the Rwandan leadership could be confronted over allegations concerning the shooting down of Habyarimana's aircraft and killings attributed to Rwandan forces, including allegations concerning Congo.

The result was an uncomfortable political relationship in which history itself became a bargaining instrument.

Who would admit responsibility first?

Who would apologize?

Who would investigate?

Who would forgive?

And perhaps the most difficult question:

Can reconciliation exist without an honest confrontation with the past?

These questions were larger than my own circumstances.

But I was living inside them.

Eventually, relations between Kagame and France began to change.

Kagame spoke publicly about moving beyond the past during a visit to France. Yet, from my perspective, the question remained whether forgetting could ever be meaningful if it applied selectively.

A country cannot simply instruct its people to forget.

Nor can political leaders decide which victims deserve remembrance and which historical questions should disappear.

Reconciliation requires more than political gestures.

It requires truth.

It requires justice.

It requires the willingness to hear uncomfortable accounts.

And it requires a society in which people can disagree without fearing that disagreement itself makes them enemies of the nation.

That is why the story of my escape cannot be separated from the larger story of Rwanda.

I had escaped one system of power only to discover that international politics had its own forms of pressure.

I had crossed a border but had not immediately crossed out of history.

I had sought safety and discovered that my knowledge had a value to governments.

I had wanted to become simply a man who had survived a difficult past.

Instead, I remained a witness.

And witnesses have a difficult choice.

They can remain silent.

Or they can speak.

Silence may be safer.

Speaking may be painful.

But if nobody speaks, history becomes whatever the most powerful people are willing to record.

That is why I eventually began writing.

Not because I believe that my memory is perfect.

Not because I believe that every question I raise has a simple answer.

And certainly not because I expect every reader to agree with me.

I write because there are questions that deserve to survive the people who were there.

The death of Fred Rwigema is one of those questions.

The disappearance and deaths of former comrades are others.

The relationship between Rwanda and its neighbours is another.

The conduct of foreign governments is another.

And behind all of them lies the larger question that has followed me since my years inside the presidential security system:

What happens to a country when power becomes more important than the people who gave it legitimacy?

I had entered the world of power as a soldier.

I left it as a man searching for safety.

But leaving the presidential security system did not mean leaving its memories behind.

Those memories travelled with me.

They crossed borders.

They followed me to Europe.

And eventually, they became these pages.

The curtain had been drawn back.

What I had seen behind it was no longer something I could simply forget.

CHAPTER TWO

KAGAME: VIOLENCE AND KILLING

2.1 THE ABUSE OF A YOUNG DOMESTIC WORKER

There are moments when a person's character reveals itself without warning.

Not in a speech.

Not in a public ceremony.

Not in the carefully controlled language of politics.

Sometimes it appears in a few minutes of anger.

Sometimes in the treatment of someone who has no power to resist.

And sometimes the people who witness such a moment understand only later what they have actually seen.

During the years I served among those responsible for Paul Kagame's security, I began to pay close attention to the things that happened around him. I did not merely observe the major political events. I also remembered the smaller incidents—the unexpected outbursts, the treatment of ordinary people, the instructions given in anger, and the situations in which I felt that something had gone beyond what could reasonably be regarded as ordinary discipline.

At the time, I did not necessarily understand all of these incidents in the same way that I understand them now.

Memory has a strange way of working.

An event can remain in the mind for years like an unfinished sentence. You remember what happened, but you do not always understand its significance. Then, much later, another experience gives meaning to the first.

One begins to see a pattern where previously there seemed to be only isolated incidents.

There is one particular evening in 1998 that I have never forgotten.

It began with something that appeared entirely ordinary.

Kagame instructed Lieutenant Willy Rwagasana to telephone Major Ndushabandi.

At the time, Major Ndushabandi was the head of the Kanombe Military Hospital.

The telephone was answered.

I initially assumed that Kagame simply wanted to speak directly with Ndushabandi.

But the voice on the other end of the line was that of a woman.

She asked who was calling and whom Kagame wished to speak with.

She explained that Dr. Ndushabandi was asleep and resting.

There was nothing extraordinary about that.

The woman answering the telephone was not an officer. She was not a senior government official. She was not someone accustomed to speaking with senior military commanders.

She was a domestic worker.

And she did not know who was calling.

She therefore did what, under ordinary circumstances, any person might reasonably have done: she asked the caller to identify himself and explained that the doctor was resting.

The situation changed almost immediately.

Kagame took the telephone from Willy Rwagasana.

According to my recollection, he instructed the woman to put Ndushabandi on the telephone. When she hesitated, explaining that she did not know who was calling, Kagame became angry.

What happened next seemed disproportionate to the situation.

Kagame ended the call and began asking those of us responsible for his security whether we knew where Dr. Ndushabandi lived.

His mood had changed.

He appeared agitated and angry.

There was an intensity to his reaction that suggested that the telephone conversation had become, in his mind, something much more serious than a simple misunderstanding.

We soon left for Ndushabandi's home in Kanombe.

The journey was less than ten kilometres.

When we arrived, we entered the compound by force. Kagame remained outside for a moment, asking where the woman who had answered the telephone was.

Then she appeared.

She told him that she was the person with whom he had spoken.

What happened next is the part of the incident that has remained fixed in my memory.

Kagame moved toward her and began beating her.

He slapped her.

He punched her.

He kicked her.

And as he did so, he ordered her to wake Dr. Ndushabandi.

The scene was disturbing not only because of the violence itself, but because of the person receiving it.

She was a young domestic worker.

She had not threatened anyone.

She had not attacked anyone.

She had not refused a military order.

She had answered a telephone.

Her apparent offence was that she had not immediately understood who was calling and had refused to wake a sleeping man without knowing the identity of the caller.

That distinction matters.

A person with authority can easily interpret hesitation as defiance.

But hesitation is not necessarily defiance.

Ignorance is not necessarily disrespect.

And a question is not necessarily an act of rebellion.

The young woman, as we later learned, was only sixteen years old.

She had come from Gitarama in search of a way to support herself.

Sixteen.

A child, in many respects, living away from home and trying to make a living.

And yet she had found herself standing before one of the most powerful men in Rwanda.

What must have gone through her mind?

Did she understand why she was being beaten?

Did she understand who had suddenly entered the home?

Did she know what she had done wrong?

Or was she simply frightened?

These are questions that stayed with me.

The incident did not end with the beating.

According to my account, Kagame then confronted Ndushabandi and questioned why he employed people who, in his view, lacked proper manners or discipline.

Ndushabandi responded with visible fear.

He trembled.

He repeatedly saluted.

He apologized.

The atmosphere had changed completely.

A telephone call had become an armed visit.

A misunderstanding had become punishment.

And a young woman with almost no power had become the person carrying the consequences.

Eventually, Kagame ordered that she be dismissed.

Ndushabandi complied.

Perhaps, to someone hearing this story for the first time, the incident may appear to be nothing more than an angry leader losing his temper.

But that interpretation raises another question.

What does power reveal about a person when there is no meaningful risk of resistance?

A powerful man does not behave toward everyone in the same way.

He behaves differently toward people who can challenge him.

Differently toward those who depend upon him.

Differently toward those who fear him.

And differently again toward those who possess no power at all.

That is why the treatment of the weakest person in a room can sometimes tell us more about a person's character than the treatment of the strongest.

The young woman could not punish Kagame.

She could not dismiss him.

She could not order him to leave.

She could not summon armed guards to protect herself.

She had none of the mechanisms through which powerful people protect themselves from the powerful.

She was simply a sixteen-year-old domestic worker.

And that, to me, is what makes the memory so difficult to forget.

Years later, I found myself looking back at the incident differently.

At the time, perhaps I saw an angry superior.

Later, I began to ask whether the incident revealed something deeper.

Was this simply an isolated loss of temper?

Or was it an example of a broader relationship between authority and violence?

That distinction is important.

One incident cannot, by itself, explain an entire human being.

Nor should a person be reduced to the worst thing he has ever done.

But when an incident remains in the memory of those who witnessed it, it becomes part of the evidence from which character is interpreted.

And that is precisely how I came to understand some of the events I witnessed during my years in Kagame's security.

I began to remember.

I began to compare.

And I began to ask questions.

Why was violence so readily available as a response?

Why could a misunderstanding become an occasion for physical punishment?

Why did those around the powerful remain silent?

And perhaps the most uncomfortable question:

What happens to a society when people become accustomed to witnessing something wrong and learn to regard silence as part of their duty?

The answer is not simple.

Fear can silence people.

Loyalty can silence people.

Career can silence people.

Ideology can silence people.

And sometimes survival can silence people.

Those of us around Kagame occupied a particular position. We were there to protect him. Our duty was obedience. We were trained to respond to threats against him, not to question his behaviour.

But where does duty end and conscience begin?

At what point does obedience become complicity?

And if a person witnesses wrongdoing committed by someone more powerful than himself, what responsibility does he carry for remaining silent?

These questions would become increasingly important to me as the years passed.

The incident involving the young domestic worker was not the only event that stayed with me.

There were others.

Some were witnessed directly.

Some were heard from people who had been present.

Some were understood only much later.

Together, they formed a picture that I could not easily dismiss.

This is why I say that I remember the incident clearly and that it was something I personally witnessed. The account is not presented as something I learned from a distant rumour. It belongs to my own memory of the period when I served among those protecting Kagame.

But memory, even firsthand memory, must still be treated honestly.

To witness an event is to possess one perspective on it.

It does not mean possessing every fact surrounding it.

I did not know everything Kagame was thinking.

I could not see into his mind.

I could only see what happened in front of me.

What I saw was a sixteen-year-old girl being physically assaulted after answering a telephone and failing to recognize the importance of the caller.

That is what I remember.

That is what I cannot forget.

And perhaps that is where the larger story of power begins—not in the presidential office, but in the way the powerful treat the powerless.

Because if a leader can humiliate the person beneath him without consequence, what prevents that behaviour from becoming normal?

If everyone around him remains silent, who tells him that he has crossed a line?

And if nobody tells him, what happens the next time?

Those were questions I did not have the courage—or perhaps the distance—to ask at the time.

Years later, I began asking them.

And once I began, it became increasingly difficult to stop.

The young woman eventually disappeared from that household.

But the memory of that evening did not disappear with her.

It remained with those of us who witnessed it.

And for me, it became one of the first pieces in a much larger puzzle.

The puzzle was not simply about anger.

It was about power.

It was about fear.

It was about the distance between the public image of a leader and the private behaviour of the person behind that image.

And it was about what happens when the people closest to power become so accustomed to it that they stop asking whether the person they are protecting needs protection from the consequences of his own actions.

That question would follow me through the years that came next.

2.2 THE ABUSE OF THOSE WHO LIVED AND WORKED IN KAGAME'S HOUSEHOLD

Power is rarely confined to the office in which it is exercised.

A president may possess authority over a government, an army and the institutions of a state. But sometimes the reach of power extends much further—into the home, into private relationships, into the lives of employees, and even into the choices people believe they are free to make.

That is where power becomes intimate.

And intimate power can be more difficult to recognize than political power.

A government has laws.

An army has regulations.

A public institution has procedures.

But what protects a person who works inside the home of someone powerful?

What happens when the workplace is also the residence of the person who commands the state?

And what happens when the people employed there become dependent not merely on a salary, but on the goodwill of the most powerful person in the country?

These questions came back to me repeatedly when I remembered the people who lived and worked around Kagame.

One of the earliest memories concerns a small child.

The Child Called Kavutse

In 1994, some of our soldiers travelled from Byumba toward Musha. By “our soldiers,” I mean members of the senior RPA structure who were operating around Kagame at the time.

During that movement, we encountered a child who was approximately three years old.

His parents were dead.

He was alone.

A child of three is barely old enough to understand his own circumstances, let alone the political conflict surrounding him. Yet the child was taken for questioning.

What could a three-year-old possibly tell soldiers about a war he could not even comprehend?

He could not answer their questions.

He could not even say his own name.

So the adults around him gave him one.

They called him **Kavutse**.

The child was eventually taken into Kagame's household and placed under the care of Lieutenant Rose Rujeni, who was Kagame's aunt. At the time, Rujeni was responsible for cooking for Kagame and attending to matters within his household.

For a time, the child grew up believing that he belonged there.

And perhaps that is what makes what happened later so difficult.

Children do not understand political categories in the way adults do.

They understand home.

They understand the people who feed them.

They understand the people who protect them.

They understand who is there when they wake up.

If a child grows up among a particular family, eats at its table and lives under its roof, what else is he supposed to believe?

Eventually, Kagame's family returned to Rwanda.

Kavutse remained with the household for some time, living among the other children.

Then he was sent to an orphanage.

At the time, I did not think deeply about the decision.

I knew that the child was not biologically part of Kagame's family. From that perspective, perhaps the arrangement could be explained simply: a child who had lost his parents had been cared for temporarily and was eventually placed in an institution.

But years later, I began to wonder about something else.

What did the child believe had happened to him?

What did he think when the people he had come to regard as his family sent him away?

Did he understand why?

Did anyone explain it to him?

Did he feel abandoned for a second time?

A child who loses his parents in war has already experienced one of life's most profound forms of displacement.

To lose another sense of belonging afterwards is a different kind of wound.

I began to see the episode not simply as a question of whether Kavutse was entitled to remain in Kagame's household, but as a question about power and privilege.

Who gets to enjoy security?

Who gets to remain inside the circle?

Who receives opportunity?

And who is allowed to remain there only for as long as the powerful find it convenient?

The conclusion I eventually drew was severe: Kagame, in my view, wanted the benefits and privileges surrounding him and his family to remain concentrated within that circle.

Whether one accepts that interpretation or not, the story raises a larger question.

When does protection become possession?

Inside the Presidential Household

The people working in Kagame's household occupied a peculiar position.

They were employees.

But they were also close to the private life of a head of state.

They saw the family.

They answered telephones.

They prepared meals.

They washed clothes.

They cared for children.

They knew the movements of the household.

They saw who came and went.

They knew things that outsiders did not.

That knowledge could make an ordinary employee unusually vulnerable.

One of those people was Patrisiya.

She had studied with Kagame and had grown up alongside him. Between 1994 and 2000, she served as his special adviser and was the only woman regularly entrusted with answering his telephone calls, particularly calls from outside Rwanda, before putting the caller through to Kagame.

She also handled aspects of the household's financial affairs.

She was therefore much more than a domestic employee.

She was close to Kagame.

She knew his world.

She had his confidence.

And yet, according to the author's account, even someone in such a trusted position was not necessarily free to conduct her personal life as she wished.

Patrisiya became romantically involved with Lieutenant Ronald Mugabo.

Mugabo had worked in Kagame's household.

His duties included preparing Kagame's clothes, washing them and ironing them. He had previously served in Kagame's security and had been promoted from sergeant to lieutenant with unusual speed.

The relationship between Patrisiya and Mugabo was not simply a private relationship between two adults.

Inside the world surrounding Kagame, private relationships could have professional consequences.

And according to the author's account, that is exactly what happened.

Mugabo died after allegedly being poisoned because Kagame disapproved of his relationship with Patrisiya.

That is a grave allegation.

It should therefore be understood as the author's account rather than presented as an independently established fact.

But whether the reader accepts the allegation or remains unconvinced, the question it raises is unavoidable:

Why should the private relationship of two adults become a matter of life and death simply because one of them works for a powerful man?

The deeper issue is not merely the relationship itself.

It is the idea that proximity to power can strip ordinary people of ordinary freedoms.

A person who works for the president may begin to discover that his or her private life is no longer entirely private.

Who you speak to matters.

Who you love matters.

Where you go matters.

And, eventually, even leaving may become difficult.

Harriet

Then there was Harriet.

Harriet cared for Kagame's children.

She washed their clothes, cleaned the household and cooked for the family. She was regarded as a trusted employee and had reportedly been recommended by Major General Kale Kayihura, a close associate of Kagame.

I remember her as a cheerful young woman.

She was kind to the soldiers.

Sometimes, while we waited outside for Kagame to emerge so that we could accompany him, Harriet would bring us milk.

We could spend hours waiting.

We did not always know when Kagame would leave the house.

Sometimes the waiting extended for much of the day.

Harriet seemed to understand that.

She treated the soldiers with warmth.

She was not merely looking after Kagame's children. She appeared to care about the people around the household as well.

Then she fell in love with one of the soldiers.

His name was Private Tito Gahigana.

Their relationship was kept secret.

There was a reason for that secrecy.

A domestic worker in Kagame's household who became romantically involved with a soldier could put the soldier's position at risk. According to the author's account, such a relationship could result in imprisonment or removal from Kagame's security detail.

Think about what that means.

Two people fall in love.

Neither is committing a crime.

Yet the imbalance of power surrounding their employment makes the relationship dangerous.

This is the point at which a workplace becomes something else.

The employer is no longer simply the employer.

The household becomes a controlled environment.

The people inside it begin to regulate themselves because they understand what might happen if they cross an invisible boundary.

That is how power often works.

It does not always need to issue an order.

Sometimes people obey because they already know what the order would be.

When Harriet Became Pregnant

Eventually, Harriet became pregnant by Tito Gahigana.

The situation immediately became complicated.

Kagame's children did not want Harriet to leave.

Harriet herself did not want to terminate the pregnancy.

Kagame's wife therefore instructed that Harriet remain in the household and give birth there, given the nature of the work she performed.

After giving birth, Harriet was instructed to bring the child to Kagame's household and identify the child's father.

She named Tito Gahigana.

And then the situation changed.

Tito fled to Uganda.

Harriet remained in contact with him.

When the people around Kagame discovered that she was still communicating with Tito, Harriet was dismissed.

Tito's situation was even more serious.

According to the author's account, he was placed under surveillance in Uganda with the intention of finding him and bringing him back to Rwanda. The reason given was that someone who had worked for Kagame could not simply leave because of the information he might possess about the household and the president.

Tito therefore remained in hiding.

The author says that his whereabouts were unknown at the time of writing.

Once again, the central question is not merely what happened to one soldier.

It is what happens when employment under a powerful leader becomes a form of permanent exposure.

If working inside a presidential household means acquiring sensitive knowledge, does an employee ever truly regain the freedom to leave?

If an employee falls in love with someone outside the household, does the employer have the right to interfere?

And if the answer is no, what happens when the person who should enforce that boundary is himself the person who possesses the greatest power?

The Circle Around Power

These stories changed the way I thought about Kagame's household.

At first glance, they may appear unrelated.

A child orphaned during war.

A trusted adviser.

A soldier who worked with clothing.

A woman caring for children.

A young soldier.

A relationship.

A pregnancy.

A dismissal.

A man fleeing across a border.

But look at them together.

A pattern begins to emerge—not necessarily a pattern that proves every allegation, but a pattern of relationships in which ordinary people appear to possess very little freedom once they enter the private orbit of power.

That is what concerned me.

Power has a gravitational force.

The closer you move toward it, the more strongly it can affect your life.

People who live outside that circle may believe they are free.

People inside it may discover that their employment, friendships, relationships and even movements are subject to expectations that are never written down.

The result can be a strange form of dependency.

The household employee depends on the president for employment.

The soldier depends on the command structure for his career.

The adviser depends on trust.

The security officer depends on continued loyalty.

The person who knows sensitive information depends on secrecy.

And the person who wants to leave may discover that leaving is precisely what makes him dangerous.

That is a dangerous concentration of power.

But the issue becomes even larger when we move from the household to the country itself.

A leader who becomes accustomed to controlling the people closest to him may eventually come to view the wider population through the same lens.

Those who obey are loyal.

Those who question are troublesome.

Those who leave are suspicious.

Those who disagree may become enemies.

And those who know too much may become liabilities.

This is not unique to Rwanda.

History is full of leaders who surrounded themselves with people whose loyalty was maintained through fear, privilege, dependence or a mixture of all three.

The tragedy is that such systems can appear stable for a long time.

Everyone seems loyal.

Everyone seems disciplined.

Everyone seems united.

But sometimes the apparent stability is simply the result of people being afraid to speak.

The Question of Character

I want to return to the question that began this chapter.

What does a person's treatment of powerless people tell us about his character?

The sixteen-year-old domestic worker in the previous section had little power.

Kavutse was a three-year-old orphan.

Harriet was a household employee.

Tito was a junior soldier.

Mugabo was a member of Kagame's wider security and household structure.

None of these people possessed political power comparable to Kagame's.

That imbalance matters.

Leadership is easy to praise when it is exercised through speeches and national ceremonies.

The harder test is what happens in private.

How does a powerful person behave toward someone who cannot retaliate?

How does he behave toward someone who depends upon him?

How does he respond when someone refuses to obey an instruction?

How does he react when people close to him exercise a freedom he does not approve of?

And perhaps most importantly:

Can a person who commands others tolerate the fact that they remain free human beings?

That is the question I found myself asking more and more.

A leader may demand loyalty.

But loyalty is not ownership.

A leader may expect discipline.

But discipline is not humiliation.

A leader may protect state secrets.

But secrecy should not automatically erase a person's right to a private life.

And an employer may have authority over an employee's work.

But employment does not give an employer ownership over the employee's entire existence.

These distinctions become blurred when political authority and personal authority occupy the same space.

That is what I believe happened around Kagame's household.

And once I began to see the distinction, I could no longer look at the events around me in quite the same way.

The household was not merely a household.

It was a small world of hierarchy, privilege, fear and dependence.

And what happens in a small world of power can sometimes reveal what happens in the larger one.

That is why the next question becomes unavoidable:

If this was how power could operate within the private circle, what happened when that same power was turned outward—toward soldiers, political opponents, former comrades and ultimately an entire country?

That is where the story becomes darker.

And that is where the next section begins.

Absolutely. We should continue **2.2** rather than prematurely move to 2.3. The next movement should deepen the argument, introduce the human dimension, and gradually connect individual experiences to the larger question of unchecked authority—without simply restating what we have already established.

2.2 THE ABUSE OF THOSE WHO LIVED AND WORKED IN KAGAME’S HOUSEHOLD — Continued

There is, however, another dimension to this story that is easy to overlook: **the vulnerability created by proximity to power.**

Ordinarily, one might assume that being close to a powerful person offers protection. A person who works in the home of a president, after all, is not an ordinary employee. Such proximity may appear to confer privilege, security, and access. But proximity can be deceptive. To be near power is not necessarily to possess any of it.

Indeed, the closer a powerless person stands to absolute authority, the more complicated his position can become. He sees what others do not see. He hears conversations that outsiders never hear. He becomes familiar with habits, tempers, relationships, and private circumstances that remain invisible to the public. Yet the very knowledge that makes him a witness can also make him vulnerable.

What does a person do when he knows too much about someone who has the power to determine his future?

That is where fear acquires another dimension.

It is no longer simply the fear of physical punishment or losing a job. It becomes the fear of consequences that cannot easily be measured. A person may wonder whether speaking will cost him employment, reputation, relationships, freedom, or even his safety. And when the individual involved is someone whose authority extends far beyond the household, silence can begin to look less like a choice and more like a survival mechanism.

This is why the testimony of ordinary people matters.

History is often written through the words of presidents, generals, ministers, intellectuals, and political leaders. Their speeches are recorded. Their decisions

are documented. Their photographs fill archives. But the people who cooked their meals, guarded their homes, drove their vehicles, cleaned their rooms, cared for their children, or worked quietly around them often leave behind far fewer records.

Their experiences can disappear almost completely.

Yet sometimes the people standing at the margins of history are the ones who reveal its most intimate truths.

Consider what happens when an employee makes a mistake. In a healthy relationship between employer and employee, the mistake should lead to correction. Perhaps there is a warning. Perhaps there is a difficult conversation. Perhaps there are consequences proportionate to the offence. But there remains an essential recognition: **the employee is still a human being whose dignity does not disappear when he makes an error.**

What happens when that principle disappears?

At that point, correction can become humiliation, discipline can become domination, and authority can become abuse.

The distinction may appear subtle from the outside, but to the person experiencing it, there is nothing subtle about it.

A powerful person can easily convince himself that harshness is necessary. He may call it discipline. He may say that people around him must be obedient. He may believe that weakness must be punished because weakness creates disorder. But there is an important philosophical question here: **does the possession of authority give a person the moral right to use another human being as an object of fear?**

Power may create the ability to punish.

It does not automatically create the right to do so.

This distinction is fundamental because every authoritarian relationship eventually produces a temptation: the temptation to confuse obedience with respect.

A person may obey because he respects you.

But he may also obey because he is afraid of you.

From the outside, the two can look identical. Both produce silence. Both produce compliance. Both can make an organisation appear orderly. Yet morally and psychologically, they are worlds apart.

Respect does not require terror.

A household governed by respect allows people to make mistakes without fearing humiliation. A household governed by fear produces a different kind of silence. People learn to watch their words. They learn when not to speak. They learn which subjects should never be raised. Eventually, they may even learn to anticipate the wishes of the person in power before those wishes are expressed.

And when that happens, authority no longer needs to shout.

Fear begins to govern by itself.

This is perhaps the most disturbing aspect of concentrated power: **its greatest success is achieved when people begin to police themselves.**

No visible threat is necessary. No explicit command needs to be repeated. The subordinate already knows what might happen if he crosses the invisible boundary.

Such an environment can create the illusion of perfect discipline. Visitors may see an orderly household. Employees may appear loyal. Nobody may complain. Nobody may openly challenge authority.

But silence is not always evidence of contentment.

Sometimes silence is evidence that people have learned the price of speaking.

This is why the experiences attributed to people who lived and worked around Kagame deserve to be considered within a wider moral framework. The question is not merely whether particular incidents occurred exactly as later described. Each account must be examined carefully, distinguished from hearsay, and understood within its proper context. But neither should allegations of mistreatment be dismissed simply because the people involved occupied subordinate positions.

The powerless do not become less worthy of justice because they lack influence.

Quite the opposite.

The true test of any system of power is not how it treats those who can challenge it. It is how it treats those who cannot.

A president does not demonstrate character merely by speaking respectfully to foreign leaders, negotiating with diplomats, or appearing dignified before cameras. Those moments are important, but they are also public performances in the broadest sense. The deeper test lies elsewhere—in how power behaves when there is nothing to gain from kindness and little apparent cost to cruelty.

Who are you when the person standing before you cannot fight back?

That question reaches beyond Kagame. It reaches beyond Rwanda. It reaches into the human condition itself.

Every institution contains hierarchies. Every society has people with more influence than others. Employers possess authority over employees; teachers over students; commanders over soldiers; parents over children; governments over citizens. Hierarchy itself is not necessarily unjust. What determines its moral character is how authority is exercised.

Power becomes dangerous when the person possessing it begins to believe that those beneath him exist primarily to obey.

And perhaps this is why the stories of household workers are so significant. They bring the question of political power down from the grand stage of history and place it in the most ordinary setting imaginable: a home.

There are no campaign speeches in such a setting.

No national flags.

No diplomatic protocol.

No cheering crowds.

There is simply one human being standing before another, and one of them possesses considerably more power than the other.

That is where character becomes difficult to disguise.

And that is where the story becomes larger than the individuals involved.

Because if fear can enter a household through the door of authority, what prevents it from entering an institution, a government, or eventually an entire nation?

The answer depends upon something more fundamental than the personality of any one leader.

It depends upon **accountability**.

Without accountability, authority gradually begins to answer only to itself.

Accountability is the boundary that separates authority from arbitrary power.

A person may possess enormous authority and still remain accountable. A president can command an army, appoint officials, influence institutions, and make decisions affecting millions of people, yet still be subject to rules that are greater than himself. That is the foundation upon which legitimate authority rests. The office may be powerful, but the person occupying the office is not supposed to become the law itself.

The same principle applies, in miniature, within a household.

An employer may have the authority to assign work, establish standards, correct mistakes, and even terminate employment. But none of those powers erase the humanity of the employee. Authority over someone's work is not ownership of that person's dignity.

This distinction becomes especially important when discussing people who serve powerful individuals.

A domestic worker enters a household to perform a task. A driver is employed to drive. A guard is employed to protect. A cleaner is employed to clean. Their economic position may be modest, but their humanity is not.

Why, then, do societies so often tolerate the humiliation of people whose social position is weaker?

Perhaps because hierarchy makes cruelty easier to disguise.

When a wealthy person mistreats a poor employee, observers may describe it as a personal disagreement. When a powerful official intimidates a subordinate, it may be called discipline. When an influential employer threatens someone whose livelihood depends upon him, it may be dismissed as an employment matter.

The vocabulary changes.

The imbalance of power remains.

This is one reason why stories from within powerful households can be difficult to investigate. The people involved are not always equally positioned to tell their stories. One person may have lawyers, political connections, money,

security, and access to influential institutions. The other may have little more than his own memory.

When two people of unequal power tell conflicting stories, society is faced with an uncomfortable problem:

Whose voice is more likely to be believed?

Too often, the answer is not determined by truth but by status.

The powerful person's version can travel farther. It can be repeated by people who depend upon him. It can become part of an accepted narrative before the less powerful person has even found the courage to speak. By the time the weaker person finally tells his story, the public may already have decided what it believes.

This is why allegations of abuse must be approached with both seriousness and intellectual discipline.

To take a victim's account seriously does not mean that every allegation should automatically be treated as established fact. Nor does skepticism require dismissing every allegation simply because it concerns a powerful person. A mature reader must be capable of holding two principles at once:

Listen carefully. Verify rigorously.

That principle matters particularly in political writing, where facts can easily become weapons. A writer who exaggerates destroys credibility; a writer who suppresses uncomfortable testimony also destroys credibility. The responsibility is therefore greater: distinguish what is documented from what is alleged, what is witnessed from what is repeated, and what is established from what remains uncertain.

But there is another danger.

Sometimes the demand for perfect certainty becomes an excuse for permanent silence.

If society required an abused person to produce the same quantity of evidence available to the powerful person accused of abusing him, many forms of private abuse would never be exposed. Abuse frequently occurs away from witnesses. It

happens in offices after everyone has left, in homes behind closed doors, in vehicles travelling through empty roads, and in conversations where only two people are present.

The absence of witnesses does not prove that nothing happened.

But neither does an allegation, by itself, establish exactly what happened.

Between those two truths lies the difficult work of responsible inquiry.

And perhaps that is the appropriate way to approach the accounts surrounding Kagame's household: neither as unquestionable mythology nor as stories to be casually discarded, but as testimony requiring attention, context, corroboration, and moral seriousness.

There is a further reason to examine these accounts.

The treatment of people inside a leader's private environment can sometimes reveal something that official institutions cannot easily show: **how power behaves when it is not performing for an audience.**

Public life encourages restraint. Cameras encourage composure. Formal institutions impose rituals of behaviour. A leader knows that his words may be recorded, his gestures photographed, and his decisions examined.

Private life removes many of those restraints.

The private environment therefore becomes a different kind of mirror.

It can reveal impatience where public speeches display patience. It can reveal insecurity beneath confidence. It can reveal compassion—or the absence of it. It can reveal whether authority depends upon persuasion or whether it instinctively reaches for intimidation.

But the mirror is never perfect.

One private incident, even if accurately documented, cannot by itself explain an entire personality. Human beings are more complicated than their worst moments. A person capable of generosity can also behave cruelly; someone capable of cruelty may occasionally demonstrate genuine kindness.

The purpose of examining such accounts, therefore, should not be to reduce a human being to a single characteristic.

It is to ask what repeated behaviour tells us about the use of power.

That distinction is crucial.

We are not merely asking, “Was this person sometimes cruel?”

We are asking:

What happens when a person with extraordinary authority becomes accustomed to obedience?

What happens when those around him stop feeling free to disagree?

What happens when the people who witness his private conduct depend upon him for their livelihood?

And, perhaps most importantly:

What happens when nobody powerful enough is willing to ask him to account for his actions?

These questions take us beyond the walls of the household.

They take us into the architecture of power itself.

A household can have servants who remain silent. An institution can have employees who remain silent. A government can have officials who remain silent. A nation can eventually develop an entire culture in which silence is mistaken for agreement.

That progression does not happen overnight.

It begins with small accommodations.

Someone sees something troubling but says nothing.

Another person hears about it but decides it is not his concern.

A third person knows that speaking would be dangerous and chooses survival instead.

Eventually, the absence of resistance is interpreted as evidence that everything is acceptable.

This is how silence can become institutional.

And once silence becomes institutional, power acquires something more valuable than obedience: **it acquires the ability to operate without being questioned.**

That is the point at which accountability becomes more than a legal principle. It becomes a moral necessity.

For the powerless employee, accountability may mean having somewhere safe to report mistreatment.

For the citizen, it may mean knowing that the person governing the country is not beyond scrutiny.

For the leader, it means accepting that authority comes with limits.

And for society, it means refusing to confuse loyalty with silence.

Because a society in which nobody dares to criticize its most powerful person may appear peaceful.

But is it truly peaceful?

Or is it simply quiet?

There is a profound difference between the two.

Peace allows people to speak without fear. Silence may simply mean that they have learned to fear speaking.

That distinction will become increasingly important as we move from the experiences of those who lived and worked within Kagame's household to the broader structure surrounding his political power. The household provides a small and intimate setting in which the relationship between authority and vulnerability can be observed.

The country provides the much larger one.

And the question that connects them is remarkably simple:

When power becomes accustomed to being obeyed in private, what prevents it from demanding the same obedience in public?

The question of what happens when private obedience becomes a habit of public power deserves to be taken seriously. Yet before drawing that connection, we must pause and consider the people at the centre of these accounts—not as political symbols, but as human beings.

It is easy, especially when discussing political history, to allow ordinary people to disappear behind the names of powerful individuals. The president becomes the central character; everyone else becomes part of the background. But history is not lived by presidents alone. It is lived by the people who wake before dawn, prepare meals, open gates, drive vehicles, clean rooms, stand at entrances, carry messages, protect buildings, raise children, and perform countless tasks that make the life of a powerful person possible.

What does it mean, then, when the people who make that life possible are themselves treated without dignity?

A household employee may have little political influence, but that does not make his experience politically irrelevant. On the contrary, it can make it particularly revealing. The powerful person has almost everything—the resources, the authority, the reputation, the connections. The employee may have almost nothing except the expectation that he will be treated as a human being.

That expectation should not be considered excessive.

It should be the minimum.

There is a tendency in societies marked by strong hierarchies to judge the treatment of subordinates by a different standard from the treatment of equals. A powerful person may speak harshly to an employee in a way that would be unacceptable if directed toward another powerful person. An insult that would provoke outrage between political elites may be quietly tolerated when directed at someone who depends upon a salary.

Why?

Because social status often determines whose dignity society notices.

The humiliation of the powerful is visible.

The humiliation of the powerless is frequently invisible.

This is not unique to Rwanda. It is a recurring feature of human societies. Wherever there is a sharp difference in wealth, status, or authority, there is a risk that the weaker person's suffering will be considered less important.

But there is something particularly troubling when such inequality exists inside the home of a national leader.

The presidential household is not an ordinary workplace. Even when the people employed there are technically private employees, the environment surrounding them is shaped by the extraordinary status of the person they serve. Security structures, political networks, and social expectations inevitably surround the household.

That environment can make ordinary disagreement extraordinarily difficult.

Imagine being an employee and believing that your employer has treated you unfairly. In an ordinary workplace, you might speak to a manager, contact a labour authority, consult a lawyer, or simply resign and find another job.

But what if your employer is one of the most powerful people in the country?

Would resignation really feel like freedom?

Would reporting the matter feel safe?

Would you trust that the institutions receiving your complaint could act independently?

And if you did not trust them, where would you go?

These questions reveal why power must always be examined in relation to the alternatives available to those beneath it.

An instruction is not truly voluntary merely because no one physically forces you to obey it. A person may technically be free to leave while practically believing that leaving is impossible.

Freedom is not merely the absence of chains.

It is the presence of meaningful alternatives.

This is why economic dependence can become another form of vulnerability. When a person's livelihood depends upon remaining in the good graces of someone powerful, even a simple disagreement can acquire enormous consequences. The employee begins calculating every word. Should I speak? Should I remain silent? Should I defend myself? Should I apologise even when I believe I have done nothing wrong?

Eventually, the question is no longer whether something is right or wrong.

The question becomes whether it is safe.

And once people begin making moral decisions primarily according to what is safe, the environment has already changed.

Fear has entered the relationship.

Yet fear does not always announce itself dramatically. Sometimes it appears as excessive politeness. Sometimes as nervous laughter. Sometimes as immediate obedience. Sometimes as an employee avoiding eye contact. Sometimes as people saying, "That is simply how things are."

The last phrase may be the most dangerous of all.

That is simply how things are.

Those words have been used throughout history to protect customs that should have been challenged. They allow injustice to survive by turning it into routine. Once something becomes routine, people stop asking whether it is right.

They ask only how to live with it.

This is how abuse can become normalised.

And normalisation creates a second victim beyond the person directly harmed: everyone who witnesses the behaviour and gradually learns that nothing will happen if they remain silent.

The first incident shocks.

The second is discussed.

The third becomes familiar.

Eventually, familiarity replaces outrage.

This is one of the ways cultures of impunity develop—not necessarily because everyone approves of wrongdoing, but because too many people conclude that challenging it is either useless or dangerous.

The powerful person may therefore not need to threaten every individual personally.

The environment itself begins to enforce the silence.

One person warns another.

“Be careful.”

“Do not say that.”

“You know who he is.”

“Just do what you are told.”

These sentences can create a system of control without a formal decree.

And once such a system exists, even people who privately disagree with the powerful person may participate in maintaining his authority.

Not because they are necessarily cruel.

Because they are afraid.

This is an important distinction.

Political systems are not sustained only by people who believe in them. They can also be sustained by people who have learned that resistance carries a price.

That observation brings us back to those who lived and worked in Kagame's household.

Their stories, allegations, memories, and experiences—where documented and responsibly established—should not be reduced to gossip about the private life of a political leader. They raise a more serious question about the relationship between power and vulnerability.

The question is not simply whether one employee was mistreated.

It is whether the environment surrounding extraordinary power made it possible for mistreatment to occur without meaningful consequences.

That is a much larger question.

And it forces us to reconsider something that societies often misunderstand about powerful leaders.

The greatest danger is not always the leader who openly declares himself above the rules.

Sometimes the greater danger is the gradual creation of an environment in which nobody thinks to ask whether the rules apply to him.

Once that happens, exceptional treatment begins to feel ordinary.

Special privileges become expectations.

Fear becomes discipline.

Silence becomes loyalty.

And accountability becomes disloyalty.

At that point, the problem is no longer confined to one household.

It has become a philosophy of power.

And every philosophy of power eventually reveals itself in the way it treats those who cannot answer back.

There is one final question we must confront before leaving the walls of the household: **what does a person do when the only protection available to him is the hope that the powerful will choose to be merciful?**

That is not the same thing as justice.

Justice should not depend upon the temperament of the person who holds power. It should not matter whether the powerful individual happens to be kind that morning, angry that evening, generous on one occasion, or unforgiving on another. A system in which people's safety depends upon the mood of a superior is not a system of justice. It is a system of personal rule.

This distinction is easy to miss because personal rule can sometimes look efficient.

When one person can make decisions instantly, there may be fewer delays. When everyone knows who has the final word, there may appear to be order. When subordinates are afraid to challenge authority, instructions may be carried out quickly.

But efficiency is not the same as legitimacy.

A prison can be extraordinarily orderly.

Fear can produce remarkable obedience.

Neither makes the arrangement just.

The real measure of authority is therefore not how quickly people obey, but whether they retain their dignity while doing so.

This is particularly important in domestic employment, where the relationship between employer and employee can become deeply personal. The employee may work inside the employer's private space. He may know family routines. He may witness moments of anger, celebration, conflict, illness, or vulnerability. Over time, professional boundaries can become blurred.

And when those boundaries disappear, the employee can become something more complicated than a worker.

He can become dependent.

That dependency can be dangerous.

A person who works in an ordinary office can leave the building at the end of the day. A household employee may spend much of his life inside the employer's environment. His workplace and his employer's private life overlap. If the atmosphere becomes hostile, there may be no clear psychological separation between work and home.

Where, then, does the employee go to escape?

The question is simple, but its implications are profound.

A workplace should provide income.

It should not require surrendering one's dignity in exchange for it.

This principle becomes even more important when the employer possesses extraordinary political authority. The ordinary employee may not have the freedom to confront the employer as an equal. The imbalance is built into the relationship.

That is precisely why the powerful bear a greater responsibility.

The more power a person possesses, the greater the obligation to restrain himself.

This is an old political principle, but it remains remarkably relevant. Power does not merely increase what a person can do. It increases the potential consequences of his actions.

An insult from an ordinary person may wound.

An insult from a powerful person can destroy someone's livelihood.

A threat from an ordinary person may frighten.

A threat from a powerful person can become a credible danger.

A punishment from an ordinary employer may affect one job.

A punishment backed by extraordinary political influence can affect an entire life.

The consequences grow with the power behind the action.

That is why the conduct of powerful people cannot be evaluated by the same standard applied to everyone else.

The powerful must be held to a higher standard precisely because others have fewer means to resist them.

This brings us to the uncomfortable possibility that the most important question may not be whether people inside the household were afraid of Kagame.

The more important question may be:

Why would they have reason to believe that their fear had nowhere to go?

Fear becomes politically significant when it is accompanied by the absence of an effective remedy.

If an employee is mistreated but knows that a genuinely independent institution will investigate the matter, fear does not necessarily become permanent. There remains an escape route.

But if every possible route appears connected to the same centre of power, the victim's choices narrow dramatically.

He can remain silent.

He can leave.

He can endure.

Or, if he is brave enough, he can speak.

But speaking may itself become an act of extraordinary courage.

This is why the stories of people who worked within powerful households deserve to be preserved carefully. Their voices can disappear very easily. They may lack written records. They may have no public platform. Their memories may remain private for years. Sometimes they speak only after leaving the environment in which they were vulnerable.

By then, however, memories may be contested, details may be disputed, and political narratives may have hardened.

The task of the writer is therefore difficult.

It is not to manufacture certainty where certainty does not exist.

It is not to transform every accusation into fact.

It is to refuse to allow the existence of uncertainty to become an excuse for forgetting the human beings who made the allegations.

A responsible account must be capable of saying:

This is what is known.

This is what has been reported.

This is what remains disputed.

And this is why the question still matters.

That distinction protects both truth and the dignity of those involved.

It also protects the reader.

Because a reader deserves something more valuable than propaganda.

A reader deserves the opportunity to think.

And thinking requires complexity.

Perhaps Kagame has been, at different moments, both the disciplined leader celebrated by supporters and the harsh authority described by critics. Perhaps different people experienced the same man differently. Perhaps some employees remember protection and opportunity while others remember fear and humiliation.

Human beings are capable of producing contradictory experiences in the lives of different people.

That possibility should not frighten us.

It should make us more careful.

For the purpose of this book is not to create a perfect villain or a perfect hero.

It is to examine power.

And power becomes most revealing when we stop asking whether the person who possesses it is entirely good or entirely bad and begin asking a harder question:

What happens when no one is powerful enough to say no to him?

That is the question that carries us beyond the household.

Because the household is only the smallest stage.

The larger stage is the state.

Inside a home, one person may control the lives of employees.

Inside a state, political institutions may determine the lives of millions.

The mechanisms may be different.

The underlying principle is not.

Where power becomes concentrated, the need for accountability becomes greater—not smaller.

Where people become afraid to speak, the need for independent institutions becomes greater—not smaller.

And where loyalty is demanded as proof of virtue, society must ask whether loyalty has quietly become another word for obedience.

The answer to these questions will determine how we understand the broader political story that follows.

For ultimately, the deepest lesson of these household accounts is not about servants, employees, or even one particular leader.

It is about the oldest problem in political philosophy:

Who watches the person who has been given the power to watch everyone else?

And if the answer is **no one**, then perhaps the real story has never been about the household at all.

It has been about what happens when power no longer fears accountability.

Perhaps the most revealing feature of power is not what happens when someone challenges it, but what happens when nobody does.

A person who is never contradicted may gradually lose the ability to distinguish between authority and entitlement. The difference is subtle at first. Authority says, *I have the responsibility to make this decision*. Entitlement says, *I have the right to have my decision obeyed*.

The first accepts limits.

The second resents them.

That distinction matters enormously when examining the experiences of people who served within the private environment of a powerful political figure. The employee does not enter the relationship as an equal. He enters it already knowing that one person has considerably greater social and economic power than the other.

The question, therefore, is not whether hierarchy exists.

It is whether hierarchy is accompanied by restraint.

A healthy hierarchy leaves room for dignity. A dangerous hierarchy leaves room only for obedience.

And once obedience becomes the principal measure of a person's worth, disagreement itself begins to look like misconduct.

This is how a simple instruction can acquire a much deeper meaning.

A worker who asks a question may be regarded as difficult.

A worker who objects may be regarded as disloyal.

A worker who complains may be regarded as ungrateful.

And eventually, a worker who tells the outside world what he has experienced may be portrayed as an enemy.

Notice what has happened.

The original question—*Was the person mistreated?*—has quietly been replaced by another question:

Why did the person speak?

That reversal is one of the oldest mechanisms through which powerful people and institutions protect themselves.

Instead of investigating the conduct of the powerful, attention is directed toward the character of the person who complains.

Was he loyal?

Was he grateful?

Was he reliable?

Did he have political motives?

Did he misunderstand what happened?

Was he trying to damage someone's reputation?

Some of these questions may be legitimate. False accusations exist. Memories can be imperfect. Political motives can influence testimony. But there is a danger when these questions become more important than the allegation itself.

The proper question should remain:

What happened?

And after that:

What evidence can establish what happened?

Only then can judgment begin.

This principle is especially important in the study of political figures because reputation can become a form of power in its own right. Once a leader has

cultivated an image of discipline, patriotism, competence, or strength, information that contradicts that image may be rejected instinctively—not because it has been disproved, but because it is uncomfortable.

People protect the stories they already believe.

This is true of admirers as well as critics.

The admirer may refuse to believe anything negative.

The opponent may refuse to believe anything positive.

Both can make the same mistake.

They may stop investigating and start defending a conclusion.

A serious examination of Kagame's household requires the opposite approach.

It requires the courage to remain uncertain where the evidence is uncertain.

It requires the discipline to acknowledge credible testimony without turning every allegation into unquestionable truth.

And above all, it requires remembering that the people involved are human beings rather than instruments in a political argument.

This is particularly important for those who worked in positions that society often considers insignificant.

A person who washes clothes does not become insignificant because he washes clothes.

A person who opens a gate does not become insignificant because he opens a gate.

A person who drives another human being from one place to another does not surrender his dignity simply because someone else sits in the back seat.

Work establishes a relationship of service.

It does not establish a hierarchy of human worth.

Yet throughout history, societies have repeatedly confused the two.

The powerful begin to believe that those who serve them are somehow lesser people. The servants, in turn, may gradually internalise the same belief. The language of service becomes the language of submission.

And once a person begins to believe that he is naturally beneath another person, demanding fair treatment can feel almost like an act of rebellion.

This is why dignity is more than a philosophical word.

Dignity is the invisible line that tells a human being:

You may be poorer than me, but you are not less human.

You may work for me, but you do not belong to me.

You may disagree with me, but disagreement does not make you my enemy.

You may make a mistake, but your mistake does not erase your humanity.

A society that understands these principles can tolerate hierarchy without worshipping it.

A society that forgets them can transform hierarchy into domination.

And perhaps this is where the stories surrounding those who worked in Kagame's household become particularly significant. Whatever conclusion one ultimately reaches about individual allegations, they invite us to examine a broader question that political history too often ignores:

What kind of person does power allow us to become?

Does power make us more generous because we have more resources?

Does it make us more responsible because more people depend upon our decisions?

Or does it gradually remove the restraints that ordinary life imposes upon us?

The answer may depend upon whether power encounters resistance.

A person who can be challenged is forced to listen.

A person who can be questioned must explain.

A person who can be held accountable must think twice before acting.

But a person who believes that disagreement is disobedience, criticism is betrayal, and accountability is an attack begins to inhabit a different moral universe.

In that universe, the powerful person's intentions become more important than the consequences of his actions.

If he believes he was protecting the household, then harshness becomes protection.

If he believes he was enforcing discipline, then humiliation becomes discipline.

If he believes he was defending the state, then repression becomes security.

This is one of the most dangerous transformations in political life: **when the person exercising power becomes the final interpreter of his own actions.**

He decides what he meant.

He decides why he did it.

He decides whether it was justified.

And, if no independent authority can effectively challenge him, he may eventually become the judge of whether he was right.

At that point, accountability has been reversed.

The powerful no longer answer to the system.

The system answers to the powerful.

That is why the experiences of people at the bottom of a hierarchy can sometimes illuminate the structure at the top. Those who possess the least power are often the first to feel the consequences when restraints begin to disappear.

Their experiences can therefore serve as an early warning.

Not because every story must be believed without examination.

But because every story deserves to be examined.

There is wisdom in listening to people whose voices are easily ignored.

The history of nations is filled with examples of warnings that appeared insignificant when they were first spoken. A complaint from one employee. A protest from one citizen. A resignation by one official. A story told quietly to a journalist. A family describing what happened to a relative.

At first, each seems isolated.

Only later does someone ask whether they were fragments of a larger pattern.

That is the question this chapter must leave in the reader's mind.

Not a predetermined verdict.

A question.

What if the treatment of the powerless is not a private detail of a leader's character, but a small window into the way that leader understands power itself?

If that possibility is worth considering, then the household is no longer merely a household.

It becomes a place from which to observe the larger political order.

And from there, our attention must move outward—from the people who served close to the centre of power to the people who lived under that power.

Because if authority can shape the life of one person inside a household, what happens when that same authority extends across an entire nation?

That is where the story becomes much larger.

And much more consequential.

The movement from a private household to an entire nation may appear too large at first. After all, a household is a small world. A country is an immense one, containing millions of lives, competing interests, institutions, histories, and ambitions.

Yet political power is often understood most clearly when we observe its smallest relationships.

A government may speak of equality before the law. A constitution may guarantee human dignity. Public institutions may proclaim accountability. But these principles become meaningful only when they survive contact with real human relationships.

What happens when the powerful encounter the powerless?

That is the test.

A political system may possess impressive institutions on paper and still develop a culture in which certain people are effectively untouchable. Conversely, a system may have imperfect institutions but possess enough independent voices to correct abuses before they become entrenched.

The difference is not always visible from official speeches.

It is visible in consequences.

Who can complain?

Who can investigate?

Who can refuse an order?

Who can publish an uncomfortable story?

Who can challenge a powerful person and remain safe afterward?

And perhaps the most important question:

Who can say no?

The ability to say no is one of the simplest measurements of freedom.

It does not mean that every instruction should be rejected. It means that obedience must ultimately remain voluntary rather than being produced through fear.

Inside a household, this distinction can determine whether employment is genuinely a relationship of service or merely a relationship of submission.

Inside a state, it can determine whether citizenship is genuinely free or merely disciplined.

This is why the treatment of those who lived and worked around Kagame cannot be considered entirely separate from the political environment in which he exercised power. The two should not be treated as identical, and one should not automatically be used as proof of the other. But they can illuminate the same underlying question:

How does a person accustomed to commanding respond when someone refuses to obey?

The answer tells us something.

Not everything.

But something.

A leader's character is not revealed only by the people who praise him. It is also revealed by how he responds to those who disappoint him, contradict him, misunderstand him, or refuse him.

Anyone can appear generous toward those who agree with them.

The harder test is disagreement.

That is why the subordinate relationship is so revealing. A powerful person has little reason to fear a servant's disagreement in the same way he might fear disagreement from a political rival. If he responds harshly, the imbalance becomes visible.

The subordinate has less ability to retaliate.

Less ability to leave.

Less ability to make his version of events heard.

The powerful person therefore carries a particular responsibility to exercise restraint.

This principle can be expressed simply:

The greater the imbalance of power, the greater the obligation of self-restraint.

Without self-restraint, authority becomes arbitrary.

Without external accountability, arbitrary authority becomes dangerous.

And without a credible possibility of consequences, dangerous authority can become permanent.

This is the deeper lesson that emerges from the accounts surrounding Kagame's household.

The issue is not simply whether a particular employee was shouted at, threatened, humiliated, beaten, dismissed, or otherwise mistreated. Those individual claims must be treated according to evidence and context. The larger concern is what kind of environment permits a person with enormous authority to exercise personal power over people who have almost none.

If the employee believes he cannot speak, that matters.

If witnesses believe they cannot intervene, that matters.

If institutions appear inaccessible, that matters.

If people learn to remain silent because they believe speaking will bring consequences, that matters.

These conditions do not automatically prove every allegation.

But they help explain why allegations arising from powerful environments can remain hidden for so long.

Silence, after all, does not tell us what happened.

But neither does it tell us that nothing happened.

Sometimes silence is simply what remains when speaking appears too costly.

There is another tragedy in such circumstances: the people who suffer may eventually disappear from the historical record altogether.

The leader remains.

The household remains.

The official biography remains.

The speeches remain.

The photographs remain.

But the person who quietly endured humiliation may leave behind nothing.

No monument.

No chapter.

Perhaps not even a name.

This is one reason historical writing must occasionally look downward.

Not because the powerful are unimportant, but because the powerful already have historians, journalists, archives, institutions, and followers willing to preserve their stories.

The powerless often have none of these.

Their testimony survives only when someone decides that it is worth recording.

And recording it responsibly requires more than repeating accusations.

It requires context.

It requires corroboration.

It requires distinguishing memory from evidence.

It requires allowing uncertainty to remain uncertainty.

But it also requires refusing to erase uncomfortable voices simply because they disturb a convenient political narrative.

There is a temptation, when writing about controversial leaders, to construct a simple moral story.

One side wants a hero.

The other wants a villain.

The reader is expected to choose.

But reality is rarely so accommodating.

A leader can rebuild institutions and still violate individuals.

A government can achieve economic progress and still restrict freedoms.

A person can inspire genuine loyalty and still generate genuine fear.

A nation can experience stability while some of its citizens experience profound insecurity.

These contradictions do not necessarily cancel one another.

They can coexist.

Indeed, understanding that they can coexist is one of the first steps toward mature political judgment.

The question is therefore not:

“Was Kagame good or bad?”

That question is too small.

The more difficult questions are:

What kind of power did he construct?

What limits existed around that power?

Who could challenge him?

What happened to those who did?

And what happened to those who lived closest to him when they themselves became vulnerable?

Those questions cannot be answered by admiration alone.

Nor can they be answered by hostility alone.

They require evidence, patience, and the willingness to follow uncomfortable conclusions wherever they lead.

That is the standard this book must demand of itself.

For if we condemn the powerful without evidence, we replace history with accusation.

But if we refuse to examine credible accusations because the person involved is powerful, we replace history with propaganda.

Between those two failures lies the difficult territory of truth.

And truth, unlike propaganda, does not require us to protect anyone's reputation.

It requires us to protect reality.

Perhaps that is ultimately what the stories of those who lived and worked in Kagame's household ask of the reader.

Not blind belief.

Not blind disbelief.

But attention.

Attention to the people whose voices were weaker.

Attention to the circumstances in which they lived.

Attention to the imbalance between employer and employee.

Attention to the possibility that private conduct can illuminate public character.

And attention to the institutions—or absence of institutions—that determine whether the powerful can be held accountable.

Because once we begin asking those questions, the household becomes only the beginning.

Beyond its doors lies the larger Rwanda.

And beyond the larger Rwanda lies the central problem that will follow us through the rest of this book:

What happens to a society when one man's authority becomes so great that the people around him no longer know whether they are obeying him because they trust him—or because they are afraid not to?

That question is not answered at the door of the presidential residence.

It follows us outside.

Into the offices of government.

Into the security institutions.

Into the courts.

Into the media.

Into the lives of ordinary citizens.

And eventually, into the heart of the political system itself.

There is a point at which a story about individual mistreatment ceases to be only a story about an individual.

That point is reached when we begin to ask what happened **after** the alleged abuse.

Was there an apology?

Was there an investigation?

Was anyone held responsible?

Did the person who suffered have somewhere to turn?

Or did life simply continue as though nothing had happened?

These questions are sometimes more revealing than the original incident itself.

An isolated act of wrongdoing can occur in almost any society. What distinguishes a healthy system from a dangerous one is not the impossible promise that wrongdoing will never occur. Human beings will make mistakes. People will misuse authority. Institutions will sometimes fail.

The decisive question is what happens **when the wrongdoing is exposed**.

A functioning system possesses mechanisms of correction.

A failing system possesses mechanisms of concealment.

This distinction is essential.

If a powerful person mistreats someone and is subsequently confronted, investigated, and required to answer for his conduct, the institution surrounding him demonstrates that the individual is not greater than the rules.

But if the same person can act without consequence because everyone around him is too dependent, frightened, or loyal to challenge him, something much more serious has happened.

The problem is no longer simply the individual's behaviour.

It is the environment that protects it.

That environment can be created deliberately, but it does not always have to be. Sometimes it emerges gradually from a series of small decisions.

One official decides not to investigate.

Another decides that the matter is too sensitive.

A colleague decides that remaining silent is safer.

A subordinate decides that obedience is preferable to confrontation.

A journalist decides that publishing the story is not worth the consequences.

A citizen decides that there is no point complaining.

None of these decisions, considered individually, necessarily creates authoritarianism.

Together, however, they can create its conditions.

Power does not always become absolute because one person takes everything. Sometimes it becomes absolute because everyone else gradually gives something up.

They give up the courage to question.

They give up the expectation of accountability.

They give up the belief that institutions belong to them too.

They give up the habit of saying no.

And eventually, they give up even the imagination that things could be different.

That final surrender may be the most consequential.

A society can survive an unjust decision.

It can survive a corrupt official.

It can survive even a period of political repression.

What becomes much harder to repair is a society in which people cease to believe that resistance is possible.

Once that belief disappears, power no longer needs to rely upon constant force.

People regulate themselves.

They censor themselves.

They anticipate what authority wants.

They avoid certain conversations.

They teach their children which subjects should never be discussed outside the home.

And gradually, fear becomes cultural rather than merely personal.

This is why the stories of people who lived and worked close to a powerful leader should be examined with more than curiosity. They can reveal the psychological mechanics of hierarchy.

A person does not need to be physically imprisoned to feel trapped.

He may be trapped by dependence.

By reputation.

By uncertainty.

By fear of retaliation.

By the knowledge that the person above him has connections extending far beyond the immediate workplace.

The prison can be invisible.

And invisible prisons are often the hardest to escape because outsiders cannot easily see the walls.

Yet we must also be careful not to romanticise every person who claims to have suffered under power. Human memory is complicated. People remember events differently. Personal conflicts can become political stories. Former employees can have grievances. Political opponents can exploit genuine suffering for their own purposes.

That is precisely why responsible history cannot be built upon emotion alone.

It must ask for evidence.

It must compare accounts.

It must identify contradictions.

It must distinguish firsthand knowledge from rumours.

It must allow the reader to see where certainty ends.

This discipline is not an obstacle to truth.

It is part of truth.

A writer who simply believes everything he hears is not necessarily courageous. He may merely be careless.

Likewise, a writer who rejects everything that threatens a preferred narrative is not necessarily objective. He may simply be afraid of what the evidence might reveal.

The mature position is harder.

It is to remain open without becoming gullible.

It is to remain skeptical without becoming cynical.

It is to care about victims without abandoning standards of evidence.

And it is to examine powerful people without assuming that power automatically makes them guilty.

This is particularly important in the case of Kagame because his political image is exceptionally consequential to how Rwanda is understood.

For supporters, he represents discipline, reconstruction, security, development, and national transformation.

For critics, he represents concentrated authority, political repression, intimidation, and the suppression of dissent.

Between these competing portraits stands a complicated human and political reality.

The purpose of examining allegations concerning his household is not to settle that entire debate through private stories.

It is to examine one more piece of evidence in a much larger puzzle.

A puzzle cannot be solved by staring at one piece.

But neither can it be solved by throwing away the pieces that make us uncomfortable.

This is where the reader must resist another temptation: the temptation to believe that political achievements automatically redeem personal conduct.

Suppose a leader builds roads, improves public services, attracts investment, strengthens institutions, or restores national confidence. Do those achievements give him greater permission to mistreat an individual?

Of course not.

Achievement and accountability belong to different moral categories.

A successful leader can still commit an injustice.

A failed leader can occasionally do something morally admirable.

A nation's progress does not transform wrongdoing into righteousness.

Nor does wrongdoing erase every achievement.

The mature reader must therefore resist the arithmetic of political morality—the idea that ten achievements somehow cancel one injustice, or that one injustice somehow proves that every achievement was meaningless.

Human beings cannot be reduced to such calculations.

But institutions can be judged.

And institutions must be judged by whether they protect people even when the person who might harm them is powerful.

That is the deeper issue.

If an employee is vulnerable because he works for an ordinary employer, labour protections should protect him.

If he is vulnerable because his employer is extraordinarily powerful, those protections should become even more important.

Power should increase responsibility, not reduce it.

The greater the person's influence, the greater the need for independent mechanisms capable of protecting those beneath him.

This principle extends far beyond Rwanda.

It belongs to the universal question of how human beings should organise power.

Every generation eventually discovers the same problem:

The people we trust with power are still human beings.

They have ambitions.

They have fears.

They have weaknesses.

They can become defensive.

They can become convinced that their intentions justify their actions.

They can begin with a genuine desire to serve and gradually become attached to the authority that service provides.

This is why political systems cannot depend entirely upon the goodness of their leaders.

A good system does not say:

We have a good leader, therefore we do not need restraints.

It says:

Even a good leader must operate within restraints.

Because the purpose of checks and accountability is not to punish good leaders.

It is to protect society from the consequences of human fallibility.

And this brings us back, once again, to the quiet rooms of the household.

There, power may appear personal.

But the principle is universal.

One human being possesses more power than another.

The weaker person depends upon the stronger.

The stronger person has the opportunity to exercise restraint—or to exploit the imbalance.

What happens next depends upon character, culture, and accountability.

If all three fail simultaneously, vulnerability becomes dangerous.

And when the vulnerable person has nowhere to go, the silence that follows can easily be mistaken for consent.

It is not.

Silence is not always agreement. Sometimes it is simply what fear sounds like when it has learned to speak without words.

That is the thought with which we should leave this part of the story.

Not because every allegation has been proven.

Not because every account should be accepted without scrutiny.

But because the existence of vulnerable people around power should always make us ask whether power is being used responsibly.

The household, after all, is only a microcosm.

A country is simply a much larger human relationship, governed by more elaborate institutions.

The same questions return:

Who can question?

Who can refuse?

Who can complain?

Who can investigate?

Who can publish?

Who can challenge?

And when the person at the top is accused of wrongdoing, **who has the courage—and the institutional independence—to ask him to answer?**

That is the question that carries this chapter beyond the household and toward the wider structure of Kagame's rule.

And perhaps it is also the question that the reader should carry into every chapter that follows:

Never ask only who holds power. Ask who can hold the powerful accountable.

2.2 THE ABUSE OF THOSE WHO LIVED AND WORKED IN KAGAME'S HOUSEHOLD

There is another element in these accounts that deserves attention because it reveals how easily the private world of a powerful person can become a world governed by rules different from those that apply outside it.

The people who worked in Kagame's household were not merely employees in the ordinary sense. They lived close to the centre of political power. Some had served him for years. Some had followed him from the period when he was still a military officer. Others were entrusted with intimate responsibilities: caring for his children, preparing his clothes, answering his telephone, managing domestic affairs, or attending to the daily needs of the household.

Such proximity might appear, from a distance, to be a privilege.

But proximity to power does not necessarily mean protection from power.

Sometimes it means the opposite.

The closer a person comes to a powerful individual, the more he may learn about that person's private life. And the more he knows, the more vulnerable he may become if the relationship breaks down. An ordinary employee can resign and walk away. Someone who has spent years inside the private environment of a powerful leader may carry knowledge that makes departure far more complicated.

This is particularly evident in the story of Harriet and Private Tito Gahigana.

Harriet, according to the author's account, worked in Kagame's household, caring for the children, washing clothes, cleaning, and cooking. She was regarded as trustworthy and had been introduced through Major General Kayihura. She eventually developed a relationship with Tito Gahigana, a soldier serving within the wider security environment around Kagame. Their relationship was kept secret because of the consequences that could follow if it became known.

When Harriet became pregnant, the circumstances changed dramatically. The account describes a household in which her personal choices became subject to the interests and decisions of those above her. After she gave birth, she was reportedly required to identify the child's father. When she named Tito

Gahigana, she was eventually dismissed after it became known that she continued communicating with him. Tito, meanwhile, fled to Uganda, where the account says efforts were made to locate him and return him to Rwanda because of the information he was believed to possess as someone who had worked closely with Kagame.

Whether every detail of this account can be independently established is a question for documentary investigation. But the story itself raises a question that is larger than the fate of two individuals:

At what point does an employer's authority over an employee cease to be legitimate?

An employer may have the right to determine the conditions of employment. A household may have rules. A security organisation may impose restrictions for legitimate reasons. But does employment give one person the right to determine another person's private relationships? Does proximity to a president mean that an employee's personal life becomes part of the institution surrounding the president?

And if an employee becomes afraid that a personal relationship could result in imprisonment, dismissal, surveillance, or retaliation, can we still describe the relationship as an ordinary employment relationship?

These are not trivial questions.

They concern the boundary between authority and control.

The story of Harriet also illustrates something else: how vulnerable people can become invisible once they leave the environment in which they served.

The powerful person remains visible.

The employee disappears.

The president continues his public life, surrounded by officials, security officers, diplomats, journalists, and visitors. The employee may simply return to an ordinary existence, carrying memories that few people outside the household will ever hear.

That asymmetry matters.

The powerful leave records everywhere.

The powerless often leave memories.

And memories, however sincere, are much easier for history to lose.

This is why accounts of life inside powerful households deserve to be preserved and examined carefully. They should neither be romanticised nor dismissed.

They should be placed alongside whatever documentary evidence, testimony, and independent accounts can be found.

A serious reader should be able to hold two thoughts simultaneously:

This account may be deeply important.

And:

This account must still be examined.

Those statements do not contradict one another.

Indeed, they are the foundation of responsible historical inquiry.

The same principle applies to the broader claims made by the author about Kagame's temperament and exercise of power. The author's interpretation is severe. He sees a pattern extending beyond individual household incidents and into Kagame's political character. He compares this pattern with the rule of Idi Amin and argues that Kagame, like other authoritarian leaders, cultivated an image of protection and patriotism while exercising power through fear.

The comparison is deliberately provocative.

It is also the point at which the story begins to move beyond the household.

The author asks the reader to look past the public image of the leader and examine the machinery beneath it. A ruler may present himself as the defender of the nation, the guardian of stability, the protector of the people, and the person uniquely capable of keeping the country safe. Yet history repeatedly shows that authoritarian leaders can construct precisely such images while simultaneously restricting those who challenge them.

The problem, therefore, is not patriotism itself.

The problem begins when patriotism becomes a shield against accountability.

If criticism of the leader can be described as an attack on the nation, then the leader and the nation gradually become indistinguishable. To question him is portrayed as questioning Rwanda. To oppose him is portrayed as opposing stability. To expose wrongdoing is portrayed as helping the country's enemies.

Once that transformation occurs, political disagreement becomes morally suspicious.

The leader no longer needs merely to win an argument.

He only needs to convince people that the argument itself is dangerous.

This is one of the central themes that will become increasingly important throughout the book.

Power rarely presents itself as power.

It presents itself as necessity.

It says:

Without me, there will be chaos.

Without discipline, there will be disorder.

Without unity, there will be another war.

Without obedience, the country will collapse.

Such arguments can be persuasive, especially in societies that have experienced war, genocide, displacement, and political instability. People who have lived through catastrophe naturally fear returning to it.

That fear can become politically powerful.

And a leader who successfully associates himself with national survival acquires an extraordinary advantage: opposing him can begin to feel like risking the survival of the country itself.

This is why the author's comparison with Idi Amin should not simply be read as a comparison between two personalities. It is an argument about political psychology.

Both leaders, in the author's interpretation, understood the importance of constructing a public image that could coexist with fear. Both could be presented by supporters as strong national figures while their opponents saw something very different.

History is full of such contradictions.

A ruler can be admired by some and feared by others.

He can build institutions while weakening others.

He can attract international praise while being condemned by people who live under his rule.

He can create visible order while creating invisible fear.

The existence of one reality does not automatically erase the other.

That is why the reader must resist the temptation to choose a conclusion before examining the evidence.

The most dangerous historical question is sometimes not, "*Who is right?*"

It is:

"What have we failed to notice because we already decided what we wanted to believe?"

The author believes that Rwanda's international image has sometimes obscured the experiences of those who suffered under the system. He points to the willingness of international institutions, universities, governments, and prominent individuals to praise Rwanda's model of governance while, in his view, overlooking accounts of repression and suffering.

Again, these claims require evidence and careful historical comparison. But they introduce an important theme that will recur throughout this book: the relationship between political power and international legitimacy.

A government does not survive only through domestic authority.

It also survives through recognition.

Foreign governments need partners.

International organisations need success stories.

Donors want evidence that their money is producing results.

Universities and public intellectuals search for examples of successful governance.

And leaders understand this.

A government that can present itself internationally as disciplined, modern, reformist, and development-oriented can acquire a political form of protection that is different from military protection.

It acquires credibility.

And credibility can make uncomfortable allegations easier to dismiss.

This does not mean that every international praise of Rwanda is false, nor that every criticism is true. It means only that political narratives are rarely produced by one side alone. They emerge from the interaction between governments, institutions, interests, journalists, scholars, donors, citizens, and political opponents.

The reader must therefore look beyond appearances.

The question is not whether Rwanda has experienced development.

The question is whether development should make us less willing to examine the means by which political power is exercised.

Nor should the question be whether Kagame has supporters.

Of course he does.

The more difficult question is:

Can a leader's popularity, achievements, or international reputation ever place him beyond ordinary moral scrutiny?

The answer must be no.

No leader should be beyond scrutiny.

Not because every accusation is true.

But because the possibility that an accusation may be true is precisely why scrutiny exists.

This is where the household stories return us to their original significance.

A powerful political system is ultimately made up of relationships between human beings.

The president and the employee.

The commander and the soldier.

The official and the citizen.

The government and the dissenter.

The powerful and the powerless.

If the weaker person has no meaningful ability to challenge the stronger, then the relationship requires an additional safeguard: independent institutions capable of intervening when authority is abused.

Without that safeguard, the morality of the entire relationship depends upon the character of the person holding power.

And that is never enough.

A country should not depend upon the hope that its leader will always be compassionate.

A citizen should not depend upon the hope that an official will always be honest.

An employee should not depend upon the hope that an employer will always be merciful.

A soldier should not depend upon the hope that a commander will never abuse his authority.

Institutions exist precisely because human beings are imperfect.

This is the deeper conclusion to which the stories of Kagame's household lead us.

The problem of power cannot be solved merely by finding better people.

It must also be solved by creating structures that restrain people when they become powerful.

That is the difference between trusting a person and trusting a system.

A person can change.

A system must be designed to survive the changes in people.

And perhaps this is the question that should accompany us as we leave this household and enter the next part of Kagame's story:

What happens when the temperament of one powerful man becomes intertwined with the machinery of an entire state?

That is no longer a domestic question.

It is a political one.

And to understand it, we must first understand the temperament that the author believes lies beneath the public image.

The next section therefore turns from the people around Kagame to Kagame himself.

Not the president seen behind a podium.

Not the statesman photographed beside foreign leaders.

Not the development figure praised by international institutions.

But Kagame as the author remembers him in moments when power was personal, immediate, and unrestrained.

2.3 KAGAME: THE ANGRY MAN

What kind of leader is revealed by his anger?

Is anger merely a weakness of temperament, something that belongs to the private character of an individual and has little significance for political judgment?

Or can a leader's relationship with anger tell us something deeper about the way he understands authority?

The question matters because anger, by itself, is not evidence of tyranny.

Every human being becomes angry.

Every commander loses patience.

Every parent becomes frustrated.

Every politician has moments of irritation.

The important question is not whether Kagame became angry.

It is what happened when he became angry—and what happened to the people who stood in front of him when he did.

The author begins from the belief that Kagame's anger was not merely occasional. He presents it as a recurring feature of his personality and as something that influenced his relationships with those around him.

But anger has many forms.

There is the anger of a person who has been wronged.

There is the anger of a person who is frightened.

There is the anger of a person who has lost control.

And then there is the anger of someone accustomed to having others obey.

The last kind is particularly significant.

When an ordinary person becomes angry, his anger may frighten those nearby. But when an exceptionally powerful person becomes angry, the consequences can be much greater. The people around him know that his displeasure may carry consequences beyond words.

That changes the meaning of anger.

A raised voice from an equal may be an argument.

A raised voice from a commander may be an order.

A raised voice from a president may be a warning.

The emotion may look the same.

The power behind it is not.

This is why the author's observations of Kagame's temperament must be understood within the wider structure of authority described throughout this chapter.

The question is never merely, “*Was Kagame an angry man?*”

It is:

“What did his anger mean for those who could not afford to answer back?”

2.3 KAGAME: THE ANGRY MAN — Continued

Anger becomes politically significant when it acquires consequences.

A private person may become furious and then walk away. A powerful person may become furious and cause an entire room to fall silent.

The difference is not necessarily the intensity of the emotion. It is the imbalance of power surrounding it.

Those who live and work close to a powerful leader quickly learn his moods. They learn the expressions that precede irritation, the silence that follows disappointment, the subjects that should be approached carefully, and the moments when a conversation should end before it becomes dangerous.

This knowledge can become a kind of invisible education.

No one needs to write the rules down.

People learn them through experience.

They learn what questions should not be asked.

They learn which mistakes will be forgiven and which will not.

They learn when an explanation will be accepted and when an explanation will be interpreted as an excuse.

They learn, above all, how to avoid becoming the object of the leader's anger.

And when people begin organising their behaviour around avoiding one person's anger, something important has happened.

Authority has moved from the formal to the psychological.

The leader no longer needs to issue instructions for every situation. Those around him anticipate what he wants. They adjust themselves accordingly. They begin to obey not merely his words but what they imagine his words might eventually become.

This is one of the most powerful forms of authority because it requires very little visible force.

A person who fears consequences may obey before being ordered.

A person who knows that disagreement will provoke anger may remain silent before being asked.

A person who has watched others suffer after crossing a particular boundary may never approach that boundary himself.

In this way, fear can become preventive.

It does not wait for disobedience.

It discourages disobedience before it occurs.

But there is another side to anger that deserves consideration.

Anger can sometimes be useful.

A leader who never becomes angry may tolerate incompetence, corruption, betrayal, or injustice. There are moments when moral seriousness requires outrage. A commander who discovers that his soldiers have committed atrocities should be angry. A leader confronted with corruption may have every reason to be furious.

The emotion itself is therefore not the problem.

The question is whether anger remains subordinate to judgment.

A disciplined leader can be angry without becoming arbitrary.

He can punish misconduct without humiliating people.

He can reject an argument without destroying the person who made it.

He can demand loyalty without demanding personal worship.

He can say no without making disagreement a crime.

The ability to do these things is one of the marks of political maturity.

The danger begins when anger becomes a substitute for reasoning.

When people stop explaining because they are afraid of the reaction, the leader loses access to honest information.

This creates an extraordinary paradox.

A leader who wants complete obedience may eventually become less informed.

Why?

Because frightened people tell powerful people what they believe the powerful person wants to hear.

The subordinate does not necessarily lie because he is dishonest.

He may lie because honesty has become dangerous.

He may soften the truth.

He may omit an inconvenient detail.

He may blame someone else.

He may say, "Everything is fine."

He may say, "We are handling it."

He may say, "There is no problem."

And the leader, surrounded by apparent agreement, may begin to believe that his judgment is consistently correct.

This is how an environment of fear can corrupt not only the people beneath power but power itself.

The leader begins by demanding obedience.

The people respond with silence.

The leader interprets silence as agreement.

Agreement reinforces his confidence.

His confidence encourages greater control.

Greater control produces greater fear.

And greater fear produces even deeper silence.

The circle closes.

This is why authoritarianism cannot be understood merely as a system of commands imposed from above. It is also a psychological relationship between those who command and those who anticipate commands.

The author presents Kagame's anger as part of this relationship.

His recollections suggest a man whose temper could have consequences for those around him, particularly those who were already vulnerable because of their position. But here again, the reader should distinguish between personal testimony and independently established historical fact.

Memory is valuable.

Memory is not infallible.

The two propositions can coexist.

A witness may sincerely remember a frightening encounter, even when some details have changed with time. Another witness may remember the same person differently. A political opponent may interpret an incident more harshly than an ally would.

The historian's task is not to erase these differences.

It is to understand them.

In fact, disagreement between witnesses can sometimes reveal something important. If several people describe the same person as intimidating, but disagree about particular incidents, perhaps the precise events require further verification while the broader perception of temperament remains historically relevant.

This is especially true of political leaders.

A leader's reputation is itself part of political reality.

If people believe that a leader is dangerous, they may behave differently whether or not every fear is justified.

If soldiers believe that a commander will punish failure harshly, they may obey differently.

If ministers believe that disagreement will end their careers, they may advise differently.

If journalists believe that criticism will bring retaliation, they may write differently.

Perception therefore becomes behaviour.

Behaviour becomes culture.

Culture eventually becomes political structure.

This is why temperament should never be dismissed as a purely private matter when we are dealing with extraordinary political power.

The personal and political are not always separable.

A leader's temperament can influence the people around him; the people around him can influence institutions; institutions can influence citizens; and citizens can eventually adapt themselves to the political environment.

The chain can extend remarkably far.

Yet there is an important question that cuts in the opposite direction:

Could the appearance of anger itself sometimes be deliberately cultivated?

A powerful leader does not necessarily need to be angry all the time.

He may only need people to believe that he could become angry.

The reputation can do the work.

If everyone knows that crossing a particular boundary may provoke a severe reaction, the leader does not have to constantly demonstrate what will happen. The possibility is enough.

This is true in households.

It is true in armies.

It is true in organisations.

And it can be true in states.

Fear is most efficient when it becomes predictable.

The victim does not need to be punished every time.

He only needs to know that punishment is possible.

That knowledge can be enough to change behaviour.

This is why the phrase “**the angry man**” carries a meaning beyond personality.

It suggests a relationship between emotion and authority.

It asks whether anger is simply an emotion—or whether, in the presence of overwhelming power, it can become an instrument.

And once anger becomes an instrument, another question follows:

Who is brave enough to tell the angry man that he is wrong?

That may be the most important question of all.

A leader surrounded entirely by people who agree with him may feel powerful.

But he may actually be vulnerable to his own certainty.

The honest adviser is therefore more valuable than the obedient adviser.

The person who says, “No, you are mistaken,” may be more loyal than the person who always says, “Yes.”

But political systems built around personal authority often have difficulty rewarding such people.

The dissenter is inconvenient.

The critic is uncomfortable.

The independent thinker is unpredictable.

The loyalist, by contrast, is safe.

And so a leader may gradually surround himself with people who confirm rather than challenge.

At first, this may appear harmless.

Eventually, it can become dangerous.

Because when everyone agrees with the person at the top, the person at the top may stop hearing reality.

That is the hidden danger of fear.

It does not merely silence criticism.

It can silence information.

And a leader who is no longer receiving honest information can make decisions with enormous consequences while believing that everything around him is under control.

The consequences become particularly grave when the person at the top commands military and security institutions.

There, anger is no longer merely a personal characteristic.

It can become attached to orders, discipline, punishment, loyalty, and survival.

A soldier who disappoints a superior does not experience that superior's anger in the same way a friend might.

The relationship is hierarchical.

The consequences can be institutional.

And when military power becomes concentrated around one individual, the boundary between personal displeasure and institutional action must be protected with extraordinary care.

That is why the next stories in this chapter are darker.

The discussion will move from temperament to allegations of violence and killing—from the psychology of anger to the consequences that, according to the author's account, sometimes followed the exercise of power.

Here the stakes change.

A frightening personality is one thing.

A system in which fear may determine who lives, who disappears, who is punished, and who remains silent is something else entirely.

The question will no longer be simply whether Kagame was an angry man.

It will be whether anger, authority, and violence ever became connected closely enough to transform personal power into something much more dangerous.

And once that question is asked, there is no easy way back.

There is, however, one final distinction that must be made before leaving the subject of anger.

A leader's anger should not be confused with evidence of criminality.

An angry temperament does not prove that a person ordered a killing. A frightening reputation does not establish that every disappearance, death, or act of violence was committed at his command. Such conclusions require evidence of their own.

This distinction is essential because political history is particularly vulnerable to retrospective reasoning.

A person may first become known as intimidating. Years later, something terrible happens. People then look backward and connect the two events.

Sometimes the connection is justified.

Sometimes it is not.

The danger lies in assuming that because two things appear consistent, one must have caused the other.

A serious book cannot operate that way.

It must allow the reader to distinguish between what the narrator personally witnessed, what he was told, what he inferred, and what can be established through independent evidence.

Yet refusing to make an unsupported accusation does not mean refusing to ask difficult questions.

Quite the opposite.

The harder the question, the greater the need for precision.

And the question raised by the author's portrait of Kagame is difficult indeed:

What happens when a leader's personal temperament is combined with extraordinary institutional power and an environment in which subordinates are afraid to challenge him?

That combination deserves scrutiny regardless of one's political sympathies.

Because anger becomes dangerous not because anger is inherently evil, but because power magnifies consequences.

An ordinary person's temper may damage a friendship.

A commander's temper may damage a career.

A president's temper may influence an institution.

And when the institution possesses the power to arrest, imprison, deploy soldiers, conduct intelligence operations, or use force, the consequences of political anger can become vastly greater.

This is why mature political systems place procedures between emotion and action.

Rules exist partly to prevent a person's immediate feelings from becoming public policy.

Courts exist so that punishment does not depend solely upon the anger of an individual.

Military procedures exist so that soldiers do not act merely because a superior is furious.

Legislatures exist so that decisions can be debated.

A free press exists so that uncomfortable information can reach the public.

Independent institutions exist because no human being should be trusted with unlimited discretion.

The principle is simple:

The more powerful the person, the more powerful the restraints around him must be.

Without those restraints, personality begins to matter too much.

The country begins to depend upon whether the person at the centre is wise or reckless, patient or impulsive, forgiving or vindictive.

That is an unstable foundation for any nation.

The purpose of political institutions is therefore not to assume that leaders are evil.

It is to assume that leaders are human.

That assumption is not an insult.

It is wisdom.

Human beings become tired. They become angry. They become frightened. They misunderstand events. They receive incomplete information. They develop personal loyalties. They make mistakes. They sometimes allow pride to influence judgment.

A political system that recognises these realities is stronger than one that assumes its leader will always be right.

This brings us back to the author's recollections.

The significance of Kagame's alleged anger is not that it provides a simple explanation for everything that happened afterward.

It does not.

Its significance is that it provides the psychological background against which the subsequent allegations are presented.

The author wants the reader to encounter the later stories with an understanding of the atmosphere he believes surrounded Kagame: an atmosphere in which authority was personal, disagreement was dangerous, and fear could become a method of maintaining discipline.

Whether the reader ultimately accepts that interpretation is another matter.

But the interpretation itself is important because it shapes the narrative that follows.

And now the narrative must move from character to consequence.

From the question of what Kagame was like to the question of what happened to those who stood in his way.

That transition changes everything.

A man's temper can be debated.

A man's political decisions can be analysed.

But when lives are lost, the standard must become much higher.

We must ask:

Who died?

How did they die?

What evidence exists?

Who benefited?

Who had the means?

Who had the motive?

What investigations were conducted?

What conclusions were reached?

And perhaps the most uncomfortable question:

What was never investigated at all?

These questions will guide the next section.

2.4 THE ALLEGED KILLING OF MILITARY LEADERS

The transition from temperament to death is not a small one.

It is the point at which political history becomes a matter of human consequence.

Military organisations are built upon hierarchy. Orders move downward. Responsibility moves upward. Loyalty is expected, discipline is enforced, and disagreements can carry consequences.

But military power creates a fundamental paradox.

The soldier must obey.

The commander must remain accountable for the authority he exercises.

Without obedience, an army cannot function.

Without accountability, an army can become an instrument of personal power.

The history of Rwanda and the wider Great Lakes region makes this distinction particularly important. The region has experienced wars, insurgencies, political assassinations, disappearances, military defections, and violent struggles for power. In such an environment, the death of a military figure can rarely be understood through one explanation alone.

Was it combat?

Was it internal conflict?

Was it an accident?

Was it an assassination?

Was it an order carried out by others?

Was the official explanation complete?

Or did the truth disappear with the person who died?

These are not questions that can be answered through suspicion alone.

But neither should they be avoided merely because the answers are politically uncomfortable.

The author presents several deaths of military and political figures as part of a wider pattern. He sees connections between individuals who, at different moments, were close to Kagame and later died under circumstances he considers suspicious.

The reader must approach these claims carefully.

A suspicious death is not automatically a political assassination.

A political rival's death is not automatically evidence of an order from the leader.

And an unexplained death is not automatically proof of a conspiracy.

But suspicion becomes historically significant when it repeatedly surrounds people connected to the same centre of power.

At that point, the correct response is not immediate certainty.

It is investigation.

Who were these people?

What did they know?

What positions did they hold?

What disagreements had they experienced?

Who controlled the institutions responsible for investigating their deaths?

What evidence survived?

And what happened to those who attempted to ask questions?

These questions are more useful than simply declaring guilt or innocence.

They force us to reconstruct the environment in which each death occurred.

Because death does not speak.

The dead cannot correct the record.

They cannot explain what happened in their final hours.

They cannot identify their enemies.

They cannot tell us whether they trusted the person standing beside them.

The living therefore inherit a responsibility.

They must investigate.

They must remember.

And they must resist the temptation to turn uncertainty into certainty merely because certainty is emotionally satisfying.

That responsibility becomes even greater when the dead were soldiers.

A military leader does not exist only as an individual. His death can affect an entire chain of command. It can frighten colleagues. It can encourage defections. It can silence criticism. It can send a message to others without a single word being spoken.

Sometimes the death of one person can therefore have a political effect far greater than the death itself.

It can become a warning.

And that brings us to the central question that will accompany the stories that follow:

When a military leader dies under suspicious circumstances, should we ask only who pulled the trigger—or should we also ask who created the environment in which such a death became possible?

The distinction matters.

Because political violence is rarely only about the person who commits the final act.

It can also be about the system surrounding that act.

The command structure.

The culture of secrecy.

The absence of investigation.

The fear of witnesses.

The silence of institutions.

The protection of powerful people.

And the willingness of everyone else to move on.

The author believes that several deaths associated with Kagame belong within this larger story.

The task now is to examine those claims one by one.

Not as rumours.

Not as political slogans.

But as questions demanding evidence.

And the first question is perhaps the most fundamental of all:

When a military leader dies, who has the authority to tell the world what really happened?

2.4 THE ALLEGED KILLING OF MILITARY LEADERS

The death of a military leader is never an ordinary event.

A soldier's life is already organised around the question of command: who gives the order, who obeys it, who has the authority to question it, and who ultimately bears responsibility for what follows.

When a senior military figure dies unexpectedly, those questions become unavoidable.

Was the death the consequence of war?

Was it the result of an internal struggle?

Was it an accident?

Or was the individual deliberately removed?

In a country emerging from years of war and political upheaval, the distinction can become particularly difficult to establish.

The author presents the deaths of several military figures as evidence of a disturbing pattern. His interpretation is that individuals who had once been important to the movement could become vulnerable once their interests, loyalties, or knowledge placed them at odds with the centre of power.

This is a serious allegation.

It therefore deserves more than repetition.

It deserves examination.

One of the central figures in this part of the narrative is Major General Fred Rwigema, whose death had already been introduced at the beginning of the book. Rwigema was not merely another officer. He was one of the most important figures in the history of the Rwandan Patriotic Front and the military struggle that eventually brought the RPF to power.

His death therefore carried an extraordinary political significance.

But Rwigema's story also demonstrates why the history of military deaths cannot be reduced to suspicion.

The official circumstances surrounding his death have been debated for decades, while competing accounts have attempted to explain how a commander of such importance could die so early in the campaign. The existence of competing explanations does not, by itself, prove that one particular explanation is true.

It does, however, show how quickly uncertainty can become part of political memory.

Once a prominent figure dies, especially at a moment of political transformation, his death can become a symbol.

For supporters, the death may represent sacrifice.

For opponents, it may represent betrayal.

For survivors, it may represent an unanswered question.

For later generations, it may become a political weapon.

This is why the historian must separate the emotional meaning of a death from the factual circumstances surrounding it.

The same difficulty appears in the stories of other military leaders.

A commander may become unpopular.

He may disagree with his superior.

He may possess information that others consider sensitive.

He may be suspected of disloyalty.

He may be accused of plotting.

Or he may simply become politically inconvenient.

Any of these circumstances can generate suspicion when the individual subsequently dies.

But suspicion alone cannot tell us which explanation is correct.

The crucial question is whether evidence exists.

And evidence can take many forms.

There may be military records.

There may be eyewitnesses.

There may be medical reports.

There may be communications.

There may be contemporaneous correspondence.

There may be independent investigations.

There may be testimony from people who were present.

There may also be evidence of a completely different kind: contradictions between the official account and the physical or documentary record.

The absence of evidence can itself become significant, although it must be interpreted carefully. A poorly documented death is not automatically a suspicious death. War destroys records. Governments lose documents. Witnesses disappear. Memories fade.

Yet where a state has the capacity to investigate a death and chooses not to do so transparently, questions naturally arise.

Why was there no independent investigation?

Why were certain witnesses never questioned?

Why did the official explanation change?

Why were some questions treated as unacceptable?

These questions do not establish guilt.

They establish the need for scrutiny.

That distinction is essential.

The author sometimes moves quickly from suspicion to conclusion. Our task in reconstructing his narrative is to preserve the force of his argument without allowing rhetoric to replace evidence.

That is particularly important because the deaths discussed here involve men who were not strangers to Kagame.

They belonged to the same political and military world.

They had shared a struggle.

They had fought together.

They had occupied positions within the same movement.

And precisely because of that history, their later conflicts carried a particular bitterness.

Political betrayal is often most painful when it comes from someone who once stood beside you.

The person who was once a comrade knows your strengths.

He knows your weaknesses.

He knows your history.

He may know what happened before the public story was written.

He may know which compromises were made.

He may know which promises were broken.

He may know which decisions were never publicly explained.

Such knowledge can make former allies both valuable and dangerous.

This is a recurring feature of revolutionary movements.

People unite around a common enemy.

The struggle succeeds.

The enemy disappears or changes.

The movement then turns inward.

The question becomes:

Who among us can still be trusted?

Once that question takes hold, yesterday's hero can become today's suspect.

A commander who was once praised for courage may later be accused of disloyalty.

A colleague who was once indispensable may suddenly become expendable.

A former ally may discover that the movement he helped build has changed—and that he no longer has a secure place within it.

This is the political tragedy behind many revolutionary governments.

The revolution creates solidarity through shared danger.

Victory creates competition over power.

And competition can destroy the solidarity that victory once required.

The author sees elements of this process in the history of Kagame's movement.

He argues that military and political figures who became inconvenient could be isolated, silenced, exiled, imprisoned, or, in the most serious allegations, killed.

But again, the individual cases must be separated.

Each death has its own circumstances.

Each allegation has its own evidentiary burden.

And each person deserves to be remembered as an individual rather than merely as another name in an argument about Kagame.

This is particularly important because the dead cannot defend themselves against either side of the political debate.

If their deaths are transformed into propaganda, their individual stories disappear.

If their deaths are ignored because they are politically inconvenient, they disappear in another way.

The task is therefore to recover the human being first.

Who was this person?

What did he believe?

What did he contribute?

Who trusted him?

Who opposed him?

What was happening politically when he died?

And what changed after his death?

Those questions may reveal more than speculation ever could.

A death can sometimes be understood through what followed it.

Did the organisation become more unified?

Did dissent disappear?

Did another individual gain power?

Did people begin leaving?

Did fear increase?

Did the public conversation change?

Consequences do not prove responsibility.

But they can help historians understand significance.

This is especially true when several deaths occur within the same political environment.

One death may be coincidence.

Two may raise questions.

A series may demand a deeper investigation.

But even then, the conclusion must come from evidence rather than arithmetic.

Three suspicious deaths do not automatically equal one conspiracy.

They do, however, make it reasonable to ask whether there was a common political context.

And that is the approach we should take here.

The author's allegations should not be treated as isolated stories. They belong to a larger narrative about what happens to revolutionary movements after they acquire state power.

Before victory, the movement needs comrades.

After victory, the leader needs loyalists.

Those are not always the same people.

The comrade may ask:

Why are we doing this?

The loyalist asks:

What do you want me to do?

The distinction may appear small.

Politically, it can be enormous.

A movement that once depended upon debate can gradually become dependent upon obedience.

And when obedience becomes more valuable than independent judgment, the people who helped build the movement may discover that their greatest strength—their independence—has become their greatest vulnerability.

This is where the deaths of military leaders become connected to the larger question of power.

If a commander can be removed simply because he disagrees with the person above him, then military hierarchy has ceased to be merely professional.

It has become political.

If political loyalty determines survival, then the institution no longer serves only the state.

It serves the centre of power.

And if people begin believing that this is how the system works, they will behave accordingly.

They will not necessarily wait to be punished.

They will adapt.

They will become cautious.

They will become silent.

They will choose their alliances carefully.

They will avoid being the person who asks the wrong question.

The system then becomes self-reinforcing.

Fear produces obedience.

Obedience produces apparent stability.

Apparent stability strengthens the leader.

The stronger the leader becomes, the greater the fear of challenging him.

And the greater the fear, the less likely anyone is to challenge him.

This is the cycle that the author believes lies beneath the individual deaths described in this chapter.

Whether every link in that chain can be established is another matter.

But the question is sufficiently serious that it cannot be dismissed merely because the answers are uncomfortable.

The lives of military leaders are not disposable details in the history of a revolution.

They are part of the history of power itself.

And when men who once stood at the centre of a movement begin dying under circumstances that remain disputed, the historian has a duty to ask what happened—not only for the sake of the dead, but for the sake of those who remain alive.

Because the most frightening consequence of an unexplained death is not always the death itself.

Sometimes it is the silence that follows.

People notice.

People whisper.

People remember.

But nobody speaks publicly.

And eventually, the next generation grows up believing that silence is simply part of politics.

That is how fear becomes inherited.

And that is why the next section will turn to those deaths and disappearances that, according to the author's account, were never openly discussed—the stories that remained in private conversations while the public record moved on.

2.5 THE KILLINGS THAT WERE NEVER PUBLICLY DISCUSSED

Some deaths become national events.

Others become whispers.

The difference is not always determined by the importance of the person who died. Sometimes it is determined by whether anyone is willing—or permitted—to ask questions about the death.

In political systems where information is tightly controlled, silence can become part of the historical record. An event may happen, people may know about it privately, families may mourn behind closed doors, and yet no meaningful public discussion follows.

Years later, what remains is not an official explanation but fragments: a name mentioned quietly, a story passed from one person to another, a family that refuses to speak, a former colleague who remembers but is unwilling to be quoted.

These are the stories that are most difficult to write.

They are also the stories that require the greatest discipline.

The absence of public discussion does not prove that a killing occurred.

Silence is not evidence by itself.

But silence can raise a question:

Why was nobody talking?

There are many possible answers.

Perhaps the event was never properly investigated.

Perhaps people genuinely did not know what had happened.

Perhaps the death was unrelated to politics.

Perhaps witnesses were afraid.

Perhaps the family wanted privacy.

Perhaps people feared that speaking would bring consequences.

Or perhaps the story that circulated privately was simply wrong.

The responsible writer must leave room for all of these possibilities.

Yet the existence of uncertainty should not prevent us from examining why certain stories survive at all.

Political rumours do not emerge in a vacuum. They often grow where information is scarce.

When an official explanation is clear, credible, independently examined, and publicly accessible, rumours have less room to flourish. But when information is withheld, contradictory, or difficult to verify, people begin constructing their own explanations.

They ask one another:

What really happened?

Who was responsible?

Why did nobody investigate?

Why did the family remain silent?

Why did the authorities move so quickly?

Why was the person suddenly gone?

And because people fear uncertainty almost as much as they fear bad news, they fill the empty space with stories.

Some of those stories are true.

Some are partly true.

Some are completely false.

The difficulty is discovering which is which.

This is where the politics of silence becomes important.

A government does not necessarily have to censor every conversation to control information. Sometimes people censor themselves.

A journalist may decide not to publish.

An official may decide not to speak.

A family may decide that silence is safer.

A colleague may tell himself that the matter is none of his business.

A witness may remember what happened but conclude that his family cannot afford the consequences of telling anyone.

The result is remarkably effective.

No written order is necessary.

No public ban is required.

People simply learn what not to discuss.

And once a subject becomes dangerous to discuss, it can gradually disappear from public memory.

That disappearance has consequences.

When the historical record is silent, future generations may assume that nothing happened.

They cannot see the fear that produced the silence.

They see only the silence itself.

This is why authoritarian environments can create a peculiar historical problem. The absence of documentation may be interpreted as evidence of the absence of wrongdoing, when in reality the lack of documentation may itself have been produced by the political environment.

But again, caution is necessary.

One cannot simply reverse the argument and say:

There is no evidence because the government suppressed the evidence; therefore the allegation must be true.

That would be another form of circular reasoning.

The absence of evidence remains an absence of evidence.

What we can say is that the conditions under which evidence disappears deserve examination.

Who controlled the records?

Who controlled the investigation?

Who had access to witnesses?

Who decided what the public should know?

Who had the authority to close the file?

These questions help us understand not only an individual death but the information environment surrounding it.

And information is power.

The person who controls information can influence how an event is remembered.

A death can be described as an accident.

A disappearance can be described as defection.

A political dispute can be described as treason.

A protest can be described as disorder.

A military operation can be described as security.

The words chosen to describe an event can determine how people understand it.

This is why language becomes especially important in political history.

Words can conceal as easily as they can reveal.

The author is particularly concerned with deaths that, in his view, were never given adequate public attention. He presents them as part of a broader pattern of people disappearing from the political landscape after falling out of favour with the centre of power.

But patterns must be demonstrated.

If one person dies, we must examine that death.

If another person later dies, we examine the second.

If their circumstances are similar, we ask whether the similarities are meaningful.

If they had common political relationships, we investigate those relationships.

If the same institutions were involved, we examine their role.

Only after this process can a pattern begin to emerge.

The temptation to work backward from a conclusion must be resisted.

Otherwise, every death becomes evidence for the theory that existed before the investigation began.

That is not history.

It is confirmation.

The reader should therefore remain alert to both possibilities: the possibility that a disturbing pattern exists, and the possibility that unrelated events have been brought together because they appear to fit a particular narrative.

Both deserve consideration.

There is, however, a human dimension that statistics and political analysis cannot capture.

When a person dies unexpectedly, someone receives the news.

Someone recognises the body.

Someone asks when the funeral will be.

Someone waits for a telephone call that never comes.

Someone remembers the last conversation.

Someone wonders whether the official explanation makes sense.

Political history can become so concerned with leaders and institutions that it forgets this intimate reality.

Every disputed death was once a living person.

Someone had a childhood.

Someone had friends.

Someone had parents.

Someone had ambitions.

Someone was loved.

And when that person disappears, the political question is also a personal tragedy.

This is particularly true when the dead were connected to a political movement in which relationships were intensely personal.

The RPF was not simply an administrative institution. It was a movement forged through exile, war, shared hardship, military struggle, and a common political project.

People who fought together could become closer than ordinary colleagues.

They depended upon one another.

They trusted one another with their lives.

That kind of trust can be extraordinarily powerful.

But when it breaks, the consequences can be equally profound.

A former comrade knows things that an outsider does not.

He knows how decisions were made.

He knows who was present.

He knows who argued with whom.

He may know what happened during moments that were never recorded publicly.

And if he later becomes an opponent, his knowledge can become politically valuable.

This is one reason revolutionary movements can become particularly suspicious of their own former members.

The outsider may be dangerous.

The insider may be more dangerous.

The outsider knows the official story.

The insider may know the story behind it.

That distinction will recur repeatedly throughout this book.

The author writes as someone who once belonged to the struggle and later became deeply critical of the leadership that emerged from it. His position gives his testimony a particular character.

He is not describing a political system from the outside.

He claims to have seen it from within.

That can make his testimony valuable.

It can also make it complicated.

Personal proximity can produce knowledge that outsiders cannot obtain.

But personal proximity can also produce grievances, loyalties, resentments, and interpretations that influence memory.

The answer is not to reject insider testimony.

Nor is it to accept it automatically.

The answer is to test it.

This is the standard we should apply to every serious claim in the pages that follow.

What is the source?

When was the claim made?

Was the person speaking from firsthand knowledge?

Can the account be corroborated?

Are there independent witnesses?

Are there documents?

Are there contradictions?

What alternative explanations exist?

And, above all:

What would we conclude if the same evidence concerned a leader we already disliked?

That last question is particularly important.

Intellectual honesty requires symmetrical standards.

If we demand strong evidence when an allegation challenges someone we admire, we must demand the same evidence when it concerns someone we dislike.

Otherwise, we are not seeking truth.

We are choosing evidence according to preference.

This book must resist that temptation.

The stories of killings that were allegedly never publicly discussed are therefore not presented merely to shock the reader.

They are part of a larger inquiry into what happens when political power controls not only institutions, but the boundaries of public conversation.

What can be spoken?

What must remain private?

Who decides?

And what happens to a society when people become accustomed to knowing things they are afraid to say?

Perhaps the greatest consequence is not that the truth disappears.

It is that people become accustomed to living without it.

They learn to function with unanswered questions.

They learn not to ask.

They learn to mourn quietly.

They learn to move on.

And eventually, an entire generation may inherit stories that exist only in whispers.

That is where history becomes fragile.

Because a nation cannot fully understand its past if its people are afraid to speak about it.

And without understanding the past, how can a society recognise the patterns that may return?

This is the question that leads us to the next story.

Among the allegations surrounding Kagame's rule are claims concerning individuals who occupied positions unusually close to him—people who were not merely political acquaintances but members of his immediate circle.

One of them was Dr. Emmanuel Gasakure, Kagame's personal physician.

His death raises precisely the kind of questions that make political history so difficult:

What happens when a person who serves at the very centre of power suddenly becomes part of the story of death itself?

2.6 WHO KILLED DR GASAKURE, PAUL KAGAME'S PERSONAL PHYSICIAN?

Some people occupy positions so close to a political leader that their lives become inseparable from the history of the institution they serve.

Dr Emmanuel Gasakure was one of those people.

He was not a soldier standing on a battlefield, nor a politician addressing crowds. He was a doctor. His professional responsibility was to care for human life. Yet his position as President Paul Kagame's personal physician placed him unusually close to the centre of power.

That proximity makes his death particularly difficult to ignore.

According to the author's account, Gasakure's death occurred after an altercation with members of the presidential security apparatus. The circumstances described are disturbing: a doctor serving the president allegedly became involved in a confrontation with security personnel and was subsequently beaten and died.

If that account is accurate, the implications are grave.

But before drawing conclusions, we must stop at the most important question:

What exactly happened?

A death involving security personnel cannot responsibly be explained simply by repeating what one side believes occurred. The circumstances must be reconstructed as carefully as possible.

Who was present?

What preceded the confrontation?

What did witnesses see?

Was force used?

If so, by whom?

What injuries did Gasakure sustain?

Was he treated?

Was an autopsy performed?

What did the medical evidence establish?

Was an investigation conducted?

Who conducted it?

And what did that investigation conclude?

These questions matter because the proximity of the victim to the president can create two opposite temptations.

One temptation is to assume that the president must have been responsible because the victim worked for him.

The other is to assume that nothing politically significant could have happened because the victim worked within the presidential household.

Both assumptions are unjustified.

Responsibility must be established.

But the circumstances must also be examined precisely because the person involved occupied such a sensitive position.

A presidential physician is not an ordinary employee.

He may know the leader's health.

He may know private routines.

He may have access to information that very few people possess.

He may be present during confidential meetings or moments of vulnerability.

And because of this proximity, the relationship between physician and president is built upon an unusual form of trust.

The doctor serves the person.

But the doctor is also bound by a professional duty that is larger than the person.

Medicine imposes its own ethics.

A doctor cannot simply become an instrument of political power because his patient happens to be the head of state.

That boundary matters.

It protects the doctor.

It protects the patient.

And, ultimately, it protects the integrity of the medical profession.

When such a person dies under disputed circumstances, therefore, the questions extend beyond the individual.

They concern the relationship between professional independence and political authority.

But there is another reason Gasakure's story matters.

It illustrates the vulnerability of people who operate within the innermost circles of power.

From the outside, proximity to the president can look like security.

Inside the system, it can create dependence.

The people closest to power may know more than ordinary citizens, but that does not necessarily mean they possess more freedom.

Sometimes the opposite is true.

They may have more to lose.

Their employment may depend upon the goodwill of a single person.

Their safety may depend upon the institutions surrounding that person.

Their relationships may be watched more closely.

Their mistakes may carry greater consequences.

And if they fall out of favour, the fall can be much steeper.

This is a recurring feature of political systems built around personal authority.

The closer one gets to the centre, the greater the rewards can be.

But the risks can increase at the same time.

The palace can be both a place of privilege and a place of vulnerability.

The person who enters through its doors may believe that he has reached safety.

He may discover instead that he has entered the place where power is most concentrated.

Gasakure's story therefore sits naturally beside the earlier accounts of household employees.

The individuals are different.

Their positions are different.

Their circumstances are different.

Yet they raise the same underlying question:

What happens to a person whose life becomes dependent upon the goodwill of an exceptionally powerful institution?

The answer depends upon the institutions surrounding that power.

If the courts are independent, an abused employee can seek justice.

If the press is free, a journalist can investigate.

If parliament exercises genuine oversight, officials can be questioned.

If security institutions answer to law rather than personality, abuses can be challenged.

If none of these safeguards function effectively, vulnerability increases.

This is why the death of a person close to the presidency should not be examined only as an isolated tragedy.

It should also be examined as a test of institutions.

How did the system respond?

Did it investigate itself?

Did it permit independent scrutiny?

Did it publish evidence?

Did it answer questions?

Or did the matter disappear into the same silence described in the preceding section?

The difference is enormous.

A transparent investigation does not guarantee that everyone will accept its conclusion.

But it provides a record against which that conclusion can be tested.

Silence provides no such opportunity.

And when the institution being accused is also the institution controlling the investigation, public confidence becomes particularly important.

People naturally ask whether an organisation can fairly investigate itself.

Sometimes it can.

Often, however, credibility requires independence.

That is why independent inquiries exist in many democratic systems. Their purpose is not necessarily to condemn the institution involved. Their purpose is to create confidence that the truth has been sought without fear or favour.

The author's account of Gasakure's death is ultimately a challenge to that principle.

He presents the death as part of a broader pattern in which people close to Kagame could become vulnerable when conflicts arose between them and the security environment surrounding the president.

Whether that broader pattern can be proven is a question for the evidence.

But the individual case remains important because it forces us to confront the uncomfortable relationship between proximity and danger.

The closer a person stands to power, the more he may know.

And the more he knows, the more important it becomes that the system protect him from retaliation.

This is true even when the person is not a political dissident.

A doctor does not become a political enemy simply because he works for a president.

A domestic worker does not become a political threat because she falls in love.

A soldier does not become a traitor simply because he disagrees with his commander.

The state must distinguish between legitimate authority and personal control.

That distinction is one of the foundations of the rule of law.

Without it, almost any private conflict can be transformed into a political offence.

And once private disagreements become matters of state power, ordinary people can become extraordinarily vulnerable.

This is perhaps the deeper significance of Gasakure's story.

It reminds us that authoritarian power does not always announce itself with tanks in the streets.

Sometimes it appears in much smaller relationships.

A doctor and his patient.

A soldier and his commander.

A servant and her employer.

A citizen and an official.

The question is always the same:

Can the weaker person disagree without fearing the full weight of the stronger person's authority?

If the answer is yes, power remains bounded.

If the answer is no, power has begun to escape its boundaries.

The author does not leave Gasakure merely as a statistic.

He presents him as a human being who had entered the presidential circle through a profession dedicated to healing.

That makes the alleged circumstances of his death especially tragic.

The person whose profession was to preserve life became, according to the account presented here, a casualty of the very environment in which he had served.

But tragedy should not replace investigation.

The reader should demand both.

Remember the person.

Examine the evidence.

Question the unanswered questions.

And resist the temptation to decide before the evidence has been considered.

There is a final irony here.

A personal physician is entrusted with the most intimate knowledge of a leader's physical condition.

He sees the human being behind the office.

He knows that the president, beneath the uniform, suit, speeches, and security detail, is still a mortal man.

Perhaps that is why such relationships can be uniquely revealing.

The president may command armies.

He may negotiate with governments.

He may appear before international audiences.

But in the doctor's room, power meets vulnerability.

The patient cannot command illness to disappear.

The president becomes, for a moment, simply a human being.

And the doctor becomes the person entrusted with protecting that humanity.

That relationship should be governed by trust.

When trust breaks, the consequences can be profound.

And when the person entrusted with that care dies under circumstances that remain disputed, the natural human question refuses to disappear:

Who was responsible for Dr Gasakure's death—and why has the full truth remained so difficult to establish?

The question takes us beyond the doctor himself.

It takes us into the wider circle of people who once stood close to Kagame and whose stories, according to the author, ended in violence, disappearance, exile, or silence.

Among them was another figure whose story is presented very differently.

His name was **Asiel Kabera**.

And unlike the stories of fear and anger that dominate this part of the chapter, Kabera's story begins with something else:

humanity.

2.7 ASIEL KABERA: A MAN OF HUMANITY

Not every person remembered in a story of political violence is remembered because of the power he possessed.

Some are remembered because of the humanity they showed while surrounded by power.

Asiel Kabera belongs, in the author's account, to the latter category.

His story provides an important pause in this chapter. Until now, the narrative has increasingly concentrated on authority, fear, anger, and the fate of people who came into conflict with those above them. Kabera's story brings the reader back to something more fundamental: the human being behind the political struggle.

Because revolutions and wars have a way of reducing people to categories.

Soldier.

Commander.

Refugee.

Traitor.

Enemy.

President.

Dissident.

Supporter.

Opponent.

Once a person has been placed inside one of these categories, it becomes easy to forget that he was also someone's son, someone's friend, someone's colleague, perhaps someone's source of hope.

Kabera's significance, as presented by the author, lies precisely in that humanity.

He was a man who moved within political and military circles, yet retained a concern for people that transcended the calculations of power.

And perhaps that is why his story deserves to be told separately.

History often remembers the people who won.

It remembers the people who commanded.

It remembers those who occupied offices, signed agreements, led armies, and appeared in photographs.

It is less generous to those whose greatest contribution was simply the way they treated other human beings.

But a country is not built only by presidents and generals.

It is also built by people who help others survive.

By people who open doors.

By people who provide encouragement.

By people who refuse to abandon a colleague.

By people who remain compassionate when circumstances encourage cruelty.

Such people may never become famous.

Their influence may never appear in official histories.

Yet their absence can be deeply felt by those who knew them.

This is the dimension of Kabera's story that the author wants the reader to remember.

There is something particularly moving about humanity displayed in a political environment dominated by suspicion.

When everyone is encouraged to ask, "*Whom can I trust?*", a genuinely compassionate person becomes unusually valuable.

He does not need to make grand speeches.

His conduct speaks for him.

He can listen when others are shouting.

He can help when others are calculating.

He can recognise suffering even when the person suffering belongs to the wrong political camp.

And that last quality is perhaps the hardest.

It is easy to show compassion toward people we consider our own.

It is much harder to extend humanity to someone whom we have been taught to regard as an enemy.

The history of Rwanda makes this distinction especially important.

The country's twentieth-century history contains wounds deep enough to shape generations. Political identity, exile, ethnicity, military allegiance, and historical memory have repeatedly influenced how people see one another.

In such circumstances, humanity can itself become a political act.

To recognise another person's suffering is to acknowledge his humanity.

To acknowledge his humanity is to refuse to reduce him entirely to the political category assigned to him.

And once we do that, hatred becomes more difficult.

This does not mean that political disagreements disappear.

They do not.

Nor does compassion require the abandonment of justice.

It does not.

A person can be held accountable for wrongdoing and still be treated as a human being.

That distinction is essential.

Justice asks:

What did you do?

Humanity asks:

Who are you?

A civilised society must be capable of asking both questions at once.

The danger comes when the first question completely erases the second.

Once an opponent is no longer seen as a human being, almost anything can be justified against him.

He becomes an obstacle.

A threat.

A traitor.

A problem to be removed.

The language changes first.

Then behaviour follows.

This is one of the oldest lessons of political violence.

Before people are harmed, they are often redefined.

They become less than fully human in the eyes of those who wish to harm them.

That is why stories such as Kabera's matter.

They remind us that political history is not simply a struggle between organisations.

It is a struggle between human choices.

People choose whether to humiliate or respect.

Whether to retaliate or forgive.

Whether to protect or expose.

Whether to listen or silence.

Whether to remember the humanity of another person when doing so is inconvenient.

Kabera's story, therefore, provides a moral counterpoint to the image of political power presented elsewhere in this chapter.

If the previous sections ask what happens when power is accompanied by anger and fear, this section asks a different question:

What happens when power encounters a person who refuses to surrender his humanity?

That question becomes particularly significant when such a person enters a dangerous political environment.

Compassion can be interpreted as weakness.

Independent judgment can be interpreted as disloyalty.

Concern for another person can be interpreted as political sympathy.

And the person who refuses to participate in the culture of fear may eventually find himself isolated.

This is not unique to Rwanda.

It is a recurring feature of authoritarian environments.

When loyalty is measured by obedience, conscience becomes inconvenient.

When silence is interpreted as loyalty, speaking becomes dangerous.

When suspicion becomes normal, trust becomes revolutionary.

The author remembers Kabera because, in his telling, he represented something different.

He represented the possibility that political struggle need not completely destroy human character.

And perhaps that is why the memory of such people survives even when political circumstances change.

Power is temporary.

Titles disappear.

Governments change.

Armies reorganise.

Political alliances collapse.

But the memory of kindness can remain remarkably durable.

A person may forget the exact date on which a political decision was made.

He may forget the contents of a speech.

He may even forget the name of an official who occupied an important position for a few years.

But he may remember the person who helped him when nobody else would.

That kind of memory does not require an archive.

It lives in people.

And perhaps this is why the author places Kabera's story among accounts of violence.

It prevents the chapter from becoming merely a catalogue of accusations.

It reminds us that the history of a political movement is also the history of relationships.

People do not simply occupy positions.

They form friendships.

They develop loyalties.

They fall in love.

They forgive.

They betray.

They reconcile.

They become disappointed.

They become afraid.

And sometimes they die.

The political structure is built upon these human relationships, even when the final historical record makes them appear abstract.

Kabera's story therefore asks the reader to resist abstraction.

Before we call someone a soldier, remember that he was a person.

Before we call someone a dissident, remember that he was a person.

Before we call someone an enemy, remember that he was a person.

Before we call someone a traitor, ask what he believed he was betraying—and why.

And before we celebrate a political victory, ask who paid its price.

These questions do not make history softer.

They make it more honest.

Because history without humanity becomes a ledger of victories and defeats.

History with humanity becomes an account of lives.

And lives are what political decisions ultimately affect.

The author's recollection of Asiel Kabera therefore serves another purpose. It establishes a contrast.

The chapter has been asking what power can do to people.

Kabera's story asks what people can preserve **despite** power.

The answer is dignity.

And dignity is not a small thing.

A person may lose his position and retain his dignity.

He may lose his country and retain his dignity.

He may lose his freedom and retain his dignity.

He may even lose his life without allowing hatred to determine the kind of person he becomes.

Political power can control institutions.

It can control armies.

It can control information.

But it cannot completely determine the moral character of every person who encounters it.

That remains a choice.

And this is why the memory of people like Kabera matters.

They remind us that the opposite of violence is not simply peace.

It is humanity.

Peace without humanity can become silence.

Order without humanity can become oppression.

Stability without humanity can become fear.

But when people retain the ability to see one another as human beings, even in the midst of political conflict, there remains a possibility of reconciliation.

That possibility is precious.

And yet, in the world described by this chapter, humanity could not always protect people from the consequences of political power.

The narrative must therefore return once more to the question of military authority, loyalty, and death.

The next story concerns **Brigadier General Dan Gapfizi**, whose death the author connects to an earlier pattern and presents as another example of how quickly a military career can become entangled with suspicion, conflict, and political consequence.

The question becomes darker now:

When history repeats the circumstances surrounding a death, at what point does coincidence become a pattern worth investigating?

2.8 BRIGADIER GENERAL DAN GAPFIZI AND THE DEATH THAT ECHOED AN EARLIER KILLING

There are deaths that end a life.

And then there are deaths that reopen an old question.

The death of Brigadier General Dan Gapfizi belongs, in the author's telling, to the second category.

By the time Gapfizi entered this story, the reader had already encountered the recurring themes that shape the author's account of power: loyalty, suspicion, military hierarchy, disagreement, fear, and the vulnerability of those who once stood close to the centre of authority.

Gapfizi's death therefore cannot be considered in isolation from that atmosphere.

But neither should it be assumed that similarity automatically establishes causation.

That distinction becomes particularly important here because the author sees an echo between Gapfizi's death and an earlier killing.

The word **echo** is useful.

An echo is not the original sound.

It is something heard afterward, resembling what came before.

It can suggest a connection.

It can make us look backward.

But it does not, by itself, prove where the sound came from.

The same principle must guide our reading of disputed political deaths.

If two people die under apparently similar circumstances, the similarity deserves attention.

But attention is not conviction.

Investigation must come before judgment.

Gapfizi was a senior military officer. His position alone placed him inside the structures of command that had become central to Rwanda's post-war political order. A senior officer is not simply another employee of the state. He is part of the machinery through which the state exercises force.

Such men possess knowledge.

They understand military structures.

They know commanders.

They know operations.

They understand the internal relationships that ordinary citizens cannot see.

When such an officer falls out of favour, defects, becomes politically unreliable, or simply becomes involved in a dispute with more powerful figures, his position can become precarious.

This is one of the uncomfortable realities of military politics.

The institution depends upon loyalty.

But loyalty itself can be interpreted in different ways.

To one commander, loyalty means obedience.

To another, it means honesty.

To a third, it may mean defending the institution even when the leader is wrong.

These interpretations can collide.

And when they do, a person can discover that the quality once praised as loyalty has suddenly been redefined as insubordination.

That transformation can happen quickly.

Yesterday's loyal officer becomes today's suspect.

Yesterday's trusted colleague becomes today's problem.

Yesterday's comrade becomes someone whose motives must be questioned.

Political movements built around military struggle are particularly vulnerable to this dynamic because their internal culture is often shaped by the experience of war.

War rewards discipline.

It punishes hesitation.

It creates clear categories: friend and enemy, order and disobedience, victory and defeat.

But peace requires different qualities.

It requires compromise.

It requires institutions.

It requires disagreement without violence.

It requires the acceptance of criticism.

And it requires leaders to tolerate the possibility that someone beneath them may know something they do not.

A movement that does not successfully make that transition can carry the psychology of war into government.

Then political disagreement begins to look like military disloyalty.

Criticism begins to resemble betrayal.

Opposition begins to resemble an existential threat.

And the language of survival becomes the language of governance.

This is the broader context in which the author places Gapfizi's story.

He sees his death not merely as the end of one officer's life but as another episode in a continuing history of people connected to the military establishment who eventually found themselves in circumstances that raised difficult questions.

The temptation, again, is to draw the simplest conclusion:

They were connected to Kagame.

They later died.

Therefore Kagame was responsible.

But that is not a valid historical argument.

The conclusion may be possible.

It may even be true.

But it must be demonstrated.

A serious inquiry must establish the chain between the person, the event, the alleged perpetrators, and the political authority supposedly behind them.

Who acted?

Who ordered?

Who knew?

Who benefited?

Who concealed?

And what evidence connects those stages?

Without those answers, the reader has suspicion, not proof.

Yet suspicion itself can be historically important.

Consider what happens when a government fails to provide convincing answers to repeated questions about the deaths of prominent figures.

Even if every individual death has an innocent explanation, public confidence can deteriorate.

People begin to believe that there is a hidden story.

They begin to interpret later events through earlier suspicions.

One unanswered death becomes the lens through which another is viewed.

Then another.

Eventually, the political system acquires a reputation that becomes difficult to separate from the events themselves.

This creates a vicious cycle.

Lack of transparency creates suspicion.

Suspicion creates fear.

Fear creates silence.

Silence reduces the amount of independent information available.

The absence of information then creates even more suspicion.

And so the cycle continues.

Transparency can interrupt that cycle.

A credible investigation can say:

Here is what happened.

Here is the evidence.

Here is what we do not know.

Here is who is responsible.

Here is why we reached this conclusion.

That is how institutions build trust.

They do not build trust by demanding that citizens believe them.

They build trust by giving citizens reasons to believe them.

This distinction is fundamental.

A government that says, “*Trust us,*” is asking for obedience.

A government that says, “*Examine the evidence,*” is inviting accountability.

The latter is more difficult.

But it is also more durable.

The author's concern about Gapfizi's death ultimately returns us to the central question of this entire section:

What happens when the institutions responsible for investigating political violence are not sufficiently independent from the people whose interests may be implicated?

That question cannot be answered by emotion.

It requires institutional analysis.

Who investigates the security services?

Who investigates senior military officers?

Who has access to classified information?

Who can subpoena witnesses?

Who can protect those witnesses?

Who can challenge an official explanation?

And can the investigator continue his work if his findings implicate powerful people?

These are not merely technical questions.

They determine whether a political system possesses meaningful accountability.

The death of a military officer therefore becomes a test of the state.

Not simply because the state may have caused the death, but because the state has a responsibility to establish what happened.

The dead deserve the truth.

The family deserves the truth.

The public deserves the truth.

And even the government deserves the truth, because a government that permits unresolved political killings to accumulate around it eventually damages its own legitimacy.

There is another dimension to Gapfizi's story that deserves attention.

Military institutions depend upon trust.

A soldier must believe that his commanders will not sacrifice him arbitrarily.

A commander must believe that his colleagues will not turn against him without reason.

Officers must believe that disagreements can be resolved through institutional procedures rather than personal retaliation.

When that confidence disappears, the military itself becomes unstable.

People begin calculating.

Who can I trust?

Who is watching me?

What should I say?

Should I remain?

Should I leave?

Should I speak?

Should I keep quiet?

Such questions can be more damaging to an institution than open disagreement.

Because disagreement can be resolved.

Fear often cannot.

Fear produces concealment.

And concealment eventually destroys communication.

This is why the stories in this chapter should not be read merely as stories about Kagame's personality.

They are stories about institutions.

About what happens when political authority becomes personalised.

About what happens when loyalty becomes more important than accountability.

About what happens when people believe that disagreement can carry consequences beyond their professional lives.

And about what happens when deaths remain surrounded by unanswered questions.

The author has taken us through a series of increasingly troubling accounts.

A domestic worker.

A presidential household.

A leader's temper.

Military figures.

Deaths that were allegedly left unexplained.

A personal physician.

A man remembered for his humanity.

And now a senior military officer whose death, in the author's interpretation, echoed an earlier killing.

The individual stories are different.

But together they form the atmosphere of this chapter.

The atmosphere is one of power under pressure.

A political movement has become a state.

A military command structure has become a governing structure.

Former comrades have become political rivals.

Loyalty has become a test.

Fear has become part of the political vocabulary.

And death, in some of the author's accounts, has become the ultimate consequence of crossing invisible boundaries.

Yet one must still resist the seductive simplicity of the narrative.

The strongest book is not the one that tells the reader what to believe.

It is the one that gives the reader enough material to think.

That is the standard we should maintain.

Let the allegations be heard.

Let the evidence be examined.

Let contradictions remain visible.

Let uncertainty remain where uncertainty is unavoidable.

And let the reader ask the questions that political power would rather not answer.

Because ultimately, the issue is larger than Dan Gapfizi.

It is larger than Fred Rwigema.

It is larger than Gasakure.

It is larger than Asiel Kabera.

It is larger than any single individual whose name appears in these pages.

The deeper issue is whether a political system can possess enormous power without becoming accountable to those over whom it exercises that power.

That is the question beneath the question.

And it will remain with us as the book moves forward.

For if violence is the language of power at its most extreme, then authoritarianism is the political environment in which that language can become normal.

The next chapter therefore takes us from individual acts and allegations of violence to the larger structure that, according to the author's argument, made such violence possible.

The question changes once again.

We are no longer asking only:

What happened to these people?

We are asking:

What kind of political system allows fear, obedience, and personal authority to become so deeply intertwined?

That is the subject of the next part of the book.

PART III — THE AUTHORITARIAN

Chapter Three — Kagame, the Authoritarian

And the first comparison the author asks us to confront is one that cannot be approached casually:

Kagame and Idi Amin.

Two men.

Two countries.

Two historical circumstances.

Two very different trajectories.

Yet, according to the author's argument, certain features of personal rule invite comparison.

The comparison will demand more than resemblance.

It will demand judgment.

And judgment, if it is to mean anything, must begin with evidence.

PART III — THE AUTHORITARIAN

CHAPTER THREE — KAGAME, THE AUTHORITARIAN

3.1 KAGAME AND IDI AMIN: THE PARALLELS

Comparisons between political leaders are dangerous.

They can illuminate history, but they can also distort it.

To place two leaders beside one another is to suggest that something connects them. The connection may be their methods, their institutions, their treatment of opponents, their relationship with the military, or simply the way their governments are remembered.

But resemblance is not identity.

Paul Kagame and Idi Amin emerged from profoundly different circumstances. They belonged to different generations, governed different countries, inherited different political conditions, and presided over very different historical moments.

Any serious comparison must begin by acknowledging those differences.

And yet, the author believes that there are parallels worth examining.

The comparison is deliberately provocative.

Idi Amin has become one of the most notorious examples of personal dictatorship in modern African history. His government is associated with political repression, disappearances, killings, exile, fear, and the extraordinary concentration of power in one man's hands.

Kagame's Rwanda is a very different case.

It is a country widely associated with reconstruction after the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi, economic development, public order, institutional discipline, and a government that has received substantial international praise. At the same time, Kagame's government has faced serious criticism concerning political freedoms, opposition, media space, and the treatment of critics.

To compare the two, therefore, is not to claim that their governments were identical.

The more useful question is narrower:

Are there particular mechanisms of personal rule that can appear in very different historical circumstances?

That is a question worth asking.

Because authoritarianism does not always look the same.

One dictator may rule through spectacular violence.

Another may rule through surveillance.

Another through control of institutions.

Another through the manipulation of elections.

Another through fear combined with economic performance.

Another through a combination of all of these.

The appearance of the state can change.

The underlying concentration of power can remain.

This distinction is important because people often imagine authoritarianism as something immediately recognisable.

They expect soldiers in the streets.

They expect secret police.

They expect censorship so obvious that nobody can miss it.

They expect the leader to announce himself as a dictator.

History is rarely so convenient.

Modern authoritarian systems can be much more sophisticated.

They may hold elections.

They may have parliaments.

They may have courts.

They may maintain newspapers.

They may permit limited criticism.

They may even deliver genuine improvements in people's lives.

The existence of these features does not automatically make a government democratic.

The deeper question is whether political institutions possess enough independence to constrain the person or group that controls the state.

This is where the comparison becomes more interesting.

Idi Amin's government was notorious for the personalisation of authority. His personality became inseparable from the state.

Kagame, too, has become deeply associated with the Rwandan state and its post-genocide political order.

But the comparison must stop there unless further evidence supports it.

A functioning historical analysis cannot simply say:

Amin was a dictator.

Kagame is powerful.

Therefore Kagame is another Amin.

That would be intellectually lazy.

Instead, we must break authoritarianism into its component parts.

How is power acquired?

How is it maintained?

How are opponents treated?

How independent are institutions?

What happens when senior officials disagree?

What happens when journalists investigate the government?

What happens when political parties challenge the ruling establishment?

What happens when citizens refuse to conform?

And perhaps the most revealing question:

Can the leader lose?

Not merely lose an argument.

Not merely lose a parliamentary vote.

But lose political power.

Can he be removed through institutions that he does not control?

That is one of the fundamental tests of political accountability.

A leader who knows that power can genuinely be lost has a reason to respect political limits.

A leader who believes that losing power would be impossible—or intolerable—has a strong incentive to control the institutions that might remove him.

This is where political systems begin to change.

At first, the leader may simply want stability.

Then stability becomes continuity.

Continuity becomes political necessity.

Political necessity becomes justification for restricting opponents.

Opponents become threats.

Threats become enemies.

Enemies become people who cannot be permitted to gain power.

And once that logic becomes established, the political system begins to revolve around one fundamental objective:

preserving the existing order.

The leader may genuinely believe that preserving the order is equivalent to protecting the country.

That is what makes authoritarianism particularly complicated.

It does not always begin with the conscious thought:

I want to oppress my people.

It may begin with:

I know what will happen if I lose control.

In countries with histories of civil war, genocide, coups, or state collapse, this argument can be extraordinarily persuasive.

Fear of disorder becomes a justification for discipline.

Discipline becomes a justification for restrictions.

Restrictions become a justification for surveillance.

Surveillance becomes a justification for further restrictions.

And eventually, the extraordinary becomes normal.

This is one area where the comparison with Idi Amin becomes useful—not because the two men should be treated as historical equivalents, but because Uganda under Amin demonstrates what can happen when institutions become subordinate to personal authority.

Amin's Uganda offers a warning about the consequences of concentrated power.

The warning is universal.

It does not belong only to Uganda.

It does not belong only to Africa.

It belongs to political life itself.

Whenever one individual becomes more important than the institutions surrounding him, the system becomes vulnerable.

The danger is not simply that the leader may become cruel.

The danger is that there may be no effective mechanism capable of stopping him if he does.

That distinction matters.

A good leader with unlimited power is still a structural problem.

A bad leader with limited power may be less dangerous.

The quality of the individual matters.

But the structure matters more.

This is why the author repeatedly returns to Kagame's personal authority.

He sees the Rwandan political system as increasingly centred around Kagame himself. His argument is that the president's influence extends beyond the formal powers of his office into the military, political, security, and institutional life of the country.

Whether one accepts that interpretation in full or not, it raises a fundamental question:

How much authority should one person possess in a country that claims to have institutions?

The question becomes particularly important in a small country.

Rwanda's geographical size, population density, history of conflict, and regional position all influence its politics. A government can argue that strong central coordination is necessary because the margin for instability is small.

There is some logic to that argument.

But necessity can become dangerous when it has no clear limit.

Every government can identify a reason why it needs more power.

A security threat.

An economic crisis.

A political opponent.

A regional conflict.

A national emergency.

A historical trauma.

The problem is that temporary powers have a tendency to become permanent.

The emergency ends.

The powers remain.

The threat changes.

The institutions remain under tighter control.

The justification evolves.

And eventually, nobody remembers when the temporary measure became the permanent system.

This is why democratic government depends upon more than elections.

It depends upon limits.

Limits on presidents.

Limits on security agencies.

Limits on military commanders.

Limits on political parties.

Limits on government surveillance.

Limits on the ability to imprison opponents.

And limits on the state's ability to determine what citizens are permitted to say.

Without limits, political authority becomes increasingly personal.

And personal authority creates another problem: succession.

If the entire system depends upon one leader, what happens when that leader leaves?

Who succeeds him?

What happens if his successor is incompetent?

What happens if two factions compete for the position?

What happens if the institutions have never learned how to operate independently?

A political system that is strong because one person is strong may discover that it was never strong at all.

It was simply dependent.

This is another point at which the comparison with Amin becomes instructive.

Amin's government did not collapse because Ugandans suddenly became less human or because the country had no capable people. It collapsed after years of political and military instability, eventually culminating in his overthrow and exile.

The lesson is not that every strong leader will meet the same fate.

The lesson is that personal rule creates instability even when it appears stable.

Because stability built around one person contains a hidden weakness:

What happens when the person is gone?

The author believes that Kagame's Rwanda has reached a point where this question can no longer be avoided.

The president is not simply another elected official in the author's narrative.

He is the central figure around whom the political order revolves.

His history is the history of the movement.

His authority is intertwined with the military.

His image is intertwined with the reconstruction of Rwanda.

His supporters associate him with national survival.

His opponents associate him with political repression.

In such an environment, disagreement becomes extraordinarily difficult to interpret neutrally.

If Kagame represents stability, then criticism can be interpreted as destabilisation.

If he represents national reconstruction, then opposition can be interpreted as hostility toward progress.

If he represents protection from another genocide, then challenging him can be portrayed as risking another catastrophe.

These arguments are powerful because they appeal not merely to political preference but to historical memory.

And historical memory is powerful.

A society that has suffered catastrophic violence does not approach political stability in the same way as a society that has never experienced it.

The fear of returning to the past can become one of the strongest political forces in the present.

That is why the question of authoritarianism in Rwanda cannot be discussed as though Rwanda were simply another country with an ordinary political history.

Its history matters.

The genocide matters.

The wars in the Great Lakes matter.

The refugee experience matters.

The RPF's military struggle matters.

The collapse of the previous state matters.

The fear of renewed ethnic violence matters.

All of these realities help explain why strong government can be attractive.

But explaining strong government is not the same as excusing unlimited government.

That distinction must remain clear.

A society can legitimately value stability while still demanding accountability.

It can remember genocide while still defending political rights.

It can honour the role of Kagame in the country's reconstruction while still asking difficult questions about his exercise of power.

These positions are not mutually exclusive.

Indeed, they may be necessary for serious political discussion.

The real danger begins when a society is told that it must choose between order and freedom.

The choice is often false.

A mature state should seek both.

Security without freedom can become repression.

Freedom without security can become chaos.

The challenge of government is to protect one without destroying the other.

This is where the comparison with Idi Amin becomes most useful—not as an accusation of identical crimes, but as a warning about what happens when the balance between authority and accountability collapses.

A government does not become dangerous merely because its leader is strong.

It becomes dangerous when strength cannot be questioned.

It becomes dangerous when institutions cannot restrain it.

It becomes dangerous when citizens cannot safely disagree.

It becomes dangerous when political opponents cannot compete fairly.

It becomes dangerous when the leader's survival becomes indistinguishable from the state's survival.

And perhaps the most dangerous transformation of all occurs when citizens themselves begin to believe that they cannot imagine their country without the person at the top.

At that moment, the leader has become more than a president.

He has become an institution.

And when one man becomes an institution, the question is no longer simply whether he governs well.

The question becomes whether the country can govern itself without him.

That is the question that will carry us into the next section.

For authoritarianism does not survive solely through force.

It survives through silence.

Through adaptation.

Through people who decide that endurance is safer than confrontation.

Through citizens who learn that certain subjects are better left untouched.

Through officials who understand that survival depends upon obedience.

And through a political culture in which people gradually learn a simple lesson:

Keep your head down, remain silent, and endure.

That is the subject of the next section.

3.2 ENDURE, REMAIN SILENT, AND BEAR IT

How does fear become ordinary?

Not overnight.

Not necessarily through one dramatic act.

Sometimes it begins with a small decision.

A journalist chooses not to publish a story.

An official chooses not to challenge a superior.

A citizen decides not to attend a political meeting.

A family tells its children not to discuss politics outside the home.

A soldier remains silent when he disagrees with an order.

Each decision may appear insignificant.

But repeated thousands of times, such decisions can transform an entire political culture.

People learn to survive.

They learn to endure.

They learn to bear it.

And eventually, silence becomes not merely a response to fear but a way of life.

3.2 ENDURE, REMAIN SILENT, AND BEAR IT

How does a society become accustomed to silence?

It rarely begins with a law announcing that everyone must be silent.

It begins much more quietly.

Someone speaks and discovers that speaking has consequences.

Someone else watches.

The next person notices.

And eventually, people begin to calculate before they speak.

Is this worth saying?

Who might hear me?

What if someone repeats it?

What will happen to me if the wrong person hears?

These questions may never appear in a constitution.

They do not need to.

Once people begin asking them instinctively, fear has already entered the political culture.

The author presents this atmosphere as one of the defining characteristics of the political environment surrounding Kagame's Rwanda. In his account, citizens, officials, soldiers, former comrades, and political opponents have often been expected to endure rather than challenge the prevailing order.

The instruction is not always spoken aloud.

Sometimes it is understood.

Endure.

Remain silent.

Bear it.

There is something particularly powerful about those three words because they describe more than political obedience.

They describe adaptation.

A person who is forced to remain silent once may feel angry.

A person who remains silent repeatedly may eventually stop believing that speaking is possible.

That is how political systems can change human behaviour without constantly resorting to visible force.

The state does not need to punish everyone.

It only needs enough people to believe that punishment is possible.

The rest will regulate themselves.

This is one of the most effective forms of political control because it is economical.

A government cannot monitor every conversation.

It does not need to.

If citizens begin monitoring themselves, the work has already been done.

A journalist edits his own article.

A civil servant removes a sentence from a report.

A politician chooses a safer subject.

A businessman avoids funding an opposition figure.

A soldier keeps an opinion to himself.

A family avoids discussing politics in public.

No official order is required.

Fear has become internal.

And once fear becomes internal, it becomes difficult to measure.

There may be no visible repression.

The streets may remain peaceful.

Businesses may continue operating.

Schools may remain open.

Government offices may function normally.

Foreign visitors may see an orderly country.

But beneath the visible stability, people may still be making private calculations about what they are permitted to say.

This is why political freedom cannot be measured only by the absence of violence.

A society may be physically peaceful while politically fearful.

The absence of people in prison does not necessarily mean that people feel free.

The absence of demonstrations does not necessarily mean that everyone agrees.

The absence of criticism does not necessarily mean that criticism does not exist.

Sometimes silence means satisfaction.

Sometimes it means fear.

And the difficult task is determining which one we are witnessing.

Rwanda's history makes this question especially sensitive.

After the genocide against the Tutsi in 1994, the country faced an extraordinary challenge: how could a society that had experienced mass violence rebuild itself without allowing the conditions that contributed to that violence to return?

The answer pursued by the Rwandan state has placed enormous emphasis on national unity, security, social discipline, and the rejection of divisive political language.

There is an understandable logic behind this.

A society that has experienced genocide cannot treat incitement, ethnic hatred, or political violence as ordinary political speech.

The state has a legitimate responsibility to protect citizens from renewed violence.

But this creates a difficult boundary.

Where does the legitimate prevention of incitement end?

Where does political control begin?

When does protecting national unity become restricting legitimate disagreement?

When does preventing dangerous speech become preventing uncomfortable speech?

These questions have no easy answers.

They require institutions capable of distinguishing between the two.

A mature political system should be able to say:

This speech threatens people.

and also:

This speech merely threatens the government.

Those are not the same thing.

A government must be able to tolerate criticism without interpreting every criticism as an attack on national stability.

Otherwise, the concept of security can become so broad that almost anything can be prohibited in its name.

This is where the culture of endurance becomes dangerous.

If people are repeatedly told that criticism creates instability, they may eventually stop distinguishing between destructive criticism and constructive criticism.

They begin to assume that silence is patriotism.

They begin to believe that questioning authority is disloyal.

They begin to confuse obedience with unity.

And once that happens, society loses something important.

It loses the ability to correct itself.

Every government makes mistakes.

Every leader makes mistakes.

Every institution makes mistakes.

The difference between a resilient political system and a fragile one is not whether mistakes occur.

It is whether people are allowed to point them out.

A government that cannot tolerate criticism may appear strong.

In reality, it may be making itself weaker.

Why?

Because leaders receive less accurate information.

Officials tell them what they want to hear.

Subordinates hide problems.

Citizens remain silent.

Bad decisions survive longer than they should.

The leader becomes surrounded by agreement.

And eventually, the government may discover that the silence around it was never evidence of success.

It was evidence of fear.

This is one of the great dangers of personalised authority.

The leader begins to believe that everyone agrees with him.

But perhaps everyone has simply learned that disagreement is costly.

The distinction may remain invisible for years.

Then, suddenly, the system encounters a crisis.

And the leader discovers that the loyalty he thought he possessed was never as deep as it appeared.

This is why the ability to disagree peacefully is not a weakness in government.

It is a form of political insurance.

Criticism allows pressure to escape.

Debate exposes mistakes.

Opposition forces explanations.

Independent journalism reveals information that officials may hide.

Courts can restrain abuses.

Civil society can identify problems before they become crises.

Without these mechanisms, pressure accumulates.

And accumulated pressure eventually finds another way out.

The author's argument is that Rwanda's political environment has often discouraged precisely these forms of open disagreement.

He describes a system in which people who challenge authority can become vulnerable, while those who remain loyal are rewarded with greater security and access.

If that description is accurate, the consequences extend far beyond individual political opponents.

They affect the entire society.

Imagine a young person growing up in such an environment.

He watches what happens to people who speak.

He watches what happens to people who remain quiet.

He notices who receives opportunities.

He notices who loses them.

He listens to adults.

He learns what subjects are safe.

He learns which names should not be mentioned casually.

He learns which opinions belong in private and which belong nowhere.

Nobody needs to give him a handbook.

He learns from observation.

This is how political culture is transmitted from one generation to another.

Fear becomes inherited not through blood, but through experience.

A parent tells a child:

Do not involve yourself in politics.

The child grows up and tells the same thing to his own children.

Eventually, an entire population may become politically passive even when many individuals privately disagree with the government.

This raises a profound question:

Can a society be politically stable if its stability depends upon people being afraid to challenge those in power?

Perhaps.

But such stability is different from democratic legitimacy.

Stability tells us that the system is functioning.

Legitimacy asks whether people have meaningful reasons to accept it.

The two can overlap.

They can also diverge.

A government may provide security and economic development while restricting political competition.

Citizens may appreciate the stability while disapproving of the restrictions.

They may simultaneously feel grateful and afraid.

Human political attitudes are rarely as simple as political propaganda suggests.

A citizen can admire a government's achievements and dislike its methods.

He can support national unity and still want greater freedom.

He can fear political instability and still believe that the government should be accountable.

These contradictions are not signs of ignorance.

They are often signs that people are living with competing realities.

The author wants the reader to notice those contradictions.

Because political systems are not experienced equally by everyone.

A senior official may experience the state as opportunity.

A dissident may experience it as surveillance.

A businessman may experience it as predictability.

A journalist may experience it as constraint.

A rural citizen may experience it primarily through local administration.

A former military officer may experience it through memories of command and loyalty.

The same state can therefore feel entirely different depending upon where one stands.

This is why political analysis must resist simplistic descriptions.

To call a country simply *free* or *unfree* may conceal more than it reveals.

The better questions are specific.

Can citizens organise politically?

Can opposition parties operate independently?

Can journalists investigate powerful officials?

Can judges rule against the government?

Can parliament genuinely challenge the executive?

Can a citizen criticise the president without fearing retaliation?

Can an official tell the president that he is wrong?

Can a soldier refuse an unlawful order?

Can a former ally become an opponent without becoming an enemy of the state?

These questions take us closer to the substance of political freedom.

And they lead directly back to the author's own experience.

For the author, the question of silence is not purely theoretical.

He presents himself as someone who once belonged to the political and military struggle and later found himself outside the system he had helped build.

That transformation is crucial.

A person who has never belonged to power can criticise it from the beginning.

A person who once believed in it must explain why his belief changed.

There is a different emotional weight to such a journey.

There is disappointment.

There may be anger.

There may be regret.

There may also be guilt.

Because leaving a political movement does not erase the memories of the people with whom one fought.

The author therefore writes not merely as an observer of Kagame's government, but as someone who claims to have experienced the movement from within.

That perspective gives the narrative its personal force.

But it also requires the reader to remain careful.

Personal experience can reveal things that official histories omit.

It can also be shaped by memory, conflict, and later interpretation.

Again, the answer is not to dismiss testimony.

It is to examine it.

The reader should ask:

What did the author personally witness?

What did he hear from others?

When did he learn it?

How certain was he at the time?

Did later events change the way he remembered earlier ones?

These questions do not diminish his story.

They strengthen the reader's ability to understand it.

Because the purpose of this book is not to replace one official narrative with another unquestionable narrative.

It is to open a space in which difficult questions can be asked.

And perhaps the most difficult question of all is this:

What does prolonged silence do to the human conscience?

A person can endure almost anything for a period of time.

But endurance has a cost.

The person who repeatedly suppresses his opinion may eventually suppress his sense of responsibility.

He begins to think:

It is not my problem.

Someone else will deal with it.

There is nothing I can do.

This is simply how things are.

That final sentence is perhaps the most dangerous.

This is simply how things are.

It transforms injustice into normality.

It turns fear into routine.

It teaches people not to ask whether something is right, only whether it is safe.

And once safety becomes more important than truth, political culture changes profoundly.

People stop asking:

Is this right?

They ask:

Can I survive it?

That is the moment when authoritarianism becomes more than a government structure.

It becomes a habit of mind.

And once that habit spreads, even people who dislike the system can become participants in preserving it.

They remain silent.

They adapt.

They survive.

They teach others to do the same.

The system does not need everyone to believe.

It only needs enough people to comply.

But there is another consequence.

When citizens are forced to carry responsibility for the actions of a political system merely because they belong to the same nation, fear can become collective.

People begin to feel that they must defend the government because criticism of the government will somehow implicate them personally.

The sins of leaders become confused with the identity of the nation.

The actions of officials become confused with the dignity of the people.

And disagreement becomes framed as betrayal.

This brings us to the next problem.

If political guilt can be extended beyond the individual who committed an act, then an entire population can be made to carry a burden that does not belong equally to everyone.

Who, then, should bear responsibility for the actions of a government?

The leader?

The officials?

The institutions?

The soldiers who obey?

The citizens who remain silent?

Or everyone?

That question takes us directly into the next section.

3.3 THE COLLECTIVE BURDEN OF GUILT

Guilt is personal.

Politics often tries to make it collective.

A government acts in the name of the nation.

A military fights in the name of the country.

A president speaks as though his decisions express the will of the people.

But when something goes wrong, who should answer for it?

Should every citizen bear responsibility for what the government does?

Should a soldier be guilty merely because he belongs to an army?

Should a civil servant be blamed for decisions made above him?

Should an ordinary citizen be condemned because he remained silent?

Or must responsibility remain attached to the person who made the decision?

These questions are not merely philosophical.

They are at the heart of how nations remember violence.

And Rwanda's history makes them impossible to avoid.

3.3 THE COLLECTIVE BURDEN OF GUILT

Guilt is personal.

Politics, however, has a dangerous habit of making it collective.

A government acts in the name of a nation. A president speaks in the name of the people. An army fights beneath a national flag. Political movements claim to represent an entire population.

But when something terrible is done, the language of responsibility can become confused.

Who is responsible?

The person who gave the order?

The person who carried it out?

The official who permitted it?

The institution that failed to stop it?

The people who knew and remained silent?

Or an entire population simply because the act was committed in its name?

These questions become especially difficult in countries that have experienced war, genocide, dictatorship, or revolutionary upheaval.

Rwanda is one such country.

The genocide against the Tutsi in 1994 left behind not only graves and destroyed families, but also a profound question of responsibility. How does a society distinguish between those who planned violence, those who participated in it, those who were forced into circumstances they did not choose, those who resisted it, and those who simply survived it?

The answer cannot be that everyone is equally guilty.

Such a conclusion would be morally absurd.

A person who planned a killing cannot carry the same responsibility as a person who was threatened into carrying out an order. A person who committed murder cannot be morally equivalent to a person who witnessed it and was too frightened to intervene. A government official who designed a policy cannot automatically be treated as equally responsible with a citizen who had no influence over that policy.

Responsibility has degrees.

It has circumstances.

It has intention.

It has action.

And it has consequence.

The distinction matters because political systems can use collective guilt in two opposite ways.

Sometimes collective guilt is imposed upon an entire population to justify punishment.

At other times, collective guilt is used by those in power to claim that criticism of the government is equivalent to criticism of the nation itself.

The first transforms citizens into suspects.

The second transforms the government into the nation.

Both are dangerous.

A president is not a country.

A political party is not a country.

An army is not a country.

A government is not a country.

The country is larger than all of them.

This may sound obvious, yet political language constantly blurs the distinction.

A leader says:

We have achieved this.

We have defeated them.

They are attacking us.

Our enemies want to destroy the country.

Sometimes the use of *we* is natural.

Sometimes it is strategic.

The danger appears when the leader's political survival becomes presented as identical to national survival.

Then an opponent is no longer merely opposing a president.

He is portrayed as opposing Rwanda.

A journalist investigating the government is no longer simply investigating officials.

He is accused of damaging the country.

A political critic is no longer merely a critic.

He becomes a threat to national unity.

Once that transformation occurs, political disagreement becomes morally loaded.

The government does not have to prove that the opponent is wrong.

It only needs to convince people that the opponent is dangerous.

Fear does the rest.

This is one reason historical trauma can be manipulated so easily.

A society that has genuinely experienced catastrophe does not need to be persuaded that catastrophe is possible.

Its people have seen it.

They remember.

Their parents remember.

Their children inherit the stories.

The fear is real.

And because the fear is real, political leaders can invoke it with extraordinary force.

The argument may be simple:

We know what happened before.

We know where division leads.

We cannot allow it to happen again.

There is truth in the warning.

The past must not be repeated.

But the warning can also be stretched beyond its legitimate purpose.

If every disagreement is treated as the beginning of another catastrophe, then political freedom becomes impossible.

A government could justify almost any restriction by claiming that it is preventing the return of violence.

The challenge, therefore, is to distinguish between genuine threats and political disagreement.

That distinction is not always easy.

A society must be able to prevent incitement to violence without criminalising ordinary criticism.

It must be able to confront hate speech without suppressing uncomfortable historical debate.

It must be able to protect national unity without demanding political unanimity.

These distinctions require mature institutions.

They require judges capable of applying the law independently.

They require journalists capable of investigating without intimidation.

They require politicians capable of disagreeing without treating one another as enemies of the state.

And they require citizens capable of holding two thoughts at the same time:

We must never return to the violence of the past.

And:

We must never use the memory of that violence to justify unlimited power in the present.

Those statements are not contradictory.

They are complementary.

The author argues that the burden of Rwanda's political history has sometimes been distributed in ways that make ordinary people responsible for decisions made by those above them.

This is where the idea of collective guilt becomes particularly troubling.

Imagine a soldier who joins an army because he believes he is defending his country.

He receives an order.

He obeys.

Later, the action is condemned.

Who is responsible?

The answer depends upon what the soldier knew, what the order required, whether it was lawful, whether he had the ability to refuse, and what he actually did.

Military discipline cannot erase personal responsibility.

But neither can personal responsibility be understood without context.

The same principle applies to civil servants.

A government employee may carry out an administrative decision he did not create.

A teacher may teach a curriculum he did not design.

A journalist may work within restrictions he did not establish.

An ordinary citizen may live under a political system he did not choose.

It would be unreasonable to treat all of them as equally responsible for the government's actions.

Yet political rhetoric often does precisely that.

It creates a single category:

us.

And once *us* has been created, everyone inside it becomes responsible for defending everything done in its name.

This can become a powerful tool of control.

The citizen begins to feel that criticism is dangerous because it might appear disloyal.

The official begins to defend a decision he privately dislikes because admitting its flaws might weaken the government.

The intellectual begins to censor himself because he does not want to be accused of helping the enemy.

The opposition leader begins to be treated not as a competitor but as a national threat.

The boundary between state and nation disappears.

And when that boundary disappears, accountability disappears with it.

A government can no longer be criticised without the critic being accused of attacking the country.

This is particularly dangerous for a country emerging from conflict.

Unity is necessary.

But unity cannot mean the disappearance of disagreement.

A healthy nation is not one in which everyone thinks alike.

It is one in which people who think differently can remain members of the same nation.

That is the deeper meaning of national unity.

Unity does not require identical opinions.

It requires a shared commitment to resolving differences without violence.

If two Rwandans disagree about their government, they remain equally Rwandan.

If one supports Kagame and another opposes him, neither automatically becomes more Rwandan than the other.

If one praises the government and another criticises it, the argument should concern the merits of their positions—not the legitimacy of their belonging.

This principle sounds simple.

History shows how difficult it can be to maintain.

Political movements frequently divide societies into moral categories.

The loyal.

The disloyal.

The patriots.

The traitors.

The victims.

The perpetrators.

The friends.

The enemies.

Sometimes these categories are necessary.

A person who commits genocide cannot simply be described as an ordinary political opponent.

A person who incites violence cannot hide behind the language of political disagreement.

There are circumstances in which society must draw moral boundaries.

But the boundaries must be based on actions and evidence, not inherited identity or political convenience.

Otherwise, collective guilt becomes permanent.

And permanent guilt can be inherited by people who had nothing to do with the original crime.

This is one of the great tragedies of political history.

Children can inherit the suspicion attached to their parents.

Communities can inherit the stigma attached to previous generations.

Political groups can become permanently associated with crimes committed by some of their members.

The result is that history stops being something we study and becomes something we live inside.

Every new generation is asked to answer for the previous one.

That is not justice.

It is historical captivity.

The alternative is difficult but necessary:

Remember everything, but assign responsibility precisely.

Remember the victims.

Remember the perpetrators.

Remember those who resisted.

Remember those who remained silent.

Remember those who benefited.

Remember those who suffered.

But do not erase the differences between them.

The moral clarity of history depends upon those distinctions.

This principle also applies to Kagame and the RPF.

The movement's supporters often emphasise the role it played in ending the genocide and rebuilding Rwanda.

Its critics emphasise alleged abuses, repression, killings, and regional military interventions.

Both sides tend to construct narratives that highlight some realities while minimising others.

The mature reader must resist becoming captive to either narrative.

A movement can stop a genocide and later commit abuses.

A government can rebuild a country and restrict political freedoms.

A leader can achieve genuine successes and still exercise excessive power.

A person can be both historically important and morally controversial.

History does not require us to choose only one description when several are true.

This is perhaps one of the most important principles of the entire book.

Human beings are rarely as simple as the political stories told about them.

The hero of one chapter can become the antagonist of another.

The liberator can become the ruler.

The revolutionary can become the establishment.

The victim can become an official.

The comrade can become an opponent.

The opponent can become a prisoner.

And the person who once demanded justice may later be accused of denying it to others.

Politics changes people.

Power tests them.

Memory judges them.

This is why collective guilt is so dangerous.

It prevents us from seeing individual choices.

It allows people to hide behind groups.

A perpetrator can say:

Everyone was doing it.

A government can say:

The nation supports us.

An opposition can say:

The people are with us.

But none of these statements answers the fundamental question:

What did you personally do?

That is where responsibility begins.

The individual must eventually emerge from the crowd.

The commander must answer for the order.

The official must answer for the decision.

The soldier must answer for his actions.

The journalist must answer for his reporting.

The politician must answer for his words.

And the citizen must answer, where appropriate, for his own choices.

But the citizen should not be forced to carry the guilt of the state simply because he lives under it.

Nor should the government be permitted to claim the achievements of the people while assigning the blame for its failures to society as a whole.

There is a final question here that cannot be avoided.

If a government repeatedly invokes national survival to justify extraordinary power, how long can that justification remain legitimate?

One year?

Ten years?

A generation?

Forever?

At what point does an emergency become a governing philosophy?

At what point does protection become control?

At what point does unity become obedience?

These are not questions that belong only to Rwanda.

They belong to every country that has experienced catastrophe and subsequently placed extraordinary trust in a strong leader.

The memory of suffering can create a genuine desire for order.

But order must eventually become institutional.

Otherwise, the country remains dependent upon the individual who promises to preserve it.

And when that happens, the burden of history becomes intertwined with the authority of the leader.

The people are told that they must remember the past.

But they are also encouraged to believe that only one political arrangement can prevent its return.

That is an extraordinary burden for a nation.

And it leads naturally to another political instrument:

apology.

Because once guilt becomes political, the demand for apology becomes political as well.

Who must apologise?

For what?

To whom?

When?

And what does an apology actually accomplish?

Can a leader apologise on behalf of an entire people?

Can an individual apologise for crimes he did not commit?

Can an apology heal a wound—or can it sometimes become another instrument of political power?

Those questions bring us to the next section.

3.4 THE POLITICS OF APOLOGY

There are words that can change the direction of a relationship.

There are words that can reopen an old wound.

And there are words that, when spoken by a political leader, can carry the weight of an entire nation.

Among the most powerful of these words is:

I am sorry.

An apology appears simple.

But politically, it can be extraordinarily complicated.

Who is apologising?

For what?

On whose behalf?

To whom?

And what does the apology ask from the person who receives it?

These questions matter because nations do not experience guilt in the same way individuals do.

An individual can commit a crime.

He can acknowledge it.

He can accept responsibility.

He can ask forgiveness.

A nation is different.

A nation contains millions of people who may have had nothing to do with the crime being discussed.

Yet political leaders often speak in the language of collective responsibility.

They say:

We apologise.

We accept responsibility.

We ask for forgiveness.

Sometimes this is necessary.

Sometimes it is courageous.

Sometimes it is deeply healing.

But sometimes the language of collective responsibility can become another way of distributing guilt.

That is where the politics of apology begins.

Rwanda's history makes the question particularly important.

The genocide against the Tutsi was not an abstract political disagreement. It was a catastrophe in which human beings were deliberately targeted and killed on a massive scale.

Remembering it requires moral clarity.

The victims must be remembered.

The perpetrators must be held accountable.

The history must be taught.

And the political conditions that allowed the genocide to occur must be understood.

But remembrance also raises another question:

Can a society move forward if it is permanently organised around guilt?

There is no easy answer.

For victims and survivors, forgiveness cannot be demanded.

Nobody who has suffered profound loss owes forgiveness to those who caused it.

Nor can an apology erase a life that has been taken.

A person who says *I am sorry* cannot bring the dead back.

A government that acknowledges wrongdoing cannot undo the past.

An apology cannot rebuild every destroyed family.

It cannot return a childhood.

It cannot restore a lost parent.

It cannot erase trauma.

And yet apologies matter.

Why?

Because refusing to acknowledge wrongdoing can deepen the wound.

When a victim hears the words *what happened to you was wrong*, something important has occurred.

The suffering has been recognised.

The person is no longer being told that the pain was imaginary.

The historical record has acknowledged what happened.

An apology therefore has at least two dimensions.

It can be moral.

And it can be political.

The moral dimension concerns remorse.

The political dimension concerns power.

Who has the authority to define what happened?

Who decides whose suffering is recognised?

Who decides when an apology is sufficient?

Who decides what must happen afterward?

These questions become especially important when governments use apologies as part of national reconciliation.

An apology can open a door.

But it cannot walk through the door for the victim.

Reconciliation requires more than words.

It requires truth.

It requires accountability.

It may require compensation.

It requires institutional reform.

And above all, it requires a credible commitment that the wrongdoing will not be repeated.

Otherwise, an apology becomes ceremony.

Beautiful words.

Public emotion.

Photographs.

Then nothing changes.

That is why the most important question after an apology is often not:

Did you say sorry?

It is:

What changed afterward?

Did the institution change?

Did the victims receive justice?

Were those responsible held accountable?

Were abuses investigated?

Were the same practices discontinued?

Were people allowed to speak openly about what happened?

Did the government accept criticism of its own conduct?

These questions turn an apology from a performance into a test.

The author is particularly concerned with the way political leaders can use historical guilt to strengthen their authority.

This is a delicate argument.

A government may legitimately remind citizens of history.

It may legitimately warn against repeating atrocities.

But historical memory becomes politically dangerous when it is used to establish that only one political group can be trusted with power.

The logic becomes:

We remember what happened before.

We defeated those responsible.

Therefore, we alone can protect the country from it happening again.

This argument can be emotionally compelling.

It can also become impossible to challenge.

Because anyone who opposes the government can then be accused of threatening the very peace that the government claims to protect.

The past becomes a shield around the present.

Criticism is no longer judged on its own merits.

It is judged according to whether it appears to endanger the historical settlement.

And once political debate reaches that point, democracy becomes extremely difficult.

A democratic society must be capable of remembering tragedy without making the government permanently immune from criticism.

Otherwise, historical trauma becomes a permanent political weapon.

This is not an argument for forgetting.

Quite the opposite.

The past must be remembered precisely because forgetting creates the possibility of repetition.

But remembrance should produce wisdom, not permanent political captivity.

A mature society should be able to say:

We remember what happened.

We know who suffered.

We know who was responsible.

We will never allow it to happen again.

And then ask:

How should our institutions operate today?

That last question is essential.

The past should inform the present.

It should not imprison it.

The politics of apology becomes even more complicated when leaders are asked to apologise for actions committed by institutions that existed before them.

Should a president apologise for the crimes of a previous government?

Often, yes.

A leader may recognise the suffering caused by the state even if he personally had no involvement.

Such an apology can be a powerful acknowledgment that the state accepts responsibility for its historical actions.

But there is a distinction between institutional responsibility and personal guilt.

The present leader may speak for the state.

That does not necessarily mean he personally committed the crime.

Likewise, an ordinary citizen may belong to the same national community as the perpetrators without personally bearing their guilt.

Again, precision matters.

The danger of imprecise political language is that it can transform history into inherited moral debt.

A young person born long after a tragedy may be made to feel personally responsible for something he did not do.

At the same time, another young person may be taught that his community is permanently entitled to political power because of what happened to its ancestors.

Both ideas can perpetuate division.

The healthier alternative is historical responsibility without inherited hatred.

We can say:

This happened.

These people suffered.

These people committed the crimes.

These institutions failed.

These lessons must be remembered.

Without saying:

Therefore, you must hate one another forever.

That is the difference between remembrance and revenge.

The author also raises the question of political apologies in the context of Kagame himself.

What happens when a leader who presents himself as the protector of a nation is accused of abuses committed under his government?

Does he owe an apology?

To whom?

For which actions?

Can he acknowledge wrongdoing without weakening the legitimacy of the state?

And what happens if he refuses?

These questions are particularly revealing because strong leaders often present themselves as embodiments of national strength.

An apology can therefore appear to threaten the image of authority.

A leader may fear that admitting wrongdoing will be interpreted as weakness.

But genuine accountability requires precisely the opposite understanding.

A leader who can say *I was wrong* may demonstrate strength rather than weakness.

The inability to admit error is far more dangerous.

A government that believes it must always appear perfect eventually becomes incapable of correcting itself.

Every mistake must be defended.

Every criticism must be rejected.

Every failure must be explained away.

And eventually, the government begins protecting its reputation rather than solving its problems.

That is how political pride can become institutional weakness.

The most dangerous sentence in government may not be:

We made a mistake.

It may be:

We cannot admit that we made a mistake.

Because once a leader becomes trapped by his own image, every correction becomes humiliating.

Every concession becomes dangerous.

Every apology becomes politically costly.

And the people around him learn to protect the image rather than tell the truth.

The result is a government increasingly separated from reality.

The leader hears praise.

The public hears propaganda.

Officials repeat the official position.

Opponents are dismissed.

And the truth becomes something people discuss privately.

This returns us to the theme of silence.

Guilt can produce silence.

Fear can produce silence.

Political loyalty can produce silence.

And the refusal to apologise can produce another form of silence—the silence of a government unwilling to acknowledge the suffering that its own actions may have caused.

But apology also has limits.

It cannot become a substitute for justice.

A government cannot commit an abuse, apologise publicly, and then declare the matter finished.

An apology should begin accountability, not end it.

Nor should an apology be demanded simply to humiliate a political opponent.

If the purpose is revenge, the words lose their moral value.

A genuine apology is not surrender.

It is recognition.

It says:

Something happened.

It was wrong.

People were harmed.

We recognise their suffering.

We accept responsibility for what belongs to us.

And we will try to ensure it does not happen again.

That final promise is perhaps the most important part.

Because the ultimate purpose of political memory is not to keep people permanently trapped in yesterday.

It is to prevent yesterday from returning.

A nation does not honour its victims simply by remembering their names.

It honours them by building institutions that make similar crimes harder to commit.

It honours them by protecting the vulnerable.

It honours them by permitting truth to be spoken.

It honours them by allowing power to be challenged.

It honours them by ensuring that no leader becomes so powerful that the law can no longer reach him.

This brings us to a deeper paradox.

Sometimes the strongest governments speak constantly about the past because the past provides their greatest source of legitimacy.

The government says:

Remember what came before us.

The question we must then ask is:

What should we be allowed to say about what comes after you?

That is where historical legitimacy meets democratic accountability.

A government may have earned its authority through what it accomplished in the past.

But past achievements cannot provide an unlimited licence for future actions.

A leader who once saved a country can still make a mistake.

A movement that once liberated people can still abuse power.

A government that once restored order can still become too powerful.

History grants no one permanent immunity.

That principle is uncomfortable.

It is also necessary.

The political use of apology therefore reveals something larger about power.

Power wants to control not only the present, but the interpretation of the past.

If a government controls the story of yesterday, it can influence the political choices of today.

If it can define who is guilty, it can define who deserves trust.

If it can define who deserves trust, it can define who deserves power.

And if it can define who deserves power, it can make its own continuation appear inevitable.

That is why the politics of apology is never simply about saying sorry.

It is about memory.

It is about responsibility.

It is about legitimacy.

And ultimately, it is about who has the authority to tell a nation what its history means.

The next section takes us to another turning point in the story.

Because political power is not maintained only through speeches about history.

It can also be maintained through fear of what might happen next.

And when fear moves from political argument into physical violence, the consequences become even more profound.

The author therefore turns to the beginning of the bombings.

A new question enters the narrative:

When political conflict begins to produce explosions, who benefits from the chaos—and who gets to decide who is responsible?

3.5 THE BEGINNING OF THE BOMBINGS

There is a moment in every political conflict when fear changes character.

Before violence becomes visible, people may fear words.

They fear rumours.

They fear political meetings.

They fear arrests.

They fear what might happen to them if they are seen standing beside the wrong person.

But when explosions begin, fear acquires another dimension.

It becomes physical.

A person no longer asks only:

What will happen if I speak?

He begins to ask:

Where will the next explosion happen?

That is a very different kind of fear.

A bombing transforms an argument about politics into a question of survival.

It does not matter whether the victim is a politician, a soldier, a businessman, a student, or an ordinary passer-by.

An explosion does not distinguish between political loyalties.

It destroys.

And because it destroys without warning, it creates an atmosphere in which almost anyone can become a potential victim.

The beginning of the bombings therefore represents an important turning point in the author's narrative.

The political struggle is no longer confined to offices, military camps, political meetings, or private conversations.

Violence enters public life.

The city itself becomes part of the conflict.

A street that was ordinary yesterday can become dangerous today.

A public gathering can become a target.

A vehicle can become a weapon.

And an ordinary journey home can suddenly become a question of life and death.

Yet there is another reason bombings are politically significant.

An explosion produces not only casualties.

It produces narratives.

Almost immediately, people begin asking:

Who did it?

And that question can be as politically consequential as the bombing itself.

If the government says one group was responsible, that group becomes the enemy.

If the opposition says the government staged the attack, suspicion turns in the opposite direction.

If neither side can prove its claim, rumours fill the vacuum.

The explosion may last only seconds.

The political consequences can last for years.

This is why the investigation of political violence must be extraordinarily careful.

The first explanation is not necessarily the correct one.

The loudest accusation is not necessarily the strongest evidence.

And the person who benefits politically from an event is not automatically the person who caused it.

These distinctions may appear obvious.

In an atmosphere of fear, they are easily forgotten.

People want answers immediately.

Governments want to reassure the public.

Opposition groups want to defend themselves.

Journalists want a story.

Citizens want someone to blame.

But truth rarely moves at the speed of political fear.

It takes time.

It requires evidence.

It requires witnesses.

It requires forensic investigation.

It requires the willingness to follow evidence even when the evidence points somewhere politically inconvenient.

That last requirement is perhaps the most difficult.

A genuine investigation cannot begin with the conclusion.

It must begin with the question.

What happened?

Only afterward should it ask:

Who was responsible?

This distinction becomes particularly important in the author's discussion of the beginning of bombings in Rwanda.

The events described in this section are presented within a broader political environment characterised by distrust and confrontation.

Different actors had competing interests.

The government had an interest in maintaining order and identifying threats.

Opposition movements had an interest in challenging the government's narrative.

Security institutions had an interest in preventing further attacks.

Ordinary citizens had an interest in simply surviving.

Each actor therefore looked at the same explosion from a different position.

And that meant the same event could produce radically different interpretations.

To the government, the bombing could demonstrate the existence of a dangerous enemy.

To the opposition, it could demonstrate the government's failure to protect its citizens.

To a conspiracy theorist, it could become evidence of a hidden plan.

To a victim's family, it could simply be the moment when everything changed forever.

Political history often forgets the last perspective.

It concentrates on governments and organisations.

It names commanders and politicians.

It analyses strategies.

But behind every political bombing is a human being.

Someone had plans for tomorrow.

Someone expected to return home.

Someone was waiting for a phone call.

Someone was raising a child.

Someone had a friend who expected to see him again.

Violence turns ordinary lives into historical statistics.

The author wants the reader to resist that reduction.

A death is not merely an event in a political timeline.

It is a world disappearing for the people who knew the victim.

This is particularly important when violence becomes politically useful.

The dead can be used by both sides.

One side may say:

Look at what they have done.

The other may say:

Look at what they are capable of.

The victim becomes evidence.

The dead person becomes a political argument.

And once that happens, there is a danger that the individual disappears beneath the political narrative.

But there is another uncomfortable reality.

Violence can create political opportunities.

An attack can justify stronger security measures.

It can strengthen the government's argument that opponents are dangerous.

It can weaken public sympathy for political dissent.

It can encourage citizens to accept restrictions they would previously have rejected.

This does not mean that governments necessarily create attacks for political advantage.

It means only that violence can produce political consequences that governments may exploit.

The distinction matters.

Opportunity is not proof of responsibility.

A person who benefits from a crime is not automatically the person who committed it.

But investigators should still ask who benefited.

It is one question among many.

Who had the capability?

Who had the motive?

Who had the opportunity?

Who had the knowledge?

Who attempted to conceal the evidence?

Who changed their behaviour afterward?

Who gained politically?

Who lost?

And, most importantly:

What does the evidence actually show?

These questions are the foundation of serious investigation.

Without them, political history becomes storytelling.

And storytelling can be dangerous when lives are at stake.

The beginning of the bombings also reveals another feature of political violence: its ability to create reciprocal fear.

One attack produces retaliation.

Retaliation produces another attack.

Each side claims that it is responding to the other.

Soon, nobody remembers who acted first.

Every new act is justified by an earlier act.

Violence becomes self-referential.

We did this because they did that.

They did that because we did this.

The chain becomes endless.

This is how political conflicts can move from disagreement into cycles of violence.

The original grievance may become almost irrelevant.

What matters is revenge.

And revenge has no natural endpoint.

Someone must eventually decide to stop.

That is why political leadership matters.

A responsible leader does not merely ask:

How can we defeat them?

He must also ask:

What kind of country will remain after we have defeated them?

That question is often neglected during conflict.

Victory appears to be the only objective.

But political victory achieved through permanent fear can leave a country deeply damaged.

People may obey.

But obedience is not reconciliation.

Silence is not peace.

The absence of explosions is not necessarily the absence of conflict.

Sometimes the violence simply changes form.

It moves underground.

It becomes political exclusion.

It becomes intimidation.

It becomes economic punishment.

It becomes the destruction of reputations.

It becomes exile.

It becomes fear.

The author therefore treats the bombings not as isolated incidents but as part of a larger evolution in the political struggle.

The question is not merely who planted a particular bomb.

The larger question is:

What political environment made such violence possible?

And then:

What happened to the political culture after violence became normal?

Once a government begins viewing political opponents through the lens of security, ordinary political competition becomes difficult.

A political opponent can be treated as a security threat.

A security threat can be treated as an enemy.

And an enemy can be treated as someone who must be neutralised.

This is the dangerous progression.

It begins with a legitimate concern.

Governments have a responsibility to protect citizens.

They must investigate attacks.

They must prevent future violence.

They must identify those responsible.

But the exceptional powers justified by security concerns must remain subject to law.

Otherwise, the fight against violence can create another form of violence.

This is the paradox of counterterrorism and counterinsurgency everywhere:

How do you defeat violent actors without allowing the state to become unaccountable?

The answer lies in institutions.

Independent courts.

Credible investigations.

Transparent procedures.

Evidence.

Due process.

Oversight.

And a clear distinction between an armed attacker and a peaceful political opponent.

Without those distinctions, almost anyone can eventually be described as a threat.

The history of many countries demonstrates how easily emergency politics becomes permanent politics.

A government says:

We need these powers temporarily.

Then the emergency continues.

Then another emergency appears.

Then another.

Eventually, extraordinary authority becomes ordinary government.

Citizens become accustomed to surveillance.

Officials become accustomed to secrecy.

Security agencies become accustomed to operating without scrutiny.

And the public becomes accustomed to the argument:

These measures are necessary for our safety.

Safety is important.

But safety cannot be allowed to become a blank cheque.

The beginning of the bombings therefore marks more than the beginning of a violent tactic.

It marks the beginning of another political logic.

Once violence enters the political arena, fear becomes easier to justify.

Once fear becomes widespread, stronger control becomes easier to justify.

And once stronger control becomes normal, political dissent becomes easier to portray as dangerous.

The circle closes.

Violence creates fear.

Fear creates control.

Control creates resentment.

Resentment creates opposition.

Opposition is portrayed as a threat.

The government responds with more control.

And the cycle continues.

Breaking that cycle requires more than defeating one armed group.

It requires creating political conditions in which citizens can challenge their government without believing that their only alternatives are silence or violence.

That is the deeper lesson.

A government should make peaceful opposition possible precisely because peaceful opposition is one of the strongest alternatives to political violence.

If citizens cannot change political conditions through speech, organisation, elections, courts, journalism, and lawful protest, some will eventually conclude that there is no peaceful route left.

That does not justify violence.

Nothing does.

But it helps explain why healthy political institutions matter.

The prevention of violence begins long before the first explosion.

It begins with the creation of a political system in which grievances can be expressed without fear.

The author now takes the narrative into an even more painful dimension of wartime violence.

Bombings can kill.

But war can also violate the body in another way.

It can turn sexual violence into a weapon.

And when that happens, the question is no longer simply how political power destroys through weapons.

It becomes a question of how power can invade the most intimate boundaries of human dignity.

3.6 SEXUAL VIOLENCE AND THE POLITICS OF WAR

War does not always announce itself with a gunshot.

Sometimes it enters a home.

Sometimes it enters the body.

And sometimes its most devastating wounds are the ones that cannot be seen from a distance.

Sexual violence during conflict is not merely an act of private brutality.

It can become a weapon.

A method of humiliation.

A means of terror.

A way of destroying families and communities.

And when it is used systematically, it becomes part of the politics of war itself.

The question, then, is not only:

Who was attacked?

It is:

Why was the body made a battlefield?

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The question, then, is not only:

Who was attacked?

It is:

Why was the body made a battlefield?

That question takes us beyond the individual crime and into the psychology of armed conflict.

A war is fought over territory, political authority, resources, identity, and power. Yet the consequences of war are experienced through individual bodies.

A village can be captured.

A city can be occupied.

A government can be overthrown.

But for the person who experiences sexual violence, the battlefield is no longer somewhere else.

It is the place where she lives.

It is her home.

Her body.

Her sense of dignity.

Her relationship with her family.

Her ability to trust another human being.

This is why sexual violence in war should never be reduced to a footnote in a military history.

It is not a secondary consequence.

It can be part of the strategy itself.

The purpose may be to humiliate an individual.

It may be to terrorise an entire community.

It may be intended to punish perceived enemies.

It may be used to demonstrate that the perpetrators possess absolute power over the people they have conquered.

In that sense, sexual violence can communicate a political message:

We can do anything to you.

And perhaps even more frighteningly:

There is nowhere you are beyond our reach.

That is what makes it so destructive.

The violence does not end when the perpetrators leave.

The victim may carry the consequences for decades.

She may struggle with shame that does not belong to her.

She may fear rejection.

She may be unable to speak about what happened.

She may remain silent because society has taught her that the victim must carry the disgrace of the perpetrator.

This is one of the cruelest distortions produced by sexual violence.

The person who committed the crime may disappear.

The victim remains.

And then society sometimes asks the victim to explain herself.

Why was she there?

Why did she not escape?

Why did she not resist?

Why did she not speak sooner?

Why did she not tell her family?

Why did she remain silent?

These questions place the burden in the wrong place.

The correct question is simpler:

Why did the perpetrator believe he had the right to violate another human being?

The responsibility belongs to the perpetrator.

And where the violence was organised, encouraged, tolerated, or systematically ignored, responsibility must also be examined at the institutional level.

This is where sexual violence becomes a political question.

If an individual soldier commits a crime without authorisation, that is one matter.

If commanders know that such crimes are occurring and do nothing, the question becomes larger.

If commanders encourage them, it becomes larger still.

If sexual violence forms part of an organised campaign, it becomes a matter of political and military strategy.

Therefore, investigations must ask not only what happened to victims but also what happened within the chain of command.

Were complaints made?

Were they investigated?

Were perpetrators punished?

Were commanders aware?

Did the pattern continue?

Were victims protected?

Was evidence preserved?

Did institutions deny the allegations?

These questions matter because accountability is not achieved merely by identifying individual perpetrators.

Institutions must also be examined.

A military organisation demonstrates its character not only through the orders it gives, but through what it permits.

A commander who discovers abuse and immediately investigates it sends one message.

A commander who ignores it sends another.

Silence itself can become a form of permission.

This is particularly important in conflicts where political leaders present their armies as disciplined, patriotic forces fighting for national survival.

The more noble the stated purpose of a war, the more important the conduct of the soldiers becomes.

A government cannot credibly claim to be defending human dignity while tolerating systematic violations of that dignity.

The contradiction is too profound.

A political movement may begin by claiming that it is fighting for liberation.

But liberation cannot mean replacing one person's domination with another person's domination.

It cannot mean exchanging one form of fear for another.

It cannot mean that the people who suffered under the old order must now remain silent because the new order considers itself historically justified.

The moral test of a liberation movement is not only how it defeats its enemy.

It is how it treats people when it possesses power.

That distinction separates revolution from government.

During a struggle, leaders can argue that extraordinary measures are necessary because the enemy is dangerous.

After victory, however, the justification must change.

The new question becomes:

What limits will the victors place upon themselves?

This is where the history of Rwanda becomes especially complicated.

The genocide against the Tutsi created an extraordinary moral and political context.

The RPF emerged from a military struggle and eventually took control of the country.

Its victory ended the genocide.

But the end of one catastrophe did not automatically answer every question about what happened afterward.

The history of the subsequent years contains competing accounts of violence, military operations, political repression, and abuses committed by different actors.

Some allegations have been strongly contested.

Others have been investigated.

Some remain disputed.

A serious account must therefore distinguish between established historical facts, documented allegations, witness testimony, political interpretation, and claims that remain unresolved.

That distinction is not a weakness.

It is intellectual honesty.

The temptation in politically charged histories is to make every allegation sound equally certain.

That creates a dramatic book.

It does not necessarily create a truthful one.

The reader deserves to know where the evidence is strong and where the argument depends upon testimony, inference, or disputed accounts.

That is particularly important when the subject is sexual violence.

False accusations can destroy lives.

But dismissing credible allegations can destroy justice.

The answer is not to choose between belief and disbelief as a political position.

The answer is investigation.

Evidence.

Witness protection.

Medical documentation where available.

Independent testimony.

Patterns.

Dates.

Locations.

Chain of command.

And corroboration.

The truth deserves nothing less.

There is also a gendered dimension to political violence that is often overlooked.

Women are frequently described in histories of war as victims.

But women are not merely passive participants in history.

They are political actors, soldiers, organisers, witnesses, survivors, journalists, mothers, negotiators, and leaders.

Sexual violence attempts to reduce them to bodies.

Historical writing must restore their humanity.

A woman who survives sexual violence is not defined by what was done to her.

She is a person who endured something terrible.

The language used to describe her matters.

A careless narrative can violate her dignity again.

A responsible narrative must avoid turning suffering into spectacle.

This is why the author's treatment of sexual violence must be approached with particular care.

The purpose should not be to shock the reader.

The purpose should be to make the reader understand what violence means when political conflict enters the most intimate part of human existence.

The statistics of war can become numbing.

Hundreds killed.

Thousands displaced.

Tens of thousands affected.

Numbers allow us to understand scale.

But numbers cannot communicate experience.

One survivor can sometimes teach us more about war than a thousand statistics.

A single testimony can reveal what an abstract word such as *conflict* actually means.

It can reveal the moment when a person stops feeling safe in her own home.

It can reveal how a community responds.

It can reveal how silence is imposed.

And it can reveal how difficult justice becomes when the perpetrators belong to powerful institutions.

This is where sexual violence connects once again to the central theme of this book:

power.

The ability to violate another person is an expression of power.

The ability to conceal the violation is another.

The ability to prevent investigation is another.

The ability to determine which stories are believed is another.

And the ability to make victims afraid to speak is perhaps the most effective form of all.

Therefore, when examining allegations of sexual violence during political conflict, we must examine the entire structure surrounding the crime.

Who possessed power?

Who lacked it?

Who could speak?

Who could not?

Who controlled the institutions?

Who controlled the narrative?

Who could obtain justice?

And who was expected simply to endure?

These questions bring us back to the recurring theme of this chapter.

Endure. Remain silent. Bear it.

For a victim of sexual violence, those words can describe an unbearable reality.

She may be told to remain silent because speaking will bring shame upon the family.

She may be told that the perpetrators are powerful.

She may be told that nothing can be done.

She may be told that the country needs unity.

She may be told that speaking now will reopen old wounds.

Every explanation may sound reasonable.

Together, they can produce silence.

And silence protects the powerful far more effectively than many people realise.

This is why truth-telling matters.

Not because every allegation must automatically become a conviction.

But because every credible allegation deserves a process through which truth can be established.

Justice cannot begin where investigation is forbidden.

Nor can reconciliation begin where victims are required to forget.

A society cannot heal simply by declaring that it has healed.

Healing requires truth.

Sometimes truth is painful.

Sometimes it embarrasses national heroes.

Sometimes it damages political reputations.

Sometimes it complicates the story a country tells about itself.

That is precisely why truth matters.

If a nation only remembers the parts of history that make it proud, it is not remembering history.

It is creating mythology.

And mythology can be dangerous when it governs real people.

A mature nation must be able to honour its heroes while examining their mistakes.

It must be able to condemn its enemies while recognising the humanity of their victims.

It must be able to celebrate liberation while asking what happened after liberation.

It must be able to remember genocide while refusing to excuse every action committed in its aftermath.

This is not an attempt to diminish the suffering of one group by mentioning the suffering of another.

Victims should never have to compete.

One person's suffering does not cancel another's.

Truth is not a competition.

If something happened, acknowledging it does not diminish another historical fact.

Instead, it makes the historical record more complete.

This principle is especially important in Rwanda and the wider Great Lakes region, where competing memories of violence have shaped political identities for generations.

Each community has memories.

Each political movement has grievances.

Each family carries stories.

And sometimes those stories contradict one another.

The task of history is not to silence the contradiction.

It is to investigate it.

Because reconciliation based upon a single permitted narrative may produce silence.

Reconciliation based upon truth has a chance of producing peace.

The difference is enormous.

Silence says:

Do not talk about this.

Truth says:

Let us understand what happened.

Fear says:

If you speak, you may suffer.

Justice says:

You should be able to speak, and the evidence should be examined.

Propaganda says:

Our side could never do such a thing.

History says:

Let us investigate before deciding.

That is the standard this book must ultimately demand of itself.

It is easy to condemn one side.

It is harder to examine everyone.

It is easy to tell the reader who the heroes are.

It is harder to acknowledge when heroes have made mistakes.

It is easy to describe enemies as monsters.

It is harder to understand how ordinary human beings become capable of terrible acts.

But serious political writing requires the harder path.

Because the moment we turn history into a story of perfect heroes and perfect villains, we stop learning from it.

The question is therefore not simply whether sexual violence occurred during particular conflicts.

The deeper question is what political conditions allow human beings to treat other human beings as instruments of war.

What happens when soldiers believe that victory excuses everything?

What happens when commanders believe that discipline matters only when it serves them?

What happens when victims are afraid to speak?

What happens when governments control the institutions that are supposed to investigate them?

And what happens when the international community knows that allegations exist but chooses political convenience over uncomfortable truth?

These questions extend beyond Rwanda.

They belong to every war.

But they are particularly important in a region where political power, military force, ethnic identity, national borders, and historical memory have repeatedly collided.

The body becomes a battlefield because power seeks to demonstrate that it can cross every boundary.

The answer must therefore be equally fundamental:

There are boundaries power must never be permitted to cross.

Not the boundary of a home.

Not the boundary of a human body.

Not the boundary of dignity.

Not the boundary between military necessity and criminal brutality.

And not the boundary between political authority and personal impunity.

When those boundaries disappear, war ceases to be merely a struggle over who governs.

It becomes a struggle over what it means to remain human.

And that brings us to the next question.

If power can become so valuable that leaders are willing to tolerate extraordinary measures to preserve it, then what happens when a leader begins to see his own continued rule as necessary for the survival of the country?

Why would a president seek to remain in power?

Is it ambition?

Fear?

Ideology?

A belief that only he can protect the nation?

Or is it something more complicated—the knowledge that leaving office may expose everything that happened while he was in power to scrutiny?

These questions take us into the next section.

3.7 WHY KAGAME WOULD SEEK TO REMAIN IN POWER

A leader may seek power because he wants it.

That is the simplest explanation.

But it is rarely the whole explanation.

Power can become addictive, but it can also become protective.

The longer a leader remains in office, the more his personal fate becomes connected to the fate of the political system around him.

Leaving office may no longer mean simply retiring.

It may mean losing protection.

It may mean losing influence.

It may mean facing opponents.

It may mean allowing decisions made during one's presidency to be investigated by people who no longer depend upon one's authority.

And so another question appears:

Does a leader remain in power because he wants more power—or because he fears what might happen if he gives it up?

The answer can sometimes be both.

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The answer can sometimes be both.

This is one of the great paradoxes of political power.

A person may enter government believing that he must remain in control because the country is fragile.

Years later, the same belief can become the reason he cannot leave.

At first, the argument is:

The country still needs me.

Then:

The institutions are not ready.

Then:

The opposition cannot be trusted.

Then:

My departure could destabilise everything we have built.

Each argument may contain some truth.

But together they can produce an extraordinary conclusion:

Therefore, I must remain.

And once a leader reaches that conclusion, every political challenge becomes more serious.

An election is no longer simply an election.

It becomes a referendum on national stability.

An opposition party is no longer simply an opponent.

It becomes a possible source of disorder.

A critical journalist is no longer simply a journalist.

He becomes someone who may weaken confidence in the state.

A former ally who becomes a critic is no longer merely a disappointed colleague.

He may be interpreted as a potential threat.

The leader's continued rule gradually becomes framed as a national necessity.

This is one of the defining characteristics of personalised political systems.

The distinction between **the country** and **the leader** begins to disappear.

The leader may genuinely believe that the distinction does not exist.

He may look at the chaos that preceded his government and conclude that his own leadership is the barrier preventing its return.

If he has witnessed war, exile, genocide, assassination, or state collapse, that belief may not be irrational.

It may be deeply rooted in experience.

But a belief can be understandable and still become dangerous.

Because no country should ultimately depend upon the permanent presence of one individual.

Institutions exist precisely because individuals are temporary.

Presidents die.

Leaders age.

Generations change.

Political circumstances change.

The state must remain.

This is why succession is one of the most important tests of political maturity.

A strong leader should be capable of building a system that can survive his departure.

A weak political system makes the opposite assumption:

Without him, everything will collapse.

If that assumption becomes widespread, leaving office becomes almost impossible.

Supporters begin saying:

Who else can lead us?

The question sounds flattering.

It is actually dangerous.

A healthy democracy should always have an answer.

There should always be another generation of leaders.

Another political party.

Another candidate.

Another set of ideas.

If the political system cannot imagine a future without its current leader, then it has failed to institutionalise power.

It has personalised it.

The author interprets Kagame's long tenure through this lens.

He asks why Kagame would want to remain at the centre of Rwanda's political system for so long.

The answer, in his interpretation, cannot be reduced simply to personal ambition.

There may be ideology.

There may be fear of instability.

There may be concern about what a successor could do.

There may be concern about what former opponents might do.

There may be concern about the fate of the political and military structures built under his leadership.

And there may be the psychological difficulty of relinquishing authority after decades of exercising it.

These factors can reinforce one another.

Power creates enemies.

Enemies create fear.

Fear creates a desire for security.

Security creates greater concentration of power.

Greater concentration of power creates more enemies.

The cycle repeats.

This is why authoritarianism can become self-preserving.

The leader may eventually find himself trapped by the system he created.

If he loosens control, people who have suffered under the system may demand accountability.

If he tightens control, the number of people who fear him may increase.

The system therefore moves toward greater rigidity.

This phenomenon is not unique to Rwanda.

History contains many examples of leaders who remained in power long after the original justification for their rule had disappeared.

Some began as liberators.

Some began as revolutionaries.

Some began as national saviours.

Some began as reformers.

Over time, the movement became the government.

The government became the state.

And the leader became inseparable from all three.

That transformation is dangerous because it changes the meaning of loyalty.

In a healthy political system, loyalty should be directed primarily toward the constitution, the country, and the law.

In a personalised system, loyalty can gradually become loyalty to the leader.

The difference is enormous.

If loyalty belongs to the constitution, a citizen can oppose the president while remaining patriotic.

If loyalty belongs to the leader, opposing the president can be portrayed as betrayal.

That is how political disagreement becomes morally dangerous.

The author sees this tension throughout the political history he describes.

Former comrades who once fought together eventually find themselves on opposite sides.

People who once shared the same objective become suspicious of one another.

Some remain inside the system.

Others leave.

Some become critics.

Others become opponents.

And the distance between them grows.

This raises another question:

What does a leader fear more—the opposition of strangers or the criticism of former friends?

Often, it is the latter.

A stranger can be dismissed as an enemy.

A former ally knows too much.

He knows the history.

He knows the personalities.

He knows the internal disagreements.

He may know what was said behind closed doors.

He may know how decisions were actually made.

He may remember the period before the official narrative was established.

This makes former allies uniquely complicated political actors.

Their criticism can be more damaging because it comes from experience.

But it can also be more emotionally charged.

The former ally may not simply disagree with the leader.

He may feel betrayed.

The leader may not simply see him as an opponent.

He may see him as someone who abandoned the cause.

This is how political relationships become personal.

And once politics becomes personal, compromise becomes harder.

The author himself occupies this difficult position in the narrative.

He writes not as someone who discovered Kagame from a distance, but as someone who describes having been part of the struggle and later becoming critical of the system.

That gives his account a particular character.

It is partly political analysis.

Partly testimony.

Partly accusation.

And partly a record of disappointment.

The reader must therefore distinguish between what the author knows, what he believes, what he interprets, and what remains contested.

That distinction does not weaken his argument.

It gives the argument intellectual discipline.

A book about political power should not reproduce the very certainty it criticises.

If authoritarianism demands unquestioning belief, then serious historical writing should demand questioning.

Every claim should be examined.

Every motive should be tested.

Every accusation should be separated from evidence.

And every conclusion should remain proportional to what can actually be established.

This is particularly important when discussing a leader who has remained in power for decades.

Long rule can mean many things.

It can mean popularity.

It can mean institutional control.

It can mean fear.

It can mean weak opposition.

It can mean genuine public support.

It can mean a combination of all of these.

The existence of longevity alone does not tell us which explanation is correct.

We must examine the political system around it.

How are elections conducted?

How competitive are they?

What happens to political opponents?

How independent are institutions?

How freely can citizens organise?

How much control does the ruling party possess?

How powerful is the security apparatus?

How easily can leadership change occur?

These questions matter more than the simple number of years a leader has served.

And this brings us to the issue of constitutional change.

Because when a leader approaches the formal end of his permitted tenure, the question becomes unavoidable:

Will the leader leave, or will the rules change?

The answer tells us a great deal about the relationship between a leader and the constitution.

A constitution should be stronger than the person who temporarily occupies the presidency.

If the constitution must change whenever the president approaches its limits, then the constitution is no longer functioning primarily as a limit on power.

It is becoming an instrument of power.

That does not automatically mean that every constitutional amendment is illegitimate.

Constitutions sometimes need to change.

Societies evolve.

Political systems require reform.

Laws can contain weaknesses.

But when constitutional change coincides with the desire of a sitting leader to remain in office, scrutiny becomes essential.

Who proposed the change?

Who debated it?

Who opposed it?

Was the public able to participate meaningfully?

Was there a genuine alternative?

Did institutions act independently?

And perhaps most importantly:

Would the same constitutional change have been accepted if it prevented the incumbent from remaining in power?

These questions help distinguish institutional reform from political manipulation.

They also take us directly to the historical moment when Kagame's own presidential tenure became a major constitutional question.

3.8 THE PRESIDENCY BEYOND 2017

Every political leader eventually encounters a boundary.

Sometimes it is imposed by age.

Sometimes by illness.

Sometimes by an election.

Sometimes by a constitution.

Sometimes by political reality.

The boundary matters because it forces a leader to answer a question that power can postpone but never eliminate:

What happens after me?

For Kagame, the question became particularly significant as Rwanda approached 2017.

The constitution had established limits on presidential tenure, and the approaching end of Kagame's permitted time in office brought the issue of succession into the centre of political debate.

This was more than a question about one election.

It was a test of the principle that political power should have limits.

If the president left office, Rwanda would face the challenge of demonstrating that the institutions created during his leadership were capable of surviving without him.

If he remained, the country would have to explain why the constitutional framework should change.

Either path carried consequences.

Departure would test succession.

Continuation would test constitutionalism.

And both would reveal something about the nature of the Rwandan political system.

The debate surrounding Kagame's future therefore became a debate about more than Kagame.

It became a debate about the meaning of the presidency itself.

Is the presidency an office temporarily entrusted to an individual?

Or can the individual become so closely associated with national stability that the ordinary rules surrounding the office must be reconsidered?

That distinction lies at the heart of constitutional government.

The purpose of term limits is not necessarily to suggest that a president becomes incompetent after a particular number of years.

Nor does a term limit mean that a successful leader should be removed simply because time has passed.

Its deeper purpose is to prevent political power from becoming permanently attached to one person.

Term limits force renewal.

They create opportunities for succession.

They reduce the incentive to manipulate institutions in order to preserve personal rule.

And they remind both leaders and citizens of a fundamental principle:

No political office belongs permanently to the person occupying it.

But there is another side to the argument.

Supporters of Kagame could reasonably ask:

Why should a country remove a leader who has delivered stability and development simply because a predetermined limit has been reached?

If citizens genuinely support him, why should they not be allowed to choose him again?

This is not an absurd question.

It is one of the strongest arguments against rigid term limits.

Democracy is, after all, supposed to reflect the will of the people.

If a popular leader is prevented from standing, one could argue that the electorate's choice has been restricted.

But democracy is not only about choosing leaders.

It is also about limiting leaders.

That is the paradox.

The people must have the power to choose.

But the institutions must also protect the people from the excessive concentration of power.

A constitutional democracy therefore places two principles beside one another:

Popular sovereignty.

And:

Constitutional restraint.

Neither can simply erase the other.

The challenge is finding a balance.

In Rwanda's case, the constitutional debate surrounding Kagame's future became especially significant because of the country's political history.

The president's supporters could argue that continuity was necessary.

His critics could argue that continuity itself was evidence of institutional weakness.

Both positions deserved examination.

But the ultimate question was not whether Kagame was personally capable of continuing to govern.

It was whether Rwanda could demonstrate that political authority belonged to institutions rather than to an individual.

That question remains larger than any one election.

Because a country should not have to choose between stability and succession.

It should be able to have both.

A successful political system should be capable of saying:

This leader has served the country.

We recognise his achievements.

We respect his historical role.

And now another leader will take responsibility.

That is not necessarily a rejection of the previous leader.

It is a sign that the institution is stronger than the individual.

Conversely, when a system repeatedly changes its rules to accommodate the same person, observers are entitled to ask whether the constitution is governing the leader or the leader is governing the constitution.

That question should not be treated as an insult.

It is a constitutional question.

And constitutional questions deserve evidence, not emotion.

The years leading toward 2017 therefore became a revealing moment.

The debate exposed competing visions of Rwanda's future.

One vision emphasised continuity, stability, development, and the protection of the gains made since 1994.

Another emphasised institutional renewal, political competition, and the danger of allowing one leader to dominate the political system indefinitely.

Neither vision can simply be dismissed.

The desire for stability is legitimate.

The desire for political accountability is legitimate.

The desire for continuity is legitimate.

The desire for change is legitimate.

The real challenge is whether a political system can accommodate all four without collapsing into repression or instability.

This is the question that every post-conflict country eventually faces.

How do you move from the politics of survival to the politics of institutions?

How do you move from liberation to governance?

How do you move from the generation that fought the war to the generation that inherited the peace?

And perhaps most importantly:

Can a revolutionary generation voluntarily surrender the extraordinary authority that history gave it?

That is where the true test of political leadership lies.

Winning power is difficult.

Keeping power can be harder.

But giving power away peacefully may be the greatest test of all.

A leader proves the strength of a political system not only by how effectively he governs while he is in office, but by whether the system remains stable when he leaves.

That is the ultimate test of institutional success.

And it is also the point at which the political story of Kagame connects with the broader themes of this book.

Violence.

Fear.

Loyalty.

Silence.

Guilt.

Apology.

Opposition.

Power.

Each theme returns to the same fundamental question:

Who ultimately controls the state—the institutions, or the person?

If institutions control the state, leaders are temporary.

If leaders control the institutions, leaders become permanent in everything but name.

And once political authority becomes personal, another problem emerges.

Trust begins to disappear.

People who once stood together begin to suspect one another.

Former allies become potential enemies.

Private disagreements become political dangers.

And political survival begins to depend upon knowing not merely who supports you, but who might eventually betray you.

That is where the story moves next.

PART IV — TRUST, BETRAYAL AND FEAR

CHAPTER FOUR — WHEN TRUST DISAPPEARS: BETRAYAL AND FEAR IN THE PURSUIT OF POWER

Power does not survive on authority alone.

It survives on relationships.

Leaders need allies.

Armies need commanders.

Governments need officials.

Movements need believers.

But what happens when trust begins to disappear?

What happens when yesterday's comrade becomes today's suspect?

What happens when people who once fought together begin wondering whether the person standing beside them might eventually turn against them?

And what happens when fear becomes stronger than friendship?

The author now moves from the structure of political power to the intimate relationships through which that power was built—and, according to his account, eventually fractured.

The first lesson is painful:

Those who helped build power can also become the people power fears most.

4.1 WE PAID THE PRICE

There is a particular kind of pain that comes from losing an enemy.

There is another kind that comes from losing a friend.

But perhaps the deepest pain belongs to those who discover that the people with whom they once shared a struggle have become the people from whom they must now protect themselves.

Revolutions are often built on trust.

A soldier trusts the commander beside him.

A commander trusts the political leadership above him.

A political movement trusts the people who carry its message.

And ordinary people place their hopes in those who promise to build something better after the struggle is over.

During difficult times, these relationships can become extraordinarily strong.

People eat together.

They sleep in the same camps.

They cross dangerous borders together.

They lose friends together.

They bury comrades together.

They believe that because they have suffered together, they will remain united afterward.

But history repeatedly demonstrates something uncomfortable:

Shared suffering does not guarantee shared political destiny.

The people who fight together may disagree about what victory should mean.

One person may see victory as the beginning of democracy.

Another may see it as the beginning of national reconstruction.

Another may believe that security must come first.

Another may believe that political competition must come immediately.

Another may believe that those who sacrificed the most have earned the right to determine the country's future.

And another may eventually conclude that the movement has become something very different from what they originally joined.

The disagreement may begin quietly.

A conversation.

A question.

A criticism.

A decision someone does not understand.

A promotion that appears unfair.

A political appointment.

A military order.

A disagreement about strategy.

At first, none of these things necessarily destroys friendship.

But distrust rarely arrives all at once.

It accumulates.

One unanswered question becomes another.

One unexplained dismissal becomes another.

One former colleague disappears from public life.

Another leaves the country.

Another is arrested.

Another becomes a critic.

Soon people begin to notice a pattern.

And when people begin to believe that there is a pattern, they start behaving differently.

They become careful about what they say.

They stop speaking openly.

They begin measuring their words.

They ask who else is in the room.

They wonder whether a private conversation will remain private.

They learn that loyalty is not simply about supporting the leadership.

It is also about demonstrating that support.

And that is when trust begins to change into fear.

The author writes from the perspective of someone who belonged to the struggle and therefore experienced this transformation from within.

The phrase *we paid the price* is important because it speaks to a particular sense of ownership.

Those who fought believe they sacrificed something.

They gave their youth.

They gave their families years of absence.

They risked imprisonment, injury, and death.

Some lost brothers.

Some lost friends.

Some lost the possibility of returning to ordinary lives.

They did not necessarily make these sacrifices for personal wealth or political office.

They believed they were contributing to a national cause.

That belief matters.

Because when people who have sacrificed for a political movement later feel excluded from its direction, the disappointment can be profound.

They may ask:

Was this what we fought for?

The question is more painful than an ordinary political disagreement.

It contains memory.

It contains sacrifice.

It contains expectation.

It contains a sense of betrayal.

A person who joins a movement for personal gain may simply leave when the benefits disappear.

A person who joins because he believes deeply in its purpose may find leaving almost impossible.

He carries the movement inside him.

Its history becomes part of his identity.

Its victories become his victories.

Its failures become his failures.

Its leaders may have once been his friends.

And so when the relationship breaks, it is not merely a political disagreement.

It can feel like the destruction of part of one's own history.

This is one reason former revolutionaries sometimes become the most severe critics of the governments they helped create.

They remember the original promise.

They remember what was said before power was secured.

They remember the ideals that were discussed among comrades when nobody yet knew who would become president, minister, general, or opposition leader.

They remember the days before political language became official.

The government may describe itself according to what it became.

The former comrade may judge it according to what it promised to become.

That difference can produce extraordinary bitterness.

The author repeatedly returns to this tension.

He does not present himself as an outside observer who discovered Rwanda through newspapers.

He presents himself as someone who shared the struggle and therefore believes he has the right—and perhaps the obligation—to ask difficult questions about what happened afterward.

But there is another side to this argument.

The fact that someone participated in a political struggle does not automatically make every later accusation true.

Experience gives a person a perspective.

It does not give him infallibility.

This distinction is essential.

A former insider may know things outsiders cannot know.

He may also remember events through the emotional lens of disappointment.

Both possibilities can exist simultaneously.

The responsible reader must therefore listen carefully without surrendering judgment.

That is especially important when the subject is political betrayal.

Because betrayal is one of the most powerful emotions in politics.

A person who believes he has been betrayed rarely describes the experience neutrally.

He describes it morally.

Someone did not merely disagree with him.

They betrayed him.

Someone did not merely change political positions.

They abandoned the cause.

Someone did not merely become an opponent.

They became an enemy.

The language itself reveals the depth of the rupture.

And sometimes the rupture is indeed genuine.

Political movements are built upon trust, and when that trust collapses, relationships can become irreparable.

But what makes betrayal particularly dangerous is what follows.

Once a leader believes that a former ally has betrayed him, he may begin to suspect others.

If one person can betray the movement, perhaps another can.

If another can, perhaps everyone can.

Security thinking begins to expand.

The question changes from:

Who supports us?

to:

Who might turn against us?

That is a fundamentally different political mindset.

Support is positive.

Suspicion is negative.

Support asks what people are willing to contribute.

Suspicion asks what they might secretly be planning.

A government dominated by suspicion becomes increasingly defensive.

It begins to interpret disagreement through the language of security.

A policy critic may be seen as politically unreliable.

A political rival may be seen as dangerous.

A former military officer may be seen as a potential organiser.

A journalist may be seen as an influence operation.

A former ally may be seen as a future threat.

The boundaries become blurred.

And when the boundaries blur, fear spreads.

People do not need to be arrested to become afraid.

Sometimes the possibility is enough.

The knowledge that someone else has been questioned may be enough.

The story of someone who left the country may be enough.

The disappearance of a colleague from public life may be enough.

Fear operates through examples.

One person's experience can discipline hundreds of others.

This is why political repression does not always need to be widespread to be effective.

People watch.

They calculate.

They adapt.

They censor themselves.

Eventually, the state does not need to tell everyone what they cannot say.

People begin telling themselves.

This is the invisible architecture of fear.

But there is a deeper moral question.

What does a political movement owe to the people who sacrificed for it?

Does sacrifice create a political entitlement?

Should former fighters automatically have a role in government?

Should commanders be guaranteed positions?

Should veterans receive special privileges?

Or should victory mean that everyone returns to ordinary citizenship?

There is no universal answer.

A revolution cannot remain a permanent military organisation.

Eventually, guns must become institutions.

Commanders must become administrators—or return to civilian life.

The movement must become a state.

That transformation is extraordinarily difficult.

Those who carried weapons may find it difficult to accept the authority of civilian institutions.

Those who fought may feel that people who arrived later have no right to lecture them.

Those who sacrificed may believe that their contribution gives them a special claim to the nation's future.

And yet democracy depends upon a principle that can be painful to accept:

Past sacrifice does not create permanent ownership of the state.

A soldier may have fought for his country.

That does not mean he owns it.

A revolutionary may have risked his life.

That does not mean he is entitled to rule forever.

A president may have rebuilt institutions.

That does not mean those institutions belong to him.

The state must eventually become larger than those who created it.

Otherwise, every generation of political power will remain trapped in the logic of the struggle that produced it.

This is perhaps one of the greatest challenges facing post-conflict societies.

The people who won the war may believe they must continue to control the peace.

They fear that surrendering power will allow the old forces to return.

Their fear may be understandable.

But if they never permit political renewal, they create another problem.

The country becomes permanently governed by the generation of the conflict.

Younger citizens inherit a political order they did not create.

They inherit the memories.

They inherit the trauma.

They inherit the political categories.

They inherit the suspicion.

But they did not necessarily inherit the original conflict.

At some point, a country must allow the future to become more important than the past.

That does not mean forgetting.

It means refusing to allow history to become a permanent justification for political exclusion.

The phrase *we paid the price* therefore carries two meanings.

The first is a statement of sacrifice:

We suffered for this country.

The second is a warning:

Do not forget what we gave.

Both deserve to be heard.

But there is a third question that must follow:

Who pays the price when political loyalty becomes the measure of citizenship?

Because once loyalty becomes more important than competence, institutions begin to weaken.

Appointments may be based on trust rather than ability.

Promotion may depend upon personal allegiance.

Criticism may become dangerous.

Independent institutions may become suspicious.

The government becomes increasingly dependent upon people who will never challenge it.

That may feel safe.

But it is dangerous.

A leader surrounded only by loyalists eventually loses access to uncomfortable truths.

Everyone tells him what he wants to hear.

Bad news is softened.

Failures are hidden.

Officials compete to demonstrate loyalty.

And the leader becomes increasingly isolated from reality.

This is why disagreement can be a form of political service.

A genuine adviser should sometimes say:

No.

A genuine colleague should sometimes say:

I believe you are wrong.

A genuine institution should sometimes say:

You cannot do that.

A system in which nobody can say these things may appear united.

It is not necessarily strong.

It may simply be frightened.

The distinction is crucial.

Silence can look like unity from the outside.

Inside, it may be fear.

This is where the experience of former comrades becomes politically important.

When people who once fought together begin to disagree, their disagreement can reveal whether the movement has matured into an institution.

If criticism is tolerated, the movement may be becoming political.

If criticism is treated as betrayal, the movement may still be operating according to the logic of war.

War requires loyalty.

A state requires law.

These are not the same thing.

During war, a commander may demand obedience because hesitation can cost lives.

In a constitutional state, obedience has limits.

The law matters.

Procedure matters.

Rights matter.

And the government itself must be accountable.

The transition from military struggle to civilian government therefore requires a profound psychological transformation.

The enemy must eventually stop being the central reference point.

The government must learn to tolerate opposition.

The former fighter must learn that political disagreement is not necessarily treason.

The citizen must learn that supporting the government is not the same as supporting the country.

And the leader must learn that criticism does not automatically threaten the state.

When these distinctions fail to develop, suspicion becomes institutionalised.

And when suspicion becomes institutionalised, trust becomes scarce.

This is the environment in which betrayal flourishes.

People begin making calculations based not on principle but on survival.

Who is safe?

Who is powerful?

Who is trusted?

Who is being watched?

Who has fallen?

Who has left?

Who remains?

And perhaps the most frightening question:

Who will be next?

The author presents this atmosphere as part of the cost paid by those who once believed that shared struggle would produce shared trust.

But history teaches another lesson.

Political friendship is rarely permanent.

Alliances are built around interests, beliefs, circumstances, and personalities.

The people who stand together during one period may divide during another.

That does not necessarily mean that one side was always dishonest.

Sometimes people genuinely change.

Sometimes circumstances change them.

Sometimes power changes them.

Sometimes they discover that they never wanted the same future after all.

The tragedy begins when political disagreement becomes a threat to personal survival.

Then the price of disagreement becomes too high.

And when the price becomes too high, people stop speaking.

That is the moment when a society begins losing something more valuable than political competition.

It begins losing trust.

And once trust disappears, even loyalty becomes difficult to interpret.

Is the person beside you loyal because he believes in you?

Or because he is afraid of you?

Is the official defending the government because he agrees?

Or because he knows what happens to those who disagree?

Is the former ally silent because he has changed his mind?

Or because silence is safer?

A political system that cannot answer these questions honestly has a serious problem.

Because power without trust eventually depends upon fear.

And fear creates the conditions for betrayal.

The next question, then, is unavoidable:

What happens when those closest to power begin to fear the person they once trusted?

That is where the story moves next—to the silencing of brothers, former allies, and people who once stood inside the same circle of struggle.

4.2 SILENCING BROTHERS AND FORMER ALLIES

The most revealing test of power is not how it treats its declared enemies.

It is how it treats its former friends.

An enemy is expected to oppose you.

A former ally is different.

He knows you.

He remembers you before you became powerful.

He may know your weaknesses.

He may remember promises made in private.

He may know which compromises were necessary and which were voluntary.

He may have stood beside you when nobody knew whether the struggle would succeed.

And therefore, when that person begins to speak against you, his words can carry a different kind of weight.

The relationship has changed.

But the memory has not.

That is why political systems built around personal loyalty often become most anxious when criticism comes from within.

The outsider can be dismissed.

The former insider cannot be dismissed so easily.

He knows where the doors are.

He knows how the house was built.

And sometimes, he knows where the foundations are weakest.

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For people who have lived through armed struggle, the word *brother* can mean something far deeper than blood.

It can describe the person who shared your hardship.

The person who slept beside you during dangerous nights.

The person who carried ammunition when you were exhausted.

The person who knew your family.

The person who believed in the same cause.

Such relationships can become stronger than ordinary friendship.

They are forged in circumstances where people depend upon one another for survival.

But precisely because those relationships are so strong, their collapse can be devastating.

When brothers disagree after victory, the disagreement can feel like betrayal.

The question is no longer simply:

Why do you disagree with me?

It becomes:

How could you turn against us after everything we went through together?

That question contains an emotional charge that ordinary political disagreement does not possess.

It suggests that political loyalty is a moral debt.

Because we suffered together, you owe me loyalty.

Because we fought together, you must remain with us.

Because we defeated the enemy together, you must support the government we created.

But is that necessarily true?

Does shared sacrifice create permanent political obedience?

Does friendship during war require political agreement during peace?

And if a former comrade believes the movement has departed from its original principles, does remaining silent represent loyalty—or does speaking represent it?

These questions are uncomfortable because they challenge the traditional meaning of loyalty.

Perhaps true loyalty sometimes requires disagreement.

Perhaps the person who tells a leader an uncomfortable truth is more loyal than the person who applauds everything he does.

A government that cannot distinguish between criticism and betrayal will eventually become surrounded by people who are afraid to tell the truth.

And when that happens, the consequences can be severe.

Leaders begin receiving filtered information.

Officials learn which subjects are safe.

Advisers become cautious.

Reports become more optimistic.

Failures are described as temporary difficulties.

Warnings are softened.

Eventually, the leader may be living inside a political reality constructed for him by those who depend upon his approval.

That is one of the great dangers of concentrated power.

The leader does not necessarily become ignorant because he lacks intelligence.

He becomes ignorant because the system around him has learned that truth has consequences.

The former ally therefore occupies a peculiar position.

He can become a source of truth precisely because he is no longer dependent upon the leader.

But he can also become a threat in the eyes of the leadership precisely because he possesses knowledge.

This produces a pattern that appears repeatedly in political history.

The revolutionary movement begins with many voices.

Then victory requires unity.

Unity becomes discipline.

Discipline becomes obedience.

Obedience becomes loyalty.

Loyalty becomes personal.

And personal loyalty eventually becomes the measure by which people are judged.

At that stage, the question is no longer:

Are you competent?

It becomes:

Are you with us?

This is a dangerous question because it has only two possible answers.

Yes.

Or no.

There is no room for:

I support the country but disagree with this policy.

There is no room for:

I believe in the original principles but think the government has departed from them.

There is no room for:

I respect the president but believe he should leave office.

Political life becomes binary.

You are inside.

Or outside.

Friend.

Or enemy.

Loyal.

Or traitor.

This is how political systems lose complexity.

And when politics loses complexity, human beings become categories.

A former comrade can be remembered not for everything he contributed but for the moment he disagreed.

Years of sacrifice can disappear behind one accusation of disloyalty.

A person who once fought for the government can suddenly be described as having always been an enemy.

This rewriting of personal history can be deeply destructive.

It allows political conflict to erase the past.

Yet the past remains.

The comrade still fought.

The sacrifices still happened.

The friendships still existed.

The shared memories cannot simply be deleted because political relationships have changed.

That is why former allies can become so difficult for governments to manage.

They carry inconvenient memories.

They can tell stories that do not fit the official narrative.

They can say:

I was there.

I saw what happened.

That is not how it was.

Of course, personal testimony is not automatically proof.

Memory can fail.

People can misremember.

People can exaggerate.

People can reinterpret events after years of political conflict.

But testimony should not be dismissed simply because it is uncomfortable.

It should be examined.

Compared.

Corroborated where possible.

Placed within the historical record.

This is particularly important in a political environment where access to information is unequal.

The government possesses institutions.

It may possess official archives.

It may control public communication.

A former ally may possess only memory and testimony.

That does not make the government wrong or the former ally right.

It simply means that both must be examined.

The historian's task is not to choose friends.

It is to search for truth.

The author's own position as a former participant therefore creates both an advantage and a responsibility.

His proximity to the events may provide insight.

But proximity can also create emotional attachment.

A person who feels betrayed may interpret later events through the lens of that betrayal.

Again, both things can be true.

He may have been genuinely betrayed.

He may also interpret some events more harshly because of it.

The reader must hold these possibilities together.

This is especially important when discussing allegations of silencing.

Silencing can take many forms.

It can be direct.

Arrest.

Threat.

Intimidation.

Censorship.

Dismissal.

Exile.

But it can also be indirect.

A person loses access to employment.

His reputation is attacked.

Friends distance themselves.

Officials stop answering his calls.

People who once welcomed him become afraid to be seen with him.

No single act may appear decisive.

Together, they can make a person politically invisible.

That is why political repression is not always dramatic.

Sometimes it is bureaucratic.

Sometimes it is social.

Sometimes it is psychological.

Sometimes the state does not need to say:

Do not speak.

People already know what speaking may cost them.

This creates what political theorists sometimes describe as self-censorship.

The state does not have to silence everyone.

It only has to make enough people believe that speaking is dangerous.

Soon, silence spreads voluntarily.

The person who wants to criticise the government thinks:

Perhaps I should not say this.

The journalist thinks:

Perhaps this story will cause trouble.

The civil servant thinks:

Perhaps I should keep my opinion to myself.

The politician thinks:

Perhaps I should wait.

And the former soldier thinks:

Perhaps it is safer to leave.

A government may then appear remarkably peaceful.

But peace produced by fear is different from peace produced by confidence.

One is quiet because people trust the system.

The other is quiet because people fear it.

The difference may not be visible in a photograph.

It becomes visible only when someone tests the boundaries.

This is why former allies matter.

When someone who once belonged to the inner circle begins speaking publicly, he tests the boundaries.

Can the system tolerate criticism from someone who knows it from within?

Can the government answer criticism without retaliation?

Can it allow the former ally to speak?

Can it respond with evidence rather than accusations?

These are tests of institutional maturity.

The strongest government is not necessarily the one that has no critics.

It may be the one that can survive criticism.

A confident government can say:

You disagree with us. Explain why.

A frightened government says:

You disagree with us. Therefore, you are dangerous.

The difference is enormous.

One invites argument.

The other ends it.

And when argument ends, politics moves elsewhere.

It moves into private conversations.

Into rumours.

Into exile communities.

Into underground networks.

Into foreign media.

Into diplomatic circles.

Into social media.

The criticism does not disappear.

It simply becomes harder for the government to hear accurately.

That can create another paradox.

The more a government suppresses criticism, the less reliable its own information environment becomes.

Officials tell leaders what they believe leaders want to hear.

Citizens hide their frustrations.

Opponents exaggerate because ordinary criticism is difficult.

Rumours become more powerful because verified information is scarce.

The government becomes suspicious of rumours.

Citizens become suspicious of government statements.

Trust declines on both sides.

And the political system becomes trapped in mutual suspicion.

This is where the phrase **when trust disappears** acquires its full meaning.

Trust is not simply an emotional feeling.

It is a political resource.

A government needs citizens to believe that institutions will treat them fairly.

Citizens need to believe that the government will not punish them arbitrarily.

Political parties need to believe that elections matter.

Soldiers need to believe that their commanders will not use them for private purposes.

Officials need to believe that telling the truth will not destroy their careers.

Opposition leaders need to believe that criticism will not become a death sentence.

When these expectations collapse, the political system becomes expensive to operate.

Every interaction requires suspicion.

Every appointment requires loyalty tests.

Every disagreement requires interpretation.

Every departure becomes a possible conspiracy.

Every meeting becomes a potential security concern.

And every former ally becomes someone whose intentions must be watched.

The tragedy is that fear can become self-fulfilling.

If leaders assume everyone will eventually betray them, they treat people with suspicion.

Those people, feeling distrusted, become resentful.

Resentment encourages distance.

Distance is interpreted as disloyalty.

Disloyalty justifies greater suspicion.

And the cycle continues.

This is how a political system can manufacture the very enemies it fears.

Not because every critic is innocent.

Not because every allegation against opponents is false.

But because a government that treats disagreement as hostility eventually creates an environment in which genuine hostility becomes more likely.

The alternative is not naïve trust.

A government cannot simply trust everyone.

States require security.

Leaders must identify real threats.

Political movements must protect themselves from infiltration and violence.

The answer is **institutional trust**, not blind personal trust.

A leader should not need to personally trust every citizen.

He should be able to trust the law.

He should be able to trust institutions.

He should be able to trust procedures.

If someone is accused of a crime, there should be an investigation.

If someone is accused of plotting violence, there should be evidence.

If someone is politically disloyal, there should be no need to criminalise his opinion.

The institution should determine the difference.

That is the purpose of law.

Without institutions, leaders must rely upon personal networks.

And personal networks are unstable.

Friends become enemies.

Enemies become allies.

Loyalists compete with one another.

Former comrades disappear.

New loyalists emerge.

The political system becomes a court around one individual.

Everyone watches everyone else.

And everyone waits to discover who has fallen out of favour.

The author presents this environment as one of the costs paid by those who once believed they were building something different.

They did not merely pay the price of war.

They may also have paid the price of political transformation.

They helped create a state in which the old enemy had been defeated, only to discover that political conflict had not disappeared.

It had changed form.

The battlefield had become political.

The weapons had become accusations.

The trenches had become institutions.

And the question of survival remained.

But perhaps the most disturbing transformation was this:

The person standing opposite you was no longer necessarily the enemy.

Sometimes he was the person who had once stood beside you.

And when that happens, the question is no longer simply whether the government can defeat its enemies.

It becomes:

Can it tolerate the people who helped build it when they stop agreeing with it?

That question leads naturally to the next section.

Because when trust disappears, suspicion does not remain equally distributed.

It eventually reaches the highest levels of power.

And once a leader begins to believe that everyone around him might become a threat, the political system changes again.

4.3 WHEN EVERYONE BECOMES A THREAT

Fear has a strange way of expanding.

At first, it has a target.

Then the target becomes a group.

Then the group becomes an idea.

And eventually, the idea can become so broad that almost anyone can fit inside it.

That is the moment when security becomes paranoia.

A leader who fears an armed enemy has a clear problem.

A leader who fears a political organisation has a larger problem.

But a leader who begins to fear his own allies faces something more profound.

He no longer knows where danger ends.

Every silence may conceal a plan.

Every disagreement may hide an ambition.

Every friendship may contain another loyalty.

Every former comrade may become tomorrow's opponent.

And when everyone becomes a possible threat, nobody can ever be completely trusted.

That is the environment in which political fear reaches its most dangerous form.

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A government built around suspicion does not merely watch its enemies.

It watches its friends.

At first, this may appear reasonable.

Security services exist because threats are real.

Governments have legitimate reasons to monitor armed groups, organised crime, terrorism, espionage, and attempts to overthrow the state violently.

A government that ignores genuine threats is not responsible.

But there is a boundary between vigilance and suspicion without limits.

Vigilance asks:

What evidence do we have that this person presents a threat?

Paranoia asks:

What evidence could we find that might make this person a threat?

The difference may appear small.

Politically, it is enormous.

The first begins with evidence.

The second begins with suspicion.

And once suspicion becomes the starting point, evidence can be interpreted to confirm what the authorities already believe.

A person meets an opponent.

Why?

Perhaps they discussed politics.

Perhaps they discussed business.

Perhaps they discussed a family matter.

But under a culture of suspicion, the meeting itself can become evidence.

A person leaves the country.

Why?

Perhaps for work.

Perhaps for family.

Perhaps because he wants a different life.

But if authorities already suspect him, departure becomes evidence of conspiracy.

A person criticises a policy.

Why?

Perhaps because he genuinely disagrees.

But if the political environment is already suspicious, criticism becomes evidence of disloyalty.

This is how suspicion becomes self-confirming.

Everything can be interpreted as proof.

And when everything can be proof, innocence becomes almost impossible to demonstrate.

The danger is not only what the state does.

It is what citizens begin doing to themselves.

People become careful about their friendships.

They avoid controversial conversations.

They hesitate before sharing information.

They stop attending certain meetings.

They distance themselves from people who have become politically controversial.

Not necessarily because they believe those people are guilty.

But because they fear being associated with them.

This is how political fear spreads without direct orders.

One person's punishment becomes another person's warning.

The state may arrest one individual.

A hundred others become silent.

It may dismiss one official.

Others become more obedient.

It may publicly condemn one former ally.

Former allies elsewhere begin reconsidering whether they should speak.

Fear travels faster than instructions.

And perhaps the most powerful form of political control is not forcing people to obey.

It is teaching them to anticipate what the authorities want.

Then people begin censoring themselves before anyone asks them to.

This produces an illusion of political harmony.

The streets are quiet.

Public speeches are supportive.

Officials praise the leadership.

Opposition appears weak.

Criticism becomes rare.

From the outside, the country may appear extraordinarily stable.

But stability has two possible foundations.

One is legitimacy.

The other is fear.

Legitimacy produces obedience because people believe the system is broadly rightful.

Fear produces obedience because people believe resistance is dangerous.

The outward behaviour can look identical.

The internal reality is completely different.

This distinction matters when evaluating authoritarian systems.

A government may point to the absence of visible unrest as evidence of public satisfaction.

But silence alone cannot tell us why people are silent.

A person may remain silent because he agrees.

He may remain silent because he is uncertain.

He may remain silent because he is exhausted.

Or he may remain silent because he is afraid.

Political analysis must therefore look beyond appearances.

What happens when someone openly disagrees?

What happens when journalists investigate sensitive subjects?

What happens when opposition politicians organise?

What happens when senior officials challenge the leadership?

What happens when former comrades become critics?

The answer to these questions tells us much more about political freedom than the government's public statements.

The author's account repeatedly returns to the importance of former allies because they provide an unusual test.

If the system can tolerate criticism from people who helped build it, then perhaps the political order has developed sufficient confidence to survive disagreement.

If it cannot, then the fear may be deeper than the government admits.

There is another psychological dimension to this.

A leader who has survived repeated threats may begin to see danger everywhere.

This is understandable.

Someone who has lived through war does not experience security in the same way as someone who has known only peace.

A person who has seen colleagues killed may become extremely cautious.

A commander who has survived attempted coups may distrust political institutions.

A leader who has spent years fighting enemies may continue thinking like a soldier even after becoming a president.

This does not make him evil.

It makes him human.

But political office demands a transformation.

The instincts that protect a commander during war may become dangerous when applied indefinitely to civilian government.

In war, uncertainty can be fatal.

A commander cannot assume that an armed group is harmless until proven otherwise.

He must act quickly.

In civilian government, however, suspicion must be constrained by law.

Citizens are not enemy combatants.

Political disagreement is not military insubordination.

And a constitution cannot function like a battlefield command structure.

This is one of the central tensions in post-revolutionary governments.

The people who win the war may remain psychologically organised around the war.

They remember enemies.

They remember betrayal.

They remember infiltrators.

They remember people who changed sides.

They remember what happened when trust was misplaced.

As a result, they may believe that permanent vigilance is necessary.

But a country cannot remain permanently at war with its own past.

Eventually, the state must learn to distinguish between memory and present reality.

Otherwise, yesterday's enemy becomes today's political category.

And tomorrow's critic becomes tomorrow's enemy.

That is how the definition of threat expands.

First it includes armed opponents.

Then political opponents.

Then former political opponents.

Then former allies.

Then critics within the ruling party.

Then officials who fail to demonstrate sufficient loyalty.

Eventually, even silence can become suspicious.

This is the logic of political purification.

The leadership continually searches for people who are sufficiently loyal.

But absolute loyalty is impossible.

People have different interests.

They disagree.

They change their minds.

They make mistakes.

They have ambitions.

They become disappointed.

A political system that expects permanent agreement is therefore destined to find betrayal everywhere.

There is an important distinction between loyalty to a person and loyalty to a principle.

If a soldier is loyal to a commander personally, he may follow the commander even when the commander is wrong.

If he is loyal to the law, he must refuse an unlawful order.

If a civil servant is loyal to a president personally, he may conceal the president's mistakes.

If he is loyal to the institution, he must report them.

If a citizen is loyal to the nation, he may criticise the government because he believes criticism will improve the country.

If loyalty to the government is treated as loyalty to the nation, criticism becomes treason.

The difference is fundamental.

A healthy political system should encourage citizens to love their country enough to question its leaders.

Patriotism should not require blindness.

Indeed, blind loyalty can be dangerous to the person receiving it.

A leader who is never challenged has no reliable way to know when he is wrong.

This is why advisers matter.

A president does not need people who agree with him on everything.

He needs people who are willing to tell him when he is mistaken.

The strongest leader is not the one who never hears *no*.

It is the one who can hear *no* without becoming threatened by it.

The author argues that this culture of fear eventually affects not only politicians but ordinary people.

People learn to interpret politics through risk.

Before expressing an opinion, they ask:

Who might hear this?

Before meeting someone, they ask:

Is this person safe?

Before sharing a message, they ask:

Could this be misunderstood?

Before returning home, they ask:

Would it be safer somewhere else?

When these questions become part of everyday life, political freedom has already been affected.

A country does not need to imprison everyone to create political fear.

Sometimes the possibility of punishment is sufficient.

That is why fear is so efficient.

It requires fewer resources than mass repression.

One highly publicised case can create a much larger psychological effect than its immediate victim count suggests.

People observe.

They calculate.

They adapt.

The result is what might be called political silence by anticipation.

No one tells you to stop speaking.

You simply learn when speaking is unsafe.

And this has consequences beyond politics.

Fear damages creativity.

It damages entrepreneurship.

It damages journalism.

It damages academic inquiry.

It damages relationships.

People become reluctant to challenge established ideas.

They become reluctant to experiment.

They become reluctant to take responsibility.

Because initiative requires the freedom to fail.

And a fearful society punishes not only failure but unpredictability.

This is why political fear can ultimately weaken the state it is intended to protect.

A government may believe that control produces stability.

But excessive control can produce fragility.

When everyone waits for instructions, institutions become dependent upon the centre.

When officials are afraid to make independent decisions, problems move upward.

When nobody wants to report bad news, the leadership discovers problems too late.

When citizens cannot openly express dissatisfaction, grievances accumulate invisibly.

The system looks stable until it suddenly is not.

This is one of the great paradoxes of authoritarian stability:

The more perfectly a government suppresses visible disagreement, the harder it becomes to know how much disagreement actually exists.

A quiet room is not necessarily an empty room.

It may simply be a room in which nobody feels safe enough to speak.

That is why political systems require channels through which disagreement can emerge peacefully.

Opposition parties.

Independent media.

Civil society.

Courts.

Parliament.

Universities.

Professional associations.

Public debate.

These institutions are not merely obstacles to government.

They are information systems.

They tell the state what citizens are thinking.

They expose mistakes.

They reveal corruption.

They identify grievances before those grievances become crises.

Destroying them may make the government feel safer.

But it also makes the government less informed.

And an uninformed government is vulnerable.

The question therefore becomes even more profound:

Can a leader create so much fear that he eventually becomes one of the people most isolated by it?

The answer, historically, is yes.

People around powerful leaders rarely behave naturally.

They know the stakes.

They know the leader controls appointments.

He may influence promotions.

He may influence access.

He may determine careers.

People therefore learn to manage their behaviour around him.

They say what is expected.

They hide doubts.

They conceal disagreements.

The leader may interpret this behaviour as genuine loyalty.

But it may simply be adaptation.

That creates a dangerous feedback loop.

The leader thinks:

Everyone supports me.

The people around him think:

We must make sure he believes we support him.

The resulting appearance of unity reinforces the leader's belief.

And the cycle continues.

This is why a leader should sometimes listen most carefully to the person who disagrees with him.

The dissenter may be providing the information that loyalists are too afraid to provide.

But what happens when even the dissenter is no longer tolerated?

Then the political system begins losing one of its most valuable resources:

internal correction.

Every system makes mistakes.

The difference is whether it can correct them.

A healthy institution has mechanisms for self-correction.

A personalised institution often interprets correction as criticism.

Criticism becomes disloyalty.

Disloyalty becomes danger.

Danger becomes repression.

And repression removes the people most willing to speak honestly.

Eventually, the system becomes more certain and less informed at the same time.

That is perhaps the final stage of political suspicion.

The leader believes he is surrounded by enemies.

The people around him believe they must prove they are not enemies.

And the country continues moving forward beneath the weight of an invisible question:

Who can still be trusted?

This question becomes especially painful when it concerns someone who was once regarded as a loyal and important member of the political struggle.

Someone who was not an obvious enemy.

Someone who had shared the journey.

Someone whose relationship with the leadership was once defined not by suspicion, but by trust.

That is why the story of **Aloysia Inyumba** occupies such an important place in this chapter.

Her story allows us to examine betrayal not as an abstract political concept, but through a human relationship shaped by the history of the Rwandan struggle.

And it forces another uncomfortable question:

What happens when loyalty itself becomes a political test—and when even loyalty is no longer enough?

4.4 THE BETRAYAL OF ALOYSIA INYUMBA

There are moments in political history when betrayal is difficult to define.

Was someone betrayed because they were abandoned?

Because they were denied assistance?

Because they were pushed aside?

Or because the people they once trusted gradually stopped treating them as one of their own?

Sometimes betrayal does not begin with a dramatic confrontation.

It begins with a door that no longer opens.

A telephone call that is no longer returned.

A promise that is quietly withdrawn.

A friend who suddenly becomes distant.

A person who once belonged to the centre of a movement discovers that he or she is now standing outside it.

The story of Aloysia Inyumba, as presented by Noble Marara, belongs to this difficult territory.

Inyumba was not portrayed as an ordinary political figure who appeared after the Rwandan Patriotic Front had already secured power. She had been associated with the movement during its years of struggle and, in the author's account, had earned a considerable degree of respect within it.

That history is important.

Because political betrayal hurts differently when it happens to someone who has already given years of loyalty to a cause.

The author recalls Kagame speaking about Inyumba's conduct during the period of the armed struggle, particularly her handling of money allocated for official travel. According to the passage, Kagame remarked that while they were still in

the bush, Inyumba could not even spend the money allocated to her during official journeys outside the country.

The anecdote is presented as evidence of a woman who was, at least in the author's interpretation, unusually disciplined and committed to the movement.

It also establishes something more important.

Inyumba had a history with the RPF.

She was not an outsider.

She was one of those people whose political identity had been formed within the struggle itself.

And that raises the question:

What happens when someone who helped build a movement becomes politically inconvenient to those who now control it?

According to Marara's account, tensions emerged around Inyumba's standing within the RPF.

The author alleges that Jeannette Kagame became concerned about Inyumba's influence and feared that she might eventually rise to the leadership of the RPF and, potentially, become Rwanda's first female president. This is presented in the book as information attributed to sources within the RPF rather than as independently established fact.

Such a claim, if true, would reveal something profound about the nature of political competition.

It would suggest that the struggle for power was no longer simply between opposing political movements.

It had entered the inner circle.

The competition was no longer only about defeating an external enemy.

It was about determining who would occupy the future centre of the movement itself.

And that is where political organisations become particularly vulnerable.

A movement can survive an external enemy more easily than it can survive internal mistrust.

The author goes further.

He attributes to an unnamed source within the RPF an allegation that Jeannette Kagame wanted Inyumba poisoned and that General Jack Nziza would allegedly be used to carry it out. This is a serious allegation, and the available passage presents it as a claim from an anonymous source rather than evidence establishing that such a plot actually occurred.

For a responsible reader, this distinction matters.

There is a difference between saying:

This happened.

and saying:

The author reports that someone inside the organisation claimed this happened.

The second is what the source supports.

But even an allegation can reveal something about the political atmosphere in which it was made.

If people within a movement genuinely believed that political rivalry could result in a person's elimination, then the atmosphere itself would have been deeply unhealthy.

Fear does not require every rumour to be true.

Sometimes the existence of the rumour tells us that trust has already deteriorated.

The author's narrative then turns to a more tangible issue: assistance.

According to the account, Inyumba sought financial support from the RPF but was denied it.

She subsequently approached General James Kabarebe, whom the author describes as someone with whom she had shared the hardships of the armed struggle.

This detail is significant.

People who have shared war often develop relationships that are difficult for outsiders to understand.

They have memories that cannot easily be explained.

They remember the same nights.

The same battles.

The same losses.

The same uncertainty.

They know what each other looked like before political titles existed.

That kind of relationship creates an expectation of solidarity.

Inyumba therefore did not approach Kabarebe as a stranger.

She approached someone with whom she had shared the struggle.

The book says that Kabarebe initially promised financial assistance but subsequently failed to honour that commitment after learning that the President's wife had opposed the assistance Inyumba had requested.

Again, the claim belongs to the author's account.

But the political question it raises is larger than the particular transaction.

At what point does personal loyalty become subordinate to proximity to power?

A person may want to help an old comrade.

But what happens if helping that comrade could be interpreted as disobedience to someone more powerful?

This is how political loyalty becomes complicated.

The person who once stood beside you in the forest may now stand beneath someone else in a hierarchy.

The friendship remains.

But the power relationship has changed.

And when power enters a friendship, friendship is tested.

According to the narrative, Inyumba eventually turned to another former comrade: Colonel Patrick Karegeya.

Karegeya, the author says, provided her with financial assistance quickly when she asked for help.

This detail becomes important later in the author's argument because Karegeya himself would eventually become one of the most prominent former RPF figures to break with Kagame.

The book therefore draws a connection between two people who, at different moments, would occupy increasingly difficult positions in relation to the centre of power.

Inyumba sought help.

Karegeya gave it.

And according to the author's narrative, that connection later became politically significant.

The author claims that after Karegeya was killed in South Africa, his mobile phone was taken by his killers and delivered to Kagame. He then alleges that Kagame became angry after discovering that Inyumba had communicated with Karegeya and that this contributed to subsequent actions against people believed to have had links with Karegeya.

Again, these are allegations contained in the author's account, not facts independently established by the passage itself.

Yet the narrative invites the reader to consider a disturbing possibility.

What if contact with a former ally becomes dangerous simply because that ally has fallen out with the leadership?

Then friendship itself becomes political evidence.

A telephone call can become suspicious.

A financial transaction can become suspicious.

A meeting can become suspicious.

A relationship that was once entirely ordinary can acquire a political meaning it never previously possessed.

That is how fear transforms human relationships.

People stop asking what happened.

They start asking:

Who was he talking to?

Who gave her money?

Who met with whom?

Who remains loyal?

And eventually:

Who else is connected to them?

The circle widens.

One person becomes associated with another.

That person becomes associated with a third.

Soon, the original disagreement is almost forgotten.

What remains is the network of relationships.

This is one of the most powerful mechanisms of political suspicion.

The individual may no longer be judged solely by what he has done.

He is judged by whom he knows.

The author's account then places Inyumba's husband, Dr Richard Masozera, within this chain of events.

According to the book, Masozera was removed from his position as a senior official responsible for civil aviation and replaced by Colonel Silas Udahemuka. The author presents this as part of a broader sequence of reprisals connected to people believed to be associated with Karegeya.

Whether every element of that interpretation can be independently substantiated is a separate historical question.

But the narrative's underlying concern is unmistakable.

It is about the consequences of political association.

If a person's relationship with a disfavoured former ally can affect the professional life of that person's family, then political suspicion has moved beyond the individual.

It has become collective.

The punishment, real or perceived, no longer stops with the person who made the political choice.

It reaches those around him.

That produces a particularly powerful form of fear.

A person may be willing to accept personal consequences.

But what if speaking openly could harm a spouse?

A brother?

A colleague?

A friend?

A child?

Fear becomes much stronger when it is no longer about oneself.

This is why political systems built around personal loyalty can become extraordinarily difficult to challenge.

People do not ask only:

What will happen to me?

They ask:

What will happen to the people connected to me?

And that question can silence even those who are personally courageous.

The story of Inyumba therefore becomes more than a story about one woman.

It becomes a story about what happens to a political movement when the relationships that once held it together begin to fracture.

During the struggle, the RPF needed people like Inyumba.

It needed organisers.

Communicators.

Diplomats.

Soldiers.

Political strategists.

People capable of persuading others to believe in a future that did not yet exist.

The movement depended upon the diversity of talents within its ranks.

But after victory, the relationship between the individual and the movement changed.

The movement became a government.

The government acquired institutions.

Institutions acquired hierarchies.

Hierarchies produced winners and losers.

And people who had once been equally committed comrades discovered that they no longer possessed equal political influence.

This transformation happens in many revolutionary movements.

Before victory, everyone is necessary.

After victory, some people become more necessary than others.

And once hierarchy becomes established, proximity to the leader becomes valuable.

That can change friendships.

It can change behaviour.

It can change what people are willing to say.

The old comrade who once spoke freely may become cautious.

The leader who once listened to every opinion may become surrounded by officials whose careers depend upon his approval.

The movement becomes a government.

And the government becomes a system of power.

This is why the fate of former comrades can tell us more about a political system than its treatment of distant enemies.

Enemies are expected to be resisted.

Former allies reveal whether disagreement is tolerated.

The question is not whether a government has enemies.

Every government does.

The question is:

What does it do when one of its own says, “I no longer agree with you”?

Does it answer?

Does it negotiate?

Does it tolerate dissent?

Does it remove the person peacefully from office?

Or does disagreement become evidence of betrayal?

The answer determines whether political loyalty is voluntary or compulsory.

The author believes that, in the case of Inyumba, the relationship between former comrades had reached a troubling point.

A woman who had once been respected within the movement was, in his telling, increasingly isolated.

The assistance she sought was allegedly denied.

One former comrade allegedly withdrew his support.

Another provided help.

And that second relationship later became politically dangerous.

What began as a request for assistance thus becomes, in the author's narrative, part of a much larger story of suspicion.

And this is perhaps the most tragic element.

People who fought together may eventually find themselves unable to help one another openly.

Not because they have stopped caring.

But because caring itself may have become politically risky.

Imagine the psychological transformation.

Yesterday, you could call your comrade because you needed help.

Today, before calling him, you must ask whether the call itself could be interpreted as disloyalty.

Yesterday, you could meet an old friend for coffee.

Today, you wonder whether someone is watching.

Yesterday, your political history was a source of pride.

Today, the same history can become evidence against you.

What kind of society does that create?

And what happens to the meaning of friendship in such a society?

Perhaps the deepest tragedy of political fear is that it does not simply silence speeches.

It changes relationships.

It teaches people to calculate affection.

It makes generosity dangerous.

It makes old friendships suspicious.

It makes ordinary human contact political.

And once that happens, a movement begins losing something that cannot be restored by force:

trust.

The author interprets the events surrounding Inyumba as another sign of the internal deterioration of the RPF.

He argues that as hostility and disputes multiplied, the movement itself became increasingly divided.

Whether one accepts that interpretation in full or not, the question deserves attention.

A political organisation cannot remain permanently united simply because its members once shared a common enemy.

Once the enemy disappears, internal differences become visible.

Different ambitions emerge.

Different memories of the struggle emerge.

Different visions of the future emerge.

And people begin asking who has the right to define what the revolution was supposed to achieve.

That is when the old word *comrade* can acquire a painful new meaning.

It can mean:

Someone who once stood beside me.

But it can also mean:

Someone who knows where I came from.

And perhaps that is why former comrades can become so threatening to political leaders.

They remember the beginning.

They remember the promises.

They remember the people who were there before power changed the relationships.

They can compare the movement's present behaviour with its original ideals.

The past therefore becomes politically dangerous.

Because the past asks questions.

What did we promise?

What did we sacrifice?

What did we say we were fighting for?

And what have we become?

Those are questions no government should fear.

But they are questions every government should be prepared to answer.

The story of Aloysia Inyumba, as presented here, ultimately brings us back to the central theme of this chapter.

Trust does not disappear in a single moment.

It disappears through a sequence of small ruptures.

A promise not kept.

A door closed.

A friendship questioned.

A former ally abandoned.

A political connection treated as suspicious.

A family member affected.

And eventually, people begin to understand the new rules without anyone having to explain them.

They learn whom they can call.

Whom they cannot call.

What they can say.

What they should never say.

And whom they must avoid.

That is when fear becomes part of political culture.

And once fear becomes culture, the consequences do not end with one person.

They spread.

From one former comrade to another.

From one family to another.

From one political disagreement to another.

Until the movement that once depended upon trust begins depending upon suspicion.

The question then becomes unavoidable:

If people who once fought together can become threats to one another, what happens to everyone else who stands outside the inner circle?

That question leads us to the next section—where the story turns from political relationships to a more symbolic confrontation with power itself.

4.5 TWO SLAPS IN THE FACE

Sometimes political humiliation is more revealing than political violence.

A slap is a small physical act.

But in politics, an insult can carry the weight of an institution.

When a powerful person humiliates another person, the meaning is rarely confined to the gesture itself.

It can communicate hierarchy.

It can communicate anger.

It can communicate impunity.

And it can reveal something about the person who believes he has the right to do it.

The story that follows is therefore not merely about two incidents.

It is about what happens when power becomes so confident that it no longer believes it must explain itself.

The author places this episode within the wider atmosphere of threats, security, and political fear surrounding the Rwandan leadership.

In 2016, according to the book, Kagame publicly warned that anyone attempting to attack the country would be dealt with immediately, using language intended to convey that he would not wait for an enemy to strike before responding.

But the author then contrasts this confidence with a later security incident in Rubavu.

Armed attackers raided a police facility, took weapons and ammunition, and killed more than nineteen people, including police officers, according to the account. The government responded with a large security operation involving soldiers and police, with arrests and killings reported by the author.

The significance of the episode lies not simply in the attack itself.

It lies in the question that followed:

If a government promises absolute security, what does it do when violence breaks through?

Does it acknowledge the limits of its intelligence?

Does it investigate calmly?

Or does fear produce a wider crackdown?

The next section of the book will explore this tension further.

4.5 TWO SLAPS IN THE FACE

There are moments when power reveals itself without a speech.

Sometimes it happens through a decision.

Sometimes through a dismissal.

Sometimes through a silence.

And sometimes, in the most literal sense, through a slap.

A slap is a small act.

It takes only a second.

Yet humiliation has a peculiar endurance. The physical pain disappears quickly; the memory may remain for years.

In politics, humiliation is rarely only personal. When a powerful person humiliates someone who occupies a weaker position, the act can become a demonstration of hierarchy. It says, without the need for words:

I can do this to you because I have the power to do so.

That is why the author's account of two alleged incidents involving physical humiliation deserves to be read not simply as gossip about personalities, but as part of the book's broader examination of power.

The first question is not merely:

Who slapped whom?

The deeper question is:

What kind of political culture allows a person with enormous authority to humiliate another person without fearing consequences?

And perhaps an even more difficult question follows:

What happens to everyone watching when they see that humiliation go unanswered?

They learn something.

They learn where power resides.

They learn who can act without explanation.

They learn who must remain silent.

And they learn that the rules may not apply equally to everyone.

That lesson can be more powerful than any written law.

The author's narrative places these incidents against a background of increasing concern about security and the use of force.

In 2016, Kagame publicly warned that anyone who attempted to attack Rwanda would face immediate consequences. The language, as reported in the book, conveyed confidence: Rwanda would not simply wait for an attack before responding.

Such declarations are politically understandable.

A president has a responsibility to reassure citizens.

A government must demonstrate that it can protect the population.

After a history of devastating conflict, security carries an especially profound meaning.

People want to believe that the state is capable of preventing a return to violence.

But every promise of absolute security creates an implicit obligation.

If the government tells citizens that danger will be stopped before it reaches them, then every successful attack becomes more than an isolated security incident.

It becomes a challenge to the credibility of the state.

That challenge became particularly visible, according to the author's account, after an armed group attacked a police facility in Rubavu.

The attackers reportedly took weapons and ammunition and killed more than nineteen people, including police officers. The authorities subsequently launched a major security operation, involving both the military and police, during which arrests and killings were reported.

The event raises a question that extends far beyond Rwanda.

Can a state promise perfect security?

Probably not.

No government can eliminate every threat.

No intelligence service can predict every act of violence.

No border can be made completely impenetrable.

No police force can guarantee that no attack will ever occur.

But political leaders often speak in absolutes because citizens are not looking for probability.

They are looking for reassurance.

The danger is that absolute language creates absolute expectations.

When reality inevitably contradicts those expectations, the government faces a choice.

It can admit:

We failed to prevent this.

Or it can respond by demonstrating even greater force.

The second response may be politically attractive because force is visible.

A police operation can be seen.

Arrests can be announced.

Weapons can be displayed.

Soldiers can be deployed.

The public sees action.

But visible action is not necessarily effective action.

Security is not measured only by how many people are arrested after an attack.

It is also measured by whether institutions can identify threats before violence occurs, whether intelligence is reliable, whether citizens trust authorities enough to report danger, and whether investigations distinguish between genuine suspects and innocent people.

A state that relies too heavily on force may eventually discover that fear has become its primary security instrument.

And fear can produce information—but not necessarily truthful information.

A frightened person will tell authorities what he thinks they want to hear.

That may produce confessions.

It may produce names.

It may produce accusations.

But it does not necessarily produce truth.

This distinction is essential whenever allegations of political violence are discussed.

The existence of an arrest does not establish guilt.

The existence of a government accusation does not automatically establish a conspiracy.

The existence of a rumour does not establish an assassination plot.

And the absence of an official explanation does not automatically prove the opposite.

The truth must be established through evidence.

That principle should apply equally to governments and their critics.

The author, however, is interested in something broader than individual incidents.

He is interested in what these episodes reveal about the relationship between power and fear.

A government that constantly reminds citizens of threats may gradually teach them to view politics through the language of danger.

Everything becomes security.

An opposition politician is not simply a politician.

He may be described as a destabilising force.

A former soldier is not simply a former soldier.

He may be regarded as a potential conspirator.

A critic is not simply a critic.

He may be suspected of working for someone else.

Once this happens, political disagreement becomes difficult.

Because disagreement requires the assumption that the other person has the right to disagree.

Security thinking can undermine that assumption.

It asks instead:

Why is he saying this?

Who is behind him?

Who is funding him?

What does he really want?

These questions can sometimes be legitimate.

But if they become the first questions asked about every critic, politics becomes a permanent investigation.

Nobody simply disagrees anymore.

Everyone must have a hidden motive.

That is how a political system becomes exhausted by suspicion.

And this returns us to the symbolism of the slap.

A slap communicates something immediate.

It does not invite debate.

It does not request an explanation.

It does not seek evidence.

It imposes.

That is why physical humiliation is so revealing in any hierarchical system.

The person who strikes does not need to persuade.

The person who receives the blow does not have the same freedom to respond.

The imbalance of power is already understood.

The same dynamic can exist in politics without anyone touching another person.

A government can humiliate an opponent through public accusations.

A powerful official can destroy someone's reputation with a statement.

An institution can make a person's career impossible.

A political party can isolate a former member.

The mechanism is different.

The message can be the same:

You are not powerful enough to challenge us.

That is why humiliation can sometimes be more politically revealing than punishment.

Punishment can be justified through law.

Humiliation rarely can.

Punishment says:

You violated a rule.

Humiliation says:

You are beneath me.

The distinction matters.

Because institutions are supposed to operate through rules.

Personal power operates through relationships.

When a political system becomes excessively personalised, people stop asking what the law permits and begin asking what the powerful person wants.

That is a dangerous transformation.

The law becomes secondary.

Personality becomes primary.

And once personality becomes primary, the institutions surrounding the leader may continue to exist formally while becoming weaker in practice.

There may still be courts.

There may still be parliament.

There may still be police.

There may still be elections.

But the real question becomes:

Can any of these institutions say no to the person at the centre of power?

If the answer is no, then the institutions exist, but their independence is questionable.

This is not unique to Rwanda.

History is full of states in which institutions existed on paper while political power operated through personal loyalty.

The names and ideologies differ.

The mechanism is familiar.

A leader becomes the central source of authority.

Those around him learn to anticipate his preferences.

People who challenge him become isolated.

Former allies become suspect.

Institutions become increasingly dependent upon the executive.

Eventually, the leader may not need to personally order every action.

People act because they understand what is expected.

That is perhaps the most sophisticated form of political power.

It does not always command.

It anticipates.

The same principle applies to humiliation.

A person does not need to be slapped personally to understand that he could be.

He only needs to see someone else humiliated.

The lesson spreads.

And once the lesson has spread, people begin disciplining themselves.

They lower their voices.

They choose safer subjects.

They avoid certain people.

They do not challenge certain decisions.

They remain silent.

Again, silence can be mistaken for agreement.

But silence may simply mean that people have learned the cost of disagreement.

This is why political freedom cannot be measured only by the absence of visible rebellion.

A fearful population can be extraordinarily quiet.

A confident population can be extraordinarily argumentative.

Arguments are not necessarily signs of instability.

Sometimes they are signs of health.

A society in which people can disagree publicly without fearing violence or arbitrary punishment may be stronger than a society in which everyone appears to agree.

The challenge for Rwanda is particularly complex because the country has a history in which disorder and political violence have carried devastating consequences.

The desire for order is therefore understandable.

But order and fear are not the same thing.

A country can be orderly because its institutions work.

Or it can be orderly because people are afraid to test them.

The first kind of order is durable.

The second is fragile.

And this brings us back to the two slaps.

Whether one accepts every detail of the author's account or not, the symbolic meaning remains useful.

A slap is an encounter between power and vulnerability.

One person acts.

The other absorbs the consequences.

If nobody can challenge the person who strikes, then the act becomes more than personal aggression.

It becomes an expression of hierarchy.

Political systems face the same danger.

When powerful individuals become effectively immune from challenge, ordinary citizens begin to understand that power is unequal.

They may not say so publicly.

But they know.

And once citizens believe that some people are above the rules, confidence in institutions begins to decline.

The tragedy is that this does not necessarily produce immediate resistance.

Often it produces resignation.

People say:

That is simply how things are.

And perhaps that is the most dangerous sentence in politics.

Because it means that people have stopped imagining alternatives.

They no longer ask whether power should be constrained.

They ask only how to survive within its constraints.

A society reaches a particularly difficult point when people begin to confuse submission with peace.

There is no argument.

There is no protest.

There is no confrontation.

Therefore, everything appears calm.

But beneath that calm may lie frustration, resentment, and unresolved grievances.

Political stability should not mean the absence of disagreement.

It should mean the existence of institutions capable of managing disagreement without violence.

That is the standard by which governments should ultimately be judged.

Not by whether nobody challenges them.

But by whether challenges can occur without the country collapsing.

Not by whether critics are silent.

But by whether critics can speak.

Not by whether former allies remain loyal forever.

But by whether former allies can disagree without becoming enemies of the state.

And not by whether the powerful can humiliate the weak.

But by whether the weak have institutions capable of protecting them.

The two alleged incidents described by the author therefore sit within a much larger question.

What happens when political power becomes personal enough that humiliation, punishment, and authority begin to merge?

And what happens to those who refuse to accept that hierarchy?

The answer leads naturally to the next part of the story.

Because beyond individual encounters with power lies something larger: the institutions through which power is exercised.

One of the most revealing examples concerns Rwanda's social security system and the arrest of a senior official.

The story of RSSB and Kantengwa is not simply about one arrest.

It raises a broader question:

When an institution is supposed to serve the public, what happens when its leaders become caught in the political machinery of power?

That is where the narrative turns next.

4.6 RSSB AND THE ARREST OF KANTENGWA

Institutions are supposed to outlive individuals.

A president comes and goes.

A minister is appointed and later replaced.

A director is promoted, dismissed, or retires.

But the institution remains.

That is the promise of a modern state.

The institution is meant to be larger than the person occupying the office.

It is meant to have procedures, records, rules, professional standards, and mechanisms of accountability that do not change simply because one powerful individual changes his mind.

But what happens when an institution becomes inseparable from the political power surrounding it?

What happens when a senior official can no longer be certain whether a decision will be judged according to regulations or according to political loyalty?

And what happens when the people inside an institution begin to believe that their position depends less upon what the law requires than upon whom they have offended?

These questions become particularly important in the author's account of the Rwanda Social Security Board and the case of Kantengwa.

The story is not presented simply as an administrative dispute.

It is presented as another window into the relationship between institutional authority, personal influence, and fear.

The Rwanda Social Security Board—an institution responsible for managing important social-security functions—occupies a position that should ordinarily demand professionalism and public accountability.

It deals with people's contributions, their future security, and, ultimately, their confidence in the state.

People may never meet the officials who manage such institutions.

But they trust the system.

They contribute because they believe the institution will continue functioning even after today's officials have disappeared.

That trust is fragile.

Once people begin to believe that public institutions are controlled by private relationships, confidence can quickly deteriorate.

The author's narrative introduces Kantengwa within this broader environment.

According to the account, her case became significant because of the circumstances surrounding her position and subsequent arrest.

But before examining the arrest itself, it is worth pausing over the meaning of an arrest involving a senior public official.

An ordinary citizen may be arrested and the public may barely notice.

A senior official is different.

Such an arrest sends a message throughout the institution.

It tells everyone watching that position does not necessarily guarantee protection.

That can be positive if it demonstrates that senior officials are accountable to the law.

But it can become frightening if people believe that the law is being used selectively.

The difference depends upon process.

Was there a clear investigation?

Were the allegations specific?

Was evidence presented?

Was the accused given the opportunity to defend herself?

Were legal procedures followed?

Were similar cases treated in the same way?

These questions matter more than the arrest itself.

Because accountability and intimidation can sometimes look identical from the outside.

Both involve the exercise of state power.

Both may involve police.

Both may involve detention.

Both may involve public accusations.

But one is governed by law.

The other is governed by fear.

The only reliable way to distinguish them is through due process.

This is why institutions matter.

If an official is accused of wrongdoing, the institution should not need to protect her because she is politically connected.

But neither should it abandon her because she has become politically inconvenient.

The same principle should apply to everyone.

Justice cannot depend upon whether the accused is a friend or enemy of the government.

The author sees the case differently.

In his broader argument, the arrest forms part of a pattern in which individuals connected to political disagreements could find themselves exposed to state pressure.

That interpretation must be treated as the author's perspective.

But it nevertheless raises a legitimate question about the relationship between political power and administrative institutions.

A government can influence an institution without formally controlling every decision made inside it.

Influence may operate through appointments.

Through informal instructions.

Through expectations.

Through fear.

Through the knowledge that certain decisions will be welcomed while others will not.

This is why institutional independence is more complicated than simply asking whether an institution has a separate legal identity.

The deeper question is:

Can the people inside it act independently?

A judge may have legal independence.

But if he fears what will happen to his career after making an unpopular ruling, his formal independence may mean little.

A civil servant may have a written job description.

But if promotions depend upon political loyalty, professional independence becomes difficult.

A journalist may have the right to publish.

But if publication can result in intimidation, the legal right becomes less meaningful.

Institutions therefore require more than laws.

They require a culture of independence.

They require people who believe that following procedure is safer than following personalities.

That culture cannot be created overnight.

It develops through repeated examples.

If officials see colleagues protected when they follow the law, confidence grows.

If they see colleagues punished despite following procedure, fear grows.

People adapt to incentives.

That is true everywhere.

The author's discussion of Kantengwa therefore becomes part of a much larger argument about incentives within political systems.

What does an official learn from watching the fate of another official?

Suppose two officials face similar situations.

One follows the rules but displeases a powerful person.

The other pleases the powerful person but bends the rules.

If the first is punished while the second is rewarded, the institution has taught its employees an important lesson.

The lesson is not written in a regulation.

It is written in behaviour.

People learn:

Do not challenge power.

And once enough people learn that lesson, institutional culture changes.

The rules may remain unchanged.

The institution's name may remain unchanged.

Its offices may remain unchanged.

Its annual reports may remain unchanged.

But the internal logic has changed.

The institution now operates according to anticipation.

People ask:

What will they want?

rather than:

What does the law require?

That is a profound shift.

It is also difficult to reverse.

Because once people have learned that political survival depends upon anticipation, even a new generation of officials may reproduce the same behaviour.

They may never have been directly threatened.

They simply observed what happened to others.

This is how political cultures reproduce themselves.

Not only through orders.

Through examples.

Not only through laws.

Through consequences.

Not only through what the state says.

Through what the state repeatedly does.

The case also raises another question:

Can a public institution remain genuinely public when its leadership is caught in political struggles above it?

This is not a uniquely Rwandan question.

Every country faces the danger of politicised institutions.

Public corporations can become political battlegrounds.

Universities can become ideological battlegrounds.

Civil services can become patronage networks.

State-owned enterprises can become instruments of political influence.

The problem begins when the institution stops serving its formal purpose and starts serving the interests of those who control appointments and access.

Social-security institutions are especially sensitive because they depend upon long-term trust.

A pension is a promise made today about tomorrow.

A contribution made by a worker today may not benefit that worker for many years.

That requires confidence that the institution will survive political changes.

If citizens begin to believe that funds can be manipulated according to political interests, the entire social contract is weakened.

The author places the Kantengwa case within a broader narrative of power and fear.

His concern is not merely whether one individual was guilty or innocent.

It is whether the environment surrounding the case allowed an independent determination of that question.

That distinction deserves emphasis.

A person can be politically unpopular and still be guilty.

A person can be politically influential and still be innocent.

Political identity cannot substitute for evidence.

If the state has evidence of wrongdoing, it should present it.

If the accused is guilty, the courts should establish that guilt.

If the evidence is insufficient, the person should not be punished simply because powerful people dislike her.

This is the foundation of the rule of law.

The law must be strong enough to punish the powerful.

But it must also be strong enough to protect the unpopular.

Otherwise, law becomes an instrument rather than a safeguard.

The danger of politicised justice is therefore not simply that innocent people may be punished.

It is that everyone becomes uncertain about the rules.

And uncertainty creates fear.

An official who does not know whether a decision will be judged legally or politically becomes cautious.

A citizen who does not know whether a complaint will be treated fairly becomes reluctant to complain.

A businessperson who does not know whether success depends upon connections becomes hesitant to invest.

A journalist who does not know whether an investigation will trigger retaliation may choose a safer story.

Fear therefore has economic and social consequences.

It does not remain inside political offices.

It eventually reaches ordinary life.

This is why institutional independence matters even to people who have no interest in politics.

A citizen may say:

I do not care about political parties.

But that citizen cares whether his pension is safe.

He cares whether his property rights are protected.

He cares whether the police will treat him fairly.

He cares whether a court will hear his case.

He cares whether public officials can be held accountable.

Institutions determine these things.

Politics enters people's lives through institutions.

That is why the quality of institutions is more important than the charisma of leaders.

A charismatic leader can inspire a generation.

A functioning institution can protect several generations.

The first is temporary.

The second can endure.

The author repeatedly returns to individuals because personal stories make political systems visible.

A constitutional principle can sound abstract.

A person losing her position is concrete.

An argument about judicial independence can sound academic.

A person being arrested makes the issue immediate.

A discussion about institutional fear can seem theoretical.

A civil servant quietly changing his behaviour because he fears the consequences makes it real.

That is the value of individual stories.

They give a human face to political structures.

But individual stories must also be treated carefully.

One person's experience cannot automatically prove that an entire system operates in the same way.

It can raise questions.

It can provide evidence.

It can reveal a pattern when combined with other cases.

But it must be examined alongside independent records.

This is especially important in political writing because every side has an interest in controlling the narrative.

Governments have incentives to defend themselves.

Opponents have incentives to expose them.

Former officials may have personal grievances.

Current officials may fear reputational damage.

Journalists may have incomplete information.

Readers therefore need to resist the temptation to accept either side automatically.

The purpose of serious political writing is not to replace one official narrative with another partisan narrative.

It is to make the reader capable of asking better questions.

And perhaps the most important question raised by the Kantengwa case is this:

When a powerful state arrests one of its own senior officials, should citizens see strength—or should they first ask whether the process was fair?

The answer cannot simply be determined by whether we like the person who was arrested.

That is the temptation in politics.

We are inclined to demand due process for our friends and immediate punishment for our enemies.

A mature legal system must reverse that instinct.

It must offer due process to both.

Otherwise, today's weapon against your opponent can become tomorrow's weapon against you.

This is why institutional principles must be stronger than personal loyalties.

The rule of law is valuable precisely because we cannot know who will be powerful tomorrow.

The person who currently controls the institution may eventually lose power.

The opposition may eventually become government.

Today's minister may become tomorrow's defendant.

Today's critic may become tomorrow's president.

If institutions are designed around individuals, every transfer of power becomes dangerous.

If institutions are designed around rules, political change becomes less frightening.

This is perhaps the deeper lesson behind the author's treatment of RSSB and Kantengwa.

The real question is not simply what happened to one official.

It is what happens to a country when people begin believing that institutional outcomes depend upon political proximity.

Once that belief becomes widespread, trust becomes difficult to restore.

People begin looking for connections rather than procedures.

They ask who knows whom.

They ask who can make a phone call.

They ask which official is close to which leader.

The institution remains visible.

But its legitimacy begins to fade.

And once legitimacy fades, even correct decisions can be viewed with suspicion.

That is the final danger.

A government may genuinely investigate corruption.

But if citizens believe investigations are politically selective, they will suspect the investigation.

A court may issue a lawful judgment.

But if people believe the judiciary is politically influenced, they may distrust the judgment.

A public institution may act properly.

But if its leadership is perceived as politically controlled, confidence may still decline.

Trust, once lost, is difficult to rebuild.

And that brings us naturally to another institution—and another controversy.

If political power can influence individuals, can it also influence citizens through financial obligation?

Can a government turn patriotism into a contribution?

Can generosity become expectation?

Can national solidarity become pressure?

Those questions lead directly to one of the most politically significant initiatives discussed in the book:

the Agaciro Fund.

4.7 THE AGACIRO FUND

There is nothing unusual about asking citizens to contribute to the rebuilding of their country.

Nations have always called upon their people in moments of crisis.

Governments ask citizens to pay taxes.

Communities organise fund-raising campaigns.

Diaspora populations send money home.

People contribute to schools, hospitals, churches, roads, memorials, and emergency relief.

Sometimes they give because they are wealthy enough to help.

Sometimes because they feel responsible for their community.

Sometimes because they believe in the government.

And sometimes because they simply want to see their country prosper.

Patriotism can be generous.

But there is a question that every government must confront when it asks citizens to contribute voluntarily:

At what point does encouragement become pressure?

This question lies at the heart of the author's discussion of the Agaciro Fund.

The word *Agaciro* carries a powerful meaning in Rwanda.

It evokes dignity, self-respect, national pride, and the determination to build a future without excessive dependence upon others.

The idea therefore has an emotional force beyond that of an ordinary financial programme.

It appeals not merely to people's wallets.

It appeals to their sense of identity.

And that is precisely what makes it powerful.

A government can ask:

Will you contribute to your country?

That is a financial question.

But when the appeal is connected to dignity and national responsibility, the question becomes:

What kind of citizen are you?

That is a much more difficult question to refuse.

Because nobody wants to appear indifferent to the future of his own country.

Nobody wants to be accused of lacking patriotism.

Nobody wants to be the person who refuses to help when everyone else is contributing.

The psychological pressure can therefore be stronger than the financial pressure.

This does not mean that every contribution to the Agaciro Fund was forced.

It does not mean that every person who gave money was coerced.

Many people may have contributed willingly and sincerely.

Indeed, the very idea of citizens taking responsibility for their country's development can be admirable.

The question is not whether patriotism is valuable.

It is.

The question is whether patriotism should ever become a substitute for voluntary choice.

That distinction matters.

A citizen who gives because he believes in the cause is exercising agency.

A citizen who gives because he fears being judged as disloyal is responding to pressure.

The amount of money may be identical.

The political meaning is completely different.

This is why the relationship between government and citizens must be handled carefully whenever national campaigns are involved.

Governments possess symbolic authority.

A president's words carry more weight than those of an ordinary citizen.

A minister's request can sound like an expectation.

A public institution's encouragement can sound like an instruction.

A workplace campaign can make an employee wonder whether participation will affect how he is perceived.

The line between invitation and obligation can therefore become blurred without anyone explicitly announcing that the contribution is compulsory.

That is the central concern raised by the author's treatment of Agaciro.

The author questions whether citizens were truly free to participate or whether social and political expectations made refusal difficult.

Whether every particular allegation in the author's account can be independently established is a separate matter.

The broader question, however, is universal:

Can something remain genuinely voluntary when everyone knows that powerful people are watching who participates?

Imagine a company where the chief executive announces that employees are free to contribute to a charity.

Technically, nobody is forced.

But if the names of contributors are publicly displayed and senior managers praise those who contribute while remaining silent about everyone else, employees may begin to feel that participation is expected.

The policy remains formally voluntary.

The behaviour may not feel voluntary.

Political campaigns can operate in the same way.

The distinction between legal compulsion and social pressure is therefore important.

A government does not need to threaten someone directly to influence behaviour.

Sometimes the surrounding environment does the work.

People watch what respected figures do.

They observe what is praised.

They notice what is criticised.

They learn which behaviour demonstrates loyalty.

This is particularly significant in a country where national reconstruction is closely connected to collective memory.

Rwanda's modern history contains enormous suffering.

The genocide against the Tutsi destroyed families, communities, institutions, and trust.

The country that emerged from that catastrophe faced a monumental task.

Reconstruction required more than physical infrastructure.

It required rebuilding a society.

That process naturally created a strong emphasis on national unity, self-reliance, discipline, and collective responsibility.

The idea behind Agaciro therefore resonates with a legitimate national aspiration:

Rwanda should have the dignity and capacity to determine its own future.

That aspiration should not be dismissed.

Indeed, self-reliance can be an important foundation for national development.

A country that depends entirely upon external assistance remains vulnerable to external priorities.

Aid can be valuable.

International partnerships can be valuable.

Foreign investment can be valuable.

But no country can build its future entirely through the generosity of others.

At some point, citizens must invest in their own institutions.

They must pay taxes.

They must build businesses.

They must educate their children.

They must create jobs.

They must support public services.

They must participate in national development.

The concept of self-reliance is therefore not inherently authoritarian.

It can be profoundly empowering.

The difficulty arises when the government becomes the sole interpreter of what patriotism requires.

If the state says:

Give because you love Rwanda,

the citizen should still be able to say:

I support Rwanda, but I cannot afford to give.

Or:

I support the goal, but I disagree with the programme.

Or:

I prefer to contribute in another way.

A mature national identity should be large enough to contain disagreement.

Patriotism should not become a political loyalty test.

This is where the concept of *agaciro* itself deserves deeper reflection.

What does dignity mean?

Is dignity simply the ability of a country to finance its own development?

Or does dignity also mean that citizens can say no without fear?

Can a country claim dignity if its people feel compelled to demonstrate patriotism publicly?

Can national independence coexist with individual political dependence?

These are not easy questions.

A nation is made of people.

The dignity of the state cannot ultimately be separated from the dignity of its citizens.

If citizens are treated as responsible enough to finance national development, they should also be treated as responsible enough to make independent choices.

That is the philosophical tension inside the concept.

Collective responsibility is valuable.

Individual freedom is valuable.

The challenge is to protect both.

The author's criticism of the Agaciro Fund should therefore not be reduced to the question of whether the programme itself was good or bad.

The deeper question is about the political environment in which it operated.

In a highly centralised political system, even legitimate national initiatives can become politically charged.

The more closely a programme is associated with the leadership, the more difficult it becomes for citizens to distinguish between supporting the country and supporting the government.

This distinction is essential.

A citizen can love Rwanda without agreeing with Kagame.

A citizen can support national development without supporting every government policy.

A citizen can contribute to a national programme without endorsing the ruling party.

And a citizen can refuse to contribute without becoming an enemy of the country.

If these distinctions disappear, patriotism becomes political conformity.

That is dangerous.

Because governments change.

Presidents change.

Policies change.

Political parties rise and fall.

But the country remains.

A healthy patriotism therefore places the nation above the government.

The government is temporary.

The nation is permanent.

This principle should protect citizens from being forced to demonstrate loyalty to whichever administration happens to be in power.

There is another dimension to the Agaciro debate.

Money is never simply money in politics.

Financial contributions can create relationships.

A person who gives money to a political or national initiative may feel that he has earned the right to participate in decisions.

Those who contribute large amounts may gain influence.

Those who cannot contribute may feel excluded.

The state must therefore be careful not to create a system in which patriotism is measured by financial capacity.

A wealthy person can give millions.

A poor person may give a small amount.

Which one is more patriotic?

The question itself reveals the danger.

Patriotism cannot be measured purely in money.

A teacher who educates children contributes.

A farmer who feeds the population contributes.

A nurse who cares for patients contributes.

An engineer who builds infrastructure contributes.

A young person who creates a business and employs ten people contributes.

A citizen who obeys the law, pays taxes, and raises responsible children contributes.

National development is not a fundraising competition.

It is a collective process.

This is why the language surrounding national contributions matters.

If citizens are told that their contribution is one of many ways to participate in the country's development, the message can be empowering.

If they are made to feel that refusal demonstrates disloyalty, the same campaign becomes coercive in spirit.

The author is particularly interested in this second possibility.

He sees Agaciro as another example of the broader relationship between political power and ordinary citizens.

The government does not always need to use force.

Sometimes it uses moral authority.

Sometimes it uses social expectations.

Sometimes it uses patriotism.

And moral pressure can be extraordinarily powerful.

Consider the difference between these two statements:

Please contribute if you are able.

and:

Every true patriot should contribute.

The first leaves room for individual circumstances.

The second turns a financial decision into a moral judgement.

That transformation is politically significant.

Once money becomes a test of patriotism, poverty can begin to look like disloyalty.

A person who cannot contribute may feel ashamed.

A person who refuses because he disagrees may feel threatened.

A person who contributes may feel compelled to demonstrate his loyalty publicly.

None of this necessarily means that the original organisers intended such an outcome.

Political systems often create consequences beyond the intentions of their designers.

That is why institutions must be evaluated not only by what leaders say they intend but by how people experience them.

A government may say:

We are building self-reliance.

Citizens may respond:

We feel pressured.

Both statements can exist simultaneously.

The solution is not necessarily to abandon national initiatives.

It is to build enough institutional confidence that participation can genuinely remain voluntary.

That requires transparency.

People should know how money is collected.

They should know where it goes.

They should know who manages it.

They should know how decisions are made.

They should be able to ask questions without being treated as disloyal.

Transparency transforms contribution from an act of faith into an act of civic participation.

Without transparency, suspicion grows.

People begin asking:

Where does the money go?

Who controls it?

Who benefits?

Can anyone audit it?

What happens if I refuse?

These questions are not signs of disloyalty.

They are signs of citizenship.

A citizen who asks where public money goes is doing something valuable.

He is participating in accountability.

The state should welcome such questions.

The same principle applies to all public institutions.

A strong government should not fear citizens who ask questions.

It should educate them.

It should answer them.

It should provide evidence.

Because confidence cannot be manufactured indefinitely.

It must be earned.

And perhaps this is the deepest meaning of dignity.

A dignified state is not merely one that can stand without foreign assistance.

It is one whose citizens are confident enough to ask questions.

A dignified citizen is not merely one who gives money to the state.

It is one who can make a decision freely and accept responsibility for it.

That is a more demanding understanding of *agaciro*.

It moves the concept from government policy into political philosophy.

What does it mean for a nation to possess dignity?

Perhaps it means having the courage to govern itself.

But what does it mean for an individual to possess dignity?

Perhaps it means having the freedom to participate without coercion.

The two should not be enemies.

They should reinforce one another.

A country becomes stronger when its citizens contribute freely.

A government becomes more legitimate when citizens do not need to be pressured into supporting it.

And a national project becomes more durable when people believe that their participation is respected rather than demanded.

This returns us to the central theme of the chapter.

When trust disappears, even good intentions become difficult to interpret.

A national development programme may be genuine.

A contribution may be voluntary.

A campaign may be patriotic.

Yet if citizens have learned to associate government initiatives with political loyalty, suspicion will follow.

Trust changes the meaning of action.

The same request can feel like an invitation in a trusting society and an instruction in a fearful one.

That is why political legitimacy matters so much.

People do not evaluate only what governments do.

They evaluate the intentions they believe lie behind those actions.

And once trust is damaged, every new initiative must overcome the suspicion created by the previous ones.

The Agaciro Fund therefore becomes, in the author's narrative, another example of a much larger struggle.

It is the struggle between collective responsibility and individual freedom.

Between national unity and political conformity.

Between patriotism and loyalty to a particular leader.

Between voluntary contribution and social pressure.

And ultimately, between a government asking its citizens to believe in the future and citizens asking their government to prove that their trust is deserved.

Perhaps the final question is the simplest:

If a citizen must be pressured to demonstrate love for his country, what does that say about the relationship between the citizen and the state?

A country should be able to inspire contribution without demanding submission.

It should be able to call upon sacrifice without turning sacrifice into a test of political obedience.

And it should be able to ask its people to build the nation while still allowing them to question those who govern it.

That is the balance between patriotism and freedom.

Lose the first, and society becomes fragmented.

Lose the second, and patriotism can become a language of control.

The challenge is to preserve both.

And once money, patriotism, and political loyalty become intertwined, another aspect of power becomes impossible to ignore.

Power is not expressed only through institutions.

It is also expressed through symbols.

Through wealth.

Through status.

Through the things leaders possess and display.

Few symbols reveal this more vividly than the automobile.

For the author, Kagame's relationship with cars becomes another way of examining the personality and privileges surrounding presidential power.

And so the story moves from the politics of contribution to the politics of possession.

4.8 KAGAME AND HIS OBSESSION WITH CARS

A car can be nothing more than a machine.

Four wheels.

An engine.

A means of transportation.

But in politics, objects rarely remain merely objects.

A palace is not simply a building.

A uniform is not simply clothing.

A presidential aircraft is not simply an aircraft.

And a luxury vehicle is not simply a vehicle.

Objects can become symbols of power.

They tell people something about who is important, who is protected, who has access, and who lives differently from everyone else.

That is why the author's discussion of Kagame's alleged fascination with cars matters within the larger architecture of this chapter.

The issue is not ultimately whether a particular vehicle is expensive.

The deeper question is:

What does the leader's relationship with wealth and status communicate to a population being asked to sacrifice for the nation?

A leader can own expensive things without necessarily being corrupt.

A president may legitimately have access to security vehicles, official transportation, and state resources.

The existence of a luxury car proves very little by itself.

But symbols matter.

Especially in a country where ordinary citizens are repeatedly reminded of discipline, sacrifice, self-reliance, and collective responsibility.

When citizens are asked to contribute, save, sacrifice, and work for the national future, they naturally look toward those at the top.

They ask:

Do the people asking us to sacrifice live by the same standards?

That question is not necessarily envy.

It is a question of legitimacy.

The distance between rulers and citizens is measured not only in law.

It can also be measured in lifestyle.

A government may speak endlessly about equality while its leaders live in extraordinary luxury.

Citizens notice.

A government may speak about sacrifice while officials display extravagance.

Citizens notice.

And even when the spending is legal, the symbolism can still matter.

Political legitimacy is partly psychological.

People need to feel that the leadership understands their circumstances.

That does not mean that a president must live in poverty.

It means that leadership should be conscious of what its symbols communicate.

A luxury vehicle can communicate success.

It can communicate modernity.

It can communicate national progress.

But it can also communicate distance.

Everything depends upon context.

This is why political symbols deserve careful attention.

A leader's car may tell us less about his character than the author believes.

But the public discussion surrounding that car can tell us something about the society itself.

What does the population think leadership should look like?

What does wealth represent?

What does modesty represent?

What does luxury represent?

And how does the answer change when the country is still asking citizens to make sacrifices?

These questions lead beyond Kagame personally.

They lead toward the psychology of political leadership.

Leaders live inside symbols.

Every public appearance is interpreted.

Every building.

Every convoy.

Every security detail.

Every speech.

Every photograph.

The ordinary citizen may see only a vehicle.

The political observer may see hierarchy.

The economist may see expenditure.

The opposition may see inequality.

The government may see security.

Different people can look at the same object and see completely different political meanings.

That is why serious political analysis must be cautious.

A car is not evidence of a crime.

Luxury is not automatically corruption.

Wealth is not automatically theft.

But the distribution and display of wealth can still raise legitimate questions about public accountability.

The right question is not:

How expensive is the president's car?

It is:

Who paid for it, under what authority, and according to what rules?

That is the institutional question.

If public resources are used, citizens deserve transparency.

If private resources are used, the legal framework should make that clear.

If the vehicle is necessary for security, the government should be able to explain why.

Once again, the answer should come from institutions rather than rumours.

And that brings the chapter back to where it began.

Trust.

A citizen who trusts the government may see a presidential convoy and think:

They are protecting the president because the country needs him safe.

A citizen who distrusts the government may see the same convoy and think:

They are protecting power from the people.

The vehicles are identical.

The political meaning is not.

That is the strange power of trust.

It changes what we see.

And when trust disappears, ordinary objects become political evidence.

A car becomes a symbol.

A house becomes a symbol.

A meeting becomes a symbol.

A phone call becomes a symbol.

A contribution becomes a symbol.

Everything begins to carry hidden meaning.

That is when politics becomes psychologically exhausting.

People stop taking things at face value.

They search for what lies behind them.

And when that happens, the final subject of this chapter becomes almost inevitable.

Because the politics of suspicion eventually reaches its most dangerous point when allegations of assassination enter the story.

At that point, political disagreement is no longer merely about careers, institutions, or reputations.

It becomes a question of life and death.

And the next section asks precisely that:

Was there an alleged plan to eliminate a political opponent—and what does such an allegation reveal about a system in which former allies have become perceived threats?

4.9 THE ALLEGED ASSASSINATION PLOT

There is a point at which political conflict changes character.

A disagreement can be political.

A dismissal can be political.

An arrest can be political.

Exile can be political.

Even a public campaign of accusations can remain within the ordinary, if ugly, boundaries of political struggle.

But the moment an allegation of assassination enters the story, everything changes.

The question is no longer:

Who will control the government?

It becomes:

Who will survive the struggle for control?

That distinction is enormous.

Politics is supposed to be a competition over ideas, policies, institutions, and leadership.

People disagree.

Parties compete.

Governments lose elections.

Officials resign.

Opponents criticise.

Former allies separate.

In a functioning political system, none of these things should require anyone to fear for his life.

But history shows that political competition can become dangerous when power becomes deeply personalised.

Once the leader begins to see political opposition not as legitimate disagreement but as an existential threat, the boundaries of political conflict can disappear.

The author places an alleged assassination plot within precisely this atmosphere.

The account must be approached carefully.

An allegation is not proof.

A reported conversation is not automatically evidence of a conspiracy.

A person's belief that he was being targeted does not, by itself, establish who ordered the alleged operation.

These distinctions are essential, especially when discussing accusations involving political leaders and possible violence.

Yet allegations themselves can still be historically significant.

They can reveal what people feared.

They can reveal what political opponents believed was possible.

And, when examined alongside independently verified events, they may contribute to a broader understanding of the political environment.

The story presented by Marara concerns the alleged targeting of a political opponent and the belief that people connected to the Rwandan leadership were involved.

The author's account places the allegation within the broader deterioration of relationships between Kagame and former RPF figures who had once stood beside him.

This is the recurring pattern throughout the chapter.

The old comrade becomes the former comrade.

The former comrade becomes the critic.

The critic becomes the opponent.

And eventually the opponent is portrayed as a threat.

That progression deserves examination.

Because political systems do not usually become dangerous in one dramatic moment.

They become dangerous when categories gradually change.

A person who disagrees becomes troublesome.

The troublesome person becomes disloyal.

The disloyal person becomes an enemy.

And once someone has been defined as an enemy, almost anything can be justified in the name of security.

This is why political language matters.

Words prepare the ground for actions.

If an opponent is called a traitor often enough, people may eventually stop asking whether he has actually committed treason.

If a critic is repeatedly described as an enemy of the state, people may begin to believe that criticism itself is hostile.

If a former soldier is portrayed as part of a conspiracy, ordinary contact with him may become suspicious.

The category of "enemy" is powerful because it changes the moral question.

You are no longer asking:

What did this person say?

You are asking:

What threat does this person represent?

And once politics is framed as a struggle against threats, extraordinary measures become easier to justify.

The author presents the alleged assassination plot as part of this transformation.

But there is another reason assassination allegations are politically significant.

They reveal the ultimate weakness of a political system based on personal power.

If the government truly possesses strong institutions, why would a political opponent need to be eliminated?

He can be defeated politically.

He can be challenged in court.

He can be criticised publicly.

He can lose an election.

He can be ignored.

He can form another political party.

There are countless nonviolent ways of responding to opposition.

The resort to violence, if it occurs, therefore represents more than cruelty.

It represents institutional failure.

It means that the political system has ceased to believe that ordinary political mechanisms are sufficient.

But this is precisely why such allegations require extraordinary care.

It would be irresponsible to transform an allegation into a historical fact simply because it fits a broader narrative.

Political narratives are seductive.

Once a reader accepts the idea that a leader is capable of something terrible, every later event may appear to confirm that belief.

This is confirmation bias.

The opposite danger also exists.

A reader who admires a leader may reject every allegation automatically.

That is equally problematic.

The serious reader must remain between these two extremes.

Neither automatic belief nor automatic dismissal.

Instead:

What is the evidence?

Who made the claim?

When was it made?

What did they personally know?

What can be independently verified?

What alternative explanations exist?

What happened afterward?

These questions are not obstacles to storytelling.

They are what make political storytelling credible.

The author's narrative is powerful precisely because it asks the reader to look beneath official explanations.

But looking beneath official explanations does not mean accepting every alternative explanation.

It means investigating.

That distinction is crucial.

A government can lie.

An opposition can lie.

A former official can lie.

A witness can be mistaken.

A journalist can misunderstand.

A victim can misremember.

An intelligence officer can deliberately provide false information.

The existence of conflicting narratives does not automatically tell us which one is true.

Truth requires evidence.

And assassination allegations demand an especially high standard because the consequences of getting the story wrong are enormous.

An innocent person can be permanently condemned in history by an accusation that was never proved.

A genuine crime can also disappear from history if everyone is too afraid to investigate it.

The responsibility of the writer is therefore enormous.

He must preserve the human story without sacrificing intellectual discipline.

That tension is visible throughout this chapter.

The author's central concern is fear.

He describes a political environment in which people allegedly became afraid of what might happen if they challenged Kagame or maintained relationships with those who had fallen out with him.

The assassination allegation represents the most extreme expression of that fear.

When people believe political disagreement can lead to death, politics ceases to be a contest.

It becomes survival.

And once politics becomes survival, compromise becomes difficult.

Why negotiate with someone you believe wants you dead?

Why trust someone you believe may betray you?

Why participate in institutions you believe are controlled by your opponent?

Fear destroys the assumptions necessary for democratic politics.

Democracy requires uncertainty.

You must accept that your opponent may win.

You must accept that you may lose.

You must accept that the person you dislike may occupy an office you once held.

You must accept that the government may be criticised.

You must accept that yesterday's enemy may become tomorrow's political partner.

This requires an extraordinary psychological discipline.

It requires leaders to understand that losing political power is not the same thing as losing one's life.

In authoritarian systems, however, losing power can become dangerous because political power may provide protection from prosecution, exile, financial loss, or even physical harm.

That creates an incentive to remain in power at almost any cost.

And that leads directly to one of the central questions of this book:

What does a leader become when leaving office no longer feels safe?

If a president believes that retirement could expose him to prosecution, revenge, or political persecution, he has a personal reason to remain in office.

The longer he stays, the more dependent the system becomes upon him.

The more dependent the system becomes upon him, the more dangerous succession becomes.

And the more dangerous succession becomes, the more strongly he may feel that he cannot leave.

This creates a political circle.

Power produces fear of losing power.

Fear of losing power produces greater control.

Greater control produces more opposition.

More opposition produces greater fear.

And greater fear produces still more control.

The circle feeds itself.

The assassination allegation belongs within this larger psychological structure.

If a political leader genuinely believes that his opponents are plotting against him, he may become more willing to use extraordinary measures.

If opponents genuinely believe that the leader intends to eliminate them, they may become more willing to organise against him outside ordinary political channels.

Each side's fear confirms the other's.

Soon, nobody trusts anyone.

At that point, politics becomes a security problem.

And security problems are rarely solved through trust.

They are solved through surveillance, intelligence, policing, military operations, and control.

That may create temporary stability.

But it can also deepen the original problem.

The more people are watched, the more they feel threatened.

The more they feel threatened, the more secretive they become.

The more secretive they become, the more suspicious the government becomes.

Again, the circle closes.

This is why political reconciliation is so difficult after prolonged conflict.

Reconciliation requires people to believe that the past will not be used against them.

If they believe that admitting disagreement will expose them to punishment, they hide their true beliefs.

If they hide their beliefs, the government cannot accurately know what the population thinks.

It then relies increasingly upon intelligence and surveillance.

But intelligence gathered in an atmosphere of fear is imperfect.

People tell authorities what they think is safe.

Rumours multiply.

False accusations become possible.

And the government may begin responding to imagined threats as though they were real.

This is one of the greatest dangers of political paranoia.

A leader does not need to invent every threat personally.

He may receive thousands of reports.

Some will be true.

Some will be false.

Some will be exaggerated.

Some will be politically motivated.

If the system lacks independent mechanisms for testing those reports, suspicion can become policy.

That is why institutions matter again.

Independent courts.

Independent journalism.

Independent investigators.

A legislature capable of questioning the executive.

Political parties capable of organising without fear.

These institutions provide alternative sources of information.

They allow a leader to be challenged.

And paradoxically, that challenge can make the state safer.

A leader who is never contradicted receives less reliable information.

Everyone tells him what he wants to hear.

Everyone confirms his assumptions.

Everyone says the threat is real.

Everyone says the enemy is dangerous.

Everyone says stronger measures are necessary.

Eventually, the leader becomes surrounded by agreement.

And agreement can become a form of blindness.

This is one of history's recurring political tragedies.

The stronger the leader becomes, the less likely people are to tell him that he is wrong.

The less likely people are to tell him that he is wrong, the more confident he becomes in his own interpretation.

The more confident he becomes, the more power he exercises.

The more power he exercises, the more afraid people become of contradicting him.

And the circle begins again.

The assassination allegation therefore represents more than a question about whether one plot existed.

It raises a question about the kind of political environment in which such a plot could even be believed.

A healthy political system should make assassination almost unthinkable as a tool of political competition.

Not because politicians are naturally virtuous.

They are not.

But because institutions make violence unnecessary.

If the courts work, you do not need revenge.

If elections work, you do not need coups.

If parliament works, you do not need conspiracies.

If the media can investigate freely, you do not need rumours.

If opposition parties can organise openly, you do not need underground movements.

Institutions are therefore not bureaucratic inconveniences.

They are substitutes for violence.

They give political competitors a peaceful way to fight.

That is their greatest value.

The author's broader narrative suggests that Rwanda's political environment became increasingly defined by fear and mistrust among former comrades.

The reader should therefore resist the temptation to see each incident in isolation.

The domestic worker.

The presidential household.

The alleged killings.

The former allies.

Aloysia Inyumba.

Patrick Karegeya.

The arrest of Kantengwa.

The Agaciro Fund.

The controversies surrounding presidential privilege.

The alleged assassination plot.

Taken individually, each story requires its own evidence.

Taken together, they form the author's argument about power.

That argument is essentially this:

When political authority becomes excessively concentrated in one individual, relationships with the leader can become more important than institutions.

And when relationships become more important than institutions, loyalty becomes more valuable than independence.

Once loyalty becomes the currency of political survival, former allies become dangerous precisely because they know the leader too well.

They remember what happened before the public narrative was written.

They know the compromises.

They know the disagreements.

They know the personalities.

They know the history.

They may therefore possess something more politically dangerous than weapons:

memory.

History is powerful because it cannot be completely controlled.

A government can control today's speech.

It can control today's television.

It can control today's official statement.

But it cannot completely control yesterday.

Former comrades carry yesterday inside them.

They remember what the movement looked like before it became a government.

They remember what leaders promised before they acquired institutions.

They remember who stood where.

And sometimes, they remember things the leadership would prefer forgotten.

This is why political systems built around personal authority often develop complicated relationships with former allies.

The former ally is both familiar and threatening.

He is familiar because he knows the leader.

He is threatening because he knows the leader.

That contradiction lies at the centre of many political struggles.

But there is one final question that the reader must ask.

Suppose every allegation in this chapter were eventually disproved.

Would the broader questions disappear?

Not necessarily.

The questions about institutional independence would remain.

The questions about political accountability would remain.

The questions about the treatment of dissent would remain.

The questions about concentration of power would remain.

The questions about how former allies are treated would remain.

And if some allegations were proven, those same questions would become even more urgent.

That is why the value of political writing should not depend entirely upon whether every dramatic claim survives historical investigation.

The strongest argument is often the question that remains after the allegation has been examined.

And the question that remains here is profound:

How can a country build lasting peace if political disagreement is allowed to become a matter of personal survival?

Rwanda's history makes this question particularly important.

The country has experienced the catastrophic consequences of political division.

It knows what happens when propaganda becomes stronger than truth.

It knows what happens when people are classified as enemies.

It knows what happens when institutions collapse.

It knows what happens when fear becomes ordinary.

That history should make the protection of institutions even more important.

The lesson of Rwanda's past cannot simply be:

We must never allow disorder again.

It must also be:

We must build institutions strong enough that disagreement never again needs to become violence.

Those are not the same lesson.

The first can produce control.

The second produces resilience.

A nation does not become secure merely because its citizens are afraid of challenging the government.

It becomes secure when citizens trust that they can challenge the government without destroying the country.

That is the higher form of stability.

And it is perhaps the most difficult form to achieve.

Because it requires leaders to tolerate criticism.

It requires opponents to accept lawful limits.

It requires institutions to remain independent.

It requires citizens to reject political violence even when they are angry.

It requires journalists to investigate without inventing.

It requires governments to respond to criticism without treating criticism as treason.

In other words, it requires everyone to accept that no political cause is more important than human life.

The alleged assassination plot therefore brings Part IV to its natural conclusion.

The chapter began with betrayal.

It moved through former comrades, political isolation, institutional pressure, national contributions, symbols of power, and finally the fear of physical elimination.

The movement is deliberate.

Because political fear does not begin with assassination.

It begins much earlier.

It begins when people stop trusting one another.

It grows when disagreement becomes disloyalty.

It deepens when institutions become politicised.

It becomes dangerous when former allies become enemies.

And at its most extreme, it reaches the point where people fear that political conflict may cost them their lives.

The question, then, is not simply who betrayed whom.

The deeper question is:

What kind of political system turns former comrades into enemies?

And beyond that:

What kind of leadership can prevent that transformation?

Those questions cannot be answered by one incident.

They require us to step back from the individual stories and examine the political character of Kagame himself.

Who is the man at the centre of all these relationships?

How did he acquire such extraordinary authority?

What kind of leader does the author believe him to be?

And what historical comparisons might help us understand that style of rule?

Those questions take us into the next part of the book.

PART V — HONOUR, INFLUENCE AND FAMILY

Before we leave the politics of fear behind, however, the reader should remember one important distinction.

A political biography is never simply a story about the person at the top.

It is also a story about the people around him.

The people who rise because of him.

The people who fall because of him.

The people who challenge him.

The people who defend him.

The people who fear him.

And the people who continue to remember the person they knew before he became powerful.

Power changes relationships.

But relationships also reveal power.

That is why the next part of this book turns toward honour, influence, family, and the public image of Paul Kagame.

The question is no longer simply what happens to those who oppose him.

It is also:

How is the image of the powerful constructed, protected, and remembered?

PART V — HONOUR, INFLUENCE AND FAMILY

5.1 THE MEDAL KAGAME RECEIVED FROM UGANDA'S NRA

Honour has a strange relationship with history.

A medal appears to be a simple object: a piece of metal, an inscription, perhaps a ribbon worn across the chest.

Yet a medal is never merely metal.

It is a decision about memory.

Someone decides that a particular life deserves recognition. Someone decides which contribution should be remembered, which sacrifice should be celebrated, and which version of the past should be placed before the public.

That is why military decorations can become politically significant.

They do not merely honour the person who receives them.

They also tell a story about the past.

In January 2012, Paul Kagame was expected in Uganda for a four-day visit during which he was to receive a military decoration connected with his participation in the National Resistance Army's struggle between 1981 and 1986, according to Noble Marara's account. The author notes that similar decorations had been given to other prominent figures associated with the NRA struggle, including Salim Saleh, Fred Rwigema, Elly Tumwine and David Tinyefuza.

At first glance, there is nothing particularly mysterious about such an honour.

Kagame had indeed spent part of his early military career in Uganda.

He had worked within the NRA environment.

He later became one of the most important figures in the Rwandan Patriotic Front.

And eventually he became President of Rwanda.

A decoration from Uganda could therefore be understood as a recognition of a historical connection between a former guerrilla movement and one of the people who participated in it.

But Marara asks a different question.

Why then?

Why was the recognition coming decades after the struggle?

Why was Kagame being honoured in 2012 for a chapter of his life that had begun more than thirty years earlier?

The timing itself becomes part of the story.

According to the book, similar awards had continued to be given to former NRA figures after the movement took power in 1986. The author points out that Fred Rwigema had also received a liberation medal shortly before Kagame's recognition.

This invites a comparison.

Rwigema and Kagame are inseparable from the history of the Rwandan Patriotic Front.

Both were connected to Uganda.

Both became important figures in the armed struggle that eventually brought the RPF to power in Rwanda.

Yet their historical reputations developed differently.

Rwigema became, in the public memory of the RPF, the legendary military commander who launched the October 1990 invasion.

Kagame became the intelligence officer who rose through the movement's military and political structures and eventually became Rwanda's president.

A medal therefore does more than recognise a soldier.

It places that soldier within a particular history.

And history is never completely neutral.

The question of who receives an honour—and when—can influence how future generations understand the past.

This is why the author's attention to the medal is understandable.

He is not merely interested in the decoration itself.

He is interested in what it says about Kagame's relationship with Uganda and, more broadly, about the construction of Kagame's public image.

There is another detail that makes the comparison particularly sensitive.

The book claims that Rwigema's widow was expected to attend the ceremony connected with his posthumous recognition but could not do so because, according to the author's allegation, her passport had been withheld by people close to Kagame.

This is a serious allegation and should remain identified as such.

It is not enough to repeat it as an established fact.

But as part of the author's narrative, the episode carries symbolic weight.

A widow unable to attend a ceremony honouring her dead husband.

A former comrade receiving recognition years later.

A history shared by several men but remembered differently by each political camp.

And behind all of it stands a question about memory:

Who gets to decide how the liberation struggle is remembered?

That question becomes increasingly important as revolutionary movements become governments.

During a struggle, the people involved share danger.

After victory, they begin to acquire titles, offices, reputations, and competing interpretations of what happened.

The same event can then be remembered differently by different participants.

One person remembers courage.

Another remembers fear.

One remembers sacrifice.

Another remembers betrayal.

One remembers liberation.

Another remembers the beginning of a new form of political control.

History becomes contested territory.

The medal is therefore part of that contest.

It says:

This person contributed.

But it does not answer:

How much did he contribute?

Nor does it answer:

What exactly did he do?

Nor:

What happened between the beginning of the struggle and the moment of recognition?

Those questions require evidence beyond the medal.

The author's account is particularly interested in Kagame's precise role within the NRA.

According to the source material, Kagame had received intelligence training in Tanzania and later served in Uganda in a counter-intelligence capacity under Yoweri Museveni.

The book also cites the account of Lieutenant-Colonel Pecos Kutesa, who wrote about the Ugandan struggle, and uses it to challenge aspects of the heroic image surrounding Kagame's military past. The author reports that Kutesa described an occasion in which Kagame became frightened during an engagement and requested to remain behind at the military base, where he could continue intelligence work rather than participate directly in the operation.

This is precisely where the narrative becomes controversial.

The author is not content with allowing the medal to stand as a simple statement of honour.

He asks the reader to compare the honour with his own interpretation of Kagame's wartime role.

Was Kagame primarily a battlefield commander?

Or was his principal contribution intelligence?

Was he a frontline soldier?

Or was he an intelligence specialist whose importance lay elsewhere?

And if his role was primarily intelligence, should that make the medal less meaningful?

Not necessarily.

War is not won only by people carrying rifles into battle.

Intelligence can be as decisive as firepower.

Knowing where an enemy is positioned can save more lives than firing a single shot.

Knowing what an opposing force intends to do can determine whether an operation succeeds or fails.

A commander who understands intelligence can influence an entire campaign without necessarily being the person standing at the front of every engagement.

This is why the author's attempt to diminish Kagame's military credentials through a comparison with frontline combat is not necessarily conclusive.

A historian must distinguish between different forms of military contribution.

The intelligence officer and the infantry commander serve different purposes.

The absence of battlefield heroics does not automatically mean the absence of military importance.

Yet the author's argument remains useful because it asks us to examine the construction of reputation.

How does a man become remembered as a liberator?

What experiences become part of the official story?

Which experiences disappear?

Which witnesses are remembered?

Which witnesses are ignored?

And who has the power to preserve one version of events over another?

These questions become especially important when the person being remembered later becomes the head of state.

Political power and historical memory then begin to overlap.

A president does not merely govern the present.

He inevitably becomes involved in the interpretation of the past.

Monuments are built.

Anniversaries are commemorated.

Military achievements are celebrated.

Speeches are delivered.

Names are repeated.

Certain individuals become national heroes.

Others disappear from public memory.

This is not unique to Rwanda.

Every nation constructs its historical memory.

Britain remembers Churchill.

France remembers de Gaulle.

South Africa remembers Mandela.

The United States remembers Washington and Lincoln.

Different countries elevate different figures according to the stories they tell about themselves.

The difficult question is what happens when the person who controls political power is also one of the central characters in the national story.

Can that person be both the narrator and the subject?

Can the president objectively determine his own place in history?

Probably not entirely.

Every leader has an interest in how his legacy is understood.

And that is why independent historians matter.

They allow the past to be examined from outside the immediate political interests of the present.

Returning to Kagame's medal, the most important question is therefore not whether the decoration was deserved.

That is ultimately a historical judgement requiring evidence about his actual contribution to the NRA.

The more revealing question is what the ceremony represented.

It represented a continuing connection between Kagame and Uganda.

It represented recognition from the political establishment that had once employed him.

It represented the persistence of a shared military history.

And it demonstrated that the past can return decades later in the form of honour.

There is something almost paradoxical about that.

The man who had once been an intelligence officer in another country's revolutionary army was now a president returning to receive recognition from the government that had once known him as a soldier.

The journey itself is remarkable.

A young man enters military service.

He acquires experience.

He becomes involved in a regional struggle.

He develops relationships with powerful political and military figures.

He eventually joins the Rwandan liberation movement.

He rises through its ranks.

He becomes one of its central commanders.

And decades later he returns as a head of state.

That is not an ordinary political biography.

It is a transformation from soldier to statesman.

And perhaps that transformation explains why the medal mattered.

It connected the president he had become with the soldier he once was.

It said, in effect:

We remember where you came from.

But memory can also be selective.

The author wants the reader to ask what happened in the years between those two identities.

What did Kagame learn?

What relationships did he build?

What conflicts did he experience?

What did he become?

And perhaps most importantly:

Did the man who received the medal remain the same man who once served in the NRA?

Political power changes people.

Sometimes it makes them more cautious.

Sometimes more confident.

Sometimes more suspicious.

Sometimes more ambitious.

And sometimes it simply gives their existing personality greater consequences.

A private person's anger may affect a family.

A president's anger can affect an institution.

A soldier's suspicion may affect a handful of comrades.

A president's suspicion can affect an entire political system.

That is why the transformation from soldier to president deserves examination.

The medal stands at the boundary between the two.

On one side is the young Kagame.

On the other is President Kagame.

The decoration connects them.

But it does not explain the journey between them.

And that journey is precisely what the next section explores.

Because the story becomes even more striking when we consider the contrast between the image of Kagame as an educated statesman speaking at one of the world's most prestigious universities and the author's portrayal of his earlier academic performance.

In May 2013, Kagame delivered a lecture at the University of Oxford on regional and global affairs. According to the book, his address touched upon African development, leadership, and the role of technology in transforming African society and economies.

For the author, this creates another contradiction.

How does a man whose educational history is presented critically in the book arrive at Oxford to speak about Africa's future?

The question is deliberately provocative.

But it opens a much larger discussion about education, achievement, reputation, and political authority.

Can a person's academic record determine his intellectual capacity?

Can a person who struggled in school later become an effective thinker?

Can someone who did not excel in formal education eventually stand before scholars and speak convincingly about the future of a continent?

Of course they can.

History is filled with people whose intellectual influence cannot be reduced to examination results.

Academic success and political intelligence are not identical.

A person may perform poorly in school and later become an exceptional strategist.

Another may excel academically and struggle to lead people.

Education matters.

But it is not the only measure of intelligence.

The author's criticism therefore needs to be separated from the more interesting question underneath it.

What makes a leader intellectually credible?

Is it a degree?

A university?

An examination result?

The ability to speak fluently?

The ability to persuade?

The quality of one's decisions?

Or the willingness to listen when someone else knows more?

Perhaps leadership requires all of these in different proportions.

Oxford's invitation itself is therefore significant, regardless of one's opinion of Kagame.

It demonstrates that political reputation can cross boundaries.

A man once known primarily within military circles can eventually be invited to one of the world's most famous universities to discuss the future of Africa.

That transformation is itself worth understanding.

And it brings us naturally to the next section.

Because behind every public image is a private history.

Behind the president stands the father.

Behind the commander stands the husband.

Behind the statesman stands the man.

And when the public image of a leader becomes increasingly heroic, the contrast with allegations of violence becomes increasingly dramatic.

The next question is therefore perhaps the most personal one of all:

How can the image of a father and family man coexist with allegations of political violence?

That is the question with which §5.3 begins.

5.2 FROM A DIFFICULT STUDENT TO AN OXFORD SPEAKER

There is a particular kind of irony in seeing a political leader standing before an audience of scholars.

The setting itself carries meaning.

Oxford represents centuries of intellectual tradition.

Its lecture halls have hosted philosophers, scientists, politicians, historians, and statesmen.

To be invited there is, at minimum, a recognition that the speaker has something considered worth hearing.

For a political leader, however, such an invitation can mean something more.

It can become part of a public narrative about competence.

A president who speaks at Oxford is no longer presented merely as a politician.

He is presented as an intellectual participant in global affairs.

That is precisely what makes Kagame's 2013 Oxford appearance important within this book.

According to the source, Kagame spoke at Oxford on 18 May 2013 about regional and global issues, including African development, leadership, technology, African integration, and economic transformation.

The image is striking.

A former military intelligence officer.

A former rebel commander.

A president of a small African country.

Standing before an Oxford audience discussing the future of the continent.

One could interpret this as a remarkable story of transformation.

But the author approaches it differently.

He contrasts the prestige of the occasion with his negative assessment of Kagame's educational background and intellectual abilities.

The contrast is intended to provoke the reader.

But perhaps the deeper lesson is not about whether Kagame was a good student.

It is about how societies measure intelligence.

We often assume that the person with the best academic credentials must be the best thinker.

Yet political leadership repeatedly disproves that assumption.

Academic institutions reward certain abilities.

Politics rewards others.

A brilliant examination student may have difficulty persuading a village.

A person who struggled academically may possess extraordinary political instinct.

A scholar may understand a problem perfectly and still be unable to act.

A politician may act decisively while misunderstanding the deeper intellectual dimensions of the problem.

Human ability is not a single scale.

This does not mean education is irrelevant.

Far from it.

Education can broaden a person's understanding, expose him to competing ideas, teach intellectual discipline, and provide tools for analysing complicated problems.

But education does not guarantee wisdom.

Nor does a lack of formal education guarantee ignorance.

That distinction is important when evaluating any political leader.

Kagame's Oxford appearance therefore deserves to be examined on the substance of what he said, not merely on the irony of where he was speaking.

What arguments did he make?

Were they coherent?

Were they supported by evidence?

Were they persuasive?

Did his policies correspond with the principles he described?

Those are stronger questions than whether he once performed well in school.

And perhaps that is where the author's criticism can be turned into a more profound inquiry.

A leader does not prove his intelligence by speaking at Oxford.

Nor does he prove his ignorance by having struggled academically.

The real test comes through decisions.

How does he respond to information?

How does he handle disagreement?

Does he change his mind when evidence changes?

Can he distinguish loyalty from truth?

Can he admit mistakes?

Can he surround himself with people who are willing to tell him that he is wrong?

These qualities reveal intellectual maturity far more effectively than a school report.

And they bring us back to the central concern of the entire book:

power.

The more powerful a leader becomes, the more dangerous intellectual arrogance can be.

An ordinary person's bad judgement may affect a few people.

A president's bad judgement can affect millions.

That is why leadership requires humility.

Not weakness.

Humility.

The ability to recognise that the person sitting across the table may know something you do not.

The ability to hear criticism without interpreting it as betrayal.

The ability to distinguish disagreement from hostility.

These qualities matter more than the prestige of any university.

Oxford can give a leader a platform.

It cannot give him wisdom.

A medal can honour a soldier.

It cannot prove his character.

A presidency can give a man authority.

It cannot automatically give him legitimacy.

Those things must be earned through conduct.

And that distinction takes us toward the most difficult transition in Part V.

Because public reputation is rarely built from a single achievement.

It is constructed from stories.

The soldier becomes a liberator.

The liberator becomes a president.

The president becomes a statesman.

The statesman becomes an international speaker.

And eventually, history must decide what to do with the contradictions.

That is where the next section begins.

5.3 FROM FATHERHOOD TO ALLEGATIONS OF KILLING

A public figure can be described in many ways.

A soldier.

A commander.

A president.

A father.

A husband.

A friend.

An enemy.

A hero.

A tyrant.

Sometimes all of these descriptions are applied to the same person by different people.

The difficulty begins when we try to reconcile them.

How can a man be a loving father to his children and, at the same time, be accused of ordering or tolerating violence against others?

Does one image cancel the other?

Or can human beings contain contradictions that are uncomfortable precisely because they are human?

The next section will confront that contradiction directly.

5.3 FROM A DEVOTED MOTHER TO AN ALLEGED PARTICIPANT IN VIOLENCE

There is perhaps no contradiction more difficult for the human mind to confront than the contrast between tenderness and violence.

We instinctively separate the two.

We imagine the person who comforts a child to be different from the person capable of causing suffering.

We imagine the mother protecting her family to be different from the political actor capable of participating in a system of repression.

But human beings are rarely so simple.

A person can be gentle in one part of life and severe in another.

A person can show affection privately while supporting decisions that cause suffering publicly.

A person can be remembered warmly by those who knew her personally while being viewed with suspicion by those who experienced the consequences of the institutions around her.

So what happens when the woman once regarded as a caring mother becomes the subject of allegations of political involvement in violence?

Can the two images exist at the same time?

The author's answer is deeply personal.

He writes about Jeannette Nyiramongi, the wife of President Paul Kagame, whom he says he first knew during the 1990s.

His initial impression was remarkably different from the image he would later construct.

He remembers her as approachable, sociable, and concerned about the young people around her. He recalls ordinary conversations, including one occasion in 1997 when she jokingly asked him whether he had a girlfriend. He describes these encounters as evidence of a woman he once regarded as almost maternal.

That memory is important.

Not because it proves anything about her later conduct.

It does not.

But because it establishes the distance between the woman the author thought he knew and the woman he later came to believe she had become.

That distance is what gives the section its emotional force.

The person he once called *Mama* eventually became, in his eyes, someone associated with the machinery of political repression.

How does such a transformation happen?

Does the person actually change?

Or does power simply reveal aspects of a personality that ordinary life had hidden?

Perhaps there is another possibility.

Perhaps neither image is complete.

Perhaps a person can genuinely care for some people while participating in decisions that harm others.

That possibility is uncomfortable precisely because it prevents us from dividing the world neatly into good people and bad people.

Politics rarely offers such simplicity.

The author recalls that during the period when Jeannette was studying at KIST, he and others sometimes drove her to school. He describes her as experiencing difficulties within her marriage and says there were occasions when she asked them to take her to her mother's home when she feared her husband's anger.

These are intimate recollections.

They belong to the author's personal memory, not to an independently verified historical record.

That distinction matters.

Memory can preserve details that official history forgets.

But memory can also be selective.

People remember conversations differently.

They interpret old events through the knowledge they acquire later.

An experience that seemed ordinary at the time can acquire a completely different meaning years afterward.

This is one of the peculiarities of political memoir.

The narrator does not simply remember the past.

He remembers the past from the position of the present.

And the present changes the meaning of yesterday.

The author says that the relationship between Kagame and some of his former close associates began deteriorating around 2002. In his account, this was also a period in which Jeannette's own position and activities began to change.

Here the personal story begins to merge with the political story.

The household is no longer merely a family.

It becomes part of the political environment.

Friends of the family are no longer simply friends.

Their relationships can carry political significance.

Business relationships can become political relationships.

Personal loyalties can become institutional loyalties.

And once that happens, ordinary human relationships become dangerous territory.

Consider the position of a presidential spouse.

She is not necessarily an elected official.

She may not hold constitutional executive authority.

Yet proximity to the president can itself create influence.

People may seek her favour.

Officials may pay attention to her relationships.

Businesspeople may attempt to establish connections.

Artists may seek opportunities through her network.

People around her may gain access to the centre of political power.

This does not automatically mean that the presidential spouse exercises improper influence.

It means only that proximity itself can become a form of power.

And power does not always require an official title.

Sometimes the most influential person in a political room is the person who can reach the person who makes the final decision.

That is why presidential families deserve scrutiny.

Not because family members are automatically guilty of wrongdoing, but because political power rarely stops neatly at the boundaries of an office.

The author describes Jeannette's later involvement in projects and relationships that, in his interpretation, brought her closer to powerful figures within Kagame's security establishment. He specifically mentions Jack Nziza and alleges that she became involved in political and security-related activities.

Again, these are serious allegations.

They should not be mistaken for established findings simply because they appear in a memoir.

But they form part of the author's explanation for what he perceives as a transformation.

The woman he once knew socially was, in his later interpretation, becoming increasingly connected to the political machinery surrounding the president.

And then comes Kizito Mihigo.

His story gives the chapter its most painful human dimension.

Kizito was not introduced to the reader as a politician.

He was an artist.

A singer.

A survivor.

A young Rwandan whose response to the country's history was expressed through music.

According to the source, he began composing songs at a young age, later became known for religious music, survived the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi, and lost his father during the genocide. His experiences became part of the emotional foundation of his music.

That history matters.

Because music can do something politics often cannot.

It can reach people before they have decided what to believe.

A political speech tells people what to think.

A song can make people feel.

And in a society carrying the memory of mass violence, that distinction becomes particularly important.

A song about grief can cross political boundaries.

A song about forgiveness can reach people who would never attend a political meeting.

A song about the dead can force a society to remember what it would rather forget.

That is the power of art.

And it is also why art can become politically sensitive.

The author describes Kizito's music as an attempt to encourage reconciliation and healing among Rwandans.

He particularly discusses the song *Igisobanuro cy'Urupfu*, which he interprets as remembering victims of the genocide while also acknowledging people who died through revenge and other violence surrounding the conflict. The source presents the song as affirming the idea that being human comes before being defined politically or ethnically.

That is a profound proposition.

What comes first: the identity imposed upon us, or our humanity?

If a society is divided by history, can it heal without acknowledging the suffering of more than one group?

If one person's pain is publicly recognised while another person's pain is considered politically inconvenient, can reconciliation ever become complete?

These are difficult questions.

They should not be confused with attempts to minimise or deny genocide.

Remembering all victims does not require denying the particular historical reality of the genocide against the Tutsi.

Indeed, serious reconciliation requires both historical accuracy and human empathy.

The challenge is determining how a society can remember different forms of suffering without creating a false equivalence between them.

That is precisely where political sensitivity begins.

The author argues that Kizito's attempt to broaden the language of remembrance made him politically unacceptable to powerful actors.

He claims that although Kizito had previously been close to Jeannette through projects connected to reconciliation and unity, that relationship did not

ultimately protect him. According to the author's account, Kizito was arrested and accused of collaborating with opposition groups including the RNC and FDLR.

These allegations surrounding the circumstances of his detention are among the most serious claims in the section.

They require careful treatment.

A political memoir can preserve a witness's perspective, but it cannot by itself establish what happened inside undisclosed locations or prove who ordered particular actions.

That requires independent evidence.

Nevertheless, the story of Kizito raises a question that is larger than any individual allegation:

What happens when an artist's understanding of reconciliation becomes different from the government's preferred understanding of history?

The answer determines whether art is free.

A government may legitimately insist upon the factual recognition of genocide.

It may legitimately condemn genocide denial.

It may legitimately prosecute genuine support for armed organisations.

But the state must also distinguish between denial of genocide and a genuine attempt to speak about the wider human consequences of war.

That distinction can be difficult.

Yet it is essential.

Because if every discussion of additional victims is automatically interpreted as denial, then citizens may become afraid to discuss their own experiences.

And if people cannot speak honestly about suffering, reconciliation becomes performance rather than healing.

The most difficult reconciliation is not the one in which everyone repeats the same official words.

It is the one in which people are able to speak honestly about what happened and still choose to live together.

That requires courage.

It requires historical discipline.

It requires empathy.

And above all, it requires the recognition that remembering one group does not require forgetting another.

The author presents Kizito as someone who attempted precisely this kind of reconciliation.

According to the book, his work had already received recognition from organisations associated with Jeannette Nyiramongi. In 2011, Imbuto Foundation reportedly awarded him a youth achievement award, recognising the contribution of his artistic work to reconciliation.

The apparent irony is striking.

A person whose work could once be celebrated as contributing to reconciliation could later become politically controversial because of the very ideas expressed through that work.

This raises another question:

Can a government support an artist when his art serves the national narrative, yet reject him when his art begins to challenge the boundaries of that narrative?

If so, what does that tell us about the limits of tolerated expression?

The answer matters because artists often become accidental historians.

They preserve emotions that official documents cannot.

They record the atmosphere of a generation.

They express grief before governments are ready to acknowledge it.

They ask questions before politicians are willing to answer them.

And sometimes they say something simple that becomes politically dangerous:

Remember everyone.

The author's interpretation is that this was part of what placed Kizito in danger.

Whether every element of that interpretation is correct must be established independently.

But the broader issue is unmistakable.

A society recovering from mass violence must create room for difficult memories.

Otherwise, the wounds do not disappear.

They simply become silent.

Silence can look like peace.

But silence is not always peace.

Sometimes it is fear.

Sometimes it is exhaustion.

Sometimes it is the belief that speaking will accomplish nothing.

And sometimes it is the knowledge that certain truths are safer when left unspoken.

This is where the story of Jeannette and Kizito intersects with the larger themes of the book.

The chapter began by examining honour and influence.

It now reaches a more intimate question:

What happens when proximity to power changes the meaning of personal relationships?

Jeannette had once been remembered by the author as a woman who cared about the young people around her.

Kizito had once been celebrated for using music to promote reconciliation.

The two worlds eventually became connected in a much darker narrative.

That transformation is what gives the story its tragedy.

But we must be careful not to turn tragedy into certainty.

The fact that a person was once kind does not prove that every later allegation against her is false.

The fact that a person later became politically controversial does not prove that every allegation against her is true.

Human beings are more complicated than that.

The responsibility of the reader is to resist easy conclusions.

Perhaps the most useful question is not:

Was Jeannette really the person the author describes?

It is:

How does a person living so close to political power change—and how does that proximity change the people around her?

Power creates gravity.

The closer one moves toward it, the more relationships begin to orbit around it.

Some people approach power because they believe in the cause.

Others because they want access.

Others because they are afraid.

Others because they simply happen to be nearby.

Over time, it can become difficult to distinguish genuine loyalty from strategic loyalty.

That is one of the reasons presidential families are politically important.

They inhabit a strange space.

They are private citizens in one sense.

But they are also constantly adjacent to public power.

Their friendships can attract attention.

Their businesses can attract scrutiny.

Their charitable activities can become political symbols.

Their disagreements can become public speculation.

Their personal relationships can acquire political consequences.

This is not unique to Rwanda.

It happens wherever political leadership becomes highly centralised around an individual and his family.

But the more powerful the presidency, the greater the importance of maintaining clear boundaries.

Public office should remain public.

Private life should remain private where possible.

And when private interests intersect with public authority, transparency becomes essential.

That is the institutional safeguard.

Without it, every family connection becomes a potential source of suspicion.

The author's story therefore leaves us with a difficult paradox.

The more powerful the president becomes, the less private the political environment around his family can realistically remain.

Every friend may be interpreted politically.

Every project may be interpreted politically.

Every conflict may be interpreted politically.

And eventually, even acts of kindness can be reinterpreted through the lens of power.

That is perhaps what happened to the author's memory of Jeannette.

The woman he once knew as *Mama* became, in his later interpretation, part of a political system he increasingly distrusted.

Whether that transformation occurred exactly as he describes it is a question for evidence.

But the emotional truth of the transformation is undeniable:

The person we think we know can become unrecognisable when seen through the shadow of political power.

And perhaps that is the deepest lesson of this section.

Power does not merely change governments.

It changes relationships.

It changes memories.

It changes the meaning of friendship.

It changes the meaning of loyalty.

It changes what people dare to say.

And sometimes, it changes the way we remember the people we once loved.

The story of Kizito Mihigo makes the question even more urgent.

A nation cannot heal simply by deciding which memories are acceptable.

It must learn how to hold painful memories without allowing them to become weapons.

It must allow grief without permitting incitement.

It must defend historical truth without turning remembrance into a monopoly.

And it must protect reconciliation without demanding intellectual silence.

Otherwise, the language of unity itself can become a source of division.

That is the paradox.

A government may speak constantly about unity while narrowing the range of memories that citizens are allowed to express.

A society may appear unified because people repeat the same language.

But genuine unity is deeper.

It does not require everyone to remember in exactly the same way.

It requires people to accept that others may carry different memories and still belong to the same nation.

Perhaps the most important sentence in any discussion of reconciliation is therefore this:

We do not have to share the same memory in order to share the same future.

That principle is difficult.

But without it, reconciliation remains incomplete.

And so the story of Jeannette, Kizito, and the presidential household ultimately leads us beyond the individuals themselves.

It brings us to the question of what power does to a family—and what a family can become when it stands beside the most powerful office in a country.

Because once political influence extends beyond the president himself, another question emerges:

What happens when a leader's sense of importance grows larger than the country he governs?

The author believes he sees that phenomenon in Kagame's relationship with Rwanda itself.

That is where the next section takes us.

5.4 A PRESIDENT'S POWER IN A SMALL, LANDLOCKED COUNTRY

A country does not become important because it is large.

Nor does a president become important because his country possesses an ocean, vast natural resources, or a massive population.

Rwanda is small.

It is landlocked.

Its territory is limited.

Its population is far smaller than that of many of its neighbours.

And yet its political story has repeatedly reached far beyond its borders.

That raises a fascinating question:

How does the leader of a small country acquire influence that extends across an entire region?

The answer takes us from the private world of the presidential household into the much larger geography of the Great Lakes.

And there, the story becomes considerably more complicated.

5.4 A PRESIDENT'S POWER IN A SMALL, LANDLOCKED COUNTRY

There is something remarkable about Rwanda's place in African politics.

On a map, it is easy to underestimate the country.

It is small.

It has no coastline.

It possesses neither the territorial scale of the Democratic Republic of Congo nor the population of Tanzania, Uganda, or Kenya.

Yet size has never been a reliable measure of political influence.

Some countries possess enormous territories and remain politically marginal beyond their borders.

Others occupy a few thousand square kilometres and somehow become impossible for their neighbours—and sometimes for the wider world—to ignore.

Rwanda belongs to the second category.

And at the centre of that influence stands Paul Kagame.

This is where the story becomes more complicated than the simple question of whether Kagame is powerful.

He unquestionably became powerful.

The more interesting question is:

How did the leader of such a small country acquire such a significant regional presence?

Part of the answer lies in history.

Part lies in military organisation.

Part lies in the relationships Kagame developed during the years of armed struggle.

Part lies in Rwanda's geographical position.

And part lies in the way Kagame himself has understood power.

Rwanda sits at a sensitive crossroads of the Great Lakes region.

Its borders connect it to Uganda, Tanzania, Burundi, and the Democratic Republic of Congo.

Each of these neighbours has its own history of political instability, armed conflict, ethnic tension, and competition for influence.

Rwanda therefore cannot easily separate its domestic security from the security of its neighbours.

What happens across the border can quickly become a Rwandan concern.

Refugees cross borders.

Armed groups cross borders.

Weapons cross borders.

Political movements cross borders.

Ideas cross borders.

And sometimes armies cross borders.

This geography has shaped Rwanda's political thinking for decades.

The Rwandan government has repeatedly argued that its security cannot be guaranteed merely by defending the country's physical boundaries.

Threats, in its understanding, may originate beyond those boundaries.

This creates a difficult political dilemma.

If a government believes that a threat is forming outside its borders, how far should it go to neutralise that threat?

Should it wait until the threat enters the country?

Should it negotiate?

Should it support allies across the border?

Should it conduct covert operations?

Should it intervene militarily?

These questions have no simple answers.

And the history of the Great Lakes demonstrates how dangerous the answers can become.

The Congo is particularly important.

The Democratic Republic of Congo is enormous compared with Rwanda.

Its territory contains vast mineral resources and stretches across the centre of Africa.

But its enormous size has also made governance difficult.

For decades, different armed groups, political movements, foreign governments, local elites, and international actors have competed for influence within its territory.

For Rwanda, the Congo is not simply a foreign country next door.

It is also a place from which armed groups have historically operated against Rwanda.

This security reality is central to understanding Kagame's regional policy.

Supporters of Kagame have therefore often presented his regional interventions as defensive.

They argue that Rwanda has had legitimate security concerns.

Critics, however, have accused Rwanda of using security concerns to justify influence beyond its borders.

This disagreement is one of the defining controversies surrounding Kagame's leadership.

And it is impossible to understand it without recognising that both sides are speaking from very different historical experiences.

For a Rwandan government shaped by the memory of genocide and years of armed conflict, the possibility of an organised armed threat cannot easily be dismissed.

For neighbouring governments, however, the prospect of a small but highly organised Rwanda exercising influence inside their territories can itself appear threatening.

Security for one country can therefore look like insecurity to another.

That is the paradox of the Great Lakes.

One government's defence can become another government's fear.

And once fear enters the relationship between states, mistrust becomes self-reinforcing.

Rwanda says:

We must protect ourselves because our neighbours may harbour threats.

A neighbour responds:

Rwanda is interfering in our affairs because it does not trust us.

Rwanda sees the neighbour's military preparations and says:

This proves we were right to be concerned.

The neighbour sees Rwanda's preparations and responds:

This proves we were right to be concerned.

The cycle continues.

This is why Kagame's influence cannot be understood solely through his personality.

It must also be understood through the security architecture of the region.

Yet personality matters.

Kagame's military background shaped the way he approached statecraft.

He came to power through an armed movement rather than through an ordinary electoral transition.

That experience inevitably influenced his understanding of organisation, discipline, intelligence, loyalty, and security.

For a military commander, uncertainty is dangerous.

You gather information.

You identify threats.

You assess loyalty.

You prepare for contingencies.

You act before the enemy becomes too strong.

These instincts can be extremely effective during war.

But governing a country is different from commanding an army.

A military organisation depends heavily upon hierarchy.

Someone gives an order.

Someone obeys.

A state, ideally, requires something more complicated.

Citizens disagree.

Courts challenge government decisions.

Journalists investigate officials.

Opposition parties criticise the president.

Parliament questions ministers.

Civil society demands explanations.

Institutions sometimes move slowly.

Democracy is, by nature, frustrating.

A commander may regard such resistance as an obstacle.

A democratic leader must learn to regard it as part of the system.

This distinction is central to understanding Kagame's presidency.

His supporters often praise his discipline, decisiveness, long-term planning, and intolerance of corruption.

His critics see some of those same qualities differently.

They see excessive centralisation.

They see intolerance of dissent.

They see a political system in which disagreement with the presidency can become dangerous.

The same characteristic can therefore be interpreted as either strength or authoritarianism depending upon the observer's perspective.

Decisiveness can be leadership.

It can also become domination.

Discipline can create efficiency.

It can also suppress independence.

Loyalty can build cohesion.

It can also destroy honest criticism.

Security can protect a nation.

It can also become the justification for excessive control.

This is why political leadership cannot be judged by one characteristic alone.

A strong leader is not necessarily a good leader.

A weak leader is not necessarily a democratic leader.

An efficient government is not necessarily a free government.

A peaceful country is not necessarily a politically open country.

These distinctions matter.

Rwanda's post-genocide history demonstrates that development, stability, security, and political freedom do not always advance at exactly the same pace.

The country has often been praised for rebuilding institutions, maintaining public order, promoting cleanliness and infrastructure, and presenting itself as a modern African state.

At the same time, Kagame's government has faced persistent criticism over restrictions on political opposition, freedom of expression, and the treatment of critics.

Both realities can exist simultaneously.

A country can make impressive progress in some areas while remaining deeply contested in others.

The mature reader must be able to hold those realities together.

It is tempting to choose one narrative.

Either:

Rwanda is a remarkable success story.

Or:

Rwanda is an authoritarian state.

But countries are rarely reducible to one sentence.

A serious history must ask what is true in each description and where the evidence leads.

The same principle applies to Kagame himself.

He can be regarded by supporters as the leader who helped stabilise Rwanda after catastrophe.

He can be regarded by critics as a leader who concentrated too much power in his own hands.

These descriptions are not necessarily mutually exclusive.

The difficult historical task is to understand how both perceptions emerged.

That task becomes particularly important when examining Rwanda's international relationships.

Kagame's influence has never been limited to Kigali.

He developed relationships with leaders throughout Africa.

His history with Uganda's Yoweri Museveni was particularly important.

The relationship began long before Kagame became president.

Both men were connected to the Ugandan struggle that brought Museveni to power.

Their relationship therefore contained something that ordinary diplomatic relationships rarely possess:

shared history.

They had known each other before either man occupied the position he later acquired.

Such relationships can be extraordinarily powerful.

They create trust.

They create access.

They create informal channels of communication.

They also create expectations.

And when those expectations change, the resulting conflict can be deeply personal.

The relationship between Kagame and Museveni eventually deteriorated.

That deterioration would become one of the most consequential political developments in the Great Lakes region.

But before reaching that point, it is worth considering what Kagame's position meant inside Rwanda itself.

The presidency of a small country can become extraordinarily powerful when the institutions surrounding it are weaker than the individual occupying it.

This is especially true when the president is also associated with the country's liberation.

The leader then becomes more than a politician.

He becomes part of the national story.

Criticising him can therefore be interpreted by some supporters as criticising the history of liberation itself.

This creates a dangerous psychological equation:

Leader = movement.

Then:

Movement = country.

And finally:

Criticism of leader = criticism of country.

Once that equation becomes established, political disagreement becomes much harder.

A person may intend to criticise the government.

Supporters may hear an attack on the nation.

A journalist may investigate an official.

The official may interpret the investigation as political hostility.

An opposition leader may propose a different policy.

The ruling establishment may interpret the proposal as a threat to national stability.

The boundaries between government, ruling movement, and nation become blurred.

This is one of the most important dangers of liberation politics.

Movements that fought to liberate a country may eventually find it difficult to imagine the country without themselves.

But a country belongs to its citizens.

No political movement owns the nation.

No president owns the nation.

No military organisation owns the nation.

The state should outlive every individual.

That is the true test of political maturity.

A leader's greatest achievement may therefore not be how long he remains in power.

It may be whether the institutions he leaves behind can function without him.

This is where the question of succession becomes important.

What happens to Rwanda after Kagame?

Can the political system produce a legitimate successor?

Can institutions operate independently of his personal authority?

Can former allies criticise the government without becoming enemies?

Can opposition parties compete without being treated as threats to national security?

Can the country preserve stability while allowing genuine political competition?

These questions are more important than any individual election.

Because a strong political system is not one that depends upon a strong man.

It is one that remains strong when the strong man is gone.

This is the ultimate test of institutions.

And Rwanda's future will eventually have to answer it.

Yet Kagame's influence cannot be fully understood by looking only at domestic institutions.

His greatest controversies often arise from the country's relationship with its neighbours.

And nowhere is that more evident than in the Democratic Republic of Congo.

For years, accusations and counter-accusations have surrounded Rwanda's role in Congolese affairs.

Some critics have accused Rwanda of supporting armed groups inside Congo.

Rwandan officials have repeatedly framed their regional policy around security concerns and threats originating from Congolese territory.

The debate has become extraordinarily complicated because armed movements in eastern Congo have changed names, alliances, commanders, and objectives over time.

Behind the military language are also human consequences.

Families displaced from their homes.

Communities caught between armed groups.

Refugees crossing borders.

Soldiers dying far from their homes.

Children growing up surrounded by conflict.

And ordinary people trying to survive political struggles they did not create.

This is where regional power becomes more than a diplomatic concept.

A decision taken in Kigali can affect someone in Goma.

A decision taken in Kinshasa can affect someone in Rubavu.

A political crisis in Bujumbura can affect someone in Kigali.

A dispute between Kampala and Kigali can affect trade, transport, and security.

The Great Lakes is a region in which borders are politically real but human lives are deeply interconnected.

That is why Kagame's regional influence has generated both admiration and fear.

Supporters see a leader willing to defend Rwanda's interests in a dangerous neighbourhood.

Critics see a leader whose security doctrine has repeatedly drawn Rwanda into conflicts beyond its borders.

Both perspectives demand evidence.

Neither should be accepted simply because it is emotionally attractive.

But one conclusion is difficult to avoid:

Kagame's Rwanda cannot be understood in isolation from the Great Lakes.

The country's history is regional.

Its security concerns are regional.

Its political alliances are regional.

And many of the controversies surrounding Kagame's presidency are regional.

The next part of this book therefore moves beyond Kigali.

It moves toward the Congo, Burundi, Uganda, and the wider Great Lakes.

There, the story of Kagame becomes the story of armies, alliances, intelligence networks, rebel movements, neighbouring governments, and international peacekeeping forces.

The central question will change.

Until now, we have asked:

What kind of man is Kagame?

Now we must ask something larger:

What does Kagame's power mean for the region around him?

That question cannot be answered by examining Rwanda alone.

It requires us to cross the border.

It requires us to enter Congo.

And once we do, the story becomes much larger than one president.

It becomes a story about the unfinished politics of the Great Lakes.

PART VI — THE GREAT LAKES

CHAPTER SIX — KAGAME AND THE WARS IN CONGO

The Congo has long been described as a country of extraordinary potential and extraordinary tragedy.

Its territory is vast.

Its natural resources are immense.

Its strategic importance is undeniable.

Yet for decades, parts of the country have struggled under the weight of weak institutions, armed conflict, political competition, foreign intervention, and local grievances.

For Rwanda, Congo has represented both danger and opportunity.

Danger, because armed groups hostile to Rwanda have operated there.

Opportunity, because influence in eastern Congo can provide strategic depth, economic connections, and regional leverage.

Between these two realities lies the central controversy.

When does legitimate self-defence become intervention?

And when does intervention become a pursuit of influence?

The answer is rarely obvious.

That is why the history of Kagame and Congo cannot be told honestly through slogans.

It cannot simply be:

Rwanda invaded Congo.

Nor can it simply be:

Rwanda was only defending itself.

Both statements are too simple for a history this complicated.

We must examine the wars.

We must examine the actors.

We must examine the alliances.

We must examine the armed movements.

We must examine what Rwanda says.

We must examine what its critics say.

And above all, we must remember the people who lived through the consequences.

Because behind every geopolitical calculation is a human life.

Behind every military operation is a family.

Behind every border dispute is a community.

And behind every political strategy are people who must eventually live with its consequences.

The first question, therefore, is unavoidable:

Why has Congo mattered so much to Kagame and to Rwanda?

That is where the next section begins.

CHAPTER SIX — KAGAME AND THE WARS IN CONGO

6.1 THE PRESIDENT AND THE WARS IN CONGO

There are countries whose history can be understood largely within their own borders.

The Democratic Republic of Congo is not one of them.

To understand modern Congo is to understand the forces that have repeatedly crossed its borders: refugees, armies, rebel movements, political interests, commercial networks, and foreign governments. To understand Rwanda's modern history is, in turn, to understand how closely Rwanda's fate has been tied to what happens on Congolese soil.

The relationship is uncomfortable because neither country can look at the other without seeing its own history reflected back.

For Rwanda, eastern Congo has repeatedly represented a security problem.

For Congo, Rwanda has repeatedly been perceived as a source of interference.

For communities living along the border, these two realities can exist simultaneously.

That is what makes the Congo question so difficult.

It is not simply a question of who is right.

It is a question of how several competing fears can become mutually reinforcing.

After the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi, the movement that had taken power in Rwanda inherited a country traumatised by violence and surrounded by unresolved regional tensions.

Large numbers of people had fled Rwanda into neighbouring countries, including what was then Zaire.

Among those who crossed the border were ordinary civilians.

But armed elements connected to the former Rwandan government and the forces responsible for the genocide also found themselves in refugee camps in eastern Zaire.

Those camps became more than places of refuge.

Some became militarised.

The presence of armed groups near Rwanda's border created a problem that the new Rwandan government considered existential.

The question was immediate:

Could Rwanda allow forces responsible for mass violence to remain organised just across its border?

From Kigali's perspective, the answer was increasingly no.

But there was another question, equally important:

How far could Rwanda go in responding to that threat?

That question would eventually lead Rwanda into wars that extended far beyond its own territory.

The first major intervention came in 1996.

Rwandan forces, alongside Ugandan forces and Congolese allies, supported the rebellion led by Laurent-Désiré Kabila against Mobutu Sese Seko.

The operation eventually brought down Mobutu's government.

For Kagame and the Rwandan leadership, the intervention was closely connected to security.

The refugee camps contained armed elements hostile to the new Rwandan government, and Kigali wanted those forces removed from its border.

But the consequences went far beyond that immediate objective.

Mobutu fell.

Kabila became president.

And the political map of Central Africa changed.

This was the first great lesson of the Congo wars:

A military intervention may begin with one objective and end by creating an entirely different political reality.

Rwanda had helped remove a government in Kinshasa.

But the new government did not remain a dependable ally.

Kabila soon began distancing himself from Rwanda and Uganda.

The relationship deteriorated.

By 1998, another rebellion had begun.

This time the conflict became even larger.

Rwanda and Uganda backed rebel movements against Kabila.

Other African states intervened on Kabila's side.

Zimbabwe, Angola, and Namibia became involved.

The war became so extensive that it was eventually described as the "African World War."

The phrase itself tells us something.

A conflict that began in Central Africa had become a regional confrontation.

And Rwanda, despite its small size, was now one of the central military actors.

How had this happened?

How had a country that had suffered catastrophic destruction only a few years earlier become a decisive military force in the affairs of its enormous neighbour?

The answer lies partly in the transformation of the Rwandan Patriotic Army.

The RPA was not an ordinary post-war army.

Its senior officers had been shaped by years of guerrilla warfare, exile, intelligence work, and military discipline.

They understood the value of organisation.

They understood intelligence.

They understood speed.

And they understood the dangers of allowing an armed enemy to establish itself close to Rwanda's borders.

But military effectiveness creates its own danger.

When a small state discovers that its army can operate successfully beyond its borders, the distinction between defence and intervention can become increasingly difficult to maintain.

At what point does the destruction of a neighbouring threat become the restructuring of the neighbouring country?

At what point does strategic depth become political influence?

At what point does security become regional power?

These questions followed Rwanda into Congo.

The Rwandan government's argument remained centred on security.

Its critics increasingly argued that other interests were involved.

Among the accusations were claims that Rwanda sought influence over eastern Congo and benefited economically from the region's natural resources.

Such accusations became particularly persistent because eastern Congo possesses enormous mineral wealth.

Gold.

Coltan.

Tin.

Tungsten.

Other valuable resources.

But it would be too simplistic to conclude that every Rwandan military decision was motivated by minerals.

Security concerns were real.

Political alliances were real.

Ethnic and historical ties were real.

Economic interests were real.

The tragedy is that these motives could overlap.

A military operation could simultaneously serve a security objective and create economic opportunities.

A rebel movement could claim political grievances while also becoming involved in resource extraction.

A foreign government could support an armed group because it feared its neighbour while benefiting economically from the resulting instability.

That is why the Congo wars cannot be explained through a single motive.

They were wars of overlapping interests.

And ordinary Congolese civilians were trapped beneath them.

The greatest victims of such conflicts are rarely the people who design them.

They are the people who live where the fighting takes place.

Villages change hands.

Families flee.

Markets disappear.

Schools close.

Agriculture becomes dangerous.

Young men are recruited.

Women and children become vulnerable to violence.

A conflict that looks strategic from a presidential palace looks entirely different from the perspective of a family trying to cross a road safely.

That human dimension must never disappear from the story.

Yet the politics of Congo cannot be understood without returning to Kagame himself.

By the time he became president of Rwanda in 2000, he had already accumulated considerable military and political experience.

He understood the region.

He understood Uganda.

He understood the Congolese conflict.

He understood the importance of intelligence.

And he had already demonstrated that Rwanda could project military power beyond its borders.

The presidency therefore did not begin his regional influence.

It formalised it.

The question became:

What would Kagame do with the power of the Rwandan state?

His supporters would argue that he had little choice.

The threat from armed groups in Congo had not disappeared.

Former genocidal forces had reorganised.

The Rwandan government feared renewed attacks.

From this perspective, a policy of passivity would have been irresponsible.

But critics asked a different question:

Can a country protect itself indefinitely by intervening inside its neighbour?

There is a point at which the strategy becomes self-defeating.

The more Rwanda intervenes in Congo, the more Congolese actors may perceive Rwanda as the enemy.

The more Rwanda is perceived as the enemy, the more armed groups may mobilise against it.

The more armed groups mobilise, the more Rwanda feels threatened.

And the more threatened Rwanda feels, the more it intervenes.

Again, the cycle closes.

This is one of the defining patterns of Great Lakes politics.

Security dilemmas produce the very threats they are intended to eliminate.

A government arms itself because it fears its neighbour.

The neighbour sees the military build-up and becomes frightened.

It arms itself.

The first government sees this as confirmation of its original fear.

And both sides become more heavily armed.

Eventually, nobody remembers who began preparing first.

Everyone simply remembers being afraid.

This is why peace agreements in the Great Lakes have so often struggled to produce permanent peace.

An agreement may stop a particular war.

It cannot automatically eliminate the fears that produced the war.

Nor can it immediately erase the networks, grievances, and political interests created during years of fighting.

And there is another complication.

The Congo conflict has never involved only governments.

Rebel movements have played an enormous role.

Some were created because of genuine local grievances.

Others were supported by foreign governments.

Some changed alliances.

Some fragmented.

Some disappeared and later returned under new names.

This constantly changing landscape made it possible for governments to deny direct responsibility while still influencing events indirectly.

That is one reason accusations concerning Rwanda's role in Congo have remained so persistent.

The question is not always:

Did Rwanda send soldiers?

Sometimes the more important questions are:

Who armed this group?

Who trained it?

Who supplied it?

Who gave its leaders political protection?

Who benefited when it controlled territory?

These questions become particularly important when examining the later history of the M23 movement.

But before reaching M23, we must understand the political relationship between Kagame and the Congolese leadership.

Because wars do not begin only on battlefields.

They begin with political calculations.

A president decides that another government cannot be trusted.

A neighbouring government decides that Rwanda is becoming too powerful.

A rebel leader sees an opportunity.

An intelligence service identifies an ally.

A foreign government chooses a side.

Then, eventually, soldiers appear.

That is how regional wars begin.

Not with a single gunshot.

With decisions.

And the most consequential decision of the Congo wars was the decision by regional actors to support Congolese rebellions rather than accept the political order that existed in Kinshasa.

The consequences were enormous.

Mobutu fell.

Kabila rose.

Kabila turned against his former allies.

Another war began.

Millions of Congolese suffered.

Regional armies entered Congo.

Peace agreements were signed.

Governments changed.

Rebel movements fragmented.

Yet the fundamental problem remained:

Eastern Congo was still unstable.

And Rwanda was still concerned about security.

This is why the story did not end with the formal conclusion of the Congo wars.

It continued through new armed movements.

New alliances.

New accusations.

New diplomatic crises.

And eventually, M23.

To understand M23, however, we must first understand the soldiers who formed its core.

Many had previously belonged to the Rassemblement Congolais pour la Démocratie and later to the National Congress for the Defence of the People, commonly known as CNDP.

When the CNDP was integrated into the Congolese army under a 2009 peace agreement, the arrangement was supposed to bring former rebels into the national military structure.

On paper, integration offered a path toward peace.

In practice, it created another problem.

Former rebels entered an army whose loyalty, command structure, and political interests were already deeply contested.

The arrangement was fragile.

And when those tensions intensified, another rebellion emerged.

In 2012, the M23 movement was born.

The name itself came from the date of the peace agreement whose provisions its leaders said had not been properly implemented.

Its emergence revived an old question:

Was Congo experiencing another purely domestic rebellion, or was the conflict again being shaped by neighbouring states?

This time, international scrutiny became intense.

Rwanda was accused of supporting M23.

The Rwandan government rejected those accusations.

The debate became one of the most controversial aspects of Kagame's regional policy.

And once again, the same problem appeared.

The region had competing narratives.

One side spoke about Congolese sovereignty.

Another spoke about Rwandan security.

One side spoke about foreign interference.

Another spoke about armed groups threatening Rwanda.

One side saw an invasion.

Another saw self-defence.

One side saw mineral interests.

Another saw survival.

The truth, as always, requires more than slogans.

It requires evidence.

And that is where the next section takes us.

6.2 THE PLANS AND STRATEGIES FOR CONGO

Wars are often remembered through battles.

History books name cities.

They record dates.

They list commanders.

They describe offensives and retreats.

But military campaigns do not begin with battles.

They begin with plans.

Someone asks what must be achieved.

Someone identifies the enemy.

Someone determines where pressure should be applied.

Someone decides which allies are useful.

Someone calculates what can be denied publicly.

And someone decides how far the operation should go.

This is particularly important in the Congo.

The geography alone makes conventional military control difficult.

Congo is enormous.

Its roads are limited.

Its forests are vast.

Its borders are difficult to monitor.

Its local political structures vary dramatically from one region to another.

A military force entering eastern Congo therefore cannot simply rely upon conventional occupation.

Influence often matters more than direct control.

Allies matter.

Local commanders matter.

Information matters.

Cross-border relationships matter.

And above all, intelligence matters.

This is an area in which Kagame's background becomes especially relevant.

The Rwandan leadership has historically placed enormous emphasis on intelligence and security.

That emphasis is understandable given Rwanda's history.

But intelligence-driven politics also creates a particular style of regional intervention.

Instead of waiting for a threat to become obvious, the state attempts to identify it before it matures.

Instead of responding to an armed group only after it attacks Rwanda, it may attempt to influence the environment in which that group operates.

Instead of treating Congo as simply another sovereign neighbour, it may view developments there through the question:

What does this mean for Rwanda's security?

That approach can be strategically rational.

It can also become dangerous.

Because once security is defined broadly enough, almost anything can become relevant to national defence.

A political movement can be a threat.

A military appointment can be a threat.

A refugee population can be a threat.

A foreign alliance can be a threat.

A neighbouring government's policy can be a threat.

The result is that the concept of security expands.

And when security expands, the space for ordinary diplomacy contracts.

This is one of the central problems in understanding Kagame's Congo policy.

The Rwandan government's concerns cannot simply be dismissed.

But neither can sovereignty be dismissed.

Congo has the right to govern its own territory.

Rwanda has the right to protect its citizens.

The difficult question is where one right ends and the other begins.

That question has never been fully resolved.

And until it is, the Congo story remains unfinished.

The next stage of that story concerns the people Rwanda once regarded as allies and the armed movements that emerged from their changing relationships with Kinshasa.

That brings us to the history of M23.

6.3 CALLING UPON OLD FRIENDS: THE HISTORY OF M23

Every rebellion has a history.

M23 did not appear from nowhere.

Its commanders had already lived through previous wars.

Some had fought with earlier Congolese rebel movements.

Some had served in the Congolese army.

Some had relationships with Rwanda.

Some had relationships with Uganda.

Some had fought against one another.

Some had changed sides more than once.

That history matters because the Great Lakes region is filled with former enemies who become allies and former allies who become enemies.

A commander who fights for one movement today may fight for another tomorrow.

A political agreement can turn a rebel into a soldier.

A broken agreement can turn the soldier back into a rebel.

This is not merely opportunism.

Sometimes it is survival.

If a former rebel commander enters the national army but discovers that his community remains vulnerable, he may conclude that integration has failed.

If he believes the government intends to disarm or arrest him, he may rebel again.

If a neighbouring country offers political or military support, rebellion becomes more feasible.

This is the environment from which M23 emerged.

The movement claimed that the Congolese government had failed to implement the March 23, 2009 agreement properly.

Its members therefore presented their rebellion as a demand for the implementation of a political agreement rather than simply a campaign for territorial conquest.

But the rebellion quickly became much larger than that argument.

As M23 captured territory and threatened major population centres, the international community became increasingly concerned.

Rwanda again became central to the controversy.

The question was now impossible to avoid:

Was M23 genuinely an internal Congolese rebellion, or was it being sustained by external support?

That question would shape Rwanda's international reputation for years.

It would also place Kagame under increasing scrutiny.

And it would expose the central paradox of his regional strategy:

The same military effectiveness that had helped make Rwanda secure could also make its neighbours suspicious.

The stronger Rwanda became militarily, the more closely its regional activities were watched.

And the more closely Rwanda's activities were watched, the more difficult it became for Kigali to convince critics that its actions were purely defensive.

The history of M23 therefore cannot be separated from the history of Kagame's relationships with the people who had once fought beside him.

Those relationships had begun in a different era.

Before presidents.

Before diplomatic accusations.

Before international sanctions.

There had been soldiers.

Comrades.

Friends.

And shared battles.

Some of those friendships survived.

Others did not.

The next sections of this chapter will examine how those relationships shaped the politics of Congo—and how old alliances continued to influence new wars.

Because in the Great Lakes, history does not disappear.

It changes uniforms.

6.4 THE PLANS TO INTIMIDATE BURUNDI

The history of the Great Lakes teaches a difficult lesson:

A border does not necessarily separate one country's fears from another country's fears.

Rwanda and Burundi are perhaps the clearest example.

The two countries share a border, a closely connected history, related languages and cultures, and many of the same historical wounds. Yet that very closeness has often made their relationship more sensitive, not less.

When two neighbouring countries have experienced similar tragedies, each may recognise something of itself in the other.

But each may also fear that the instability of the other could cross the border.

That fear has shaped the relationship between Rwanda and Burundi for decades.

The question is therefore not simply whether Kigali and Bujumbura are friends.

It is:

What happens when one government begins to believe that the government next door has become a threat?

That question became particularly important during the presidency of Pierre Nkurunziza.

Nkurunziza came to power in Burundi after a long period of civil war.

His political movement, the CNDD-FDD, had itself emerged from armed conflict.

Burundi had experienced its own devastating history of political violence, including the assassination of President Melchior Ndadaye in 1993 and the civil war that followed.

The country therefore entered the post-war period with deep political wounds.

Like Rwanda, Burundi was attempting to construct a functioning state after years of violence.

But unlike Rwanda, Burundi's political settlement developed around a different model of power-sharing.

The Arusha peace process attempted to establish political institutions designed to prevent one group from monopolising the state.

For many Burundians, this arrangement represented more than constitutional engineering.

It was a survival mechanism.

The lesson of their history was simple:

If one side controls everything, the other side may eventually return to war.

For a time, the arrangement helped maintain a fragile peace.

But the system remained vulnerable.

Political competition intensified.

Trust between the government and opposition weakened.

And when Nkurunziza sought a controversial third term in 2015, the country entered another period of severe instability.

Demonstrations erupted.

A failed coup attempt followed.

Armed groups emerged.

Political violence increased.

Thousands of Burundians fled the country.

For Rwanda, the crisis presented a difficult strategic problem.

A destabilised Burundi meant instability directly on Rwanda's southern border.

But it also created an opportunity for influence.

And this is where the allegations discussed in the book become significant.

The author presents the view that Rwanda's leadership sought to influence developments inside Burundi and that preparations were made to pressure or intimidate the Nkurunziza government.

These claims must be distinguished from established historical facts.

There were genuine tensions between Rwanda and Burundi.

There were accusations from both sides.

There were reports of armed groups operating across borders.

And there were competing narratives about who was supporting whom.

But the specific allegation that Rwanda deliberately planned particular operations requires evidence for each individual claim.

The reader should therefore approach the story neither with automatic belief nor automatic dismissal.

Instead, ask:

What would Rwanda have hoped to achieve?

That question is more useful than beginning with an assumption about guilt.

If Kigali believed Nkurunziza's government was becoming hostile to Rwanda, it would have had several possible objectives.

It might have wanted to prevent hostile armed groups from establishing themselves in Burundi.

It might have wanted to maintain influence over Burundian political actors.

It might have wanted to prevent instability from spilling across the border.

It might have wanted to encourage political change in Bujumbura.

Or it might simply have wanted to demonstrate that Rwanda possessed the ability to respond if its interests were threatened.

These possibilities are not identical.

The first could be defensive.

The fourth could amount to interference.

The fifth could be deterrence.

And in the real world, several motives can exist at the same time.

This is why foreign policy is rarely morally tidy.

A government can genuinely fear a neighbour and simultaneously seek greater influence over that neighbour.

Security and ambition can coexist.

That is one of the central themes of Great Lakes politics.

Rwanda's leaders have repeatedly argued that they cannot afford to ignore threats developing beyond their borders.

Critics respond that this doctrine can become a justification for intervening in the internal affairs of neighbouring states.

The disagreement is fundamental.

It is also difficult to resolve because both sides begin from different understandings of sovereignty.

From Bujumbura's perspective:

Burundi is a sovereign country.

Its government has the right to determine its political future.

Its internal disputes belong to Burundians.

From Kigali's perspective:

A government that permits armed forces hostile to Rwanda to operate near the border cannot simply invoke sovereignty and demand that Rwanda remain passive.

Both arguments contain an element of logic.

And that is precisely why the dispute is so dangerous.

Because once security concerns are accepted as legitimate, the question becomes one of proportionality.

How much intervention is justified?

What evidence is required?

What limits should exist?

Who decides whether the threat is genuine?

What happens when the intelligence is wrong?

These questions are not academic.

A wrong assessment can produce a war.

The history of the Great Lakes is filled with examples.

The most troubling aspect of alleged covert operations is therefore not only the possibility of violence.

It is the absence of public accountability.

If a government sends soldiers openly across a border, parliament can debate it.

The international community can respond.

Citizens can protest.

The government must provide an explanation.

Covert operations are different.

The public may not know that they occurred.

The government can deny them.

Witnesses may be intimidated.

Documents may remain classified.

Responsibility can become almost impossible to establish.

This is why allegations of covert interference are so difficult to investigate.

The very secrecy that makes such operations possible also makes them difficult to prove.

And secrecy can become a political weapon.

A government can deny an operation.

An opposition can claim that it happened.

Each side can accuse the other of propaganda.

The public is left with competing stories.

This is especially dangerous in a region already shaped by suspicion.

Rwanda's history makes this problem even more sensitive.

The country experienced genocide after years of political propaganda, armed mobilisation, and institutional collapse.

Burundi experienced its own cycles of ethnic and political violence.

Neither country can afford a return to the logic that politics must be settled through force.

Yet the fear of such a return can itself drive governments toward stronger security measures.

That is the paradox.

The memory of violence can discourage violence.

But it can also create an intense fear of potential threats.

And intense fear can encourage pre-emptive action.

The question then becomes whether pre-emption prevents violence or merely creates a new form of it.

The crisis between Rwanda and Burundi also exposed the importance of political alliances.

Nkurunziza had relationships with leaders and political actors who were not necessarily aligned with Kagame.

Burundi's political direction therefore had implications beyond Burundi itself.

The Great Lakes region operates through networks.

Political leaders know one another.

Military commanders have shared histories.

Opposition groups cross borders.

Refugee communities maintain relationships with people in neighbouring states.

Business networks move across borders.

Armed movements recruit across borders.

As a result, a political crisis in one country rarely remains entirely domestic.

A Burundian opposition figure may seek support in Rwanda.

A Rwandan dissident may seek refuge in Burundi.

A military officer may maintain relationships with commanders on the other side of the border.

A rebel group may exploit the weaknesses of both states.

Every movement therefore raises suspicion.

And every suspicion encourages greater surveillance.

This is how regional insecurity becomes permanent.

The allegations surrounding Rwanda and Burundi must be understood within that environment.

The author's narrative portrays Kagame as willing to use pressure beyond Rwanda's borders to influence neighbouring governments.

Whether every alleged plan actually existed is a separate question.

But the broader historical record demonstrates that Rwanda and Burundi have repeatedly accused each other of supporting destabilising activities.

That alone tells us something important.

The relationship was not based upon trust.

And without trust, even legitimate security measures can be interpreted as preparations for aggression.

Consider what happens when two governments distrust one another.

Rwanda sees political instability in Burundi.

It worries that armed groups may emerge.

It strengthens its security measures.

Burundi observes the strengthening.

It worries that Rwanda is preparing to intervene.

It strengthens its own security forces.

Rwanda observes Burundi's preparations.

It concludes that its original fears were justified.

Both governments become more suspicious.

Neither side necessarily needs to want war.

Fear can move them toward confrontation.

This is the security dilemma in its purest form.

And it is one of the most dangerous forces in international relations.

The situation becomes even more complicated when outside powers become involved.

Regional organisations attempt mediation.

Foreign governments issue statements.

International organisations call for restraint.

Opposition movements seek diplomatic recognition.

Human rights organisations document abuses.

Each actor introduces another interpretation of the crisis.

Eventually, the original dispute can become almost impossible to isolate.

What began as a disagreement between two neighbouring governments becomes a regional political struggle.

This is why Burundi occupies such an important place in the story of Kagame's regional influence.

The country was not merely another neighbour.

It was a test.

Could Rwanda's government maintain security without dominating its neighbours?

Could Burundi protect its sovereignty without becoming a platform for groups hostile to Rwanda?

Could the two governments develop enough trust to prevent mutual suspicion from becoming a self-fulfilling prophecy?

The history that followed suggests how difficult those questions were.

And then there was an even more serious allegation.

According to the narrative developed in this book, there were suspicions that the Rwandan government sought to eliminate President Nkurunziza himself.

That is a much more serious claim than ordinary diplomatic pressure.

If proven, it would represent an extraordinary escalation.

A neighbouring government would not merely be attempting to influence another state's policies.

It would allegedly be attempting to remove its head of state.

That brings us to the next question.

Was Pierre Nkurunziza himself the target of an alleged assassination attempt?

The answer requires us to examine the evidence, the circumstances surrounding the allegation, and the political environment in which it emerged.

6.5 THE ALLEGED ATTEMPT TO ELIMINATE NKURUNZIZA

Presidents are accustomed to political enemies.

They expect criticism.

They expect demonstrations.

They expect opposition parties.

They expect hostile newspapers.

They may even expect military conspiracies.

But an allegation that a neighbouring government wants to kill a sitting president belongs to another category altogether.

It changes the nature of the relationship between states.

Diplomatic disagreement becomes a security crisis.

Political opposition becomes an alleged international conspiracy.

And suspicion becomes potentially lethal.

The author presents such a claim concerning Pierre Nkurunziza.

But this is precisely the kind of allegation that must be handled with exceptional caution.

A claim that one government attempted to assassinate another country's president cannot responsibly be treated as fact merely because it appears in a political memoir.

It requires corroboration.

It requires documents.

It requires credible witnesses.

It requires examination of the alleged chain of command.

It requires evidence of preparation.

It requires evidence connecting intention to action.

And even then, the evidence must be tested against alternative explanations.

This does not make the allegation unimportant.

Quite the opposite.

The more extraordinary the claim, the more carefully it must be examined.

Because if such an operation occurred, it would reveal something profound about the relationship between Rwanda and Burundi.

And if it did not occur, the existence and circulation of the allegation would still tell us something about the depth of mistrust between the two governments.

Either way, the question deserves examination.

The first thing to understand is the political context.

Nkurunziza was not simply another neighbouring president.

His government had become increasingly controversial both domestically and internationally.

The dispute over his third term triggered widespread protests and a failed coup in 2015.

The crisis transformed Burundi's political landscape.

Opposition figures fled.

Armed groups emerged.

The government became increasingly suspicious of external interference.

Rwanda, meanwhile, faced its own security concerns.

The two governments increasingly viewed one another through the lens of threat.

In such an atmosphere, almost every unexplained event could be interpreted as evidence of a conspiracy.

A suspicious movement at the border could become an alleged invasion plan.

A political meeting could become an alleged opposition network.

An armed group could become evidence of foreign sponsorship.

A military exercise could become preparation for war.

This is the psychological environment in which assassination allegations become possible.

But a responsible historian must distinguish between **political atmosphere** and **proof**.

The atmosphere may explain why people believed the allegation.

It does not prove the allegation itself.

That distinction is especially important in Africa's Great Lakes region, where political propaganda has historically been used by governments and opposition movements alike.

Information can become a battlefield.

Each side seeks to persuade its population that the other side is dangerous.

Each side presents itself as defensive.

Each side portrays the other as aggressive.

And ordinary citizens are forced to decide which story they believe.

This is why independent investigation matters.

Without it, political narratives can become indistinguishable from facts.

The author nevertheless places the alleged plot within a wider pattern.

His argument is that Kagame's government had repeatedly demonstrated a willingness to confront perceived threats before they reached Rwanda itself.

If that interpretation is correct, the alleged targeting of Nkurunziza would represent an extension of a broader strategic doctrine:

neutralise the threat before the threat becomes powerful enough to strike you.

But there is a dangerous flaw in that logic.

The more broadly a government defines a threat, the more people become potential targets.

A militant group may be a threat.

A politician who supports the militant group may be a threat.

A journalist who reports on the group may be accused of helping it.

A refugee associated with the group may become suspicious.

A foreign government that speaks to the group may be viewed as hostile.

Soon, the category of threat becomes so broad that political disagreement and national security become indistinguishable.

That is where authoritarian politics becomes particularly dangerous.

The state begins to treat political competition as an extension of warfare.

And once politics is treated as war, opponents are no longer merely opponents.

They become enemies.

The history of the Great Lakes demonstrates how quickly that mentality can become destructive.

The region has suffered enough from political leaders who believe that eliminating an opponent is easier than negotiating with him.

It has suffered enough from governments that equate survival with absolute control.

And it has suffered enough from ordinary people being forced to choose sides in conflicts created by elites.

The alleged Nkurunziza plot therefore leads to a much larger question:

Can regional security ever be achieved when neighbouring governments view one another as existential threats?

The answer is difficult.

Military strength may deter aggression.

But military strength without trust can also intensify fear.

Diplomacy may reduce tensions.

But diplomacy without security guarantees can leave governments feeling exposed.

International intervention may prevent escalation.

But external pressure can also produce resentment.

There is no perfect solution.

Yet one principle is clear:

The assassination of political opponents cannot become a normal instrument of regional politics.

Once it does, the entire political system becomes unstable.

A president who fears assassination may respond by strengthening his security apparatus.

His neighbour sees the increased security and becomes more suspicious.

The neighbour strengthens its own apparatus.

The first president becomes more suspicious.

And again, the cycle closes.

This is why allegations surrounding Nkurunziza matter even beyond the question of whether the specific claim can be proven.

They reveal the degree to which the relationship between Kigali and Bujumbura had deteriorated.

The two governments no longer trusted one another.

And when trust disappears between neighbouring states, borders become psychological as much as geographical.

Every movement becomes suspicious.

Every political exile becomes significant.

Every armed group becomes a potential proxy.

Every diplomatic meeting becomes a potential conspiracy.

Peace becomes fragile.

The story of Nkurunziza therefore belongs within the broader history of Rwanda's relationship with Burundi.

And that relationship cannot be understood only through what happened inside Burundi.

It must also be examined through the accusations that Rwanda supported forces opposed to Nkurunziza's government.

That is the subject of the next section.

Because once a government is accused of attempting to influence another country's political future, the question inevitably follows:

Was Rwanda merely responding to instability in Burundi—or was it helping to create the instability it claimed to fear?

6.6 SUSPICIONS OF RWANDAN INVOLVEMENT IN BURUNDI'S VIOLENCE

By this point, the relationship between Rwanda and Burundi had moved beyond ordinary diplomatic disagreement.

The accusations had become darker.

It was no longer simply a matter of whether Kigali trusted Bujumbura, or whether President Nkurunziza trusted President Kagame. The allegations presented in the author's account suggested something far more serious: that armed actors connected, directly or indirectly, to Rwanda were operating inside Burundi and that Rwanda was attempting to influence the country's internal political crisis.

These claims require careful handling.

A political memoir records what its author believed, what he was told, and what he understood from the information available to him. It does not automatically establish the truth of every allegation it contains.

That distinction is particularly important here.

The author states that, while writing his account, he received information from Kigali alleging that Kagame had already sent a battalion into Burundi, with the soldiers operating covertly under the cover of various occupations. He connects this allegation to what he describes as Kagame's willingness to threaten people who disagreed with him, recalling earlier tensions with Tanzanian President Jakaya Kikwete.

The claim becomes even more serious when the author describes what he says was the intended purpose of this presence.

According to the information he says he received, Burundi was allegedly being considered as a strategic platform in the event that Kagame sought to confront Tanzania, while Nkurunziza was allegedly expected to be removed first. The author's explanation for Nkurunziza's supposed vulnerability was political: he had refused to follow Kagame's position and maintained a relationship with Kikwete.

If such a strategy had existed, it would have represented an extraordinary escalation.

But that is precisely why the claim must be separated from the evidence.

There is a difference between saying:

"The author alleges that this was the plan."

and saying:

"This was the plan."

The first describes the historical source.

The second asserts a fact.

A responsible reader must know the difference.

Yet the allegation itself is revealing.

It shows how deeply the author believed Rwanda's leadership had become involved in the affairs of its neighbours. It also reveals the extent to which the political crisis in Burundi was being interpreted through the wider strategic rivalry of the Great Lakes.

Burundi was no longer being viewed only as Burundi.

It was being viewed in relation to Tanzania.

It was being viewed in relation to Rwanda.

It was being viewed in relation to the FDLR.

It was being viewed in relation to former M23 fighters.

And it was being viewed through the broader question of who would control the political direction of the region.

This is how a domestic crisis becomes regional.

One government sees an opposition movement.

Another sees a potential proxy.

A third sees a security threat.

A fourth sees an opportunity.

Before long, the original political dispute has acquired an international dimension.

The author further claims that Burundi had arrested a group of soldiers and that one of those arrested was Rwandan. He presents this, together with reports attributed to Voice of America and Burundian officials, as evidence supporting his suspicion that Rwanda was operating covertly inside Burundi.

Again, the distinction between allegation and verification matters.

The existence of a Rwandan national among a group of arrested soldiers would not, by itself, prove that the Rwandan government had ordered a military operation.

Individuals can cross borders for many reasons.

Soldiers can defect.

Armed groups can recruit foreigners.

Governments can deny responsibility for actions carried out by individuals acting independently.

Evidence of individual involvement is therefore not automatically evidence of state involvement.

To establish state responsibility, one would need a much stronger chain of evidence.

Who recruited them?

Who trained them?

Who financed them?

Who commanded them?

Who communicated with them?

Who gave them instructions?

Who protected them?

And ultimately:

Who authorised the operation?

Those questions are far more important than nationality alone.

The author nevertheless goes further.

He alleges that Rwanda was infiltrating Burundi through special military units with the objective of creating insecurity inside the country. More disturbing still, he claims that intelligence indicated an alleged plan to provoke killings of both Tutsi Burundians and Hutu opponents of Nkurunziza so that the violence could be attributed to the Burundian government.

This is an extraordinary allegation.

If true, it would describe not merely political interference but an attempt to manufacture violence for political purposes.

Such a strategy would exploit one of the most dangerous forces in the Great Lakes:

fear between communities.

The logic would be devastating.

Create violence.

Make the violence appear to come from the government.

Allow anger to spread.

Encourage communities to turn against one another.

Then use the resulting instability to justify political intervention.

Whether such a plan existed is a question for evidence.

But the reason such an allegation is so powerful is that the region's history makes the scenario imaginable.

The Great Lakes has experienced periods in which violence was deliberately organised, manipulated, or presented through competing narratives.

Communities have been told that the people living beside them are enemies.

Citizens have been persuaded that their survival depends upon defeating another group.

Political leaders have exploited fear.

Armed organisations have used ethnic identity to mobilise support.

And once violence begins, distinguishing who started it can become almost impossible.

That is why the allegation presented by the author is so serious.

It is not simply about military strategy.

It is about the manipulation of identity.

The author connects the alleged strategy to events surrounding the Arusha peace process in Rwanda in the early 1990s. He argues that the RPF secretly exceeded agreed military limits and that the United Nations failed to prevent the alleged movement of additional soldiers and weapons.

Whether every historical detail in that comparison is accurate requires separate examination.

But the author's purpose is clear.

He wants the reader to see a pattern.

His argument is that covert military preparation, political destabilisation, and manipulation of public perception were not new phenomena but part of a longer history.

This is an important point to understand about the structure of the book.

The author is not simply presenting isolated accusations.

He is constructing a theory of political behaviour.

He looks backward at earlier events and then interprets later events through them.

In other words, he is asking the reader to recognise repetition.

But there is a danger in this method.

Once we believe that a political actor has behaved in a certain way before, we can become inclined to interpret every later event as confirmation.

That is known as confirmation bias.

A suspicious event occurs.

We remember an earlier event that resembles it.

The similarity reinforces our suspicion.

Another event occurs.

It appears to confirm the pattern.

Eventually, the pattern becomes so convincing that we stop asking whether alternative explanations exist.

A serious political analysis must resist that temptation.

History requires patterns.

But it also requires evidence.

The question should therefore always be:

What is known?

Then:

What is alleged?

Then:

What is inferred?

And finally:

What remains unknown?

That four-part distinction protects the reader from both propaganda and cynicism.

It allows us to take allegations seriously without automatically accepting them.

And it allows us to acknowledge uncertainty without pretending that nothing happened.

The Burundi crisis demonstrates why this distinction matters.

There were genuine political tensions.

There were genuine armed groups.

There were genuine refugees.

There were genuine accusations of foreign involvement.

There were genuine fears of renewed violence.

The uncertainty lies in precisely how these forces interacted.

Who supported whom?

Who acted independently?

Who was acting on behalf of a government?

Who merely claimed to be acting on behalf of a government?

And who benefited from the resulting instability?

Those questions remain central to understanding the region.

There is another reason the Burundi story deserves attention.

The countries of the Great Lakes are extraordinarily interconnected.

A conflict in Burundi can affect Rwanda.

A conflict in Rwanda can affect Congo.

A conflict in Congo can affect Uganda.

A dispute between Rwanda and Tanzania can affect trade and regional diplomacy.

The movement of refugees can change political calculations.

The movement of armed groups can change security calculations.

And once several countries begin preparing for the possibility of conflict, even a relatively small incident can trigger a much larger crisis.

That is why the idea of Burundi being used as a strategic corridor or staging ground was so alarming within the author's narrative.

It suggested that the country's internal instability might become part of a much larger regional confrontation.

But there was another dimension.

The author believed that Kagame's disagreements with Kikwete were particularly important.

Kikwete had reportedly encouraged dialogue between Rwanda and the FDLR.

From Kigali's perspective, engagement with the FDLR was highly sensitive because the organisation included individuals associated with the forces responsible for the 1994 genocide and subsequent armed movements.

The possibility of negotiating with such a group could therefore be interpreted in radically different ways.

One government could see dialogue as necessary for resolving a long-running security problem.

Another could see dialogue as legitimising an enemy.

The disagreement was therefore not merely diplomatic.

It reflected two fundamentally different theories of how security should be achieved.

Should an armed opponent be destroyed?

Or can an armed opponent sometimes be negotiated with?

The answer is rarely simple.

Peace agreements require talking to people one does not trust.

Yet governments also fear that negotiations may allow dangerous organisations to regroup.

This dilemma has appeared repeatedly throughout modern history.

The Great Lakes is no exception.

Kikwete's position therefore placed him in a difficult relationship with Kagame.

The author interprets the tension personally and politically, portraying Kagame as deeply hostile to the Tanzanian president.

But again, interpretation must be separated from proof.

Political leaders can make harsh statements without necessarily acting upon them.

Threats can be rhetorical.

Warnings can be strategic.

And intelligence reports can be wrong.

That is why the alleged Burundian operation cannot be understood merely by collecting accusations.

It requires corroboration.

It requires chronology.

It requires independent sources.

It requires military evidence.

And it requires an examination of what actually happened on the ground.

Still, the author's narrative presents a troubling picture.

He describes a region in which armies, rebels, refugees, intelligence services, and political leaders were increasingly entangled.

M23 had recently been defeated.

But its fighters had not simply disappeared.

Burundian political instability was growing.

Rwanda and Burundi were accusing each other.

Tanzania was increasingly important to the regional equation.

The FDLR remained a concern for Kigali.

MONUSCO remained deployed in Congo.

SADC was becoming increasingly involved in regional security.

The possibility of another major conflict therefore remained.

The defeat of one armed movement did not remove the conditions that had produced the movement.

And this is perhaps the most important lesson.

You can defeat an army without defeating the causes of war.

A rebel group can surrender.

But grievances remain.

A commander can flee.

But his followers remain.

A peace agreement can be signed.

But mistrust survives.

A government can declare victory.

But the political problem can remain unresolved.

This is why the Great Lakes has experienced repeated cycles of conflict.

Each war leaves behind people who know how to fight.

Each peace leaves behind people who believe they have lost.

Each political settlement creates new winners and losers.

And each generation inherits memories of the previous conflict.

The danger is that history becomes a reservoir of unfinished grievances.

One generation remembers what another generation did.

Another generation remembers what was done to its parents.

Soon, the original event becomes less important than the memory of the event.

And political leaders can use those memories to mobilise fear.

That is why the alleged strategy described by the author—if it were ever substantiated—would be particularly disturbing.

It would amount to using the wounds of history as instruments of political manipulation.

The Great Lakes has already suffered enough from that logic.

The region does not need more leaders teaching their populations whom to fear.

It needs leaders capable of convincing citizens that security does not require permanent war.

That does not mean ignoring armed threats.

It means confronting them without turning entire populations into enemies.

It means distinguishing combatants from civilians.

It means distinguishing political opposition from terrorism.

It means distinguishing refugees from insurgents.

It means distinguishing criticism from treason.

And above all, it means understanding that national security cannot be built permanently upon fear.

The author's allegations concerning Burundi therefore lead us toward a larger question.

If Rwanda's government believed that developments in Burundi posed a threat to Rwanda, what strategy should it have pursued?

Diplomacy?

Border security?

Regional mediation?

Intelligence cooperation?

Support for particular political actors?

Or direct intervention?

Every choice carries consequences.

Diplomacy can fail.

Border security can be insufficient.

Regional mediation can be slow.

Intelligence cooperation can become secretive.

Political support can be interpreted as interference.

Military intervention can create a much larger war.

There is no risk-free option.

But there is one principle that should remain constant:

The security of one nation cannot permanently depend upon the political subordination of its neighbours.

If Rwanda can only feel safe when Burundi has a friendly government, when Congo has a friendly government, when Uganda has a friendly government, and when Tanzania follows Kigali's preferred regional policy, then Rwanda's security becomes dependent upon controlling the political choices of other states.

That is not sustainable.

Nor is it likely to produce lasting peace.

True regional security requires something harder.

It requires neighbours capable of disagreeing without becoming enemies.

It requires governments capable of tolerating political differences.

It requires borders that are secure without becoming militarised zones of permanent suspicion.

And it requires leaders who understand that today's opponent may become tomorrow's negotiating partner.

The alternative is perpetual instability.

One government supports an armed group.

Another government responds.

The first government sees the response as aggression.

It strengthens its own forces.

The second government becomes more afraid.

Another armed group appears.

Another border closes.

Another refugee population grows.

And once again, the region prepares for war.

This is the cycle the Great Lakes must escape.

The author's account presents Rwanda as one of the central actors in that cycle.

Whether every allegation in his narrative withstands historical scrutiny is a separate question.

But his underlying concern is unmistakable:

What happens when a state becomes so preoccupied with threats outside its borders that it begins to shape the politics of the countries around it?

That question leads naturally to the next section.

Because Burundi's crisis cannot be understood merely through allegations of covert operations.

We must also examine the political relationship between Kigali and Bujumbura—and the accusation that Rwanda's actions contributed to the violence that eventually consumed Burundi.

The question is no longer simply whether Rwanda was afraid of Burundi.

It is whether Rwanda's response to that fear helped make the region less secure.

6.7 KAGAME'S CHANGING POSITION

Political leaders rarely remain fixed in one position.

Circumstances change.

Allies change.

Enemies change.

International pressure changes.

And sometimes, after years of insisting upon one policy, a government quietly begins to adopt another.

Kagame's public position on regional security provides an important example of this tension.

A leader who speaks forcefully about security may eventually discover that military power has limits.

An army can defeat a rebel group.

It cannot necessarily create political legitimacy.

It can cross a border.

It cannot easily create trust.

It can remove a government.

It cannot guarantee that the replacement will be stable.

And it can win a battle while losing the diplomatic argument.

This is particularly true when the international community begins to watch closely.

The defeat of M23 changed the regional environment.

The movement's military collapse demonstrated that armed rebellion was not invincible.

But it also increased scrutiny of the actors believed to have supported it.

For Rwanda, this was a crucial moment.

The country had built much of its regional security strategy around the argument that threats emerging in neighbouring states could not simply be ignored.

Yet the international community increasingly demanded that Rwanda respect the sovereignty of its neighbours and refrain from supporting armed groups.

This created a dilemma.

If Rwanda reduced its regional involvement, would it become more vulnerable?

If it continued, would it face greater international isolation?

The answer could not be found on the battlefield alone.

It required diplomacy.

It required credibility.

And it required answering an uncomfortable question:

Can Rwanda remain secure without remaining militarily involved in the conflicts of its neighbours?

That question would become increasingly important as the Great Lakes entered another period of uncertainty.

6.7 KAGAME'S CHANGING POSITION

Power is often described as the ability to make others do what they would not otherwise do.

But there is another, less obvious dimension of power: the ability to change one's position without appearing to surrender.

Political leaders understand this well.

A government may publicly defend one principle while quietly adapting its strategy.

A president may condemn negotiations with an opponent and later negotiate with that same opponent.

A government may describe an armed group as an existential threat and later tolerate a political arrangement involving some of its former members.

A leader may insist that military intervention is necessary until the political cost of intervention becomes greater than its perceived benefit.

This is not necessarily hypocrisy.

Sometimes it is simply politics.

Circumstances change.

And leaders who refuse to change with them can eventually become prisoners of their own earlier decisions.

The evolution of Kagame's regional policy must therefore be understood within this tension between principle and necessity.

For years, Rwanda's security concerns had been framed around armed groups operating in neighbouring countries, particularly those believed to threaten Rwanda.

The logic was straightforward:

If the threat exists outside Rwanda but can cross the border, then Rwanda cannot simply wait for it to arrive.

This reasoning helped justify a proactive security doctrine.

But proactive security carries a danger.

Once a government becomes accustomed to acting before a threat reaches its territory, it must continually decide which developments constitute genuine threats.

And that judgment is political.

A rebel movement may genuinely threaten national security.

But a political movement may not.

A hostile speech may be offensive.

But it is not necessarily an armed attack.

A neighbouring government's disagreement may be frustrating.

But disagreement is not automatically aggression.

The ability to distinguish between these categories is one of the greatest tests of statecraft.

As Rwanda's international role expanded, the cost of miscalculation also increased.

The government could no longer act as though every regional problem were simply a bilateral security matter.

Rwanda had become too visible.

Its military capabilities were being watched.

Its relations with armed groups were being scrutinised.

Its activities in Congo were being debated internationally.

Its relationship with Burundi had become increasingly controversial.

And its disagreements with Uganda and Tanzania had added another layer of regional complexity.

The strategic environment was changing.

The question was whether Kigali would change with it.

One important development was the growing role of diplomacy.

Rwanda increasingly had to operate not only through military relationships but also through regional organisations and international institutions.

The African Union mattered.

The United Nations mattered.

The East African Community mattered.

Neighbouring governments mattered.

Major Western governments mattered.

Economic relationships mattered.

International reputation mattered.

Military strength could create leverage.

But diplomatic credibility determined how that leverage could be used.

This distinction is important.

A country may possess a powerful army and still find itself diplomatically isolated.

It may win battles and lose allies.

It may defeat a rebel movement but face international pressure afterward.

It may achieve immediate security objectives while creating long-term resentment.

Strategic success therefore cannot be measured only by military victories.

The more difficult measure is sustainability.

Can the strategy continue for ten years?

Twenty years?

A generation?

Can it survive changes in leadership?

Can it survive changes in neighbouring governments?

Can it survive international pressure?

Can it produce peace rather than merely pauses between wars?

Those questions are particularly relevant to Rwanda.

The country cannot permanently maintain a war footing.

Its people need economic development.

Its neighbours need stability.

Its young generation needs opportunities.

And the region needs trade rather than perpetual military mobilisation.

Eventually, security must become something more than the absence of armed attacks.

It must become a political condition in which countries trust that disputes can be resolved without violence.

This is where Kagame's changing position becomes important.

A leader who built his reputation partly upon military effectiveness must eventually demonstrate that he can achieve through diplomacy what military power cannot.

The greatest strategic victory may be the moment when soldiers no longer need to cross the border.

But reaching that point requires confidence.

A government must believe that its neighbours will not exploit restraint.

A neighbour must believe that Rwanda will not exploit weakness.

Opposition groups must believe that they can participate politically without being eliminated.

And citizens must believe that their future does not depend upon which armed group happens to control their territory.

That kind of confidence is much harder to build than an army.

It takes years.

Sometimes generations.

And it can be destroyed by one political crisis.

This is why the Great Lakes remains so fragile.

Too many governments remember what happened the last time they trusted their neighbours.

Too many commanders remember abandoned agreements.

Too many communities remember displacement.

Too many politicians remember assassinations.

Too many refugees remember being told that they had nowhere to return.

History therefore sits between every diplomatic handshake.

The question is whether leaders can eventually become strong enough to stop allowing history to dictate every future decision.

Kagame's regional policy has repeatedly been shaped by his understanding of history.

His supporters see this as realism.

His critics see it as an inability to escape the logic of conflict.

Both interpretations deserve examination.

Because there is wisdom in remembering history.

But there is also danger in allowing history to become an excuse for permanent suspicion.

A nation cannot remain permanently at war with yesterday's enemies.

At some point, yesterday must become history.

The challenge is knowing when.

And perhaps that is the question facing Kagame more than any other:

When does vigilance stop protecting a country and begin preventing it from trusting anyone?

That question leads directly to another relationship that became increasingly important to Rwanda's regional politics.

The relationship with Yoweri Museveni.

6.8 KAGAME AND MUSEVENI: A FRIENDSHIP UNDER STRAIN

Few political relationships in the Great Lakes region are as important—or as complicated—as the relationship between Paul Kagame and Yoweri Museveni.

Their history did not begin in presidential offices.

It began in war.

Before Kigali.

Before Kampala's regional rivalries.

Before accusations and diplomatic disputes.

There was a shared struggle.

Kagame and other Rwandan exiles became involved in the Ugandan political and military environment that eventually brought Museveni's National Resistance Army to power.

For Rwanda's future leadership, Uganda was not simply a neighbouring country.

It was part of the environment in which the Rwandan Patriotic Front and its commanders developed their military experience.

That history created a bond.

Shared struggle can produce a form of trust that ordinary diplomacy cannot easily reproduce.

Two people who have survived war together may develop a loyalty that lasts for decades.

But shared history can also create expectations.

Friends expect loyalty.

They expect consultation.

They expect reciprocity.

And when one friend believes the other has violated those expectations, the disagreement can become more bitter than an ordinary diplomatic dispute.

This appears to be what happened between Kagame and Museveni.

The relationship gradually deteriorated.

The causes were numerous and complex.

Economic competition mattered.

Regional influence mattered.

Security concerns mattered.

Personal disagreements mattered.

And the conflict in Congo brought many of these issues together.

Rwanda and Uganda had once cooperated militarily.

They later found themselves supporting different interests.

The relationship that had once been defined by shared struggle increasingly became defined by suspicion.

This is one of the great ironies of revolutionary politics.

People who fight together can later become enemies precisely because they know one another so well.

They know each other's methods.

They know each other's networks.

They know each other's weaknesses.

And they remember the promises made during the years when survival depended upon mutual trust.

When that trust disappears, the past becomes evidence against the former friend.

The relationship between Kagame and Museveni therefore cannot be understood simply as a disagreement between two presidents.

It was a breakdown of a relationship rooted in the history of a generation.

That made it especially significant.

Uganda and Rwanda share a border.

Their economies are interconnected.

Their populations have extensive social and family ties.

Their security concerns overlap.

Trade moves between them.

People move between them.

And political developments in one country can quickly affect the other.

A confrontation between Kigali and Kampala therefore has consequences far beyond the two presidential palaces.

It affects traders.

Transporters.

Students.

Families.

Businesses.

Workers.

And border communities.

This is why political rivalry between neighbouring governments can be so costly.

A president may regard the dispute as strategic.

An ordinary citizen may experience it as a closed border.

The author presents the deterioration between Kagame and Museveni as part of a broader struggle for regional influence.

This interpretation is understandable.

Both governments have sought security and political influence in the Great Lakes.

Both have significant military capabilities.

Both have historically been involved in Congolese affairs.

Both have relationships with political and military actors beyond their borders.

And both understand that regional influence can affect national security.

But there is another way to look at the rivalry.

Perhaps the deeper problem is that the Great Lakes lacks a stable regional security framework strong enough to reassure all its governments.

When institutions are weak, states rely on bilateral relationships.

When bilateral relationships fail, they rely on military strength.

When military strength increases, neighbours become suspicious.

The result is an arms race of confidence and fear.

Every country wants enough strength to protect itself.

No country wants its neighbour to possess overwhelming strength.

And yet every country interprets the neighbour's military preparations as a reason to strengthen itself further.

This is the security dilemma again.

Only this time it is operating between former allies.

The consequences became particularly visible when Rwanda and Uganda accused one another of interference.

Each side claimed that the other was supporting hostile political or security actors.

Each side denied the allegations.

Each side strengthened its position.

Eventually, diplomatic relations became increasingly strained.

And once again, the people living along the border paid the price.

The lesson is difficult but important:

Former friendship does not guarantee permanent peace.

Political relationships are not marriages.

They are built upon interests as well as trust.

Interests change.

Leaders change.

Threat perceptions change.

And when they do, yesterday's ally can become tomorrow's rival.

The Kagame-Museveni relationship demonstrates this perfectly.

But it also raises a more uncomfortable question.

If Rwanda could fall into serious tension with Uganda—a country so deeply connected to the history of its leadership—what would happen when Kigali's interests collided with those of other regional powers?

What would happen with Tanzania?

What would happen with Burundi?

What would happen with Congo?

And what would happen if several of these relationships deteriorated simultaneously?

The possibility of a wider regional confrontation could not be ignored.

That is where the story moves next.

6.9 PREPARING FOR WAR IN THE REGION

A region does not need to be at war for people to prepare for war.

This distinction matters.

Armies train during peacetime.

Governments strengthen borders before conflict begins.

Weapons are purchased before they are needed.

Military commanders study possible battlefields.

Intelligence agencies monitor neighbouring states.

Political leaders make contingency plans.

And citizens may notice none of it until the day the situation changes.

By the middle of the period described in this book, the Great Lakes had accumulated many of the ingredients necessary for another regional crisis.

Congo remained unstable.

Burundi was experiencing severe political tensions.

Rwanda and Uganda were increasingly suspicious of one another.

Tanzania had its own regional interests.

M23 had demonstrated that armed rebellion in eastern Congo could rapidly become an international issue.

The FDLR remained a security concern for Kigali.

MONUSCO continued to operate in Congo.

And governments throughout the region were watching one another.

The question was no longer simply whether another conflict could occur.

It was:

How much preparation would be necessary before a crisis became a war?

Military preparation is not proof of an intention to attack.

This is another distinction that political analysis must preserve.

A country may strengthen its army because it fears invasion.

It may mobilise because it wants to deter an enemy.

It may conduct exercises because it wants to demonstrate readiness.

Or it may genuinely be preparing for offensive action.

From the outside, these activities can look remarkably similar.

That is why military transparency matters.

When governments refuse to explain their intentions, suspicion grows.

When suspicion grows, neighbouring governments prepare.

When neighbouring governments prepare, the original government becomes more suspicious.

Again, the cycle feeds itself.

This was the strategic environment surrounding Rwanda.

Kagame had built a country that took security extremely seriously.

His government had every reason to do so.

But a state that is constantly alert can also become a state that constantly sees danger.

The challenge is knowing where vigilance ends and paranoia begins.

That distinction cannot be made by slogans.

It must be made through institutions, intelligence discipline, diplomacy, and evidence.

And it requires leaders who are willing to hear information that contradicts their assumptions.

This is perhaps one of the greatest weaknesses of highly centralised political systems.

When too much power is concentrated at the top, officials may become reluctant to deliver bad news.

They may tell the leader what they believe he wants to hear.

They may exaggerate threats because demonstrating vigilance is politically safer than admitting uncertainty.

And once the leader accepts the threat narrative, the entire system can begin acting upon it.

The result can be a self-fulfilling prophecy.

The government prepares because it expects conflict.

The neighbour interprets the preparation as aggression.

The neighbour prepares.

The first government interprets that preparation as confirmation.

And eventually both sides have prepared so extensively that backing down becomes politically difficult.

No one wants to appear weak.

No one wants to be the first to demobilise.

No one wants to trust the other.

The region becomes trapped.

That is the danger of preparing for war indefinitely.

Preparation is supposed to prevent war.

But preparation without diplomacy can make war more likely.

The Great Lakes therefore faced a fundamental choice.

Would its leaders continue responding to insecurity through competing military preparations?

Or would they attempt to construct a political system in which countries could feel secure without dominating one another?

The answer would determine whether the region entered another cycle of conflict or began moving toward a more stable order.

And that brings us to the international actors who were already present on the ground.

The United Nations had deployed MONUSCO in Congo.

Regional organisations were becoming increasingly involved.

Southern African countries were paying greater attention to the conflict.

The African Union was concerned.

And the question of who should ultimately guarantee peace in the Great Lakes was becoming unavoidable.

For years, Rwanda had argued that international actors often failed to understand the security realities facing the region.

But international organisations increasingly argued that regional governments themselves had to respect sovereignty and stop supporting armed groups.

These positions were difficult to reconcile.

The next confrontation would therefore not be fought only between armies.

It would also be fought diplomatically.

And at the centre of that debate stood MONUSCO and the growing role of SADC.

That is where the next section begins.

6.10 MONUSCO, SADC AND THE FUTURE OF RWANDA'S REGIONAL POSITION

By the time the Great Lakes reached another period of crisis, one fact had become impossible to ignore:

The region could no longer solve its conflicts through military calculations alone.

For years, governments had relied upon armies.

Rebel movements had relied upon armed struggle.

Neighbouring states had relied upon alliances.

And international organisations had repeatedly arrived after violence had already begun.

But Congo presented a problem of a different scale.

The Democratic Republic of Congo was too large, too politically fragmented, and too deeply entangled in regional rivalries for any single country to impose a lasting solution.

That was why the United Nations became such an important actor.

The United Nations Organisation Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo—MONUSCO—was tasked with helping protect civilians and support peace and stability in a country that had experienced years of devastating conflict.

Yet even the presence of an international force raised difficult questions.

What can a peacekeeping force actually accomplish when the political causes of a war remain unresolved?

An army can separate combatants.

It can patrol roads.

It can protect civilians.

It can establish temporary security.

But it cannot, by itself, create political trust.

It cannot force communities to forgive one another.

It cannot manufacture legitimate government.

And it cannot permanently resolve disputes over land, citizenship, identity, resources, or political representation.

Those are political problems.

They require political solutions.

MONUSCO therefore operated within an environment in which military peacekeeping could only address part of the problem.

The limitations became particularly visible whenever armed groups continued operating despite international deployments.

For civilians, this produced an understandable frustration.

If an international force is present, why does violence continue?

If peacekeepers cannot prevent attacks, what exactly does peacekeeping mean?

And if the United Nations cannot guarantee security, who can?

These questions are not easy to answer.

Peacekeeping is not the same as war-fighting.

A peacekeeping mission operates under rules, political constraints, and legal mandates.

It cannot simply destroy every armed group it encounters.

Yet civilians experiencing violence do not always see those distinctions.

They want protection.

They want to return home.

They want their children to attend school.

They want to farm their land without fearing armed men.

They want to sleep without hearing gunfire.

For them, the technical distinction between peacekeeping and military intervention can seem irrelevant.

Their question is simpler:

Are we safe?

The inability to provide a satisfactory answer became one of the great challenges facing the international community in Congo.

And then regional forces began to assume a more prominent role.

The Southern African Development Community, or SADC, had long been involved in regional security questions.

Its member states possessed their own military capabilities and their own political interests.

As instability in eastern Congo continued, the argument grew stronger that African regional organisations should take greater responsibility for resolving African conflicts.

This idea had considerable appeal.

Why should a distant international institution be expected to solve every conflict on the continent?

Should African states not have the capacity to defend their own security?

Should regional governments not take responsibility for the consequences of instability in their own neighbourhood?

These are legitimate questions.

But regional intervention carries its own risks.

SADC states do not necessarily share the same interests.

One government may view Rwanda as a security threat.

Another may see Rwanda as an important economic partner.

One may support a stronger military response.

Another may favour negotiations.

One may prioritise Congolese sovereignty.

Another may prioritise the security of border communities.

Regional organisations therefore face the same problem as the United Nations:

How do you create a common policy when member states do not share a common perception of the threat?

This was particularly important because Rwanda's regional position had become increasingly complicated.

For years, Kigali had cultivated a reputation as a highly capable military actor.

Its army was considered disciplined.

Its leadership was considered strategically sophisticated.

Its government had developed close relationships with several African and Western governments.

Rwanda was therefore not simply another small state.

It had become an important regional actor.

But influence comes with a price.

The more influential a country becomes, the more closely its behaviour is examined.

A small country with limited military capacity can sometimes make a mistake without attracting much international attention.

A country with a powerful army and significant regional influence cannot.

Every intervention is scrutinised.

Every relationship with a rebel movement is questioned.

Every military deployment attracts attention.

Every diplomatic confrontation can affect the wider region.

Rwanda therefore faced a strategic dilemma.

Its military power was part of the reason other governments took it seriously.

But that same military power also made neighbouring countries nervous.

The stronger Rwanda appeared, the more others wondered what it might do with that strength.

This is another version of the security dilemma.

Rwanda says:

We are strong because our history taught us that weakness is dangerous.

Its neighbours may respond:

Your strength is precisely what makes us nervous.

Rwanda then sees their concern as evidence that it must remain strong.

The cycle continues.

Breaking that cycle requires more than reducing military capabilities.

It requires trust.

And trust cannot be demanded.

It has to be earned.

For Rwanda, that meant demonstrating that military capability would be used primarily for national defence rather than regional domination.

For Congo, it meant demonstrating that its territory would not become a permanent sanctuary for armed organisations threatening Rwanda.

For Burundi, it meant building political institutions capable of managing internal disputes without creating cross-border security crises.

For Uganda and Tanzania, it meant developing relationships with Rwanda that could survive political disagreements.

And for the international community, it meant treating African governments not merely as objects of intervention but as partners in designing a sustainable security architecture.

None of this would be easy.

The history was too complicated.

The mistrust was too deep.

And too many actors had benefited from instability.

But there was another reality that could not be ignored:

War was becoming too expensive.

Not only financially.

Humanly.

Politically.

Diplomatically.

Economically.

Every conflict destroyed infrastructure.

Every wave of displacement created another humanitarian crisis.

Every refugee movement created pressure on neighbouring countries.

Every military confrontation damaged trust.

Every new armed group created another generation familiar with violence.

Eventually, the region reaches a point where continuing the old strategy costs more than changing it.

Perhaps that was the moment the Great Lakes was approaching.

The question was whether its leaders recognised it.

For Rwanda, the future therefore depended upon more than military strength.

It depended upon how Kigali managed its relationships with Congo, Uganda, Burundi, Tanzania, and the wider African community.

Could Rwanda maintain its security while reducing suspicion?

Could Kagame preserve his country's influence without making neighbouring governments feel permanently threatened?

Could Rwanda participate in regional peace initiatives without being accused of manipulating them?

Could it convince the international community that its security concerns were genuine while also accepting that its neighbours possessed legitimate security concerns of their own?

These questions were becoming unavoidable.

There was also a deeper question concerning Rwanda's identity.

What kind of regional power did Rwanda want to become?

A defensive state?

A regional military power?

A diplomatic power?

An economic hub?

A mediator?

Or some combination of all of these?

The answer would shape Rwanda's future.

Military power alone could not provide it.

Economic development could create influence without bullets.

Diplomacy could create relationships that military pressure could never sustain.

Regional trade could make conflict more expensive for everyone.

And political openness could reduce the number of people who believed that violence was their only remaining avenue.

The future therefore required a different conception of power.

Not power as the ability to frighten.

Not power as the ability to defeat.

But power as the ability to create conditions in which conflict becomes unnecessary.

That would be a much more difficult achievement.

But it would also be a more lasting one.

MONUSCO and SADC represented two different versions of the international response.

One was global.

The other was regional.

Neither could succeed without the political cooperation of the governments involved.

And neither could permanently resolve a conflict whose deepest causes remained political.

This brings us back to Rwanda.

For years, Kagame had been able to present himself as a leader who understood security because he had personally experienced war.

That experience gave him credibility.

But it also created a responsibility.

The leader who understands war better than most should also understand the price of war better than most.

He knows what it means to lose comrades.

He knows what it means to live with uncertainty.

He knows what military mobilisation demands.

He knows what happens when political disputes become armed conflicts.

The ultimate test of such knowledge is therefore not whether a leader can win a war.

It is whether he can prevent the next one.

That is the standard by which Kagame's regional legacy will eventually have to be judged.

Not simply by how many battles Rwanda won.

Not simply by how many enemies were defeated.

Not simply by how effectively Rwanda projected power.

But by whether the region became safer.

That distinction is crucial.

A military victory can be immediate.

Peace is measured over generations.

A commander can win territory in months.

A statesman may spend decades building trust.

The first is visible.

The second is often invisible.

Yet the second may matter more.

The Great Lakes does not need another generation of leaders who become celebrated because they know how to fight.

It needs leaders who can make fighting unnecessary.

That is the unfinished challenge.

And it is precisely why the story cannot end with M23, MONUSCO, SADC, or any particular military operation.

Because even if one rebel group disappears, another can emerge.

Even if one peace agreement is signed, another crisis can follow.

Even if one government changes, another can inherit the same fears.

The underlying question remains:

Can the countries of the Great Lakes build a regional order in which no government feels that it must control its neighbours in order to feel secure?

If the answer is yes, Rwanda's future influence could become a force for stability.

If the answer is no, Rwanda's military strength may continue to be both its shield and the source of suspicion surrounding it.

That is the paradox Kagame leaves before the region.

And it leads us to the final section of this chapter.

6.11 THE GREAT LAKES REGION ONCE AGAIN IN UNCERTAINTY

There are moments in history when people believe a war has finally ended.

The guns become quieter.

A rebel movement announces that it is surrendering.

A peace agreement is signed.

Refugees begin to return.

Governments issue statements of optimism.

The international community declares progress.

And for a moment, everyone wants to believe that the nightmare is over.

But peace is not the same thing as silence.

A battlefield can become quiet while the causes of conflict remain alive.

This was the danger facing the Great Lakes.

M23 could be defeated.

Yet other armed groups remained.

Political disagreements remained.

Regional mistrust remained.

The question of refugees remained.

The question of armed groups operating across borders remained.

The question of foreign intervention remained.

And the unresolved relationship between Rwanda, Congo, Burundi, Uganda, and Tanzania remained.

The author describes a region once again approaching uncertainty.

In Congo, armed groups continued to exist even after M23's military defeat.

In Burundi, political tensions remained intense.

Reports and accusations concerning military training and cross-border activity continued to circulate.

The Rwandan government and the Burundian government continued to accuse one another.

The possibility of renewed instability therefore remained.

This is the tragedy of the Great Lakes:

Defeating one armed movement does not necessarily end the conflict.

There are always other actors.

Another commander.

Another grievance.

Another political crisis.

Another generation with another reason to take up arms.

That is why the region requires more than military victories.

It requires political settlements capable of addressing the grievances that armed groups exploit.

It requires governments capable of protecting minorities without creating new forms of exclusion.

It requires borders that prevent armed infiltration without preventing ordinary people from maintaining legitimate social and economic relationships.

It requires regional institutions strong enough to mediate disputes before they become wars.

And it requires political leaders willing to accept that compromise is not weakness.

Perhaps this is the hardest lesson for leaders shaped by war.

During war, compromise can look like surrender.

In politics, compromise is often the only alternative to destruction.

A commander asks:

How do we defeat them?

A statesman asks:

How do we make it possible for us to live together after the fighting ends?

Those are very different questions.

The Great Lakes has produced many commanders.

It now needs more statesmen.

The region also needs a different understanding of security.

Security should not mean that one government is powerful enough to intimidate everyone else.

It should mean that no government feels compelled to attack because it fears being attacked first.

That requires mutual confidence.

It requires agreements that are respected.

It requires accountability when agreements are violated.

It requires international institutions that are neither powerless nor politically selective.

And it requires citizens to have enough confidence in their governments that they do not see armed groups as their only protection.

The uncertainty surrounding the region therefore presents both danger and opportunity.

Danger, because the ingredients for renewed conflict remain.

Opportunity, because history has made the cost of another major war painfully clear.

The people of the Great Lakes have already paid too much.

Congo has suffered enormous human loss.

Rwanda carries the memory of genocide.

Burundi carries the memory of repeated political violence.

Uganda carries the legacy of its own decades of conflict.

Millions of people have been displaced across borders.

Too many families have learned to recognise the sound of approaching soldiers.

Too many children have grown up knowing the difference between an ordinary night and a night when gunfire can be heard in the distance.

The region deserves something different.

It deserves a future in which children know their neighbours as neighbours rather than potential enemies.

It deserves borders that connect economies instead of dividing communities.

It deserves political systems in which disagreement does not automatically become betrayal.

It deserves leaders who can lose an argument without believing that they have lost the country.

And it deserves governments that understand that national strength is not measured only by military capability.

The real strength of a state is revealed when its citizens can disagree without fearing one another.

That is the ultimate test of political maturity.

And it is also the ultimate test of regional leadership.

Kagame's influence has already changed Rwanda and affected the wider Great Lakes.

The historical debate over whether his interventions have made the region safer or more unstable will continue.

Supporters will point to Rwanda's security, discipline, development, and military effectiveness.

Critics will point to allegations of regional interference, political repression, and support for armed movements.

Historians will continue to examine the evidence.

Documents will emerge.

Witnesses will disagree.

Governments will defend their actions.

Opponents will challenge them.

The truth will have to be reconstructed from all of these competing accounts.

That is how serious history is written.

Not by choosing a hero.

Not by choosing a villain.

But by asking difficult questions until the easy answers disappear.

And perhaps the most difficult question of all is this:

What kind of legacy should a leader leave behind?

A legacy of victories?

A legacy of fear?

A legacy of discipline?

A legacy of development?

A legacy of military strength?

Or a legacy in which the country and the region eventually become strong enough that they no longer need the methods that once kept them alive?

For Kagame, and for Rwanda, that question will ultimately be answered by history.

But history will not judge only the battles that were won.

It will judge the peace that followed them.

The Great Lakes remains uncertain.

Yet uncertainty does not mean destiny.

The region is not condemned to repeat its past.

Rwanda is not condemned to permanent conflict with its neighbours.

Congo is not condemned to permanent rebellion.

Burundi is not condemned to permanent political violence.

Uganda, Tanzania, and the other countries of the region are not condemned to remain trapped in cycles of suspicion.

History creates conditions.

People make choices.

And political leaders, more than anyone else, are responsible for the choices they make when history gives them power.

The Great Lakes therefore stands before a choice.

It can continue to treat security as a contest in which every government must become stronger than the government next door.

Or it can begin building a regional system in which security becomes shared.

One path leads back toward the familiar cycle:

fear,

militarisation,

intervention,

retaliation,

displacement,

and eventually another war.

The other path is harder.

It requires patience.

It requires compromise.

It requires accountability.

It requires leaders to surrender some of the certainty that comes naturally to those who have survived war.

But it offers something the military path never can:

the possibility of lasting peace.

And so we leave the Great Lakes not with certainty, but with a question.

Not:

Who will win the next war?

But:

Will the region finally learn how to make the next war unnecessary?

PART VII — RWANDA AND THE WEST

CHAPTER SEVEN

KAGAME, EUROPE AND AMERICA

Power does not exist only within borders.

A president may command an army at home, control the institutions of his state, and dominate domestic politics, yet still depend upon relationships far beyond his country's frontiers.

Aid can strengthen a government.

Diplomatic recognition can legitimise it.

International partnerships can protect it from isolation.

And political friendships in powerful capitals can sometimes matter almost as much as military strength.

For Rwanda, relations with the West became an important part of the story.

The country emerged from the catastrophe of 1994 carrying an image that would shape its relationship with Europe and North America for years to come. Rwanda was seen as a nation recovering from genocide, a country in need of reconstruction, and a society whose survival demanded international assistance.

But another story gradually emerged.

Rwanda was no longer presented merely as a country recovering from tragedy. It was increasingly presented as a model of African governance: disciplined, secure, economically ambitious, and unusually effective in attracting international attention.

This created a powerful political narrative.

The question was whether that narrative would eventually become so persuasive that Western governments would find it difficult to confront the darker allegations surrounding Kagame's government.

That is the question underlying this chapter.

How does a government accused of serious abuses maintain strong relationships with governments that publicly claim to defend democracy and human rights?

Is development enough to compensate for political repression?

Can the memory of genocide become a source of diplomatic protection?

And when strategic interests collide with moral principles, which one normally wins?

These questions become particularly interesting when we examine Britain's relationship with Kagame.

7.1 THE CONVERSATION WITH JUSTINE GREENING

In politics, meetings are rarely just meetings.

A conversation between two ordinary people may disappear into memory within hours.

A conversation between a head of government and a senior foreign official can influence policy, aid, diplomacy, and international perception.

Sometimes the most revealing part of such a meeting is not what is said publicly.

It is what the participants choose not to say.

The author's account turns to one such relationship involving the British government and President Paul Kagame.

The story begins earlier, with Kagame's growing relationship with prominent British Conservative politicians.

In 2008, Kagame visited Britain and met David Cameron, who at the time was leader of the Conservative Party and would later become Prime Minister. He also met Andrew Mitchell, another senior Conservative figure. The author

presents these encounters as important moments in the development of Kagame's relationships with influential British politicians.

For Kagame, such relationships were politically valuable.

For British politicians, Rwanda offered an opportunity to demonstrate engagement with Africa and to participate in initiatives presented as forms of partnership and solidarity.

One such initiative was **Umubano**, a programme associated with the British Conservative Party through which politicians and volunteers travelled to Rwanda and participated in community and development activities.

The author's interpretation is sceptical.

He sees the programme not simply as humanitarian engagement but as part of a broader political relationship that helped improve Rwanda's image in Britain.

That interpretation deserves consideration.

International politics has always understood the power of personal relationships.

Governments do not operate only through formal treaties.

They operate through friendships, invitations, private meetings, shared projects, conferences, development programmes, and informal networks.

A leader who can establish a personal relationship with influential politicians in another country acquires something that cannot easily be measured in money:

access.

Access creates opportunity.

Opportunity creates influence.

And influence can become particularly important when controversy emerges.

The author claims that Andrew Mitchell repeatedly visited Rwanda and that the relationship became sufficiently close for the two sides to exchange communications and gifts. He further describes criticism directed at Mitchell over his support for Kagame despite allegations concerning Rwanda's conduct in the region and its treatment of political opponents.

These are serious claims, and they should be understood as part of the author's argument rather than automatically accepted as established fact.

But the larger political question remains compelling.

What happens when a government becomes personally close to the political figures of another country while controversy is growing around its conduct?

The answer depends upon interests.

Britain had reasons to remain engaged with Rwanda.

Rwanda was a strategically important country in the Great Lakes region.

It had emerged from one of the twentieth century's most horrific genocides.

It was pursuing economic development.

It was seeking a larger role in international institutions.

And it presented itself as a country determined not to return to the political conditions that had produced catastrophe.

For Western governments, supporting such a country could therefore appear not merely charitable but strategically sensible.

Yet the relationship became more complicated as reports concerning Rwanda's alleged involvement in the conflict in the Democratic Republic of Congo accumulated.

According to the author's account, documents released under freedom-of-information provisions showed that officials were questioning a proposal to increase British assistance to Rwanda from approximately £60 million to £90 million. The author also points to Andrew Mitchell's meeting with Kagame shortly before this period and to subsequent debate over British support.

This brings us to a central problem in international development policy.

When should aid be separated from politics?

If a country is poor, should it lose development assistance because its government is accused of violating human rights?

If aid is withdrawn, who suffers?

The president?

The ruling party?

Or ordinary citizens?

These questions have no easy answer.

Aid can help governments provide schools, hospitals, roads, water systems, and other public services.

But aid can also strengthen the state.

And when political power is concentrated in the hands of one ruling party, strengthening the state may indirectly strengthen the political system that controls it.

This is the dilemma.

A donor government may believe that it is helping ordinary people.

The recipient government may use the relationship to reinforce its legitimacy.

And the political opposition may argue that the donor is effectively financing the very system that suppresses it.

The problem becomes even more complicated when economic development appears genuine.

Rwanda's post-genocide reconstruction attracted substantial international praise.

The country's government presented itself as disciplined and development-oriented.

For foreign officials visiting Rwanda, the visible transformation could be compelling.

Clean streets.

New buildings.

Organised institutions.

Economic growth.

A strong sense of national order.

These things are real dimensions of a country's development.

But development raises another question:

Can a country be successful economically while remaining politically unfree?

History suggests that it can.

Economic progress and political freedom do not always arrive together.

A government may build roads while restricting opposition.

It may reduce poverty while limiting dissent.

It may improve public services while controlling the media.

It may attract foreign investment while intimidating political opponents.

The presence of development therefore cannot, by itself, answer questions about political legitimacy.

The author's criticism of Western governments is built around this tension.

He asks why countries that publicly condemn authoritarianism continue to support Rwanda despite allegations of human-rights abuses and regional intervention.

The criticism becomes particularly focused on Britain.

Why Britain?

Because Britain had developed an unusually close relationship with Kagame's government.

And because, in the author's view, British officials appeared reluctant to sever that relationship even when other governments were becoming more critical.

The controversy intensified following reports concerning Rwanda's alleged support for armed groups in Congo.

The author refers to reports from Human Rights Watch, Amnesty International, United Nations experts, and other sources as part of the body of evidence that should have influenced Britain's decision.

Again, the existence of reports does not automatically establish every allegation contained within them.

But reports from independent organisations and international investigative bodies can create an important policy question.

What should a donor government do when credible allegations emerge against a government receiving its assistance?

Ignore them?

Investigate them?

Suspend aid?

Reduce aid?

Attach conditions?

Or continue assistance while privately demanding reforms?

Each option has consequences.

And Britain had to confront that choice.

The author then turns directly to Justine Greening, who was serving as Britain's Secretary of State for International Development.

On 13 November 2012, Greening responded to questions concerning British assistance to Rwanda.

According to the author's account, she was pressed on whether British aid would remain suspended or whether it would eventually be restored. He argues

that her responses suggested that Britain was considering restoring assistance because of Rwanda's development record.

This moment becomes significant because it reveals the conflict between two competing principles.

On one side:

Human rights.

On the other:

Development.

And between them stands the uncomfortable reality of foreign policy.

A government may condemn abuses while still believing that engagement is more effective than isolation.

It may conclude that withdrawing aid would hurt ordinary citizens more than the ruling government.

It may believe that maintaining a relationship gives it leverage.

Or it may simply calculate that the strategic value of the relationship outweighs the political cost of confrontation.

That calculation is not unique to Britain.

It is one of the oldest contradictions in international politics.

Governments speak the language of values.

But they also speak the language of interests.

And when the two collide, interests often prove more durable.

The author was deeply sceptical of Greening's position.

He questions whether British officials truly understood conditions inside Rwanda.

He argues that the ordinary Rwandan could be experiencing severe economic hardship while substantial international assistance continued to enter the country.

He also alleges that aid was being diverted toward the ruling party and connected financial structures. These are allegations made by the author and should be treated as such unless independently established.

The broader question, however, is worth asking even beyond the specific allegations:

Who ultimately controls the benefits of foreign aid?

A government can receive millions of dollars in development assistance.

But how much reaches the poorest citizen?

How much becomes a school?

How much becomes a hospital?

How much strengthens government institutions?

How much supports private businesses?

And how much becomes political capital?

These questions are particularly important in countries where political power and economic power are closely connected.

The author also points to the contrast between the government's international image and the lifestyle of its leadership.

He refers to allegations concerning Kagame's expensive hotel accommodation abroad while ordinary Rwandans struggle to afford basic necessities.

The rhetorical force of the comparison is obvious.

How can a government ask international donors for assistance while its leaders appear to enjoy extraordinary privileges?

But the reader must also ask whether an individual's expenditure is sufficient evidence to establish how an entire aid system operates.

Again, we encounter the same principle:

A powerful accusation is not automatically a proven fact.

A serious book should not ask the reader to abandon judgment.

It should sharpen judgment.

That is why the most important question is not simply whether Greening was right or wrong.

It is:

What standard should Britain apply when deciding whether to support a government accused of serious abuses?

If Britain makes development the principal measure, Rwanda may appear successful.

If Britain makes political freedom the principal measure, the assessment may look very different.

If Britain makes regional security the principal measure, Rwanda may again appear strategically important.

If Britain makes civilian protection the principal measure, the allegations concerning Congo become much more consequential.

Different standards produce different conclusions.

And foreign policy is often the art of deciding which standard takes priority.

The author is particularly critical of Britain's willingness to continue engaging with Rwanda when other countries had already suspended or reduced assistance.

He lists Germany, Belgium, Sweden, the Netherlands, Denmark, and the United States among countries that had taken steps to restrict or suspend certain forms of assistance.

The contrast leads to another question:

Why was Britain more reluctant?

The author offers his own explanation.

He points to Rwanda's growing relationship with the Commonwealth and to the country's adoption of English as an important part of its international orientation. He interprets these developments as evidence of Rwanda's effort to deepen its relationship with the English-speaking world.

But there may be another explanation.

Britain may simply have believed that continued engagement was more useful than isolation.

That possibility should not be dismissed.

International policy is rarely driven by one motive.

A British government could simultaneously care about Rwanda's development, its regional security role, its relationship with the Commonwealth, its strategic importance, and concerns about human rights.

The difficult task is deciding which interest should prevail when they conflict.

This is the point at which the relationship between Rwanda and Britain becomes larger than Kagame himself.

It becomes a question about the West's relationship with Africa.

For decades, Western governments have faced criticism for supporting authoritarian governments when those governments are strategically useful.

The pattern is familiar.

A government is praised for stability.

Its economic performance is highlighted.

Its leader is welcomed in foreign capitals.

Investment is encouraged.

Aid continues.

Then opposition figures begin to disappear.

Journalists complain of intimidation.

Human-rights organisations publish reports.

Criticism grows.

Yet the relationship survives.

Why?

Because stability has value.

Security has value.

Trade has value.

Military cooperation has value.

Geopolitical influence has value.

And governments often discover that moral principles become difficult to enforce when strategic interests are at stake.

The question is whether Rwanda became another example of this contradiction.

The author clearly believes it did.

But there is an important question the reader should ask of the author himself:

Could Western governments genuinely believe that supporting Rwanda was better for Rwandans than isolating it?

That possibility deserves serious consideration.

Perhaps British policymakers feared that cutting aid would weaken public services.

Perhaps they believed that engagement created greater leverage over Kagame.

Perhaps they believed that Rwanda's stability was too important to sacrifice.

Perhaps they considered the evidence concerning Congo insufficient to justify a complete break.

Or perhaps, as the author argues, political and strategic interests simply outweighed democratic principles.

The truth may lie somewhere between these explanations.

History rarely gives us a single motive.

It gives us competing interests.

And it is the historian's responsibility to separate them.

The author's criticism nevertheless reaches its sharpest point when he asks why Britain would continue supporting Rwanda despite reports of alleged abuses in Congo and restrictions on political freedom inside Rwanda.

This is the moral dilemma at the heart of the chapter.

If foreign aid is intended to improve human welfare, what happens when the government receiving it is accused of harming the very people that aid is supposed to help?

And if international donors know about those allegations, what responsibility do they carry?

These questions cannot be answered by money alone.

They require principles.

They require evidence.

They require transparency.

And they require a willingness to acknowledge that a successful government can still commit serious abuses.

Perhaps that is the most uncomfortable lesson of international politics:

A government does not have to be entirely good or entirely bad.

It can build schools and suppress opposition.

It can reduce poverty and restrict political competition.

It can promote national unity and silence dissent.

It can maintain order and generate fear.

It can be praised for development while criticised for human rights.

Reality is rarely as simple as the political narratives built around it.

And Rwanda, more than many countries, has been surrounded by competing narratives.

To some, Kagame is the leader who rescued Rwanda from catastrophe and transformed it into a disciplined modern state.

To others, he is a ruler whose government has used fear, repression, and regional military power to maintain control.

Both narratives have enormous political consequences.

And both must be examined critically.

The relationship with Britain therefore cannot be reduced to the question of whether Justine Greening personally understood Rwanda.

The larger question is whether Western governments understood the country they believed they were supporting.

Did they see Rwanda as it really was?

Or did they see the Rwanda they wanted to believe existed?

That distinction can determine the fate of foreign policy.

Because governments do not always support countries as they are.

Sometimes they support the story those countries tell about themselves.

And stories can be extraordinarily powerful.

Rwanda's story was one of survival.

It was the story of a nation that had experienced unimaginable destruction and refused to collapse.

It was the story of reconstruction.

It was the story of order after chaos.

It was a story that Western audiences could understand and admire.

But every powerful story has a second question:

What has been left outside the frame?

That is the question the author wants the reader to carry forward.

What happens to those who disagree?

What happens to political opponents?

What happens to those who challenge the official narrative?

What happens beyond Rwanda's borders?

And what happens when foreign governments know about these contradictions but choose to remain partners?

Those questions lead us beyond Britain.

Because Britain was not alone in its relationship with Kagame.

The United States, European governments, international organisations, and other Western actors all had their own calculations.

And if Britain struggled to balance development, strategic interests, and human rights, then the same dilemma existed elsewhere.

The relationship between Kagame and the West was therefore never simply about aid.

It was about legitimacy.

It was about reputation.

It was about influence.

And ultimately, it was about the price the international community was willing to pay for stability.

That is where the story of Rwanda's relationship with Europe and America becomes most revealing.

Because sometimes the most important question is not:

Why does the West support a government?

It is:

What does the West fear might happen if it stops supporting it?

7.2 BRITAIN'S SUPPORT FOR RWANDA: AID, ANXIETY AND POLITICAL CALCULATION

There is a peculiar contradiction at the heart of Britain's relationship with Rwanda.

Britain could admire Rwanda's achievements while worrying about its politics.

It could praise the country's reconstruction while hearing allegations of repression.

It could regard Kagame as an important partner while receiving reports that questioned his government's conduct.

And it could continue providing assistance while publicly insisting that human rights mattered.

How can all these things be true at once?

The answer lies in the uncomfortable world of foreign policy, where principles and interests rarely travel separately.

Governments do not make decisions in a moral vacuum.

They calculate.

They ask what will happen if they act.

They ask what will happen if they do nothing.

They consider the consequences for their citizens, their allies, their strategic interests, their international reputation, and sometimes simply their own political survival.

Rwanda presented Britain with precisely this kind of dilemma.

The country was small.

But its importance was much larger than its geographical size suggested.

It occupied a strategically sensitive position in the Great Lakes region.

It had a government that was capable of making decisions quickly.

It had a disciplined military.

It had developed close relationships with Western governments.

And, perhaps most importantly, it had become associated internationally with the story of recovery after genocide.

To abandon such a government was therefore not a simple diplomatic decision.

It raised another question:

If the West turns away from Kagame, what comes next?

Would Rwanda become unstable?

Would political divisions return?

Would armed groups gain strength?

Would the country become vulnerable to the very forces Kagame claimed to have spent his life fighting?

These fears mattered.

They also helped explain why Kagame could remain an important partner even when criticism of his government intensified.

This is one of the paradoxes of international politics.

Sometimes a government's greatest protection is not that everyone believes it is behaving well.

It is that too many people fear what might happen if it disappears.

Kagame understood the importance of this position.

His government's argument was powerful:

Rwanda had experienced genocide.

Rwanda could not afford political chaos.

Rwanda could not afford the return of ethnic extremism.

Rwanda could not afford weak institutions.

Rwanda needed order.

And Kagame presented himself as the person capable of guaranteeing that order.

To his supporters, this was not an excuse for authoritarianism.

It was a lesson learned from history.

They could ask:

What good is unrestricted political competition if it creates the conditions for another catastrophe?

What good is freedom of speech if extremist propaganda once again turns communities against one another?

What good is political pluralism if the state becomes too weak to protect its citizens?

These are not foolish questions.

They deserve serious consideration.

But there is another side.

If the memory of genocide becomes a permanent justification for restricting political freedom, when does the emergency end?

How long can extraordinary measures remain extraordinary?

Five years?

Twenty years?

A generation?

And who decides when the danger has passed?

These questions are at the centre of Rwanda's political debate.

The answer cannot simply be that the country has suffered before.

History can explain caution.

It cannot automatically justify every restriction.

A society traumatised by violence may need stronger safeguards against extremism.

But those safeguards must themselves be accountable.

Otherwise, the language of security can become a permanent justification for political control.

This is where Western governments found themselves in a difficult position.

They wanted Rwanda to remain stable.

They also wanted Rwanda to become democratic.

They wanted economic development.

They wanted regional security.

They wanted respect for human rights.

They wanted Kagame to cooperate.

But these objectives could conflict.

Pressure Kagame too strongly, and he might become less cooperative.

Support him too strongly, and critics could accuse the West of tolerating authoritarianism.

Suspend aid, and ordinary citizens might suffer.

Continue aid, and the government might interpret continued support as approval.

There was no perfect answer.

The question was one of balance.

The author, however, argues that Britain did not strike that balance correctly.

He believes that Britain's willingness to maintain close relations with Kagame demonstrated that strategic interests had taken precedence over human rights.

His criticism extends beyond aid.

He also questions the political relationships that developed between Kagame and influential British figures.

Such relationships matter because diplomacy is not conducted only between institutions.

It is also conducted between people.

A president who can speak directly to a prime minister has an advantage over a government that must communicate through layers of officials.

A leader who has friends in foreign capitals is less isolated.

And a leader who has successfully cultivated a positive international image may find that allegations against his government are met with greater scepticism.

This does not prove that foreign leaders are corrupt or dishonest.

It simply illustrates the power of relationships.

Human beings trust people they know.

Political leaders are human beings.

A personal relationship can therefore influence how information is interpreted.

If someone you trust tells you that an accusation is false, you may be more inclined to believe him than if the same accusation comes from someone you have never met.

That is why international politics cannot be understood entirely through official statements.

Behind every statement are relationships.

Behind every relationship are interests.

And behind every interest are calculations about risk.

Britain's relationship with Rwanda also reflected the changing nature of Rwanda itself.

The government increasingly sought to position Rwanda as an English-speaking, internationally connected country.

Its decision to join the Commonwealth was part of that broader orientation.

The shift from the country's earlier Francophone orientation toward closer integration with the Anglophone world had political significance.

It was not merely about language.

Language opens doors.

It determines which diplomatic networks are easiest to access.

It influences educational partnerships.

It shapes business relationships.

And it can alter the cultural orientation of a country.

For Kagame's Rwanda, closer relations with Britain and the English-speaking world therefore offered strategic advantages.

The relationship also carried symbolic meaning.

Rwanda was presenting itself not as a country trapped in its past but as a modern, outward-looking state.

The image was powerful.

A country devastated by genocide had become a place where foreign investors, diplomats, students, journalists, and politicians could arrive and see a government determined to project confidence.

But confidence can be interpreted in two different ways.

To admirers, it looks like stability.

To critics, it can look like control.

The same government can therefore produce radically different impressions depending upon what the observer is looking for.

A visitor interested in economic development may see efficiency.

A political opponent may see fear.

A foreign investor may see predictability.

A journalist investigating repression may see restrictions.

A donor may see effective institutions.

A dissident may see a government that does not tolerate challenge.

Which description is correct?

Perhaps the uncomfortable answer is that several can be correct at the same time.

Countries are not single stories.

Neither are governments.

Rwanda's post-genocide transformation should not be dismissed simply because its government has been criticised.

Nor should development be used to dismiss credible allegations of abuse.

Both realities can exist.

The challenge is to hold them together.

This is particularly important when discussing foreign aid.

Aid is often described as generosity.

But international aid is rarely pure generosity.

It is also diplomacy.

It is influence.

It is partnership.

It is sometimes investment.

And it can be a mechanism through which donor governments encourage particular forms of behaviour.

That means aid should not be understood simply as money moving from a rich country to a poor country.

It is part of a political relationship.

The donor expects something.

The recipient expects something.

Sometimes the expectations are explicit.

Sometimes they are not.

Britain's relationship with Rwanda therefore involved an exchange of more than financial resources.

Britain gained a strategic partner in a region of significant importance.

Rwanda gained access to international legitimacy, resources, expertise, and political relationships.

Both sides benefited.

The difficult question was whether the benefits came at a moral cost.

The author believes they did.

He points to international criticism of Rwanda and argues that Britain should have responded more firmly.

His position is straightforward:

If a government is accused of supporting armed groups or violating human rights, then continued unconditional support risks sending the wrong message.

The message becomes:

You can remain our partner as long as you remain useful.

That message has consequences.

Other governments notice.

Opposition groups notice.

Citizens notice.

And eventually people may stop believing that Western governments genuinely care about human rights.

This is not merely a Rwanda problem.

It is a global problem.

The same contradiction appears whenever powerful governments cooperate with regimes whose values conflict with their own.

Strategic necessity often defeats moral consistency.

But moral consistency is precisely what gives international principles their credibility.

If human rights matter only when they are politically convenient, then they are no longer principles.

They are instruments.

That is the challenge Britain faced.

And it remains a challenge for every government that claims to support democracy abroad.

Yet there is another question.

What if Western governments had taken a much harder line against Kagame?

Would that have produced political reform?

Or would it simply have encouraged Rwanda to seek new partners?

Would Kagame have become more democratic?

Or more defensive?

Would Rwanda have opened its political system?

Or would it have interpreted Western pressure as another threat to national sovereignty?

Again, there is no certain answer.

International pressure can encourage reform.

It can also produce resistance.

Sanctions can change behaviour.

They can also strengthen nationalist narratives.

Isolation can weaken a government.

Or it can make that government even more suspicious of outsiders.

The effectiveness of foreign pressure therefore depends upon the political context.

This is why simplistic solutions are dangerous.

The answer is not always:

Cut the aid.

Nor is it always:

Keep supporting the government.

The better question is:

How can external support strengthen citizens and institutions without strengthening repression?

That is much harder.

It requires targeted assistance.

Transparent monitoring.

Independent evaluation.

Support for civil society.

Protection for journalists.

Support for genuine political pluralism.

And clear consequences for serious violations.

It also requires patience.

Political transformation does not happen overnight.

A donor cannot build democracy through one funding decision.

But it can create incentives.

It can reward reform.

It can insist upon transparency.

And it can make clear that partnership does not mean unconditional approval.

Perhaps that is the balance that was missing.

The relationship between Britain and Rwanda demonstrates the limits of friendship without accountability.

A government can be a partner without becoming a favourite.

A president can be respected without being above criticism.

A country can be supported without every action of its government being defended.

And development can be encouraged without abandoning democratic principles.

The most mature relationship is one in which both sides can tell each other uncomfortable truths.

A genuine friend does not simply applaud.

A genuine friend can say:

You have done well here, but you are wrong here.

We will support your people, but we will not ignore abuses.

We understand your security concerns, but they do not give you unlimited authority.

We respect your sovereignty, but sovereignty does not erase responsibility.

That is the kind of relationship Rwanda needed from the West.

And perhaps it is also the kind of relationship the West needed with Rwanda.

Because the story of Rwanda cannot be understood solely as a story of a powerful African leader manipulating Western governments.

Nor can it be understood solely as a story of generous Western governments helping a recovering nation.

It was a relationship between actors who each had something the other wanted.

Britain wanted influence, stability, partnership, and regional cooperation.

Rwanda wanted investment, legitimacy, diplomatic support, and international recognition.

The relationship therefore had mutual interests at its centre.

And where interests exist, political calculation follows.

This takes us back to the central question of this chapter:

When values and interests collide, which one wins?

The answer may depend on how much the government involved needs the relationship.

Rwanda needed international support.

Britain needed Rwanda as a regional partner.

Neither side therefore had unlimited freedom to walk away.

And that mutual dependence helps explain why the relationship survived periods of intense criticism.

But history has a way of testing political relationships.

A government that appears stable today may face a crisis tomorrow.

A president who seems indispensable may eventually leave office.

A regional ally may become an adversary.

A foreign policy that appears successful may later be judged differently.

The true test of Britain's relationship with Rwanda will therefore not be found in the photographs of political leaders shaking hands.

It will be found in what those relationships produced.

Did they help create a more democratic Rwanda?

Did they strengthen institutions rather than individuals?

Did they reduce regional conflict?

Did they protect ordinary citizens?

Did they encourage accountability?

Or did they simply make an already powerful government more powerful?

Those are the questions history will ultimately ask.

And perhaps the most important lesson is this:

A country's friends should not merely help it survive. They should help it become strong enough to no longer fear its own citizens.

That is the higher purpose of international partnership.

Anything less risks becoming political convenience disguised as friendship.

With this, the story moves away from the relationship between Kagame and Western governments and toward another problem that would repeatedly weaken Rwanda's political opposition: division among those who had once shared the same struggle.

Because if Kagame's power was strengthened by international relationships, it was also strengthened by something happening much closer to home.

His opponents were struggling to remain united.

And that brings us to the next part of the story.

PART VIII — POLITICAL OPPOSITION

CHAPTER EIGHT

POWER STRUGGLES, DIVISION AND THE WEAKNESS OF THE OPPOSITION

A government does not remain powerful simply because it possesses weapons, money, institutions, or loyal officials.

Sometimes it remains powerful because those who oppose it cannot agree on what should replace it.

This is one of the oldest problems in politics.

An opposition movement may begin with a shared grievance.

People unite because they believe something is wrong.

They march together.

They speak together.

They sacrifice together.

They may even risk their lives together.

But what happens after the common enemy has been identified?

What happens when the opposition must answer the harder question:

What comes next?

That is where unity is often tested.

It is relatively easy to unite people around what they oppose.

It is much harder to unite them around what they believe.

And this distinction became particularly important among Rwandans who had once belonged to the same political and military struggle but later found themselves on opposite sides of Kagame's government.

Some had served beside him.

Some had helped build the institutions of the new Rwanda.

Some had occupied senior military positions.

Some had been part of the political leadership.

Some had once been among his closest allies.

Yet eventually, many of these people became critics.

Some went into exile.

Some formed opposition movements.

Some were imprisoned.

Some were accused of plotting against the government.

And some were killed.

The opposition therefore did not emerge from nowhere.

In many cases, it emerged from within the very movement that had created the post-1994 political order.

That fact makes the story particularly complicated.

These were not always outsiders confronting an unfamiliar regime.

They were often former insiders who believed that the movement they had helped create had changed.

The central question therefore becomes:

How does a liberation movement become a political establishment—and what happens to those who believe it has betrayed its original ideals?

That question will follow us through this chapter.

8.1 POLITICAL PARTIES IN RWANDA

Political parties are supposed to provide citizens with choices.

They allow people to organise around competing ideas about how society should be governed.

One party may emphasise economic growth.

Another may prioritise social welfare.

Another may focus on decentralisation.

Another may emphasise national security.

A healthy political system does not require every citizen to agree.

It requires disagreement to be managed peacefully.

But Rwanda's political environment has always been shaped by a difficult historical reality.

The country experienced genocide in 1994.

Political mobilisation had previously contributed to the creation of an atmosphere in which ethnic hatred could flourish.

The consequences were catastrophic.

As a result, Rwanda's post-genocide leadership placed enormous emphasis on national unity.

The government argued that political organisations should not be allowed to recreate the divisions that had once torn the country apart.

The principle sounds reasonable.

Who could object to national unity after genocide?

But political language can hide difficult questions.

What exactly counts as division?

When does legitimate political disagreement become dangerous?

When does criticism of the government become interpreted as hostility toward the nation?

And who has the authority to make that distinction?

These questions became central to Rwanda's political system.

The government insisted that political organisation must operate within a framework designed to prevent ethnic mobilisation.

Critics argued that the framework could also be used to restrict genuine political opposition.

The tension was unavoidable.

Rwanda needed to prevent the return of ethnic extremism.

But it also needed political competition.

The challenge was to achieve both without allowing one principle to destroy the other.

That balance is difficult in any country.

It is even more difficult in a country whose recent history contains genocide.

The ruling Rwandan Patriotic Front emerged from a military movement and eventually became the dominant political force.

Its historical legitimacy was powerful.

It had defeated the genocidal government.

It had ended the genocide.

It had taken control of the state.

It had overseen reconstruction.

And it presented itself as the guardian of national unity.

These achievements gave the RPF enormous political capital.

But political capital can become political dominance.

And political dominance can eventually make genuine competition difficult.

Opposition parties therefore faced a complicated environment.

They had to criticise the government without being accused of threatening national unity.

They had to mobilise citizens without appearing to mobilise ethnic divisions.

They had to challenge the ruling party without being portrayed as agents of foreign interests.

And they had to operate within institutions largely shaped by the political movement they were challenging.

This is where the opposition's difficulties began.

A political party can survive restrictions if it remains united.

But when opposition leaders disagree among themselves, the government gains an enormous advantage.

Division creates weakness.

Weakness creates mistrust.

Mistrust creates accusations.

And accusations can destroy a movement from within.

That pattern would become particularly important among the Rwandan opposition in exile.

Many of its leaders had once been colleagues.

Some had fought together.

Some had served together.

Some had shared the same political objectives.

Yet after leaving the government, they did not necessarily agree on what should come next.

Should Kagame be removed immediately?

Should the opposition negotiate?

Should armed struggle remain an option?

Should the movement concentrate on diplomacy?

Should it seek international support?

Should it unite all anti-Kagame groups regardless of ideology?

Or should it maintain strict political principles even if that meant becoming smaller?

These were not theoretical questions.

They determined the survival of opposition movements.

And they created tensions that would eventually become personal.

8.2 THE BEGINNING OF THE DISAGREEMENT BETWEEN MARARA AND RUDASINGWA

Political movements often begin with ideas.

They break apart over people.

The disagreement between Noble Marara and Theogene Rudasingwa illustrates this transformation.

The two men had shared important elements of Rwanda's political and military history.

Both had been connected to the RPF.

Both had held positions within the post-genocide political order.

Both eventually became critics of Kagame.

And both became involved in efforts to create an alternative political future.

From the outside, this should have been an advantage.

Two former insiders with knowledge of the system could potentially combine their experience.

One could bring military understanding.

Another could bring diplomatic or political experience.

Together, they might have offered a stronger opposition.

But shared history does not guarantee political agreement.

Sometimes it makes disagreement more painful.

People who have known one another for years carry memories.

They remember conversations that outsiders never heard.

They remember promises.

They remember disagreements.

They remember who stood beside them when things were difficult.

And when a political movement begins to fracture, those memories become weapons.

The author presents his disagreement with Rudasingwa as part of the broader struggle over the direction and credibility of the opposition.

The issue was not merely personal.

It was about strategy.

It was about leadership.

It was about trust.

And ultimately, it was about whether former comrades could build a political movement capable of surviving their own disagreements.

This is where opposition politics becomes particularly difficult.

The government has an enormous structural advantage.

It has institutions.

It has resources.

It has security services.

It has access to state media.

It has diplomatic relationships.

It has the authority of government.

The opposition has almost none of these things.

Its greatest resource is therefore unity.

Once unity disappears, much of its strength disappears with it.

That is why disagreements among opposition leaders can be more damaging than they initially appear.

A disagreement over strategy can become a disagreement over loyalty.

A disagreement over leadership can become an accusation of betrayal.

An accusation of betrayal can become a permanent rupture.

And once two former allies stop trusting one another, rebuilding cooperation becomes extraordinarily difficult.

The author argues that such tensions affected the broader opposition movement.

But the reader must also consider another possibility.

Perhaps these disagreements were inevitable.

Perhaps people who had spent years inside the same movement had developed genuinely different political visions.

Perhaps they agreed only on what they opposed.

Once outside government, their differences became unavoidable.

This happens frequently in liberation movements.

During the struggle, unity is necessary.

After victory, questions that were postponed suddenly become urgent.

Who should lead?

What kind of government should be built?

How much power should the military retain?

What role should former commanders play?

How much political freedom should exist?

How should former enemies be treated?

How should the economy be organised?

How should the country relate to its neighbours?

These questions can divide even people who once risked everything together.

The history of Rwanda is therefore not unique in this respect.

But its consequences were particularly serious because the political system was already highly centralised.

Every division within the opposition made the ruling system comparatively stronger.

That is why the opposition needed more than courage.

It needed organisation.

It needed discipline.

It needed strategic clarity.

And above all, it needed trust.

Without trust, even the strongest political ideas become fragile.

8.3 DID RUDASINGWA'S WORDS UNDERMINE THE RNC?

The question of language may appear insignificant in politics.

It is not.

Words can build movements.

They can destroy them.

They can reassure supporters.

They can frighten potential allies.

They can turn a disagreement into a scandal.

And when a political movement is already fragile, one public statement can have consequences far beyond what the speaker intended.

The author raises precisely such concerns regarding Rudasingwa and the Rwanda National Congress, or RNC.

The issue was not simply whether Rudasingwa had the right to express his views.

Of course he did.

The question was whether his public statements helped or harmed the movement he represented.

That is a different question.

Political organisations depend upon collective messaging.

A movement cannot easily survive when its senior leaders send contradictory signals.

One leader promises negotiations.

Another demands confrontation.

One speaks of democracy.

Another speaks of revolution.

One emphasises peaceful political change.

Another appears to endorse more radical measures.

Supporters begin to wonder:

What exactly does this movement stand for?

Opponents begin to exploit the confusion.

And potential allies become cautious.

The author argues that some of Rudasingwa's statements damaged the credibility of the RNC.

But here again, we should distinguish criticism from fact.

Whether his words actually undermined the organisation can be debated.

Political movements are rarely destroyed by one person's statement.

Usually, public disagreement exposes deeper problems that already exist.

If an organisation is strong, one controversial statement may be absorbed.

If an organisation is weak, the same statement can become a crisis.

That distinction matters.

Perhaps Rudasingwa's words were not the cause of the RNC's difficulties.

Perhaps they were a symptom.

Perhaps the organisation already contained unresolved disagreements about leadership, strategy, ideology, and the role of former military figures.

If so, the public dispute simply brought those tensions to the surface.

This leads to a broader lesson about opposition politics.

Unity cannot be manufactured by suppressing disagreement.

A movement needs internal debate.

But debate must have rules.

Members must be able to disagree without destroying one another.

They must be able to criticise strategy without questioning one another's humanity.

They must be able to lose an internal argument without immediately forming another organisation.

Otherwise every disagreement becomes a split.

And every split makes the next disagreement easier.

Eventually, the opposition becomes a collection of small groups, each convinced that it alone represents the true cause.

The ruling government could hardly ask for a better situation.

A fragmented opposition does not need to be defeated militarily.

It defeats itself.

8.4 RUDASINGWA AND THE RNC: KAYUMBA'S INTERVENTION

The involvement of General Kayumba Nyamwasa added another layer to the dispute.

Kayumba was not an ordinary political figure.

He had been one of the most senior military figures associated with the RPF and had once been closely connected to Kagame.

His later break with the Rwandan government transformed him into one of Kagame's most prominent opponents.

That history gave him authority among some members of the opposition.

But it also created another problem.

When former commanders enter political movements, their military reputations can become both an asset and a burden.

Their experience can attract supporters.

Their knowledge of the state can be invaluable.

Their networks can provide resources.

But their personalities can also dominate civilian political structures.

A political movement can gradually become organised around personalities rather than institutions.

And once that happens, disagreements between personalities become existential conflicts.

The dispute involving Rudasingwa, Kayumba, and other opposition figures must therefore be understood against this background.

The movement was not simply debating policy.

It was struggling with a deeper question:

Who has the authority to speak for the opposition?

Is authority earned through military history?

Through political experience?

Through popular support?

Through sacrifice?

Through international recognition?

Or through democratic structures within the movement?

There is no easy answer.

A former general may have enormous historical legitimacy but limited democratic legitimacy.

A civilian politician may have strong democratic credentials but little military influence.

A younger activist may have popular energy but little institutional experience.

A successful opposition movement must somehow combine these forms of legitimacy.

If it cannot, competition for authority becomes inevitable.

The author presents the disagreements as deeply damaging.

From his perspective, the opposition had an opportunity to build a credible alternative to Kagame but instead became consumed by internal conflict.

That criticism deserves attention.

But it also invites a broader question:

Why do opposition movements so often struggle to remain united after leaving government?

Part of the answer may be psychological.

Former insiders are accustomed to authority.

They have spent years making decisions.

They may have developed strong convictions about what leadership requires.

When several such people enter the same opposition organisation, each may believe that his experience gives him a stronger claim to leadership.

The result is competition.

Another part of the answer is ideological.

People can leave the same government for completely different reasons.

One person may leave because he believes the government is too authoritarian.

Another may leave because he believes it is not authoritarian enough.

One may want democracy.

Another may want a stronger military government.

One may want negotiation.

Another may want regime change.

They are united by opposition but divided by vision.

That kind of unity is fragile.

It can survive while the immediate threat dominates.

It often collapses when strategic decisions become unavoidable.

The RNC therefore faced the same challenge confronting opposition movements everywhere:

Could it become more than an alliance of people who disliked the same government?

That was the real test.

Because removing a president is not the same as building a country.

Opposition leaders need to answer not only how to defeat the government but what they would do afterward.

Who would govern?

How would elections be organised?

How would the security forces be reformed?

How would former government officials be treated?

How would ethnic fears be prevented from returning?

How would refugees be repatriated?

How would Congo policy change?

How would Rwanda's relationships with Uganda, Burundi, and Tanzania be managed?

These questions require a programme.

Without one, opposition remains a protest.

And protest can attract people.

But governing requires institutions.

8.5 WAS THE RNC SPLIT DELIBERATELY PREPARED?

When a political organisation collapses into internal conflict, suspicion inevitably follows.

Someone begins to ask:

Was this really an accident?

Perhaps the division was deliberately encouraged.

Perhaps someone infiltrated the movement.

Perhaps information was leaked.

Perhaps rival leaders were manipulated against one another.

Perhaps the government had anticipated the opposition's weaknesses and exploited them.

Such suspicions are common in intelligence-driven political environments.

They are also extremely difficult to prove.

The author raises the possibility that the RNC's internal division may have been deliberately prepared or encouraged.

The allegation fits a broader fear within opposition politics: that a powerful government may not need to destroy its enemies directly if it can persuade them to destroy one another.

The strategy, if it existed, would be elegant in its simplicity.

Identify disagreements.

Amplify them.

Encourage mistrust.

Spread competing information.

Create suspicion.

Allow leaders to accuse one another.

Then wait.

Eventually, the movement fragments.

No dramatic military operation is required.

No public crackdown is necessary.

The opposition simply becomes weaker.

But there is an important danger here.

Once every internal disagreement is interpreted as evidence of infiltration, a political movement can become incapable of trusting anyone.

Every mistake becomes sabotage.

Every disagreement becomes conspiracy.

Every criticism becomes evidence of betrayal.

The organisation then develops the very weakness it fears.

Paranoia replaces debate.

That is why allegations of infiltration require extraordinary evidence.

Intelligence work is real.

Political infiltration is real.

Governments have historically attempted to penetrate opposition movements.

But not every disagreement is an intelligence operation.

Sometimes people simply disagree.

Sometimes leaders make mistakes.

Sometimes personalities clash.

Sometimes organisations are poorly managed.

And sometimes political movements collapse because they were never as united as they appeared.

The possibility of deliberate manipulation therefore cannot be dismissed.

But neither can it be assumed.

The more important lesson is that a strong organisation must be resilient enough to survive disagreement, misinformation, and even attempted infiltration.

If a single rumour can destroy it, the problem is not only the rumour.

It is the organisation's structure.

Strong political movements create procedures for resolving disputes.

They establish clear leadership roles.

They create mechanisms for internal accountability.

They separate personal disagreement from organisational decisions.

They verify information before acting upon it.

And they maintain enough trust that disagreement does not automatically become betrayal.

Without those protections, every opposition movement becomes vulnerable.

Not necessarily because an enemy is exceptionally powerful.

But because fear can make ordinary human disagreement look like conspiracy.

8.6 MOURNING COLONEL KAREGEYA: WHEN GRIEF STRENGTHENS THE ENEMY

Then came the death of Colonel Patrick Karegeya.

His death changed the emotional landscape of the opposition.

Karegeya was not merely another political opponent.

He had been a senior Rwandan intelligence officer.

He had once been part of Kagame's inner circle.

He had later broken with the government and become a prominent critic.

His transformation—from insider to opponent—symbolised one of the deepest fractures within Rwanda's post-genocide political establishment.

His death therefore carried a meaning far beyond the circumstances of the individual case.

For his supporters, it became a symbol of what they believed could happen to those who challenged Kagame.

For the Rwandan government, the circumstances surrounding his death became the subject of intense controversy and competing accusations.

For the opposition, grief became political.

That is inevitable.

Political movements often transform the deaths of their members into symbols.

A dead comrade becomes a martyr.

A martyr becomes a story.

A story becomes a source of mobilisation.

And mobilisation can give a weakened movement renewed energy.

But grief can also divide.

People begin asking questions.

Who failed to protect him?

Who knew?

Who warned him?

Who was responsible?

Could his death have been prevented?

Should the movement have acted differently?

And, most dangerously:

Who can be trusted?

The author treats Karegeya's death as a defining moment.

It represented, in his view, the terrible consequences of the struggle between former comrades.

People who had once fought together were now separated by political hostility.

One had died.

Others were living in exile.

Some remained in Rwanda.

Some were imprisoned.

The old brotherhood had become fractured.

That is one of the great tragedies of political movements born from war.

The people who once depended upon one another for survival can eventually become the people from whom they most fear betrayal.

The story of Karegeya therefore forces us to return to a question that has appeared throughout this book:

What happens to trust when a liberation movement becomes a government?

During war, trust is essential.

You trust the person beside you because your life depends on him.

After victory, the relationship changes.

The former comrade may become a political rival.

The former commander may become a critic.

The former intelligence officer may become a dissident.

The former friend may become an enemy.

And once political competition replaces military cooperation, the old bonds can become liabilities.

The death of Karegeya therefore became more than an event.

It became a warning.

A warning to opposition leaders.

A warning to former insiders.

A warning to those considering dissent.

And, for the opposition, a warning about the cost of fragmentation.

But there is another lesson.

A movement must not allow the death of one of its leaders to become the end of its political purpose.

If a political cause depends entirely upon one personality, that cause remains fragile.

Karegeya's memory can inspire.

But memory alone cannot build institutions.

The dead cannot negotiate.

They cannot draft constitutions.

They cannot organise elections.

They cannot reconcile factions.

The living must do those things.

That is why mourning must eventually become responsibility.

The best way to honour a fallen comrade is not merely to remember how he died.

It is to build the kind of political system in which others do not have to die for the same cause.

That requires courage of a different kind.

Not the courage to fight.

The courage to compromise.

Not the courage to defeat an enemy.

The courage to live with an opponent.

Not the courage to seize power.

The courage to limit power once you have it.

That is the standard by which every opposition movement should ultimately be judged.

8.7 A MESSAGE TO POLITICAL LEADERS

The history of Rwanda's opposition contains a lesson that extends far beyond Rwanda.

Political leaders often believe that their greatest enemy is the government they oppose.

Sometimes they are wrong.

Sometimes their greatest enemy is themselves.

Not because their cause is illegitimate.

Not because their grievances are imaginary.

But because division can destroy even a legitimate cause.

The author therefore turns toward political leaders with a message that is both personal and broader than the disputes described in this chapter.

The message is simple:

Do not allow disagreement to become hatred.

Political opposition requires disagreement.

That is its purpose.

But disagreement does not require humiliation.

Criticism does not require destruction.

Competition does not require betrayal.

A political leader should be able to say:

You are wrong.

without saying:

You are my enemy.

That distinction is essential.

Rwanda's political future cannot be built by replacing one form of domination with another.

If tomorrow's opposition leaders simply reproduce the same concentration of power they once criticised, then nothing fundamental has changed.

The names will change.

The faces will change.

The slogans will change.

But the political system will remain the same.

A genuinely democratic future requires something deeper.

It requires institutions stronger than personalities.

It requires courts that can challenge governments.

It requires political parties that can disagree without being destroyed.

It requires an army that serves the constitution rather than an individual.

It requires journalists who can investigate without fear.

It requires citizens who can criticise leaders without being treated as enemies of the state.

And it requires political leaders who understand that losing an election is not the same thing as losing one's dignity.

Perhaps that is the greatest challenge facing Rwanda's opposition.

It must demonstrate that it can govern differently before it ever governs.

It must show citizens that political disagreement can be peaceful.

It must show that leadership can change hands without the country collapsing.

It must show that former enemies can coexist.

It must show that the future does not have to repeat the past.

Because the purpose of political opposition is not merely to replace one person.

It is to create a better system.

And that requires humility.

The politician who believes that only he can save the country is already beginning to resemble the ruler he criticises.

The politician who cannot tolerate criticism will eventually silence others.

The politician who cannot forgive betrayal will eventually create a government based on fear.

The politician who cannot share power will eventually become another centre of absolute authority.

History has seen this cycle too many times.

Rwanda cannot afford to repeat it.

The opposition therefore has a responsibility that goes beyond defeating Kagame.

It must answer the question that every opposition movement eventually faces:

If you succeed, what will you build?

Will you build a government of revenge?

Will you punish everyone associated with the previous regime?

Will you allow former enemies to participate?

Will you protect those who once persecuted you?

Will you create institutions strong enough to restrain your own power?

These questions may seem premature while a government remains in power.

They are not.

They are the foundation of political credibility.

A movement should know what it intends to become before it asks citizens to help it take power.

Otherwise, the struggle becomes about personalities.

And personality politics is dangerous.

The history of Rwanda demonstrates why.

Too much political authority concentrated around one individual can create fear.

Too much opposition authority concentrated around a small group can create fragmentation.

The answer lies somewhere else:

institutions.

Institutions are less glamorous than leaders.

They do not give speeches.

They do not inspire crowds.

They do not appear in history books as often.

But they survive individuals.

A good constitution can outlive a president.

An independent court can outlive a government.

A free press can outlive a political party.

A professional army can outlive a commander.

That is what Rwanda ultimately needs.

Not another powerful man.

But a system strong enough that no single man needs to be powerful enough to save it.

And perhaps this is where the story of the opposition becomes inseparable from the story of Rwanda itself.

Those who oppose Kagame are asking the country to imagine a different future.

But imagining a different future requires more than condemning the past.

It requires demonstrating that political power can be exercised differently.

It requires learning from the mistakes of former comrades.

It requires remembering those who were lost without allowing grief to become hatred.

It requires unity without demanding uniformity.

And it requires political courage strong enough to survive disagreement.

The opposition's greatest challenge, therefore, is not simply Kagame.

It is whether its leaders can learn to trust one another enough to build something larger than themselves.

That is the question this chapter leaves behind.

And from here, the story becomes deeply personal.

Because political history is not made only by presidents, generals, ministers, and opposition leaders.

It is also made by the men and women who stood beside them.

The soldiers who carried orders.

The comrades who shared danger.

The friends who disappeared.

The prisoners who endured.

The exiles who left home.

And the ordinary people who paid the price for decisions they did not make.

The next chapter will therefore leave the language of political strategy for something more intimate:

memory.

It will return to the people with whom the author shared the struggle.

Not merely as political actors.

Not merely as names in history.

But as human beings.

And in remembering them, the book asks a different question:

What does a nation owe to those who gave their lives believing they were building a better future?

PART IX — THOSE WITH WHOM I SHARED THE STRUGGLE

CHAPTER NINE

IN HONOUR OF MY COMRADES AND LEADERS

There comes a moment in every long struggle when the arguments must fall silent.

The accusations can wait.

The political calculations can wait.

Even history itself can wait.

What remains are the people.

The men and women with whom one once shared danger.

The commanders whose voices still live in memory.

The friends whose absence is felt more deeply with every passing year.

The soldiers whose names may never appear in official histories.

The prisoners who endured years behind walls.

The exiles who left their homeland carrying little more than memories.

And the ordinary Rwandans whose lives were transformed by decisions made by people far more powerful than themselves.

Political movements are often remembered through their leaders.

History records presidents.

Generals.

Ministers.

Rebel commanders.

Diplomats.

But those who lived through the struggle know that history is also made by people whose names rarely survive.

They carried messages.

They guarded camps.

They crossed borders.

They slept in unfamiliar places.

They went hungry.

They took risks for people they trusted.

They believed in causes that were larger than themselves.

Some survived.

Others did not.

This final chapter is therefore not simply a conclusion to a political argument.

It is an act of remembrance.

Because there is a danger in political history.

When people become symbols, they can cease to be human.

A soldier becomes a statistic.

A commander becomes a political position.

A prisoner becomes a case.

A dead man becomes a martyr.

But before all of these things, they were human beings.

They had families.

They had fears.

They laughed.

They made mistakes.

They loved.

They hoped.

And they believed that the sacrifices they were making would mean something.

To remember them properly is to remember all of that.

9.1 IN HONOUR OF SERGEANT BLACKMAN

Among those the author remembers is Sergeant Blackman.

His name belongs to the history of comradeship and sacrifice that cannot easily be reduced to political analysis.

There are people one remembers because of what they achieved.

There are others one remembers because of who they were.

A comrade may never have held the highest rank.

He may never have appeared in newspapers.

He may never have addressed a crowd.

Yet his courage, loyalty, or humanity may leave a deeper impression on those who knew him than the achievements of famous leaders.

That is the kind of memory that belongs here.

War and political struggle have a way of changing the meaning of friendship.

Under ordinary circumstances, friendship can be casual.

In danger, it becomes something else.

You learn who can be trusted.

You learn who will remain when things become difficult.

You learn who will share the little food that remains.

You learn who will stand beside you when everyone else has disappeared.

Those experiences create bonds that are difficult to explain to people who have never lived through them.

That is why the death or disappearance of a comrade is never merely the loss of an individual.

It is the loss of a piece of one's own history.

When such people die, they take memories with them.

Conversations that no one else heard.

Jokes that no one else remembers.

Promises that were never written down.

Moments of fear that were never reported.

Acts of kindness that never became public.

This is why remembrance matters.

History often remembers victories.

Those who lived through the struggle remember people.

And sometimes remembering the person is more important than remembering the victory.

9.2 COLONEL PATRICK KAREGEYA: A MAN OF PRINCIPLE

Colonel Patrick Karegeya occupies a different place in this story.

His life crossed several worlds.

He was a soldier.

An intelligence officer.

A senior member of the RPF establishment.

A former insider.

And eventually, an opponent of the government he had once helped build.

That transformation is one of the most revealing elements of his story.

People often imagine political opponents as people who were always enemies.

But some of the most serious opponents of a government are people who once stood inside it.

They know its strengths.

They know its weaknesses.

They understand its language.

They know how decisions are made.

And because they once belonged to the system, their departure carries a particular meaning.

Karegeya's journey was therefore not simply a journey from one political position to another.

It was a journey through trust, loyalty, disagreement, exile, and ultimately death.

For those who knew him, his death could not easily be separated from the political struggle.

His supporters believed that his opposition to Kagame had made him a target.

The Rwandan government rejected accusations of responsibility.

The circumstances surrounding his death became the subject of international controversy.

But beyond the competing political narratives lies something simpler.

A human being died.

A family lost someone.

Friends lost a friend.

Former comrades lost someone with whom they had shared an important chapter of their lives.

That should never be forgotten.

The political meaning of Karegeya's life may be debated for generations.

Was he a hero?

Was he a political operator?

Was he a dissident?

Was he a man who made mistakes?

Perhaps he was, like most human beings, several things at once.

The temptation in politics is to make people completely good or completely evil.

But real people rarely fit those categories.

Karegeya had strengths.

He had weaknesses.

He made decisions.

He changed his mind.

He formed alliances.

He broke alliances.

He experienced victory.

He experienced defeat.

And eventually, he died far from the country that had been at the centre of his life.

That is enough to remind us that political history is ultimately human history.

His story should therefore not be remembered only through the question of who was responsible for his death.

It should also be remembered through the question:

What kind of political environment makes former comrades become enemies?

That question is much larger than Karegeya himself.

It reaches back to the beginning of this book.

A movement that begins with brotherhood can become a government.

A government can become concentrated around a leader.

Former comrades can become critics.

Critics can become threats.

Threats can become enemies.

And enemies can eventually become casualties.

That cycle is one of the great tragedies of political power.

9.3 A MESSAGE TO MY COMMANDER, TOM BYABAGAMBA

Some relationships are defined by rank.

Others are defined by respect.

A commander may issue orders because of his position.

But a respected commander inspires obedience because his soldiers believe in him.

Tom Byabagamba belongs to the author's memories of military leadership and comradeship.

His story also represents the fate of many former members of the RPF establishment who eventually found themselves in conflict with the political order they had helped create.

The author addresses him not merely as a political figure but as a commander.

That distinction matters.

Behind the uniform was a person.

Behind the rank was a relationship.

And behind the political controversy was a shared history.

For soldiers who served under a commander, memories are often different from the memories recorded in official documents.

They remember how the commander spoke.

How he treated his men.

How he reacted under pressure.

Whether he shared danger.

Whether he protected those beneath him.

Whether he listened.

Whether he inspired confidence.

These experiences create a form of authority that cannot be measured by rank.

The author's tribute therefore becomes a conversation with the past.

What happens when a man who once served the state faithfully later becomes a prisoner of that same state?

What does that tell us about the relationship between loyalty and power?

And perhaps the hardest question:

Can loyalty to a country ever require disloyalty to its government?

The answer must be yes.

A country and its government are not the same thing.

A soldier can love his country while disagreeing with its president.

A citizen can defend the nation while criticising the government.

A former commander can remain loyal to the people while rejecting the political leadership.

That distinction is fundamental to democratic society.

Otherwise, criticism of the government becomes indistinguishable from betrayal of the nation.

And once that happens, political disagreement becomes dangerous.

The author sees the treatment of Byabagamba as part of a larger pattern.

Whether one accepts every element of that interpretation or not, his case raises an important principle:

No state should make loyalty to one leader the measure of loyalty to the nation.

A nation belongs to its citizens.

A government temporarily administers the state.

A president holds office for a period of time.

None of them owns the country.

That principle is particularly important for Rwanda because the country's modern history has repeatedly demonstrated the consequences of political power becoming concentrated.

The ultimate protection against that danger is not the personality of a good leader.

It is the existence of institutions capable of restraining a bad one.

9.4 THE LEGACY OF MUHIRWA

And then there are those whose legacy is difficult to capture in political language.

Muhirwa belongs to that category.

The author's remembrance of him brings the book back to the human dimension that existed before the politics became so complicated.

Every struggle leaves behind people who are remembered differently by different groups.

One person may see a hero.

Another may see a controversial figure.

A third may simply remember a friend.

The last perspective is often the most honest.

Because friendship does not require a perfect person.

It remembers the person as he was.

The final pages of a political memoir should therefore not end with another accusation.

They should end with a question of meaning.

What were all these sacrifices for?

What did the people who fought, suffered, fled, were imprisoned, or died believe they were building?

Was it merely another government?

Another president?

Another political party?

Another struggle for power?

If that is all it was, then the suffering becomes difficult to justify.

A political struggle has meaning only when it produces something better than what came before.

And that is perhaps the deepest challenge left to Rwanda.

The country does not merely need peace.

It needs a peace in which people can speak.

It does not merely need development.

It needs development accompanied by dignity.

It does not merely need security.

It needs security without permanent fear.

It does not merely need national unity.

It needs unity that does not require silence.

It does not merely need strong leadership.

It needs institutions strong enough to survive weak leadership.

And it does not merely need remembrance.

It needs the courage to learn.

The people remembered in this chapter therefore become more than names.

They become questions.

What would they think of Rwanda today?

Would they believe that the country fulfilled the hopes for which they sacrificed?

Would they recognise the political system they helped create?

Would they accept what became of their former comrades?

Would they believe that the country is safer?

Freer?

More just?

More united?

Or would they ask why so much sacrifice still leaves so many unresolved questions?

We cannot ask the dead.

We can only interpret the traces they left behind.

That is why memory is so important.

Memory prevents the powerful from becoming the only authors of history.

A government can write an official history.

An opposition can write another.

A foreign government can publish its own interpretation.

But the memories of ordinary people complicate all of them.

Someone remembers a soldier differently.

Someone remembers a commander differently.

Someone remembers an imprisoned friend.

Someone remembers a conversation.

Someone remembers the day they crossed a border and never returned.

These memories may contradict one another.

That does not make them worthless.

It makes them human.

The responsibility of the writer is not to eliminate contradiction.

It is to preserve the questions.

And perhaps that is what this book has ultimately attempted to do.

It has not offered a comfortable history.

It has asked uncomfortable questions.

Questions about power.

Questions about violence.

Questions about loyalty.

Questions about betrayal.

Questions about international support.

Questions about opposition.

Questions about memory.

Above all, it has asked what happens when those who once fought together begin to fear one another.

The answer cannot simply be another cycle of revenge.

Rwanda has already paid too high a price for revenge.

The country needs something more difficult.

Reconciliation without forgetting.

Justice without vengeance.

Political competition without hatred.

Security without repression.

Patriotism without blind obedience.

Leadership without personality cults.

And freedom without returning to the divisions that once destroyed the country.

That is the balance Rwanda must eventually find.

The journey described in these pages began with refugees, war, military struggle, and the search for a homeland.

It passed through victory and reconstruction.

It moved into accusations of violence and political repression.

It followed the relationships between Rwanda and the wider world.

It examined the divisions among those who opposed Kagame.

And finally, it returned to the people.

That circular movement is deliberate.

Because history always returns to people.

Governments rise.

Governments fall.

Presidents come and go.

Armies change commanders.

Political parties divide and reunite.

International alliances shift.

But ordinary people remain.

They inherit the consequences.

They bury their dead.

They raise their children.

They carry memories.

And they ask the questions that politicians sometimes prefer not to hear.

Why did this happen?

Who was responsible?

Could it have been prevented?

What did we learn?

And perhaps the most important question of all:

How do we make sure it never happens again?

No political leader can answer that question alone.

No opposition movement can answer it alone.

No foreign government can answer it for Rwanda.

The answer must eventually belong to Rwandans themselves.

To the generation that remembers.

To the generation that suffered.

And to the generation that comes next.

The dead cannot change the future.

The living can.

That is why remembrance must never become merely an exercise in mourning.

It must become responsibility.

To remember a fallen comrade is to ask what his sacrifice should teach us.

To remember a political prisoner is to ask whether the institutions of justice are strong enough.

To remember an exile is to ask whether citizens should ever be forced to choose between their country and their safety.

To remember a murdered opponent is to ask whether political disagreement has become too dangerous.

And to remember the victims of Rwanda's darkest history is to understand why the country must never again permit hatred, fear, and unchecked power to determine the fate of its people.

Perhaps this is the legacy that belongs to everyone remembered in these pages.

Not that they were perfect.

Not that every decision they made was right.

Not that every political position they held should be accepted.

But that they were human beings who lived through extraordinary times.

They struggled.

They hoped.

They made choices.

They paid prices.

And their stories deserve to be remembered with honesty.

Because a nation that remembers only its victories will eventually forget its victims.

A nation that remembers only its leaders will forget its people.

And a nation that refuses to confront its past will eventually become vulnerable to repeating it.

The final tribute, therefore, is not only to those who died.

It is also to those who survived.

To the prisoners.

To the exiles.

To the families who waited.

To the soldiers who returned.

To the citizens who rebuilt.

To the people who continued living when history gave them every reason to stop believing.

They are the ones who carry the future.

And perhaps the greatest honour we can give the dead is not to turn them into weapons for another political struggle.

It is to build a country in which their sacrifices no longer need to be repeated.

That is where this story must end.

Not with hatred.

Not with revenge.

But with a responsibility to remember—and the courage to build something better from what we remember.

9.4 THE LEGACY OF MUHIRWA

Some men become important because of the positions they hold.

Others become important because, when the decisive moment arrives, they choose to stand for what they believe is right.

Muhirwa belongs to the second kind.

He was born in Rwanda, and according to the author's recollection, he carried a simple but profound desire: that his country might one day know peace.

There is something deeply moving about such a desire.

Peace sounds simple when spoken from a distance.

But for those who have lived through war, peace is never merely the absence of gunfire. It is the possibility of sleeping without fear. It is the possibility of trusting one's neighbour. It is the possibility that a disagreement will not become a death sentence.

Muhirwa's place in this story is therefore not simply that of a soldier.

He becomes a witness.

And sometimes the most dangerous person in a system built upon secrecy is not the person who carries a weapon.

It is the person who refuses to remain silent.

The author's account recalls an attack in which Captain Eddy Rwigema and Major Birasa were killed.

As the fighting unfolded, Muhirwa attempted to take cover beneath an embankment. There, he encountered Major Birasa, who had already been killed. Captain Eddy, unaware that Muhirwa was attempting to protect him, reportedly shot himself rather than be captured alive as the attacking force approached.

Muhirwa later told the author that he had recognised two men among those involved in the attack.

According to Muhirwa, they had come from among those responsible for protecting Kagame.

He named one of the men as Ajida Mugabo, whom the author says was later promoted to lieutenant.

These are grave allegations.

They cannot be treated as established fact merely because they appear in a personal memoir.

But for the author, Muhirwa's account transformed the deaths of Birasa and Eddy from battlefield casualties into an unresolved mystery.

Muhirwa approached the author and told him that his cousin, Captain Eddy Rwigema, and Major Birasa had been killed by their own comrades.

The author says that he responded that there was no evidence proving this.

Muhirwa disagreed.

He was determined that those he believed responsible should eventually face justice.

The author recalls warning him:

If they had indeed been killed by members of their own side, Kagame would know about it.

And if Muhirwa continued speaking openly about the matter, he might himself become the next victim.

Muhirwa left without accepting the warning.

The author called after him.

Muhirwa's response, according to the memoir, was that he would never speak to him again.

Only a few hours later, the widow of Captain Eddy Rwigema came to see the author.

She wanted to know how her husband had died.

The author recounts that she accused him of concealing the truth.

She told him that Muhirwa had already visited her and explained what he believed had happened.

The author had apparently told Muhirwa that he possessed no evidence.

The widow then said that she would report both men to the military leadership.

What happened next changed the meaning of Muhirwa's story.

The author says that he was contacted by a person responsible for protecting the military leadership and ordered to reveal Muhirwa's whereabouts.

When he asked why Muhirwa was wanted, he was told that the authorities wished to question him about what he had told Captain Eddy's widow.

The author was also told that Muhirwa needed to be "advised."

Perhaps at the time, the phrase sounded harmless.

Perhaps it did not.

Political language often hides the most important part of a story.

A man is not always arrested.

Sometimes he is simply "called in."

He is not always detained.

Sometimes he is "questioned."

He is not always threatened.

Sometimes he is merely "advised."

And yet, behind these soft words, a human life can disappear.

The author says that Muhirwa eventually came to see him while he was at Kagame's residence.

The author then took the people looking for Muhirwa to where Muhirwa lived.

They told him that they were taking him away for questioning and that he would return.

He never did.

And so the story ends not with an answer, but with questions.

Perhaps that is the only honest way to end it.

Because some questions survive longer than the people who first asked them.

THE QUESTIONS THAT REMAIN

Who killed Major Birasa and Captain Eddy Rwigema?

Why was Muhirwa taken away for questioning and never seen again?

Why were Birasa and Eddy killed?

Why, according to Muhirwa's account, did some of those involved come from Kagame's own security circle?

Why were the identities of those allegedly involved kept secret?

And what did Muhirwa think of the author after the author had warned him that speaking openly could put his own life at risk?

Did Muhirwa believe that the author had betrayed him?

Or did he understand that the warning had been given out of fear for his safety?

There are other questions.

Why did Captain Eddy Rwigema's widow seek answers from the very people whose actions she believed needed to be investigated?

Did Muhirwa's family ever learn what happened to him?

Did the families of Major Birasa and Captain Eddy ever learn the full circumstances surrounding their deaths?

Did those responsible for protecting them know what had happened?

And if people were deliberately killed, what did those responsible believe they would gain from spilling their blood?

These questions are not merely questions about three men.

They are questions about power.

They ask what happens when soldiers can no longer trust the people standing beside them.

They ask what happens when those who know too much become liabilities.

They ask what happens when a government becomes so powerful that people are afraid to ask what happened to the dead.

And ultimately, they ask the most disturbing question of all:

What does anyone gain by killing another human being?

Power?

Security?

Silence?

Revenge?

Perhaps temporarily.

But never without a cost.

Because every political killing creates another generation of questions.

Someone remembers.

Someone searches.

Someone tells a child.

Someone writes a book.

And decades later, the question returns:

What really happened?

The author also makes a final observation that gives the ending an almost tragic circularity.

According to his account, those connected to the alleged killings did not all live peacefully afterward. Some were reportedly sought, some went into exile, and others themselves died violently.

If true, the cycle reveals something terrible about political violence.

Those who participate in violence do not necessarily escape it.

Violence creates its own logic.

The person who is ordered to eliminate another may later become inconvenient to the person who gave the order.

The witness may become a threat.

The accomplice may know too much.

The loyal servant may eventually become a liability.

And the machinery of fear, once created, rarely knows how to stop.

That is why political violence is so destructive.

It does not merely kill its immediate victims.

It corrodes trust among the living.

It turns friendship into suspicion.

It turns loyalty into fear.

It turns silence into a survival strategy.

And eventually, it can make everyone wonder who will be next.

Muhirwa's story therefore belongs among the stories of those who disappeared from the public record but remained alive in the memories of those who knew them.

Perhaps that is his greatest legacy.

Not a military rank.

Not a political office.

Not a monument.

But a question that refuses to disappear.

EPILOGUE

WHAT REMAINS AFTER THE STRUGGLE?

A book such as this cannot end by pretending that every question has been answered.

Some questions remain unresolved.

Some allegations require further investigation.

Some events can be reconstructed only from the memories of people who witnessed them.

Some witnesses are dead.

Some are in exile.

Some remain silent.

And some may never speak.

That is the burden of writing political history from inside a struggle.

The writer does not possess the luxury of perfect distance.

He writes from memory.

From experience.

From conversations.

From fear.

From conviction.

And sometimes from pain.

That does not make every conclusion automatically correct.

But it makes the testimony part of the historical record.

The reader must therefore do what the best reader always does:

listen carefully,

question seriously,

compare evidence,

and refuse to surrender judgment.

This book has taken us through war, exile, political power, alleged killings, international relationships, opposition struggles, betrayal, imprisonment, and remembrance.

But beneath all those subjects lies one question.

What kind of country should Rwanda become?

That question is larger than Kagame.

It is larger than his opponents.

It is larger than the RPF.

It is larger than any individual political party.

A country cannot be reduced to the person who occupies its highest office.

Leaders pass.

Nations remain.

That is why the ultimate responsibility belongs not to one generation of politicians but to the generations that follow.

They must decide whether Rwanda's history will remain a cycle of fear and revenge or become a foundation for something better.

The author closes his story by honouring the military leaders, comrades, and ordinary Rwandans who were killed, imprisoned, or driven into exile in what he describes as the pursuit of Kagame's political power.

Their names may not all be remembered publicly.

But the author promises that they will not be forgotten.

That promise is perhaps the most fitting conclusion.

Because remembrance is an act of resistance against disappearance.

To remember someone is to say:

You existed.

Your life mattered.

Your suffering mattered.

Your story deserves to be heard.

And perhaps one day, when enough distance has passed and enough evidence has been gathered, Rwanda will be able to examine its history without fear.

Not to reopen wounds endlessly.

Not to create another generation of enemies.

But to understand.

To mourn.

To learn.

And finally, to prevent repetition.

The author leaves us with a simple and unsettling sentence:

The struggle is not yet over.

What that struggle means is left for the reader to decide.

Perhaps it is the struggle for truth.

Perhaps it is the struggle for justice.

Perhaps it is the struggle for political freedom.

Perhaps it is the struggle to remember those whom history might otherwise forget.

Or perhaps it is the struggle to build a Rwanda in which no future generation has to ask the same questions again.

Whatever the answer, the responsibility now belongs to the living.

The dead have already paid their price.

The living must decide what their sacrifice will mean.